

SCREAM FOR ME DUET | BOOK I

I DIDN'T JUST HOLD
HIS FRAGILE SANITY
IN MY HANDS...

SWEET WICKED THING

I PLAYED GOD
WITH IT.

JESSIE WALKER

SWEET WICKED THING

SCREAM FOR ME DUET | BOOK ONE

JESSIE WALKER

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Sweet Wicked Thing

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

First off, thank you for picking up this book. Before you dive in, please keep in mind that *Sweet Wicked Thing* is the first book in a dark romance duet, and needs to be read first. *Vicious Fate*, book two, is coming soon, which concludes Vale and Aston's story.

As some of you might know, this story was initially published as part of *Anti-Valentine*, a limited-release MM anthology (February 2023). It has since undergone heavy revisions and been expanded by over 100k words of new content.

You do not need to read the anthology version or any of my other books in order to read this. While all my contemporary works exist in the same universe, unless noted otherwise, Vale and Aston's story stands completely on its own.

A summarized content warning can be found on the next page, with a link to a more detailed breakdown for those who need it. You can also find the list of triggers at the back of the book, following the Acknowledgements. Be warned—they do contain major spoilers, so feel free to skip the next page if you prefer to go in blind.

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CONTENT WARNING

This book has content that may be difficult and uncomfortable for some to read, including but not limited to CSA, child abuse/neglect (systemic and familial), violence (sexual, physical, and verbal), mental illness, on-page death, and toxic depictions of relationships including cheating. For a more in-depth breakdown, refer to the back of the book following the Acknowledgments, or refer to the author's [website](#).

Disclaimer: this book contains heavy, disturbing content that is addressed with morbid and at times insensitive humor that might offend some readers. How these characters cope/process abuse is not intended to romanticize anything inappropriate or problematic. You can expect many instances of ableist language regarding mental illness. Instances of homophobic and sexist language may also be present throughout the book, that in no way reflects the author's beliefs and ideals, but is meant as a realistic portrayal of lived experiences. These characters are morally gray, even morally bankrupt at times, and their thoughts/actions reflect that...but are not condoned in a real-life setting. This is purely fiction and intended solely for entertainment. Mature audiences 18+ only.

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*This one's for all the haters who can't seem to stay away.
Kisses!*

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PLAYLIST

[Find the complete playlist on Spotify.](#)

“Crazy On You” — Heart
“The House of the Rising Sun” — alt-J
“Heaven Is A Place On Earth” — Belinda Carlisle “Lips Like Sugar” —
Echo & the Bunnymen “Youth of America” — Birdbrain “I Touch Myself”
— Divinyls
“The Horror Of Our Love” — Ludo “These Dreams” — Heart
“Somebody’s Watching Me” — Rockwell “Blood” Starbenders
“Nothing’s Gonna Hurt You Baby” — Cigarettes After Sex “Monster
Mash” — This Cold Night “Dead of Night” — Orville Peck “All Out of
Love” — Air Supply “I Want to Know What Love Is” — Foreigner “Psycho
Killer” — Talking Heads “BONEZ” — SH4RD
“Death” — White Lies
“Every Breath You Take” — The Police “I Only Have Eyes For You” —
Boyz II Men “In The Shadow Of The Valley Of Death” — Marilyn Manson
“Love Hurts” — Nazareth
“In Love With a Liar” — Green or Blue “Dead Boys” — Sam Fender
“Goo Goo Muck” — The Cramps ...and a whole lot more.

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Your memory is a monster; you forget—it doesn't. It simply files things away. It keeps things for you, or hides things from you—and summons them to your recall with a will of its own. You think you have a memory; but it has you!

— JOHN IRVING

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PROLOGUE

ONE, two, three...

I'm on a boat, it's storming, and the waves are thrashing the cabin. It smells like sweat and stale beer, salty and pungent, and I imagine it's my crew pressed up alongside me as we ride out the storm raging outside these four walls. We've been at sea for days, with nothing but the ocean and a bar of soap to wash ourselves.

It's hot.

It's humid.

It's rank.

The rocking picks up, and reality begins to creep in when a sharp twinge sparks at the base of my spine, hollowing out my belly.

...six, seven, eight...

Eleven point five.

He never makes it past eleven point five, not when he's drunk like this.

My eyes are squeezed shut, the pillow damp against my cheek. I tell myself it's just sweat. Or maybe some seawater spraying in from a crack in the window.

It's so hot...sticky. It smells. I'm—

I'm not here, I'm not here, I'm not here, I chant.

I'm on a boat. I'm a fisherman. No, a pirate.

...nine...

Pirates are strong. They're deadly and brave. No one messes with pirates.

The mattress squeaks beneath me, and I inhale sharply, my body going rigid.

Squeak, inhale.

Squeak, inhale—

Groan.

I squeeze my eyes shut so tight I feel like my eyeballs might pop. *Block it out, just block it out.*

My fingers are buried so deep in my pillow, the cotton pushes my nails back into my skin. It burns, so I push them in deeper, counting and inhaling, choking on thin, musty air. Willing my body to relax. It hurts less that way, but sometimes, like right now, it's hard to remember that.

Eleven...

A noise—a creak.

It halts everything, seizing my lungs with a sharp, high-pitched gasp.

That didn't come from the bed, I realize, as the rocking comes to a stuttered stop.

My eyes fly open, the fantasy shattering to reveal the brown wood-paneled wall of my bedroom. I know it's the floorboard by the door I just heard. I just *know* it.

And so does the man on top of me.

My much smaller body shudders as he pulls away, relieving the pressure, like pulling a stopper from a drain. The bed frame whines. "What th—" he starts to growl.

I roll my head over just in time to catch the short, skinny body flying across the room—shorter and skinnier than even me.

No!

It's dark, but not so dark that I can't immediately tell who it is.

My eyes widen as I take in the small pale hands grappling at Rick's shirt as the older, much taller and wider man stumbles back off the bed. His jeans are tangled around his knees, and he nearly falls on his backside, catching himself at the last possible second.

"You little fuckin' shit!"

There's a flash of wide, dark eyes—too big for his gaunt face—just before Rick lunges, hands flexed and aimed for my brother's throat.

"Vale," I breathe.

Blink.

Glass shatters. A pained grunt.

Blink.

Squelching sounds.

Blink.

My cheeks hurt...my throat, my hand...

It's *wet*.

Blink.

Someone's screaming. A woman.

But someone is laughing too.

It doesn't make sense. Nothing is making sense.

Why does my arm hurt? Why is everything so wet?

Something tugs on my pajama shirt, and I hear my name whispered.

Aston.

Suddenly, the world explodes into color. A mighty gasp hiccups from my lungs.

Red. It's all red.

I'm surrounded by it. Even the foggy brown eyes vacantly staring up at me look red.

Heavy footsteps thud up the stairs. A woman is crying, and someone is still laughing. The world is still rocking, too, just like it was earlier, but the pressure is gone. The pain is gone.

Well, mostly. My hand hurts. Burns. It's bunched into a fist, and feels... weird...

Stiff.

Stuck.

"What did you do?" the sobbing female wails from the doorway. Several dark figures push past her, swarming the room. And still she screams, "What did you do?!"

"Jesus," someone breathes.

More curses, more sobbing, more...giggling. It seems to be coming from everywhere all at once, all this *noise*. Somewhere, in the back of my mind, I register lights flashing through the window—red and blue, not unlike the Christmas lights on the house across the street. Sirens ring out into the night—*wee-woo, wee-woo!*

I try to swallow, but when I do, it doesn't feel right, doesn't taste right. It's sharp and bitter, like I was licking old pennies, and it doesn't want to go down. It just keeps coming back up.

Oh, I realize. It's because *I'm* the one laughing.

Hunching my shoulders, I curl inward, my knees coming up to my chest as I try to bite down on the sounds erupting from my mouth. Something warm and clammy brushes my bare butt, and I tense when I realize what it is, but only for a moment.

Something tells me I won't have to worry about *that* anymore.

The thought has me laughing even harder. I can't stop. Even when I bring my warm, wet, sticky fists to my mouth, I can barely keep it all in.

"Son..." The voice is deep. Warbly and faraway, like it's coming from underwater.

Someone crouches next to me, and I flinch, my rocking coming to a halt. I snap my gaze to the strange man now staring back at me. His hands are raised, his furrowed eyes darting between my face and my fists.

Cops are here, I realize, finally registering the man's uniform, and all I can think is, *Good, they'll finally take us from this place*. Relief softens some of my irritation, quieting the awful sounds coming from my lips.

Something creaks. The floor. The spot right next to the door. It always creaks when someone steps there. Vale should've known better.

Stupid, stupid, brave little— I gasp. *Vale!*

My laughter, which was already dimming, breaks off with another sharp, hiccupping gasp as I whip my head to the side. The officer throws himself back, but I pay him no notice. I'm too focused on the boy kneeling a few feet away, trembling like a leaf.

"It's okay," I say, cheeks aching with how hard I try to stop smiling.

Dark nearly-black eyes peer blankly back at me from a face so pale, it could belong to a ghost.

Laughter bubbles up once more. My vision blurs as I try to keep it all in, but it's no use. "It's okay, Valey."

He doesn't blink. He doesn't move. I can't even be sure he's even breathing. I kind of want to shake him. Slap him, even. If anyone should be freaking out right now, it should be me.

"I got him," I whisper.

His eyes redden, tightening at the corners.

A sharp laugh erupts out of me, this time through my mouth. I quickly press a fist to my lips, like I can shove it back in. But it's no use.

"I got him!" This time, my voice carries, loud and high-pitched, threatening to crack, before it breaks off into another round of giggles.

That old penny taste and smell is stronger than ever with my wet fingers mashed up against my mouth. But I don't really mind.

I got him. It's all I can think. All that matters.

Everything will be better now, Vale. You'll see. It'll all go back to the way it was, but better!

"Son...could you please drop the weapon so we can help?" a gentle male voice is saying from somewhere close by.

My smile starts to slip again as my eyes dart around aimlessly, somehow taking everything in, but not able to focus on just any one thing.

So, I seek out Vale once more, because he's smart. So much smarter than me. He'll figure it out. What *it* is, I don't know. I just know he'll make everything okay again.

"V-Vale..."

Why does he seem so far away?

Why do I feel so sad all of a sudden?

What weapon?

All the voices surrounding me seem to tune in and out, making it hard to keep track of who's speaking. My chest squeezes, strangling the sounds still trying to escape from my throat.

This isn't so funny anymore.

"How old is he?" someone asks. This one comes from further away. I'm assuming they're referring to me.

"Nine, I think. Maybe ten now," a choked female voice responds.

I know that one. Louise. Our foster mom.

What's left of my smile flattens completely as I think, *I'm twelve, you stupid bitch.*

"Something's never been right with that boy. I mean, look at him!" Her voice breaks on a sob. "Look what he did to my Rick!"

"Rick was bad," I hear myself whisper, still not taking my blurry gaze off Vale's blank face. "Very, very bad."

A weird sort of stillness blankets the room in the wake of my softly spoken words.

Vale remains frozen.

I sense a body drawing close, big and looming, not unlike the one under me.

"What's your name, kid?"

"Aston," I say absently, frowning. I sniff. "Like the car."

He's bleeding, a voice whispers in my head as I drop my gaze to Vale's lap. His hands are bright red, like he's been finger painting, but he's way too old for that. Thirteen now, almost a whole year older than me...not that he looks it.

Neither of us look our ages.

"Are you hurt?" I hear myself ask, voice cracking.

No response. It's like he didn't even hear me.

"He's bleeding," I croak, finally turning to the man crouched over me. A metal plate across his breast pocket reads *Ferris, J.* My gaze drops to where his hand rests on his belt, just next to a gun and a baton. "My brother's hurt. Can you help him?"

Thick, unruly brows dip low over his pinched eyes when I meet his gaze. He has a pudgy nose and too-thin lips peeking out under his mustache that makes him look like one of those muppets from TV.

"Yes, we can help him," he says slowly, carefully. His gaze flits between mine. "But you have to be a good boy and drop the weapon first, okay?"

I frown, following his gaze to where something sharp and pointy, reflecting a blood-streaked face sticks out from my fist.

Oh.

My fist bursts open, and the long shard of mirror I'd been unknowingly gripping clangs to the floor. The cop hurries to sweep it out of reach while I hiss through my teeth and bring my bleeding, aching hand to my chest.

Owww.

"...come with us," a warbly voice says.

I blink at the cop's outstretched hand but ignore it. Instead, I drop my hands to Rick's squishy chest and use it for leverage as I stand, grimacing when I almost slip on his slick skin. His chest weeps red, and his big gut is all ripped open, spilling blood all over the place.

That's gonna suck cleaning up.

Realizing I'm still naked from the waist down, I quickly reach down with my good hand and pull up my underwear and pajama pants, cheeks heating when it occurs to me that everyone just saw my penis.

I loved these pajamas, I think sadly as I scrub my hand on the already stained fabric. They have monkeys on them. I've had them since I started living here when I was five. They don't really fit me anymore—I'm a lot

taller now—but they’re mine, all mine. Plus, they’re the only pajamas I have.

“Can I get new pajamas?” I say, wrinkling my nose when I realize my arms are splattered red. It’s getting all crusty. I can feel it under my nails. *Gross*. “Can I shower too? It’s all sticky.”

A beat passes before Officer Ferris says, “Yes. You can have all of that as long as you cooperate.”

Frowning, I glance up at him. *Why wouldn’t I?* I wonder silently. I’m always a good boy. It was Rick who was bad. Rick who— A weird sort of roaring sound floods my ears, cutting off the thought.

Officer Ferris is staring at me, no, *into* me, like he’s trying to figure something out. I stare back until my eyes start to cross, not sure what else to do. People are always staring at me, and it’s not nice. Makes me feel weird.

His throat bobs and he nods, like he’s found whatever it was he was looking for. But he doesn’t seem too happy about it as he turns his head, dipping his chin to talk into his walkie-talkie.

Vale and I had walkie-talkies once. I stole money from Louise not long after Vale moved in. She was passed out in her recliner and never seemed to notice that the twenty-dollar bill from her wallet was missing. Probably thought she spent it on more of that powder stuff she was always melting on a spoon.

It was the first time I got Vale to smile. He doesn’t smile often, or very big when he does. And he smiled even less so back then. But faint that it was, it might as well have been as bright as the sun when I showed him what I got us.

“Hey! What are you doing?” Louise rushes out, her nasally voice cracking.

I glance over to find two officers pulling her arms behind her. I hear the snick of metal—handcuffs. Her red-rimmed eyes are wide as they dart around. “I didn’t do anything wrong. I didn’t—”

“Ma’am, you have the right to remain silent...”

I let their voices fade as I turn to face Officer Ferris once more. “She was bad too.”

He nods and glances down, lashes twitching over his now hidden eyes. Lifting a hand, he wiggles his fingers, gesturing at something behind me.

Hands grab my arms from behind, and I widen my eyes. “What—”

“You sure about this?” someone asks as I feel the distinct sensation of handcuffs hooking over my own wrists.

Officer Ferris swallows and meets my gaze once more. “Just a precaution,” he says tightly, thickly, like he’s not happy about this. “You understand, right? We’re just doing our jobs. It’s to keep everyone safe. We’ll get this all sorted out at the hospital.”

Hospital?

I stare at him, ignoring the way my heart is now pounding in my ears. “But you’ll help Vale, right? And the others too?”

Either I’m imagining it, or the room grows eerily quiet. “Others?”

“Their room is in the basement. They have to share ’cause they’re the youngest.”

“How many?”

“Three. T-try not to s-scare th-them,” I hear myself chatter as the world around me slants, wobbling, darkening...

A staticky sound fills the room, piercing through some of the weirdness. A voice rattles off numbers, calling for backup.

I don’t feel so good. Why are my hands cuffed? I was good, I was a good boy...

Officer Ferris tells me, “Yes. They’ll all be taken care of. You have my word.”

Inhaling deeply, I nod. “O-okay.” I feel my lips move, but my voice is lost to me.

Turning as far as the cops let me, I search for Vale. He’s still seated on the floor, staring at nothing. A woman—a female cop I didn’t see before—squats down next to him, wrapping a blanket around his shoulders.

He’s shivering so bad. Is it that cold? Maybe he’s coming down with something. Maybe that’s why he came into my room in the first place—maybe he wasn’t feeling well.

“Hey, Valey,” I say.

At first, nothing.

But then he blinks and peeks up at me through his lashes.

“I’ll s-see ya later, ’kay?” I say with a smile. It feels stiff—everything kind of does—and I’m not quite sure why. “Everything’s gonna be bb-better now, you’ll see.”

His eyes widen and he throws his head side to side, his cheeks reddening. His mouth opens as if he wants to say something, but nothing

comes out.

“Let’s go, kid,” Officer Ferris says gruffly, just as the cop who handcuffed me steps into my line of sight, blocking my view of Vale right as his big, nearly black eyes start to fill with something that looks a lot like fear.

My face scrunches up with a scowl, but I bite the inside of my cheeks to keep from throwing a fit. *They’re going to help him, they’re going to help them all, just be good*, that voice in my head assures me as they lead me out of the room and down the hall toward the steps. *He’ll be okay*.

I do hope they let us live together again though. Vale and me. Maybe if we tell them we’re actually brothers, they won’t separate us. I really, really don’t want to be separated from him. I feel twitchy at the thought.

Don’t they know he’s mine?

Who else will try to make him smile?

Who else will keep an eye on him while he sleeps?

The first floor is dark as we descend the steps, opening for us like a giant black pit, broken up only by the flicker of red and blue lights coming in through the thick slats of blinds covering the windows downstairs.

“...wets the bed sometimes,” I hear myself saying, my voice muffled, like it’s coming from down a long tunnel. “He’s scared of thunderstorms too. Chloe can’t sleep without her giraffe. And Frankie’s allergic to peanuts...”

I keep rambling, words babbling out of me, teeth chattering. “Vale has nightmares sometimes. And he hates ketchup. Oh, and his food can’t touch. He also probably won’t talk to you. It’s why he has to stay with me. I’m the only person he likes.”

It’s cold, much colder than upstairs in that stifling, sweat-ripe bedroom. Cold enough that I’m surprised I don’t see my breath when I pucker my lips and blow out air.

The pilot light must be out again.

That or they forgot to pay the bill...again.

I can’t stop chattering.

Somewhere, a grim female voice says, “Mike, I think you’re gonna wanna see this.”

“Jesus fucking Christ. Is that—are those...”

The growing distance combined with the roar filling my ears drowns out his horror, stealing whatever else is said.

Must've found the pictures. A choking sound bursts from my nose and lips.

No, not a choking sound.

A laugh.

A giggle.

Stupid Rick. Stupid, stupid Rick.

Officer Ferris mutters something into his walkie, just as his fingers on my shoulder tighten the faintest bit, holding me steady as we reach the bottom step.

It's then, and only then, that the boy I left upstairs starts screaming.

Only then, as I fight against the cuffs and thrash against the too-big, too-rough hands dragging me out into the snowy, red and blue-lit night—my throat on fire as I scream raggedly for Vale—does the gravity of my actions and everything that came before begin sinking in.

What did I do?

What did I do?

What did I—

SIX YEARS LATER

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CHAPTER 1

ASTON

Dear diary,
Today's the day I earn my wings.
We'll see how long this lasts...

XOXO
-A

AUGUST

THE EASTERN TAILED-BLUE.

Cupido comyntas.

No bigger than the tip of my finger, their light blue gossamer wings flutter over the foliage growing along the chain-link fence.

Distinguished from their other blue brethren by white threadlike tails on their hindwings, these little guys are also known for being one of the few species of butterflies that actually flock to humanity. Thriving in areas others would consider disturbed; dangerous and inhabitable.

Sadly, by the time most tailed-blues reach adulthood, they'll have lost their itty-bitty tails. Including the one currently holding my attention—a

male, as evidenced by its shimmer, rainbow-like sheen when the wings catch on sunlight—fluttering over the patch of weeds and white wildflowers before me.

Pity, I muse, wondering how it happened. If the tails withered away due to wear...or if some cruel, awful predator ripped them off in an attack.

Seated with my legs crossed like a pretzel a couple inches away, overgrown grass and weeds curling up around me, I narrow my eyes thoughtfully on the critter, head cocked to the side.

Did they try to hold him down?

Was he scared?

Did it...hurt?

A breeze blows through, making my hair and the butterfly's wings dance. It's a much-needed relief from the muggy, stagnant afternoon heat. As is the flickering shade provided by the trees creeping over the brick wall keeping me in.

Not that I'm complaining. Winter will be here all too soon, which means no more butterflies for five long months. Maybe only four if global warming is on our side, and spring arrives early, breathing new life into their summer home as it welcomes these fragile creatures back north.

Not like you'll still be here, a voice in my head sings, prompting a smile to creep up my face.

No siree, I'll have a garden of my own to tend to by then, along with a whole new host of butterflies to befriend and give forever homes to.

Not to mention, I'll no longer have to deal with—

As if conjured by that train of thinking, a loud buzzing sound echoes across the enclosed yard, coming from the brown brick fortress behind me.

Time's up, buttercup.

With a bittersweet sigh, I slowly extend my hand, approaching the butterfly still lingering by a patch of white petals. "Hey, little buddy," I whisper under my breath, beckoning it with a curl of my finger.

Its glimmering blue wings twitch a little harder, like it's readying for lift-off, and I freeze. Watching. Waiting. Holding my breath. Somewhere overhead, a crow caws. Leaves rustle. A car drives by beyond the trees, bass thumping rhythmically as it whooshes past.

Maybe it's deaf, I think, when the butterfly doesn't seem to be startled by all the ruckus. It just shifts side to side, swooping when the wings catch on another breeze.

“That’s it,” I murmur, inching forward. “Come to Daddy.”

My mouth ticks up as the butterfly crawls up my first knuckle. Gently, slowly, so as not to disturb it, I lift my hand to eye-level. Sunlight flickers over its glimmering blue wings, highlighting its gray interwoven threads.

“Gotcha,” I say, smiling.

And in a move too quick for the butterfly to sense, I bring my other hand up, and with well-practiced ease and precision, I pinch its thorax between my thumb and pointer finger, crushing his little itty-bitty heart, snuffing the itty-bitty life out of him.

“It’s okay,” I coo quietly. “Quick and painless, right?” I admire its petrified body. The taut, yet slackened wings fanned out from its narrow, flattened core.

Pride and relief puff up my chest. *Perfect.*

“Yo, James, pick up the pace before they yeet your ass back into the pit.”

I stiffen. *Fucking Marshall.*

Snapping my head around, I bare my teeth at him as I emphasize, “It’s *Saint James.*”

Marshall knocks shoulders with Vinny, one of his brainless lackeys. “Nothin’ saint-like about this one.” They both snicker and curl their fingers over their head, making the sign of devil horns.

Seriously?

“That wasn’t what Vinny was saying when I was sucking his dick last week.”

They both freeze at my words. Vinny’s face turns beet red, and he sputters, “Wh-what? Fuck you, fag. I’d nev—”

“Daniels,” someone barks. “Kline. Get inside.”

Vinny shoots me a glare before shuffling away. Marshall gives me one last scathing once-over and spits at the ground, before following suit.

I roll my eyes and turn away. *The nerve of some people.*

“Aston...” a deep familiar voice warns.

“I’m comin’, I’m comin’,” I mumble.

Unlike the other patients here, most of the orderlies call me by my first name, and it’s not because I’ve blown several of them. It’s just less of a mouthful than *St. James*, I suppose. I’ve also been here longer than most, so we’re practically family. A somewhat kinky one, but a family, nonetheless.

Plus, at least Aston is the name I was given at birth. St. James was only bestowed upon me because that was the name of the church where I was dumped as a baby.

In nothing more than the blanket embroidered with my name and a bright red rosary placed atop my chest, I became known as Aston St. James, ward of the state of Pennsylvania.

And a ward I've been since. Something I don't see changing anytime soon, despite what today is.

Climbing to a stand, I take great care not to lose my new little friend or break his wings as I slip him up my sleeve, letting him rest just over my fluttering pulse-point. I make sure to tuck my thumb inside the fabric, cinching it around the heel of my palm, securing him.

Many a friend haven't survived this trip in the past, what with having to hide my treasures in my sleeves, fists, pockets, or mouth in order to transfer them safely to my room.

Not that dead butterflies are considered contraband, technically—at least to my knowledge—but I figure it's best not to draw attention to myself. I'm sure Dr. Zahiri—Ashwood's on-call pediatric psychiatrist, and the bane of my sheltered existence—wouldn't look too kindly on my little hobby after all the so-called *progress* I've made.

Some people just have no appreciation for the arts!

Bruce, one of the orderlies who I don't actually despise, waits for me wearing a dull look of impatience. As usual, I'm the last straggler, but for once, it's not because I'm dreading going back inside.

No, today I'm saying goodbye.

Fluttering my fingers over weeds and bushes sprouting up from the ground, breathing in the fresh air tinged with sickly sweet pungent notes from the dump down the road...

Fare thee well, dear friends.

Plus, even if I wasn't getting released today, it's not like I'd be sent to the pit—AKA the south wing, where they house the padded rooms among other super fun things—for something as innocent as stalling.

You only get sent there when you do something really, *really* bad.

Or just need a little alone time to...decompress.

But more often than not, when you misbehave, they'll just stick a needle in your tush and carry you off to your room for a little reboot. Siesta a la booty juice. Less resources used up that way.

But the other patients floating in and out of this place don't know that. It would seem not just the asylum's reputation, but my own, often precedes us—how, I have no idea, but I don't bother trying to change their minds. Fear offers far more protection in a place like this than anything else. Especially when you're a scrawny, skinny thing like me, standing at only five-seven with little to no muscle mass.

And it's not like I *can't* be as bad as they think. It's not like their fears are totally unfounded. It's not like they didn't prove as much when they were foolish enough to *test* me....

These days, though, I'd just much rather have people know what I'm capable of, than risk jeopardizing my freedom now that I'm finally eighteen.

"Aston. Stop dragging your feet. I have places to be."

I peek up through my lashes to find Bruce holding the door open, watching my approach with a knowing look on his rugged face. Not exactly handsome, but better-looking than some of the other orderlies. He's also one of the nice ones. Gentle, even if he has to pretend to be all stern and scary when the others are around.

"Today's my birthday."

"Happy birthday," he responds flatly.

"Did you get me anything?"

"No."

I release a dramatic sigh. "I'll let it slide this time, Brucey, given the circumstances." Stopping directly in front of him, I tilt my head, biting my lip. "You're gonna miss me, aren't you?" His jaw tenses, eyes darkening as I drag a finger down his barrel chest. "Because I'm sure gonna miss *you*," I croon, pushing up on my toes, arching into him.

He flushes, and quickly steps to the side, clearing of his throat. "Let's go, Aston." Making a point to look anywhere but at me, he gestures for me to walk ahead.

Whistles and stomping greet us inside when we cut through the rec room. The television is on, playing some football game that seems to have nearly my entire second floor cohort in a tizzy.

"Hey, Ass-ton," someone yells out, taking great care to make sure *everyone* hears the way he emphasizes my name. I glance over to find it's none other than Jude, my long-time arch-nemesis who's been a patient here almost as long as I have. Why am I not surprised?

He smirks, while the others cackle and howl as if what he said is the most original thing since sliced bread.

Puh-lease.

While the other orderlies converge on the room before things escalate and someone has a cow because of all the noise, Bruce squeezes my shoulder in one of his big meaty hands, giving me a little shove to keep going.

He knows Jude's been testing me for weeks now, all because he overheard that not only am I getting out—as if it's *my* fault he's got a few months left to go—but that I'll be moving in with my caseworker. One who just so happens to be his caseworker as well, along with five other lucky ingrates currently glaring at me from various spots around the room.

Sucks to suck, boys.

As if summoned, a loud female voice rings out from the doorway just ahead of me, silencing the room in a heartbeat. "That's enough, Judas."

Someone *oohs* at the use of Jude's full name.

Matilda Jennings.

My sweet, little ol' Tillie.

Standing at five-foot-nothing, with bright red hair chopped short around her ears, her command of an entire room of baby lunatics and would-be criminals is half the reason why I adore her endlessly.

The other half being that I'm her favorite, something that's widely known around here.

Heck, it's only thanks to this woman that I have a place to go now that I'm eighteen. If not for Tillie and her stuffy husband—who I've yet to meet—I'd be left to fend for myself on the streets, until I ended up either face-first in a fly-infested gutter—nameless, faceless, and forgotten; a no one to anyone and everyone...

Or back here at Ashwood, where I'd be thrown into gen pop and sentenced to spend the rest of my days getting my brain zapped and pumped full of so many meds that I'm nothing more than a lifeless, slack-faced husk staring blankly at a wall.

And that's only if I was lucky enough not to wind up in prison instead. Which, given my track record with all things *luck*...well, I'm about as bankrupt there as I am in funds and fucks to give.

Maybe if the other patients stopped acting like uncivilized shitheads once in a while, they would've realized this could've been them too.

But *nooo*, they just had to go and keep making things harder for themselves. Getting into fights, sneaking contraband, flipping their lid when the cafeteria ran out of pudding cups...

Didn't anyone tell them that no one likes a lost cause?

When Tillie's attention finally zeroes in on me, I don't miss how her gaze flits to my shoulder, hardening.

As if realizing he's still touching me—not only that, but caressing my neck with his thumb—Bruce retracts his hand like I burned him.

I smirk. *Busted.*

Tillie's fiery gaze meets mine, but I know her ire isn't toward me. Not really. After all, it's not *my* fault I'm so irresistible. It's the orderlies who should be ashamed for being so weak-willed. From the second I turned sixteen, they've been on me like bees to honey. Content to delude themselves that things like age of consent still apply in a place like this... Anything to justify that what they're doing isn't *wrong*.

I wanted it after all.

Begged for it.

Seduced them with my feminine wiles.

And even if I didn't...

Who am I to claim the R word?

Who are any of us to think our voices actually matter?

We're crazy. Degenerates. Black stains on society.

Dirt to be brushed under the rug.

A secret to be hidden away.

"That'll be all, Bruce," Tillie says shortly, dismissing him.

Okay, so to Tillie, they matter. *We* matter. But she doesn't have a penis. And waving that around is about the only way to get anything done around here. Trust me on that.

As I spare one last cursory sweep of the room, I don't miss Jude glaring my way. I lift my fingers into a V and waggle my tongue between them.

Later, babe.

He lurches forward, face reddening with his snarl.

So vicious!

I almost regret never tapping that.

Not waiting around to see what happens, I quickly skip off after Tillie, hoping my new little friend tucked safely against my wrist can wait just a little bit longer.

A WARDROBE CHANGE, an exit interview, and a whole bunch of tedious paperwork later, I burst out the double doors of Ashwood free as a dove.

Cue the heavenly lights. The trumpets. The choir of angels.

I'm back, bitches.

Thumbs hooked through the straps of my ratty, faded red JanSport that I've had since I was a kid, I descend the stone steps in my brand spankin' new high-tops. Tillie takes the wheelchair ramp, a rolling black suitcase in tow.

My suitcase, apparently. My very first one.

Not that I needed it. I don't think she realized how very little I actually owned in my rather cluttered room. I could have easily split my belongings between my backpack and a grocery bag or two.

Parked along the curb, a baby blue Volkswagen Beetle waits for us, one that up until now I've only seen through barred windows.

"Why does your car have eyelashes?"

It was the first thing I ever said to her.

She just shrugged and said, *"Why not? It's fun."*

That was two years ago. I was sixteen, and she was as green to the job as the sparkly nail polish she wore, not scared of me in the slightest. We've been inseparable ever since.

And by inseparable, I mean she's the only caseworker who hasn't run crying to the powers-that-be, begging for reassignment the second things got a little...dicey.

You bite a guy one time...

You'd think I committed murder or something.

While Tillie loads my suitcase into the trunk, I get settled in the passenger seat, reacquainting myself with things like seatbelts and glove compartments and vent switches. I also take the opportunity to double check that my newest little buddy is safe and sound in the front pocket of my backpack. It's not ideal, but it'll have to do until I'm alone again and can put him with the others.

"This is it," I tell him in a whisper. "We're free."

The trunk slams shut, and I quickly zip my bag back up, hugging it tightly against my chest with a deep inhale. Taking stock of the new, yet strangely familiar smells washing over me.

Pine air freshener.

Stale coffee.

Motor oil.

Like crisp early winter mornings, blowing through yellow lights to make it to work on time, exhaust fumes blowing clouds into the frost-bitten air. A crackling radio playing “Manic Monday” as a new work week begins.

I picture Tillie behind the wheel, flipping down the sun visor to inspect her makeup in the mirror in between looking at the road, rolling her lips together to even out the pink gloss she’d brushed on hastily before rushing us out of the house.

She’d be a good mom...

“Ready?” Tillie says brightly, joining me, and popping my little daydream like a balloon.

The door slams shut, and I meet her crinkly-eyed grin, mirroring it with one of my own. “Born ready.”

The radio kicks on with the sputtering start of the engine, and I perk up when the song just coming on is one I recognize. “Heaven Is a Place on Earth” by Belinda Carlisle.

Tillie whoops and cranks the volume up to full-blast, gesturing for me to roll down my window before she does the same.

And just like that, with a popping shift of gears and a squeal of tires—exhaust smoke clouding the hazy, late summer air—I bid goodbye to the last six years with a middle finger salute waving on the wind, and a vicious smirk stamped across my face.

Sayo-fucking-nara, losers.

CHAPTER 2

ASTON

TRAFFIC CONGESTING the interchange doubles what is normally only a half-hour commute for Tillie, and by the time we reach the old mining town of Crowley, heavy rain clouds have gathered across the horizon, blotting out the sun, making it feel a lot later than it actually is.

Trees blur past, broken up only by dilapidated barns and service structures. The further away from the highway we get, the more open it becomes. Cornfields stretching as far as the eye can see. Radio towers and steel stacks reaching for the sky like skeletal arms thrusting out from their graves.

By the time Tillie steers us down a narrow residential street, the asphalt smooth and dark, looking freshly redone, the first drops have just started to fall, splashing the windshield.

It's a stark contrast to most of the neighborhoods I grew up around just outside of Philadelphia, where I spent the majority of my childhood. First in the orphanage, then bouncing from one overcrowded group home to the next, before finally getting thrown into foster care at age five and moving in with the Baders.

While it's fuzzy up until that point—undeveloped brains and all—it's even murkier after that. At least for the first couple years...

"What kind of trees are these?" I blurt quickly, focusing intently on a droplet of water streaking down the window. Tracing it with my finger.

"Um, sycamores mostly, I think. We'll have to ask Walt. I'm sure he knows."

I hum in response, heart thumping in my ears. Sweat has gathered across my palms, and I scrub them roughly down my thighs. Rough enough

I'm surprised the friction doesn't spark.

"You okay?"

I whip my head toward Tillie, eyes wide like I'd just been caught doing something I shouldn't. "Huh? Oh. Yeah." Her brow knits as she darts her gaze between me and the road. I wave off her concern. "Just not used to... cars."

Really? That's what you're going with?

I expect Tillie to laugh, but if anything, her frown only deepens. "Right..." she murmurs, sounding miles away.

I turn my attention back to the road, unable to help myself from cataloging the differences.

The street the Baders lived on didn't have space for many trees. The houses were pressed too closely together. Not here though. This is the kind of neighborhood where kids play together in the middle of the road. Not the kind with crackheads shuffling along the sidewalk like zombies.

A wiper blade squeaks across the still-mostly dry windshield as we ease into a paved driveway, one that leads to a sprawling red brick two-story.

It's huge. Probably not by most peoples' standards but compared to the Baders and the other homes I lived briefly in as a kid, it's a mansion. It even has a covered porch overlooking a flourishing bright green yard that stretches across the entirety of the front. Big enough for another small house to sit.

This is going to look so pretty in the winter with Christmas lights...

My lips rise, and I don't even bother waiting for the garage to fully open so that Tillie can pull in. The second she brakes, I'm flinging the door open and all but throwing myself out, my backpack clutched protectively to my chest. I ignore the slam of her breaks and the startled sound she makes.

All I can do is gape at my new home.

"Wow," I breathe, just as I'm joined by Tillie moments later. I'm only vaguely aware of the garage doors closing. I didn't even notice her pull in and kill the engine.

"Nice, huh?" she says, sidling up next to me. With the hand not dragging along my suitcase, she shields her eyes from the raindrops pinging down on us. "It was Walt's mother's. She passed away a few years ago."

I gesture toward the bright pink hydrangeas lining the porch, blinking the moisture from my eyes. "Did she plant those?"

Tillie laughs. "You know it."

It's a running joke between us that she's got a black thumb—can't keep an indoor plant alive for the life of her. It's one of the things we talked about—planned for—when it was decided I would come live here.

A garden just for me and me alone to grow and tend to. Something I've wanted for years.

Unfortunately, with winter right around the corner, that will have to wait until spring.

Who knows if I'll even still be here by then...

She tips her head toward the front of the house. "Come on."

The suitcase bumps noisily along the bumps and grooves making up the stone path curving toward the porch, light enough that it's easily swooped up with one arm when we reach the steps. Meanwhile, I linger at the bottom, taking time to absorb everything.

"It's so clean," I find myself murmuring in awe as I turn in place.

No garbage bags crowding the porch—only dark wicker furniture with cream cushions.

No rusted metal or broken toys scattered across a neglected, weed-infested yard—only perfectly trimmed grass.

No newspaper or tarp taped over any of the windows. No bars...

"Yes, well," Tillie says, laughing, as she opens the door. It's black, like the shutters, with white windowed panels on either side. "Now that we have a sullen teenager who rarely leaves his room, it's much easier to maintain."

Yeah, so, I'm still reeling over the fact she actually *is* a mom already. But I'll circle back to that.

Inside, a brightly lit foyer welcomes my shuffling steps, and just like the exterior, I can't help but compare it to the other homes I've lived in. Where I'd normally find peeling, yellowed, stained wallpaper—or worse, wood paneling—and crushed shag carpeting, instead I'm met only with gray paint and polished wood floors.

And the smell...

Like dryer sheets mingled with something more sweet and potent—leathery.

Just as the scent registers, I get an even stronger whiff when a set of French doors to my right open, revealing a tall, skinny man with thinning brown hair dressed in a gray tracksuit. He emerges from what appears to be some kind of fancy man cave with a leather recliner facing a huge flat screen against the far wall.

I stand up a little straighter as Tillie introduces us, pasting on an expression of polite indifference as I nod in greeting. It doesn't escape me that Walter doesn't extend his hand for me to shake, nor does it seem to escape Tillie, if the purse of her lips is anything to go by.

Ah.

Let me guess: *somebody* wasn't fully on board with this whole taking me in thing.

Naughty, naughty, Tillie...

I, for one, couldn't care less what Walter here thinks. If anything, I'm relieved we're not about to fake pleasantries. If it was up to me, he wouldn't even be here. How someone as vibrant and wonderful as Tillie could end up with such a dud—his name is *Walter* after all—beats the crap outta me.

I wonder if his son is just as lame as him...

"Is Eden in his room?" Tillie asks him, darting a look up the stairs, and I perk to attention. I swear she's a mind reader sometimes.

"Yeah, he just got back a little while ago."

Following her gaze, I'm unable to make out anything more than the curved banister overlooking the foyer. It's a far-cry from the narrow walled-in stairwell at the Baders, with its uneven planks covered in that awful brown carpeting.

I wonder if these creak...

Tillie turns toward me, and I blink away the thought. "He works part-time at the library," she explains. "It's right down the road. Perhaps he can take you sometime, so you can get yourself a card."

Nodding, I force on a small smile. "Sounds good."

While Tillie chats briefly with Walt, who barely contributes, I only half-pay attention, not really absorbing anything as my thoughts wander back to what she revealed to me in the car.

In the two years I've known her, she's never shied away from sharing tidbits about her personal life with me. Another thing that sets her apart from the rest.

Unprofessional and naive? Probably.

But I appreciated it, nonetheless.

Little did I know though...all this time, she was keeping a pretty big secret from me.

She has a *kid*. A son.

And not some snot-nosed toddler for me to get roped into taking care of, but a teenager who's apparently not much younger than me. Sixteen, going on seventeen next month.

I can't even be mad she kept this from me. It just goes to show she really is a good mom, just like I thought she'd be.

Although...I can't shake this nagging sensation in the pit of my stomach that tells me, *hold up, wait a minute, put a lil sus in it.*

Because let's be a little real for a second: why risk this? Keeping his existence from me made sense. But bringing me into his life? Not so much.

And it's been this thorn twisting deep in my brain ever since she casually dropped the bomb on me.

When it was just her and Walt taking me in, I didn't question it—adults always think they have things under their control, despite what their instincts might say, and people like Tillie—the good, doting sort of people that are rare to find—often feel a need to...swoop in. Play savior. *Fix me...*

As if it's just a given their little pet project won't turn on them. After all, how could a grown-up *possibly* be undermined by a child? Or at least in the case now, someone decades younger than them, who is as clueless as a newborn to the workings of the real world.

But then again...maybe that's exactly it. That false, deluded sense of invincibility, giving them a conflated sense of control.

You'd think, knowing now that they're *parents*...Tillie, in particular... that their instincts would be much, much harder to ignore. That they'd be selfless enough to put their egos aside to not risk a child's—their child's, their sweet, innocent, flesh and blood's—wellbeing.

Not dangle him in front of the monster like a candied carrot.

I look down at the floor, jaw working, as I tell myself there has to be a reasonable explanation. Something that justifies her confidence in putting me in her son's path.

Because Tillie's not like that. She's not like *them*.

If anything, her only sin here is naivety. In her blind faith that I'm not as hopeless a case that deep down, past my fabulous exterior, we all know I am.

"Come on. I'll give you a tour," Tillie says with a squeeze of my shoulder, snapping me from my thoughts. Having not seemed to notice anything amiss, she hands my suitcase off to Walt for him to take upstairs, and with a bright smile, begins leading me around the main level.

I clutch my backpack, trailing her steps dutifully, nodding and smiling and commenting when deemed appropriate.

When we're about to exit the living room, blue light radiating from the corner catches my eye. And all lingering doubts and questions that followed me through the house fade into the background. My excitement returning.

Lips rising, I rush over to the tank. "You have fish?" I crouch and dart my eyes around, searching for movement between the plants.

Tillie sidles up next to me, mirroring my position. "Just one. An angelfish." She points to the back left corner, where a black and yellow striped fish the size of my palm swims out from behind a rock. "We've had a couple tetras and goldfish over the years, but they've all died, and we just never got around to replacing them."

"Do you think he killed them?" I say, tilting my head as I stare at its beady little eye.

Tillie laughs softly. "No, it's not likely. Angels only get aggressive when they're feeling threatened, and we made sure to only get fish that they're compatible with, who let him rule the tank. It's why they don't recommend having more than one. They can be very territorial. And you *definitely* shouldn't house them with bettas. Something we learned the hard way when we brought this guy home."

"Did he eat them?"

She glances my way, blue eyes glittering with amusement. They practically glow and ripple from the reflection of the tank. "No, they're over there." I follow the kick of her chin to where a smaller tank sits atop a short bookcase. "We separated them before they could do too much damage."

My eyes widen. "The bettas?"

She nods.

"But they're so tiny..." I say in awe, glancing back at the angelfish currently weaving its way between strands of grass.

"And yet, see that silvery discoloration on his left side?"

"They did that?"

"One of them did."

I smile at that. *So fierce!*

"Does he have a name?"

"Freddie."

"Freddie?"

Smirking, she stands to her full height. “Freddie Mercury actually.” She gestures for me to follow her back down the hall. “Eden named him. He was ten at the time and was going through a Queen phase.” She lowers her voice and gives me a conspiratorial wink. “But don’t tell him I told you that.”

Before returning to the front of the house, she points out the door leading to the basement. “One day, we’ll get around to going through my mother-in-law’s things. God knows, she kept *everything*. But if you can find your way through the maze, there’s a treadmill and heavy bag if you ever feel like working out.”

I make a face and look down at myself. “Are you trying to tell me something?” If anything, I need to put on weight, not lose it.

She laughs, patting my shoulder as she steers me back toward the hall. “Exercise is good for the mind.”

“Pass.”

She just shakes her head and takes us back to the front of the house. As I suspected, the room to the left of the front door is Walter’s lair—Tillie’s word of choice, not mine. She doesn’t take me in there, just mentions it.

“He’s a very private person,” she tells me halfway up the stairs, turning her head just enough so she can roll her eyes at me. “He’s like our son that way.”

“So, what you’re saying is, don’t go snoopin’ around?” I say as sweetly and innocently as ever.

At the top, she levels me with a narrowed, humored look. “Yes, that’s exactly what I’m saying, Aston.” She points out the bathroom, the linen closet, and her and Walt’s bedroom at one end of the hall. “Walt and I have our own private ensuite, so this bathroom here is all yours and Eden’s.”

Down the other end of the hall where she leads me, there are two rooms facing each other. Tillie pauses and turns to face me. “We respect privacy around here, Aston. Just as Walt’s study and Eden’s room is off-limits—unless invited in of course—so too is *your* bedroom. No one enters without permission, okay? Your things will be left alone.” Her mouth quirks and she steps back, not waiting for a response. Waving me on ahead, toward a door that’s been left open a few inches, she says, “Go on.”

Brushing past her, I push the door open all the way, revealing a perfectly square bedroom twice the size of my room back at Ashwood.

And that's not the only thing that's been doubled. For the first time in my life, I get to sleep on a mattress that isn't a twin. One that looks to be at least twice the thickness of all the beds I can remember.

Stepping inside, I drop my gaze to the carpet. Gray and soft-looking, it looks like it's been vacuumed recently. It's a couple shades darker than the painted walls, which are bare, with the exception of where there's a window facing the street. It overlooks a black, sloped roof that is partially obscured by the thick branches of a tree.

"We'll go shopping tomorrow, and get you some curtains, bedding of your choosing...clothes..."

I start to smile, but then I remember—

"I don't have any money."

"Don't worry about that right now."

Well, if you insist...

Resuming my exploration of my new living quarters, I finally set my backpack down, dropping it on the bed as I make my way over to the closed closet doors. Walt is nowhere to be seen, but my suitcase sits against the wall where he must've parked it before heading back downstairs.

Throwing the bi-fold doors open, I sweep my gaze over the empty space, taking in the racks and hangers and shoe cubby just waiting to be filled up.

Meanwhile, from the hall, just outside my door, there's a soft knock, followed by Tillie's muffled voice. "Eden? Can you come out here?"

The closet and room's potential forgotten, I whirl around just as I hear the muffled click and creak of a door opening. Straightening to my full height, I wipe my palms on my jeans, and give myself a nod of encouragement. *Don't be lame.*

I'm not sure what I was expecting. But the skinny, slouched, greasy-haired boy shuffling awkwardly behind Tillie in ripped jeans and a t-shirt so big, it reaches his thighs, and a look of complete and utter boredom stamped across his face, is not exactly giving *killer queen*.

I suppose I was just imagining someone a little more...put together? Maybe cool like Tillie with funky colored hair. Or a septum piercing.

Not that I'm judging!

Biting my lip, I lift my hand and wiggle my fingers at him in a wave.

His brows slam together, and he side-eyes Tillie with a look I can't decipher.

“Eden,” she says, squeezing his shoulder, “this is Aston. Aston...I’d like you to meet my son, Eden.”

The boy’s lips twist when he meets my gaze once more, and he kicks his narrow chin up in one of those silent *sup, mans* I’ve seen exchanged between the guys back at Ashwood.

So, I mimic it.

Supppppp.

And again, his face gets all twisted up. But this time, he quickly drops his gaze to the ground.

Oh well, A for effort and all.

Tillie claps her hands together, and I don’t miss Eden’s little flinch. Frowning, I only half pay attention to Tillie going on about dinner, as I wonder what that’s about.

He can’t be....scared of her.

This woman couldn’t hurt a fly.

“Aston?”

I snap my gaze to Tillie’s, eyes rounding. “Yeah?”

Her lips purse, and she spares a glance at Eden who shifts foot to foot, once more looking down at the floor. This time, though, he’s got his head fully tipped forward, making it so his long brown hair curtains his face, hiding whatever he might be thinking.

“I asked if you had any preference for toppings? I’m going to order a couple trays from Dino’s.”

“I’m good with whatever.”

She arches a knowing brow, silently calling me out on my bullshit.

I sigh dramatically. “*Fine*. Extra cheese.” *As if she doesn’t already know this...*

Grinning, she looks down at her son. “See? You two already have something in common.” I don’t miss how his shoulders stiffen at her words. “Extra cheese is what he always gets too.”

I narrow my eyes. She did that on purpose. *Sneaky, sneaky...*

“I’ll go do that while you get settled and get to know each other.”

And then she’s gone.

And it’s just the two of us.

Alone.

Cocking my head, I watch curiously as Eden doesn’t immediately bolt like I’m expecting.

Is he waiting for me to say something?

I dimly notice Tillie's fading footsteps. When she descends the steps, I strain my ears, waiting for a creak that never comes.

I don't know whether to be relieved or not.

Eden must have been doing the same thing as me—listening. Waiting. Only I don't think it's for the same reason as me.

When he turns to leave without a word, I find myself lurching forward. "Wait!"

Shockingly, he obeys.

With his back to me, he hovers just inside the threshold. "What?" he says in a quiet, clipped voice.

Locked in place, I look aimlessly about the room, and mouth, *What the fuck do I say?* as if the furniture might have the answer. I didn't really plan this far ahead.

With a sigh, Eden twists to look over his shoulder, face bunched in a scowl. Eyes slitted. "I didn't agree to this."

I blink. "Okay? Good to know?"

He curls his lip in disgust, clearly not very impressed with me. *Rude!*

I cock my head, studying him more closely. Either Tillie conveniently left out the more...colorful aspects that make up *moi*. Or this kid has even less self-preservation than her.

Mumbling something under his breath, he looks down, his hair swinging forward to cover his face.

"What was that?"

"Nothing." With a huff, he all but stomps across the short distance between our rooms.

Grabbing the knob of my door, I watch as Eden turns to face me just inside the threshold of his room, mirroring my position.

"Just...stay out of my way, and I'll stay out of yours." His eyes darken, cheeks flushing, and he glances down, thick lashes framing his high cheekbones. "And whatever you do, don't you dare come in this room and touch my shit."

And with that, he slams the door shut, not even attempting to be quiet about it.

A second later, music kicks on, loud, angry, and bass-heavy, vibrating the walls.

I wait a beat to see if Walt or Tillie will rush up here to demand what's going on, but when I hear not a peep, I quietly close my door, before whipping around to face my new room, alone at last.

A slow, manic grin stretches across my face.

“Welcome home, Aston,” I whisper.

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TRANSCRIPT OF RECORDED INTERVIEW

DATE: 02.14.XXXX

LOCATION: EMERGENCY DEPT, CROWLEY GENERAL HOSPITAL

TIME: 00:00:30

DL: THIS INTERVIEW IS BEING RECORDED. I AM DETECTIVE P. LANSING BADGE # ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ HERE WITH DETECTIVE R. WILLIAMS BADGE # ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ FROM CROWLEY POLICE DEPARTMENT. THE TIME IS ZERO ZERO THIRTY HOURS. IT'S SUNDAY, FEBRUARY FOURTEENTH ■ ■ ■ ■ . AND WE'RE HERE AT CROWLEY GEN WITH WITNESS # ■ ■ .

[PAUSE]

DL: BEFORE WE BEGIN, WE WANT TO REMIND YOU THAT YOU HAVE THE RIGHT TO REMAIN SILENT. ANYTHING YOU SAY CAN AND WILL BE USED AGAINST YOU IN A COURT OF LAW. YOU HAVE THE RIGHT TO A LAWYER AND HAVE THEM PRESENT WITH YOU WHILE YOU ARE BEING QUESTIONED. IF YOU CANNOT AFFORD A LAWYER, ONE WILL BE APPOINTED TO YOU FREE OF CHARGE. DO YOU UNDERSTAND THESE RIGHTS?

VR: YES, I UNDERSTAND.

INTERVIEWEE'S LAWYER: I AM FRANK GALLOWS, COUNSEL FOR MR. RIVIERA. I AM PRESENT TO ADVISE MY CLIENT

DURING THIS INTERVIEW, PER HIS REQUEST.

DL: PLEASE STATE YOUR FULL NAME AND DATE OF BIRTH FOR THE RECORD.

VR: VALE RIVIERA. NOVEMBER 7TH ■ ■ ■ ■

DL: AND WHAT IS THE NATURE OF YOUR RELATIONSHIP WITH MISTER SAINT JAMES?

VR: HE'S MY BOYFRIEND.

DL: DO YOU KNOW WHY YOU'RE BEING QUESTIONED BY POLICE?

VR: BECAUSE I DIRECTLY WITNESSED A CRIME THAT TOOK PLACE EARLIER TONIGHT, RESULTING IN THE DEATH OF ANOTHER STUDENT.

DL: OKAY. WE'D LIKE YOU TO TAKE US BACK TO THE BEGINNING. HOW DID YOU AND MISTER SAINT JAMES MEET?

VR: DO WE REALLY NEED—

DW: MISTER SAINT JAMES IS A PRIME SUSPECT IN A STRING OF MURD— **VR:** IS? YOU'D THINK AFTER WHAT HAPPENED TONIGHT, AND GIVEN HIS CURRENT STATUS— [THROAT CLEARS]

DW: WE HAVE TO COVER ALL BASES, MR. RIVIERA, AS I'M SURE YOU CAN UNDERSTAND. WE HAVE A TRAIL OF BODIES LEADING TO YET ANOTHER DEAD KID. AND ONE CRITICALLY INJURED. WHAT HAPPENED TONIGHT, WHAT WAS DISCOVERED IN THE MINES— **VR:** MAKES ME A SUSPECT NOW TOO. I KNOW HOW IT LOOKS.

[PAUSE]

[THROAT CLEARS]

DL: I UNDERSTAND YOU'RE IMPATIENT AND WORRIED ABOUT YOUR BOYFRIEND. BUT RIGHT NOW, THIS IS HOW YOU HELP HIM.

[PAUSE]

VR: YOU'RE RIGHT. I'M SORRY. I JUST...I REALLY NEED TO KNOW HE'S OKAY.

[PAUSE]

DL: YOU CARE ABOUT HIM A LOT.

VR: YES.

DW: CAN YOU TELL US IN YOUR OWN WORDS HOW YOU TWO CAME INTO EACH OTHERS' LIVES?

VR: WHICH TIME?

[PAUSE]

DL: LET'S EASE INTO THE PAST, YES? YOU MAY START WITH THE PRESENT-DAY, WHEN YOU FIRST SAW HIM AGAIN, AND TAKE IT FROM THERE AT YOUR OWN PACE. IF AT ANY POINT YOU NEED TO TAKE A BREAK, SAY THE WORD.

[PAUSE]

VR: OKAY.

DL: WHENEVER YOU'RE READY.

VR: IT WAS A FRIDAY. THE NIGHT OF THE BELL GAME. TWO WEEKS INTO SENIOR YEAR...

CHAPTER 3

VALE

SEPTEMBER

“RIVIERA, GO LONG!”

It takes me a split second longer than it should to realize that means *me*, and I quickly run to catch the unexpected pass.

You’d think after all these years I’d be used to my new last name. Hell, it’s printed across my jersey and taped across my locker. I write it on every test and paper, and hear it shouted and cheered at every single game.

It *should* be as a part of me as my first name.

It shouldn’t feel like a lie.

Loud *whoops* go out around the field as I catch a perfect spiral. Rolling my eyes, I toss the football behind me, not waiting to see who will stumble forward to catch it.

Hands come out to slap mine as I jog over to the bench like I just scored the game-winning touchdown. When really, we’re just warming up before we kick off our biggest, most attended game of the regular season, which is set to start in less than an hour.

The stands are already filling up, forming a sea of black, burgundy, and gray, the official school colors of Grady Prep. It’s our turn to host this year’s Bell Game—an annual face-off between us and our rivals across the river, in which the victorious team gets custody of the revered, retired town hall bell until the other team can win it back.

It's been a town tradition for going on eighty years. There's an opening ceremony and everything. Then, tomorrow, the big, bronze monstrosity currently placed at the old Colonel D. Grady train station—from which our school got its name—will be loaded back up on a cart and rolled across the bridge connecting the town.

Well, that's only if we lose.

Crowley High hasn't had a turn with the bell in three years, and we don't plan on surrendering it anytime soon. Definitely not under my watch.

"Yo." A shoulder knocks mine, pulling me out of my thoughts. A muscular arm reaches around me for the pile of water bottles.

"S'up," I mumble, popping the sports cap on my bottle with my teeth, before tipping my head back and shooting a stream of water down my throat.

Fletch, our star defensive lineman, looks around the stadium with hard, determined eyes. "Gonna be a good game. A blow-out." He nods. "Gonna crush 'em, I can already tell."

I snort softly at that. "Yeah, how's that?"

He cuts me a sideways look, black paint smudged across his flushed bronzed cheeks. It's mid-September, but the sun's been brutal today; not so much hot as bright. He points to his temple, where his sweat glistens just near his buzzed hairline. "I can just feel it."

"With your brain?"

He nods, grinning like an idiot. "With my *soul*."

"And your soul's in your brain?"

He steps back, cupping his junk protectively through his burgundy compression pants, and thrusts obscenely into the air. "No, man, it's *allll* in here."

I chuck my bottle at his head, and he ducks just before it could hit him in the nose. He's still laughing as he turns and jogs away.

With a rueful shake of my head, I remove my helmet.

"That wasn't very nice," Casey says, joining me. He plops down on the bench, legs spread out before him, heels of his cleats digging into the grass. "Good catch," he pants, smirking through his face guard as he glances my way.

"Nice throw," I say dryly.

As the quarterback to his running back, usually I'm the one barking commands at *him* and throwing balls his way. Not the other way around.

We stretch and shoot the shit while the D-line runs drills. Soon, we'll be migrating to the locker rooms for last-minute wrapping and pre-game rituals. Coach will do his little speech to get us all hyped up, and then it's go-time.

It's one of my favorite parts of the game. That anticipation just inside the tunnel before we get the go-ahead to run full-steam ahead onto the field. Heart racing. Chest vibrating. Music blaring from the speakers, warring with the thundering crowd as we explode through whatever fancy-ass banner the cheerleaders put together for that week.

Never gets old, even if everything else about high school has.

"Oh, hey, there's your dad." Casey goes to wave, but quickly pulls his hand back, sucking in air through his teeth. "Damn. Remind me to never get on his bad side. He looks *pissed*."

Frowning, I turn my head to follow his gaze.

Over by the concession stand, I can just make out the first three letters of my last name printed across a burgundy jersey. Angled away from the field, he paces in a small circle, phone pressed to his ear.

My frown only deepens when Quentin throws a hand up, before jabbing a finger in the general direction of the field. I catch sight of his profile—his rigidly held jaw—and can practically see the flare of his nostrils from here.

It's not so much that my adoptive dad is upset that has me concerned. It's that he's *visibly* upset.

Quentin Riviera is nothing if not carefully controlled. Poised. Hell, I don't think I've ever seen him this animated in all the years I've known him. Even back before he took me in, when he had no choice but to stand in front of a courtroom and defend the people—the *system*—who failed me in a state-level court case that made national headlines, he wasn't this... expressive.

He won the case, because of course he did. He wasn't the state's attorney for nothing. The man is a ruthless, callous force to be reckoned with when he has to be.

But despite what prosecutors might say, he isn't heartless.

Hell, to make up for what he had to do, he adopted me. What better way to right such a wrong, than by saving one of its victims from winding up in another shitty home?

Casey whistles under his breath. "Who do you think he's talking to?"

I shake my head. “No clue.” Yet I can’t escape the feeling that whatever’s going on somehow involves me.

That hunch is confirmed a second later when Quentin’s eyes dart my way. He abruptly stops talking when our gazes clash, his eyes widening a fraction while mine narrow, his shoulders tensing at having been caught mid-tirade.

What the fuck is going on?

Lips pursed, he rubs a hand across his stubbly jaw, and glances away, nodding to whoever’s on the other end of the call. He says something I can’t make out before hanging up.

“Yo, did you guys hear?” a voice pants.

Casey shifts his attention to the newcomer.

Not really in the mood to hear whatever fresh tea’s got my teammates foaming at the mouth, I tune them out.

Just when it looks like Quentin’s about to make his way over here and hopefully shed some insight as to what’s going on, something in his periphery steals his attention. Freezing him in place.

The fingers knotted in his hair are slow to release and drop to his side to hang lifelessly. And it’s then, at that perfectly timed moment, a snippet of conversation from behind me filters through, taking a half-second longer than it should to register.

“Ashwood as in the *insane asylum*?” Casey blurts.

No...

Oh fuck no.

My vision begins to tunnel, blackening around the edges. Next thing I know, I’ve whirled around and grabbed the collar of some underclassman’s jersey. “The fuck you say?”

The kid’s eyes widen, cheeks visibly blanching.

I’m dimly aware of Casey letting out an uneasy laugh. “Dude...”

Throat constricting around my swallow, I release whatever his name is, shoving him back a step.

He gulps, darting a look just over my shoulder. “Um, I was just telling Casey about the new charity case. My mom’s on the school board. Guess they had an emergency meeting today to address some, uh, concerns. He starts Monday.”

“Did you get a name?”

The kid gives a quick, jerky shake of his head. “A-all I know is he’s enrolling as a s-senior. And r-r-rumor has it he... he—”

I snap my fingers impatiently. “He what?”

“Vale,” Casey warns softly. I can feel him shifting nervously next to me, as if debating whether or not to risk a season-ending injury.

The kid’s shaking like a leaf, but I don’t care. I stare him down hard, waiting.

Another audible swallow, then, “K-killed someone.”

I go utterly and completely still.

It can’t be...

“That so?” I say in a dangerously quiet voice.

The kid nods. Shrugs. Shakes his head. “I-I don’t know. L-like I said, it’s just a rumor. I mean, just ’cause he was a patient at Ashwood—if-if that’s even true—doesn’t mean he’s dangerous?” He says it like a question.

“My uncle did a stint there,” Casey says, nodding. “Bipolar. Stopped taking his meds, and just got, like, super depressed. Definitely not a threat to—”

At the look I shoot him, he raises a hand. “Shutting up now.”

“Anything else?” I say quietly to the kid, my tone flat.

His face reddens, and he shakes his head.

Nodding shortly, I dismiss him and make my way over to the bench.

It takes me a second to realize Casey’s followed, and he’s saying something, his voice slow to penetrate the heavy fog clouding my senses.

“...that about?”

I give a little shake of my head. “Nothing.” Out of habit, I go to fiddle with my eyebrow piercing, only to remember I had to take it out for the game.

“Didn’t seem like nothing.”

I sigh, drop my hand to my lap, and cut him a flat look.

Rolling his eyes, he says, “Fine. Whatever.” A beat passes, before he can no longer resist asking, “Do you think it’s true?”

“What?”

“That this dude murdered someone when he was only *twelve years old*? That would mean he’s been locked up for, what, five? Six years?”

“Congrats, you can do math.”

My heart pounds. I must’ve missed that part of the conversation.

Casey scowls, but it's quick to morph into a snort of laughter. He shoves my shoulder. "Asswipe. What's it to you anyway?"

Spreading my legs, I rest my elbows on my thighs and hang my head between my padded shoulders. I don't say anything right away. It's not often I lose control like I just did, and it's for this very reason.

Not that those closest to me, like Case and Fletch, haven't seen glimpses over the years. But it was always because I *allowed* it. The end game far outweighing the risk of them seeing too much—of them prying into things that are better left in the dark.

Knowing I have to give Casey something, I finally shrug, and say, "Just reminded me of a story I saw on the news years ago. About a kid who went ape shit on his abusive foster dad." I pause, before adding, "We lived in the same area. Went to the same school."

Not lies...just not the whole truth.

"So, it was more like self-defense..."

I shrug. "Sure."

"And he was in the system like you," Casey finishes softly, ensuring no one overhears us. He's one of the very few people at Grady Prep who know this. Knows I was adopted.

With him, it was one of those "benefits outweighed the costs" things—I knew I needed someone to have my back. Someone to pity me and excuse my behavior whenever I struggled to keep up pretenses.

Plus, his dad's a cop. Those kinds of connections are invaluable, as Quentin would say.

Jaw working, I give him a short nod.

"Did you...did you know him? Do you think it's actually the same guy?" *Were you abused too?*

No, he's probably not actually thinking that last bit. But then again, it's not that far of a reach.

Still, I'm probably just being paranoid.

"No, and...no," I say. "The odds of that are..." Straightening suddenly, I jump to a stand and turn toward the concession stands. Eyes darting around.

I forgot about Quentin. The phone call. He was headed over here, and then—

"Hey, babe!"

Startled from my search, I blink into focus the figure standing on the other side of the chain-link fence, fingers curled around the metal rungs.

“What are you doing here?” I all but growl as I close the distance, my voice harsher than usual. Behind me, someone makes kissy sounds—probably Casey, the dumbass—but I hardly pay him any notice.

Seth’s brown eyes widen, filling with something like hurt, before narrowing with a familiar flash of anger. “Nice to see you too.”

Blowing out a breath, I cover Seth’s fingers with my hand, trying not to be obvious as I glance over his shoulder. Softer this time, but no less distracted, I mutter, “Sorry, just lost in my head. You know what it’s like before a game.”

I forcefully shift my attention to the guy standing before me. “I thought you were gonna be late,” I say through numb lips, feeling like my pulse is seconds away from punching out of my throat.

Seth shakes his head with a quiet huff. “I texted you. Study group ended early, and...”

His voice fades into the background as I once again find my gaze sweeping over the crowd, words playing back through my head.

Ashwood...killed someone...twelve years old...

Would I even recognize him if I saw him? It’s been almost six years. Not long in the grand scheme of things, but given how much I’ve changed, it’s possible he did too.

Memories begin pushing their way to the surface, this time more vivid than they’ve been in years.

Pale, gray skin. Wide, vacant eyes.

Blood.

So much fucking blood.

There’s a wet, squelching sound, and my hand burns, it stings, flooding with warmth—

“V-Vale?”

And then more memories. Dancing on the fringe of that night, darker but no less vivid to my senses.

The thread of smoke curling up from the overcrowded ashtray, blanketing the room in the stale scent of tobacco.

From the old tube television across the room, a laugh track playing during some family sitcom.

I’m on the floor...on my back...

It's itchy, grimy, and—

My eyes squeeze shut, and I barely manage to hold back my flinch.

This can't be happening. Not now. Not after all this time.

"You're hurting me."

Releasing Seth's fingers like he burned me, I'm only vaguely aware of him letting go of the fence and bringing his hand to his chest, massaging his knuckles.

"Sorry," I mutter, lifting my hand to my face, ignoring the way it trembles as I pinch the bridge of my nose between my thumb and forefinger.

My gut hollows as I almost expect to find them wet and sticky and smelling of metal. Relief is instant when all I catch is a whiff of sweat and dirt.

"Are you okay?" Seth's question somehow pierces the roar in my ears, and the sights and sounds of the field surge forward, the present once more returning to me. Sharper than they probably should be. Almost painful in their intensity.

Knowing he's watching me closely, too closely, I will the tension in my shoulders to unwind, and my pulse to slow down.

It's been so long since I let myself think about that time in my life, much less the boy who hides in the deepest corners of my memories. The one who lurked around the edges of my sleep, in that space between consciousness and that black pit where dreams should be.

"Yeah," I say quietly, pasting on a look of indifference as I drop my hand back at my side. This time, I don't break my boyfriend's gaze as I plaster on a small smile and say simply, "Headache. Sorry. Came out of nowhere."

Seth's brow pinches like he's not quite sure he believes me. Thankfully, it's right at the moment Coach blows his whistle and shouts for us to hit the lockers.

Forcing a swallow, I shrug and say, "Gotta go," and make to pull back my other hand.

Seth grips my fingers through the gaps in the fence, tugging me before I can get too far. Already knowing what he wants, I step forward and meet his lips through a hole in the fence in a quick, chaste kiss.

"Have a good game," he says softly, my weird behavior from only moments ago already forgotten, just like that.

Typical, I think with a quiet huff. Not that I'm complaining. It's moments like these I'm reminded why I've put up with him for so long.

My gaze flicks between his eyes as I nod.

Stepping back, I chance one last look over his shoulder, this time in search of Quentin.

There.

Just past the apparel stand, under the flourishing canopy of a tree, he's once more got his phone pressed to his ear. He's nodding, his face pulled taut. Eyes locked in the direction of the bleachers.

"Thanks," I murmur absently to my boyfriend, bracing myself for what I'll find as I follow Quentin's gaze.

Or rather...*who*.

My heart pounds. Lungs strain for air as I hold it.

Only it's...Mr. Jennings. My freshmen history teacher.

An odd sight to see at a football game, sure—he made it no secret about his distaste for jocks when I had him. Pretty sure he's never attended a game before today. But why he'd be the focus of Quentin's attention...the source of what's got him uncharacteristically agitated...

I frown, searching those around Jennings, taking in those who pass by. But other than a short woman with bright red hair standing at his side, there's no one else of note lingering about.

"Vale?" Seth, still standing where I'd left him, follows my gaze. "What are you looking at?"

"Nothing." And with that, I turn away, thoughts churning with questions that will just have to wait to be answered until the end of the game.

Reaching for my helmet where it rolled across the grass, I shove it over my head, providing some much-needed cover from what feels like more than one set of eyes watching me.

Seth.

My teammates still lingering nearby.

Perhaps Quentin now too, at having finally sensed how on edge I am... and why.

And someone else's...someone's watchful, piercing stare I tell myself I'm just imagining. Just a phantom sensation creeping out from the past I've done everything I could to bury.

It's not him. He's not here. There's just no possible way.

Without looking back, I turn away and start jogging after my teammates, the tunnel to the locker room looming ahead just as music starts blaring from the speakers overlooking the field. People cheer, knowing it's nearly time.

I let it all wash over me. The sights, the sounds...

The orange evening sunlight bearing down on me.

The fresh scent of grass and dirt burning a pathway up my nose.

The pre-game jitters buzzing through my veins.

I let it consume me and eradicate everything else as my cleats eat up the distance, putting me further and further away from my past. From the sinking gut feeling that tells me everything's about to change.

After what he did, what the cops walked into...

The mess he left, the way he was *laughing*.

And then everything else that came to light in the days and weeks and months to follow...

It has to be a mistake.

There's no fucking way fate would dare put Aston St. James back in my path.

No fucking way.

CHAPTER 4

ASTON

Dear Diary,

*Kill me now, because I'm about to become soooooo
insufferable.*

You have no idea.

XOXO

-A

“YOU’RE DROOLING.”

“Am I?” I sigh dreamily.

There’s a huff of annoyance, then, “I’m leaving.”

I roll my eyes, and blindly reach out, grabbing Eden by the arm and dragging him back to my side before he gets too far. “*Uh uh uh*. Remember the deal?”

He makes a low growly sound, ripping away from my hold. I don’t have to look to know he’s crossing his arms and pouting like someone jizzed in his Cheerios.

Speaking of cereal...

“Someone’s been drinking their milk and eating their Wheaties, that’s for sure,” I whisper, watching #33’s tight tush bobbin’ away as he jogs off into the sunlight. I mean, *come on*. Can you blame me? Hello, spandex, the greatest invention since...

Yeah, I’ve got nothing right now.

Riviera.

That’s what the back of his black jersey says.

And yet...

The second he’s out of sight, and time resumes, I whirl on Eden. “Why didn’t you *tell* me you go to school with Vale?”

His brow creases. “What?” His gaze darts toward the field, and his scowl deepens. “You know that asshole?”

I gasp. “How *dare* you talk about my brother like that.”

Eden’s wide brown eyes swing to mine, his lips parting. “Your *brother*?”

Waving him off, I look around to make sure Tillie’s still out of the vicinity. Someone bumps into me from behind, and I shoot the woman passing by with her kid a withering glare. It’s gotten a lot busier in the last however minutes since my world got rocked on its axis.

I spot Walt first, over by the porta potties. He’s looking down at someone I can’t see, telling me it’s probably Tillie.

“Come on,” I murmur, grabbing Eden’s wrist, and tugging him out of the line for food.

Dragging him in the opposite direction of the bleachers, I ignore his protests and attempts to shake me off as I cut a path through the crowds of people gathered around the concession stands. Leading us toward the woods beyond.

Once we’re far enough away from the masses, I finally let Eden tear himself away.

Crossing my arms, I level him with a no-nonsense look. “Talk.”

Glaring at me through a curtain of tangled dark brown hair, he mimics my position. But with far less *I mean business*, and a whole lot more of hunched defensiveness. And not for the first time, I can’t help but appreciate just how *precious* my new brother is.

This skinny, angry music-loving, baggy clothes-wearing sixteen-year-old with the perpetual scowl is the picture of petulant teenage angst, and fuck if he doesn’t deserve to be protected at all costs.

I mean it! If anyone so much as dares to say a negative word about him or thinks of harming a single strand of his long, greasy, unbrushed hair, I won't be held responsible for my actions.

"About what?" he says sharply. I don't miss how twitchy he seems suddenly. He keeps flitting his gaze away.

He's probably jealous someone came before him.

"How was I supposed to know he was your...brother?"

I stare at him. Blink. "Forget that. Tell me everything you know about Vale DuPont."

A shiver works down my spine, fingers buzzing. I haven't said that name aloud in years.

Rolling his eyes, Eden says, "Well, first of all, his last name is Riviera. In case you missed it in bold across his back."

Oh, did I mention my new brother is also *sassy*?

I steeple my hands together against my chin like I'm praying. "Eden. Sweetie. It's called being *adopted*."

Scowling, he fires back, "Or it's a totally different person."

I open my mouth to refute that, only to slam it together when I realize... okay, he *could* be right.

I mean it *is* pretty far-fetched, now that I think about it, Vale being here, living in the town I just so happen to have moved to. Playing football for the very same private school I'll be attending, no less.

I know, I know—you're probably wondering how this happened.

How I went from merrily skipping my way out of the asylum I called home the last six-ish years, to struttin' my stuff through a crowd of unsuspecting townspeople all geared up in jerseys, foam hands pointing toward the sky, laughing and smiling and totally oblivious to the fact there's a child killer in their midst...a child killer who will be attending school with *their* children starting Monday.

First of all, though, I should probably clarify for those who skipped the prologue—yeah, I see you, heathens, and yes I'm one-hundred percent judging, because you've definitely missed out on some critical info—when I say *child* killer, I don't mean that I've killed children. Come on, even I'm not that fucked up.

I was the child. He was an adult. For more deets, circle back.

Anyway...

Luckily for all these people here at the game, I'm an adult now. Legally, at least. And as of—let me check my watch—4:46 P.M. today, September 23rd, a whole month since I earned my wings, I've yet to become an *adult* killer.

So really, they've got nothing to worry about. Nothing at all.

Hashtag thriving.

I'm totally rocking this freedom thing.

So yeah, as I was saying, there I was a fortnight ago...

"SAY WHAT NOW???" I all but screech.

"We enrolled you into high school," Tillie repeats calmly from the other side of the table, before biting off another piece of meatloaf from her fork.

I blink rapidly, waiting for the punchline.

It never comes.

Fuck me, she's serious.

I turn to Eden. "Did you know about this?"

He shrugs, not taking his eyes off the food he pushes around with a fork.

So, I turn to Walt instead, and surprise surprise, he's not looking at me either.

"You'll be a senior," Tillie says. "It's taking longer than it should for the paperwork to go through, otherwise you would've started with your peers this week."

My face pulls in as I stare down at mostly cleared plate. *Senior*, I repeat silently, mouthing it and testing it out, like it's something foreign.

So only one year behind...

"Just think," Tillie goes on brightly, "you'll get to go to prom, walk across a stage to receive your diploma..." Her voice trails off with a sort of pointedness I'm not quite sure I understand.

I mean, hypothetically, I do. Hypothetically is how I understand most things.

Mouth dry, all I can do is stare blankly at my plate, until my vision blurs.

High school.

Prom.

Graduation.

Things I only ever got to see in movies and read about in books. Things I never thought I'd get to experience myself, when I knew I'd be locked

away until I turned eighteen.

I figured I'd be too old for all that stuff by the time I got out. If anything, I figured Tillie would force me to get my GED. She's mentioned it a couple times over the years. But this? This has never come up. Wasn't even on my radar.

"But...why?" I eventually ask.

"I said it at your hearing, and I'm saying it again now," Tillie says. "I truly believe, if given the opportunity, a little bit of trust, and the resources to be a productive member in society, you'd thrive." She pauses, her voice thickening in that way it sometimes does when she adds, "You're a good kid, Aston. A good kid who got dealt a...a very crappy hand."

A derisive snort escapes me before I can stop it. And it's all I can do to hold back the eye roll begging to accompany it.

A crappy hand.

The party line.

How many more times will I have to hear that excuse in my lifetime?

They want to believe so, so bad that I'm not a lost cause...

Tillie goes on to say something, but I quickly cut her off before she can add any more bullshit to her bullshit sandwich. "You don't have to lie, you know. I know why you're really doing this." I shrug and lift my gaze to hers. "You don't want to leave me unsupervised. I get it."

There's a long moment where she just stares at me, lips pressed tightly together, fork paused halfway to her mouth. When she does eventually speak, her voice is quiet. Careful and measured. "It's not that I don't...trust you, Aston." She lowers the fork, her food momentarily forgotten. Arching a knowing brow, she says, "But do you really want to be cooped up here alone day after day?"

I frown. I hadn't actually considered that. Now that Eden's gone all day...

Bored.

I'd get bored.

I don't do well with bored.

Images flash across my mind of all the times I got thrown into the pit. Not that I really remember much. Sometimes things just get a little fuzzy, and when I come to, there just so happens to be...blood. Sometimes a lot.

I shudder.

I hate being sticky...

“Aston.”

My eyes snap open. I didn’t even realize I closed them.

Oopsie.

Tillie’s no longer smiling. No, she looks concerned. Something tells me that’s not the first time she tried to get my attention.

I dart a look toward Eden who watches me with narrowed, thoughtful eyes through a curtain of messy hair. Then to Walt, not surprised he’s now watching me too, only he looks a lot more wary. And not the *I’m scared of you* kind of wariness, but the *try something, I dare you* kind.

As if you could stop me, I sneer silently. Based on the tension newly lining his face, something tells me he got the message.

Turning to Tillie, I clear my throat and offer her a small, demur dip of my chin. “I’m fine,” I tell her. “I just...” Shaking my head, I scrape around for the words I want. “I didn’t think I’d ever get to go to high school.” I even get my voice to crack for good measure.

Her features soften, her gaze turning far less worried and more sad.

Bingo.

“Well, then this is your chance to see how the other half live. Trust me, you’ll probably realize it’s not all it’s chalked up to be.” She laughs a little at that, though her eyes remain tight.

“And they’re...allowing this? The school, I mean.”

Do they know what I did?

Tillie casts a long sideways at her husband. “We pulled some strings.”

Right...because he’s a teacher. History, because a lame name and dull fashion-sense weren’t bad enough.

“Look, Aston, I would never risk this—any of this—if I wasn’t one-hundred percent confident you could handle it.”

I nearly rear back at that. “One-hundred percent, huh?”

Oh, Tillie. My sweet, sweet summer child...

“Yes,” she says strongly. I don’t miss the look she shoots Walt. “These first few weeks—months—are going to be critical. Which is why we must take a proactive approach, to ease the transition as much as possible, and prevent any possible set-backs.” She pauses meaningfully. “You’ve improved so much in the last year, Aston,” she goes on softly. “It’s been so long since you’ve had an episode.”

Memories surge forth, the images fractured and obscured like shards of dust-caked glass.

One...

Two...

Watching my finger circle the rim of my glass, I murmur, "And if I am...bad?"

There's a creak—like the sound of a door opening. Like the sound of mattress springs giving way. Like the sound of body shifting in a chair.

I sneak a look up through my lashes just in time to catch her easygoing expression faltering.

There it is...

Dipping my gaze, I watch her throat work with a swallow, and I see it. Feel it. If only for a second. That fear. That deep, ingrained *knowing*.

My pulse speeds up.

The air grows thinner.

Blackness tinges the edges of my vision.

That...*thing* inside me. That thing that isn't right.

It yawns to life.

It...*purrs*—

A figure steps in behind her, hands coming down on her shoulders.

I expect her to flinch.

She doesn't.

She slumps...like she's relieved.

I frown and look up to find Walt watching me with narrowed eyes. I never heard him get up. "You'll be meeting with the school psychologist once a week," he tells me matter-of-factly. "He's to keep us, as well as Headmaster Locke, informed of any...trouble adjusting. The second you step out of line—"

Tillie reaches a hand up to squeeze his, cutting off his words.

Gone is that brief flash of fear I saw. And back in place is that usual steely, determined optimism I've come to associate with her.

It's fascinating. Almost as if her instincts are something to conquer—a problem to solve—and not her body's way of saying, *Run*.

Whether it's out of sheer stubbornness or sheer stupidity, I don't know. And I'll probably never have the balls to ask. What with Walt looming over us, watching me like a hawk.

But I can't deny that isn't...tempting...to see how far she'll take it.

What do I have to do to get her to break?

What do I have to do to get her to give up on me?

“This is your *only* chance,” she says, drawing my attention once more to the conversation. There’s an unmistakable gravity to her words, and a pointedness to her gaze, almost like she’s warning me. Like perhaps she’s not as naive as she makes herself out to be. “You understand that, right? You get that this is it?”

And I know that Tillie’s no longer just talking about high school anymore, but my future in general.

Because I’m no longer just some severely malnourished, traumatized no-name kid who finally snapped after years of prolonged abuse—a tragic tale you’d hear about on the 11 o’clock news, and tut your tongue at. *What a shame...that poor boy...*

In the eyes of the law, I’m an adult now. One with a pretty gnarly history, even if most of my questionable behavior—save for that night—happened behind the barred windows of a mental institute.

Lose your shit once, shame on them.

Lose your shit again...

And again...

And again...

Shame on you, cupcake.

Chills spiral down my spine, shards of memories prickling at my awareness once more. Ones filled with sticky warmth and vacant dishwater-colored eyes and flashing red and blue lights. And the *relief* I felt... the vindictive pride...

No, I don’t need a psychiatrist or a courtroom to tell me I’m dangerous.

I know I am. I know what I’m capable of.

I know what lives inside me.

“So, what do you say, Aston?” Tillie says.

I flit my gaze around the table, from her kind, trusting face to Walt’s pinched, untrusting one...to Eden, who’s still watching me curiously.

You’re gonna fail, a voice sings, one that sounds suspiciously a lot like *mine*.

Its promise settles inside me like a boulder, and yet...

Glancing down at my plate, I feel a small smile creep up my face. “It depends...”

Everyone tenses.

“Do you think they’ll let me join Drama Club?”

I peek through my lashes to find her blinking, gaping at me, clearly not having expected that.

But then she throws her head back against her husband's chest, letting out that twinkling laugh of hers that never fails to make me feel all gooey. Softening up all the sharp things inside me.

Tilting my head, I watch the way the tendons in her neck stand out, as if begging for my fingers to crush them. Just like the itty-bitty bodies of my butterflies.

My mouth waters at the thought, at the images playing out in my head. My heart pounds, fingers trembling as I dig my nails into my palms, imagining it's her skin breaking open for me. It's just...so...*pure* looking.

Something so flawless is just begging to be destroyed.

But I quickly shove it down—the weird intruding thoughts, these impulses...

Down, down, all the way down, where no one will find them. Until I can almost believe I've squashed them completely.

Tillie's good, I remind myself, remind that *thing* inside me, the thing that isn't *right*.

We like Tillie. We want to keep her. Just like this.

She can't laugh until she's crying if she's dead.

Nor would she be able to provide a roof over your head... a different, more practical voice points out.

A throat clears, and I meet Walt's hard, knowing gaze. I give him an innocent smile. "What can I say? I've always wanted to be a star." A glance at Eden shows him staring at me, and I toss him a wink.

He flushes, glares, and abruptly stands up to take his dishes to the sink. Fleeing the room before anyone can stop him.

Oh well. He'll come around.

I meet Tillie's gaze and give her a sympathetic smile. "He had a long day. Don't take it personally."

Later that night, I'm flopped down on my stomach in bed, feet kicked up in the air, scribbling in my diary as "These Dreams" by Heart plays from the old Boombox I found in the basement.

Who knows?

Maybe high school is just what I need.

A fresh start.
A chance at normalcy.

I lift the gel pen, nibbling on the end. My gaze drifts to the gray butterfly taped to the top of the page, wings splayed.

“Well shucks, little guy,” I whisper. “Maybe I’ll even get voted Prom Queen.”

Stranger things have happened...

LIKE THE MOTHER of all plot twists that is running into my estranged foster brother a whole two hours away from where we were placed together years ago. At a *high school football game* of all things.

If it’s even him, that is.

Now that the shock is starting to wear off, the doubts are quick to rush in to try and support Eden’s logic.

You see, I’d already been staring at him—watching him from afar—when recognition decided to make a whore of me and pimp-smack me across the face.

The sexy football player who’d caught my eye and stopped me in my tracks... He was impossible to miss—tall and domineering in a way that drew my ravenous gaze like a moth to a flame.

Dark tousled hair.

The broody kind of pout only those naturally miserable can pull off.

A body just *begging* to be climbed and rubbed up on.

The heavens might as well have opened up and shined a light down on the most perfect specimen ever conjured up. The man of my dreams, created just for *moi*.

So perhaps I did just imagine it—saw something I wanted to see, for whatever crazy reason. *Felt* something I only wanted to feel.

A change in the air.

A shift in the course of my future.

A sinking *knowing*...

A terrible *wanting*...

An aching *missing*...

Those eyes...

Dark and fathomless. Watchful, and yet somehow blank even after all these years. Scouring the stands, the crowd, like he was searching for something.

Searching for someone.

I couldn't believe it.

Vale DuPont.

The boy who saved me.

The boy who wrecked my life.

The boy I never thought I'd see again.

The boy who grew up to be a *god*.

Could it really just be a freaky coincidence?

After all, other than his eyes, it's near-impossible to reconcile the six-foot hunk with the bulging biceps and granite-cut jawline, and an ass I could bounce quarters off of, with the quiet, mousy little boy I once called *brother*.

But his name...

Eden mumbles something I don't catch.

"What was that?"

"I *said*... he moved here five years ago."

I perk up at that, my doubts disintegrating as quickly as they'd formed. "From where?"

"Don't know. Aside from that and the whole jock-football thing, all I know is he was held back a year, he's gay, and he's dating the captain of the debate team." He shrugs.

My face bunches "Well, that's unexpected."

"Him being gay?"

Shaking my head, I say, "No, him dating such a loser. Aren't jocks supposed to date cheerleaders?"

"He's gay."

"Yeah, and boys cheer too. You've seen *Bring It On*, haven't you?"

"No."

Ignoring that, I turn away, and begin pacing, wondering how this happened—what it could mean...

To think, I didn't even really want to come tonight.

Not that I was *totally* unwilling, unlike Eden who had to be bribed to tag along. I'm just not really into the whole sports thing, you know? It makes people crazy. Men especially. I have a feeling Eden's of the similar opinion,

given some of the mumbled commentary about *fucking jocks* I'd picked up here and there since we met.

But apparently, football is like this *huuggeee* deal around here. And for reasons I didn't really pay attention to, tonight's game in particular is a big one. *Unmissable*.

So, Tillie was nothing if not determined to make a family night of it. Said it was a rite of passage I couldn't miss. Nor should Eden, who scowled at that and said, "*Since when?*"

I mean, yeah, those football pants are *tight*—it's a glorious sight to behold and will provide much fodder for my fantasies—but it's not like I find watching a bunch of jocks running back and forth across a field just to catch a ball as life-affirming as she made it out to be. Or as the guys back at Ashwood did when they'd stomp and throw shit at the television.

But what do I know? My idea of affirming is seeing how far down my throat I can take a cock before I gag. We all have our priorities, I suppose.

A phone chirps. A moment later, Eden says, "It's Mom. Game's about to start. She's wondering where we are."

Nodding, and without a word, I start heading back the way we came. Eden grumbles under his breath as he jogs to catch up. In my periphery, he thumbs out a message before locking his phone and clutching it in his hand.

The marching band gathers into formation across the field, and just as we reach the bleachers, music explodes into the early evening. The crowd cheers. A deep voice sounds over the speaker, hyping everyone up.

Fortunately, Tillie and Walt were able to score enough space for the four of us halfway up the stands, smack-dab in the center. Finding our way over there is a journey and a half, but we finally make it. With Eden taking the lead, we squeeze past Tillie to sit between her and Walt.

"I thought you guys were getting food," Tillie says.

Eden scowls, while I lie for both of us, "Line was too long. Got impatient."

She eyes me curiously, like she's debating whether or not to believe me, but ultimately lets it go. "That's too bad. Try again in a little bit. I'm sure it'll clear out now that the game's started."

I smile at the field. "I'm good."

Who needs a hot dog when you've got a football player to fantasize nibbling on?

Eden huffs, and mutters, “I’m not.” Walt pats him on the shoulder and offers to go with him.

Whether or not they end up doing that, I have no idea. They could be snatched up by aliens, and dropped back later, butt-probed and brain-dead, and I’d be none the wiser.

Nothing—no one—exists, but *him*.

All throughout the opening ceremony, and then the game, I indulge myself on the visual feast that is Vale Riviera, #33, Grady Prep Archers’ star motherfucking quarterback. Salivating over the way his muscles flex anytime he pulls his arm back and lets the football sail across the field. The way his ass looks in those sinfully tight compression pants.

Hot. *Damn*.

I get it now.

I get why all the boys go ga-ga for this sport.

Yes, baby, do that again. Do what that announcer guy said—penetrate that hole.

Gnawing on my lip, I bounce my knee, impatient for...something. Answers. Confirmation.

I need to know.

Is it him?

Is it my Vale?

Nerves swirl with dread, intermingling with a lust so forceful—a lust and *want* unlike anything I’ve ever felt before—it’s a wonder I haven’t cleared out the bleachers with the amount of pheromones wafting off me.

It’s fucked up—twisted—given who he is to me.

Or rather *was*...

If it is in fact him.

And yet it does nothing to rein in my smile anytime #33 takes the field.

Or the hungry hearts blooming from my eyes whenever he jogs back over to the bench, removes his helmet, and shakes the sweat from his thick, dark hair like a porno come to life.

Or the bulge in my jeans I hide under my crossed legs whenever he bends over, drawing my gaze to that bitable tush of his.

If anything, the wariness poking through my desire—the warning bells going off somewhere in the back of my mind—only heightens the thrill of this new development. Providing fuel for the fire licking my blood and setting my nerve-endings ablaze.

A secret grin inches up my face.

Come out, come out, wherever you are, little mouse...

A whistle blares. Cheers rise.

The game ends.

Below, jogging once more toward the sidelines, Vale whips off the helmet. Even from up here, I can make out the droplets of sweat gleaming under the lights when he slicks his hair back. His gaze lifts to the erupting stands as his teammates swarm him in celebration.

And through a rippling, clashing sea of burgundy and black—signs and foam arrows jutting out into the night, waving in the breeze—those fiercely cold midnight eyes home right in on mine.

As if he knew exactly where to look.

Where to find me.

Like he's known all along.

Found you.

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CHAPTER 5

VALE

WE WIN the game by a landslide, just as Fletch predicted, earning a fourth consecutive year with the town's beloved bell.

Which is why I *should* be out celebrating with my teammates right now...and not on the verge of losing my shit in the school parking lot.

"So, it's true."

Quentin blows out a breath from where he sits behind the wheel. "Vale..."

Snarling back a curse, I bang my fist on the glove compartment so hard it pops open, sending a streak of welcome pain up my arm.

"Hey! Easy."

Teeth gritted, I curl forward, burying my fingers in my hair, trying to rein in the rage coursing through my veins. "This cannot be fucking happening."

Quentin leans across the seats to close the glove compartment with a soft click. He doesn't say anything—doesn't lecture me for losing my cool or try to calm me down like he used to when he first took me in, and my emotions would get the best of me.

He just waits it out.

Throughout the game, it was easy—probably too easy—to put all thoughts of Aston and what his being here could mean for me to the back of my mind, in favor of turning my focus to the field.

If there are two things I'm really fucking good at it, it's compartmentalizing, and getting what I want.

And what I wanted was to lead my team to victory and forget all about my past.

But no sooner than the final whistle was blown, and the field erupted in celebration, my reprieve ended. And it all came rushing back with a single, fateful glance at the stands.

Because there in the bleachers, sticking out like a beacon in his glaringly white t-shirt, watching me with a devilish curl of his lip and unabashed intensity—felt and seen even from the field, like razor-sharp claws tearing into my skull—stood none other than my worst nightmare.

Aston St. James.

My once-upon-a-time foster brother.

The boy who ruined my life...

And whose life I ruined right back.

Eyeing me up like I was his next victim.

On the outside, I remained as cool and collected as always, not letting my face betray the sharp spike of shock—of anger. Maybe even a little panic, much to my annoyance. Fortunately, it lasted all of a second—if that—before the connection was broken with the dog piling of my teammates.

For once, I was grateful for it—their ridiculous post-win antics that always ended with me being crushed into the grass, smothered by sweat and pungent body odor.

Who knows what would've happened, had they not intervened, albeit unknowingly. Probably saved me from doing something mind-blowingly stupid. Like, say, swinging myself over the fence, charging Aston, and using my fist to wipe that ridiculous look off his face.

All throughout the post-game ceremony, I had to make a pointed effort to keep up pretenses, only half-paying attention to what was going on as I willed my blood to cool. Nodding when I was supposed to. Clapping when others clapped. Fist-pumping the air when cheers and chants broke out as the bell was officially bestowed to us for another year.

And doing everything in my power to avoid looking in my foster brother's direction.

After accepting the plaque commemorating our victory, we were finally dismissed, and I wasted no time making a break for it. All the while, acutely aware of the eyes boring holes into my back, as they chased me into the shadows of the tunnel.

I barely remember stripping off my uniform and jumping in the shower once I busted into the locker room. Barely remember talking and shooting the shit with the guys, even though I know I did. My smile felt more

wooden than usual, my words stilted, but no one seemed to pick up on anything out of the ordinary.

Even after, when I all but ran from the room like the hounds of Hell were on my ass, did anyone say anything other than, “Good game, Riviera,” or to ask if I was headed to the Furnaces for the afterparty.

I nodded, smiled, confirmed I’d see them all there, and then I got the fuck out.

Quentin was waiting for me in the parking lot, leaning against his black Lincoln Navigator, hands tucked in the pockets of his jeans. Eyes trained on the ground as if all of the world’s problems could be solved in the chipped, confetti-speckled asphalt of Grady Prep’s parking lot.

He barely said a word once he noticed me, other than a quick, “Congrats,” as he finally pushed himself away from the SUV to grab my duffle and slap my back.

After tossing the bag in the backseat, he joined me in the front, sliding behind the wheel.

For a long moment, neither of us said anything. Just watched as fans skipped across the lot, finding their cars, smiling and laughing as if it was just any other game night. As if my world hadn’t just come crashing down.

Now, several minutes have passed. And when I give him a little nod, telling Quentin without words I’m good, he picks up the conversation as if nothing happened.

“There might be a way to fix this,” he hedges quietly, his voice nearly getting lost under the low hum of the idling engine and open vents blowing cool air at us.

Snorting humorlessly at that poor attempt at optimism, I drop my hands and straighten, flopping back against the seat with a thump of my head. I turn my gaze toward the moonroof.

“How did this even happen?” I eventually whisper. It’s more rhetorical than anything, but Quentin doesn’t know that.

“He aged out,” he tells me. “Turns out, the wife of one of your history teachers—”

“Jennings.”

“Yes...” He hesitates as if waiting for me to fill him in on how I already knew that. When I don’t say anything, he goes on to explain, “It just so happens she works at Ashwood. She was his caseworker there. From what

I've gathered, she took him in to live with her and her family—saved him from ending up on the streets.”

Nodding, I lower my head, not really seeing anything as I fiddle with my eyebrow piercing.

In my periphery, Quentin rubs a hand across his mouth before gripping the wheel so hard it creaks. “I didn’t think they’d be here tonight. I might’ve...panicked a little when I spotted Jennings through the crowd. It caught me off guard.”

With all the dryness in the world, I say, “Tell me about it.”

He slants me an unreadable look. “I don’t think she knows who you are. I was going to approach her, pull her to the side and have a chat, but...” He shrugs and looks off in the distance. “Unless Aston told her about you—which I sincerely doubt, given what Bryce told me—”

“Locke?” I say, cutting him off. “Is that who you were arguing with on the phone earlier?”

“Yeah, he’d finally gotten around to calling me back.” He and Bryce Locke, Grady Prep’s headmaster, have been close for years, both having grown up in this town. “I only found out this morning,” he goes on. “I was going to tell you tomorrow. I didn’t want to screw with your head before the game.”

“He can’t seriously be considering allowing this to happen,” I all but growl.

The thinning of Quentin’s lips tells me all I need to know: it’s already a done deal.

“You told him what a bad idea this is, right?”

Now, that’s the understatement of the century...

“All I told him was that you were fostered together as kids, that you both went through something traumatic in the home you shared, and that being in close proximity after all this time could be potentially very distressing. For both of you.”

Distressing.

Looks like I’m not the only one willing to underplay the situation,

“That’s it?”

“That’s it. Anything more would’ve been a huge breach of confidentiality. Which, as I hope you know, I would happily do if it meant keeping you safe. But...”

I'm already nodding as I finish for him, "You can't spill his secrets without spilling mine."

"Exactly."

"I take it that wasn't a good enough reason to get him to change his mind?"

"Nope. Apparently, the paperwork was filed weeks ago, before Aston was even discharged. To get approval, he had to apply to some outreach program. Or rather, it sounds like his new guardian applied for him." He pauses to inhale deeply. "It probably helped that her husband's a teacher here and—"

He cuts himself off and waves his hand in a vague gesture. "You know what, it doesn't really matter. Just bureaucracy bullshit. I won't bore you with the details. Simply put, getting him transferred won't be as easy as I hoped it would be."

I huff a short humorless laugh and turn my face toward the passenger window. "So, what you're saying is I'm fucked."

The parking lot is empty now. It's quiet. My reflection is visible in the glass—shadowy, save for the glint of my piercing. I stare without really seeing anything.

A long moment passes, before Quentin speaks again. "Not...necessarily. We could always, well, go a more...drastic route." If his reluctant tone is anything to go by, he's not a fan of whatever this idea is.

Which means I probably won't be either.

Still, I humor him. Why the fuck not? I'll take any suggestion and consider any solution at this point. Anything to go back to how things were just mere hours ago, when I had no idea my life was about to be upended by a ghost.

I narrow my eyes at nothing. "Such as?"

"A legally binding one."

Frowning, I tear my gaze from the lot, and turn to the man responsible for the cushy, privileged life I live now. "Like a restraining order?"

He nods. "He would then have no choice but to transfer. I'd make sure it's in the terms. Not only that, but it would also forbid him from approaching you outside of school, seeing as he'll still be living here in Crowley regardless. At least, for the time being."

Inhaling deeply, I crack my knuckles and roll the idea around.

I can't deny that a part of me isn't tempted to take him up on the offer, drastic that it may be. It's a fairly clean-cut fix to the problem, one that would help ensure this year goes as planned.

But I also can't ignore the niggling voice in the back of my head outright rejecting the idea. For more than one reason. One of which, Quentin is quick to verbalize.

"However...I do worry what can of worms that might open. Like I was saying before, I don't think his guardian—" He waves a hand. "—caseworker, whatever. I don't think she knows who you are. She knows about your existence, yes, but unless Aston told her your name, it's unlikely she has any clue that the very same boy who was there that night has been living right under her nose these last few years."

I nod. Makes sense. I was a minor. My name would have been redacted from his records.

Quentin pauses for a long moment. Then, "I could speak with her—tell her, if that's something you want. If she truly cares about Aston's well-being, and seeing as she's gone out of her way to not only take him in, but get him enrolled in high school—to experience some semblance of normalcy, pointless at this stage that it may be—then I'm willing to bet she *does*..." He sighs. "It's very possible that if she *did* know what kind of risk this is to his progress, that—"

"What does that mean?" I interject.

He hesitates, before saying, "Bryce could only divulge so much...as I'm sure you can understand."

I nod.

"From the sounds of it, Aston's only progressed as far as he has, because he's repressed so much of what happened to him. All that he's been through... what happened that night...what he did..." He shifts an unreadable look my way. "It's become a sort of taboo topic over the years—his childhood. Specifically, his time living with the Baders. A subject his therapists have noted should be approached with extreme caution, and only if deemed absolutely necessary. With proper... measures in place, so as to ensure no one gets hurt."

Frowning, I look down at my lap, watching blindly as I wring my hands together. "What...what exactly happens? What does he do?"

Quentin doesn't respond for a long moment. "He didn't say. Only that Jennings' wife assured him that Aston is stable...enough. That he's

medicated, and in therapy, and that he's no threat—"

I blink. "Stable... enough..." I reiterate slowly. "So, he's *not* fucking stable?"

At Quentin's pointed look, I wave him off. *Right*. This isn't news. Not to us.

Not to anyone who saw what he did first-hand, whether it be through crime scene photos plastered across a projector in a courtroom...

Or experienced it in its technicolor, high-def, real-time glory.

Hell, I not only *watched* as my twelve—*twelve*—year-old foster brother blindly stabbed a grown man over and over and over again, until you couldn't see any skin left. All the while *laughing* and *singing*.

I wore the damn evidence of his sickness.

I was covered in it.

Carried the stains of it in my nail beds for days. The mental scars even longer.

There's no doubt in my mind that Rick deserved it, but for fuck's sake, has he ever heard of a little thing called restraint?

Glancing down at my palm, I run my finger over the faint, jagged line running just over the meat of my thumb. My eyes flick to the little slashes of discoloration down the insides of my fingers, just under the middle knuckles.

"Nothing screams stable quite like pulverizing a man well beyond his last breath," I mumble, stroking the scar.

Quentin inhales sharply. "What was that?"

"Nothing." I close my hand into a fist and stare straight ahead. "So, what you're telling me is there's a chance he might not even remember me. That he might not *want* to remember me."

My heart pounds at the possibility. I already know it's not likely. The image surging forth of him smiling down at me from the stands—the fervent intensity with which he met my gaze—proves as much.

"It's possible..." Quentin says slowly, but I barely hear him.

Perhaps he was ogling you for reasons that had nothing to do with recognizing you...

It would definitely explain that brief flare of hunger I swear I sensed radiating from him. In fact, it's the only logical explanation.

He liked what he saw *because* I'm a stranger to him.

Because if Aston did recognize me, there's no way in hell he'd feel anything but rage, and maybe disgust. Not after everything...not after that night...not after what came after...

The kind of power this would give me. Over him, over the situation...

Fuck if my traitorous body doesn't like the thought of that far more than it probably should—the idea of him lusting over me, clueless to who I once was to him.

“Which is why I wonder if perhaps we should just...let it go,” Quentin goes on after a moment, pulling me from my thoughts. I don't have to look over to know he's watching me very carefully. Scrutinizing me with that sharp lawyer gaze of his. “At least for now. After all, it's possible that even if he does remember, he might not want anything to do with you. Perhaps he'll come forward about this all on his own, and...I don't know, transfer to Crowley High. For the sake of *his* own mental state, and all the progress *he's* made. In which case, you'd be left completely out of it.”

My simmering blood threatens to boil over once more, and I tell myself it's because I sincerely doubt that'll happen. And not because I don't *want* it to happen.

“For all we know, we're worrying for nothing. He's probably just as unsettled by this turn of events as you are. And that's only if he remembers you at all.”

My jaw clenches as I recall the spark in Aston's eye earlier when our gazes locked.

The tilt of his full pink lips

That hungry, predatory, single-minded focus he had on me...

Something tells me he was watching me long before I spotted him. And if it weren't for being so preoccupied by the game—and so dead set on ignoring anything beyond that—I'm certain I would've caught him watching me. Tracking my every movement.

No. Unsettled is the last word I'd use to describe how he feels about this.

Whether he remembers me or not, it's no matter—something about me piqued his interest.

And that's a very, very dangerous thing. I would know. He was once the center of *my* universe and look where it got me.

“Even if he does remember more than he's led professionals to believe—and he's more self-aware than they give him credit for—he's had *years*

to—”

“Plot his revenge,” I finish flatly.

Quentin sighs. “Vale, that's not—”

“You saw the crime scene photos.” My jaw tightens. “He fucking disemboweled him. Practically carved his heart out. It was a massacre.” I wave my fingers. “Not that Rick didn’t deserve it, but you know what I mean.”

Had it not been for me walking in that night...

I sense more than see the harsh disbelieving look shot my way, and I roll my eyes. “I had every damn right to snoop. It was *my* file.”

He huffs. “No, the file just so happened to contain reports of you as a witness and victim. A *minor* at that.”

I scowl at that. *I’m not a fucking victim.*

“How the hell did you even figure out the code?”

Shrugging, I mumble, “Maybe try to be less predictable.”

He swats the back of my head, and I give him a sharp, slitted look.

Shaking his head, he says, “I don’t know whether to be impressed or worried.”

“If it helps, I know a really good lawyer.”

By his blazing stare, I know he’s not amused.

After a long moment, he says, “May I ask why?”

Another shrug. “I was curious.” *Not a complete lie.*

“About what? You do realize how dangerous that could have been for you, right?”

Dangerous for me, or...

Cracking my neck, I shove away that thought and turn to look out the tinted window. It’s so dark now without all the headlights, making my stone-faced reflection all the more visible.

“Reliving a trauma like that...” Quentin’s voice trails off into another long-winded sigh.

I absently rub at the scar stretched across my palm. “Still here and talking, aren’t I? If I haven’t cracked yet in the two years since I took a peek, I’m pretty sure I’m in the clear.”

He groans. “*Two years?* Jesus Christ, Vale.”

My mouth twitches. I know he’s more annoyed that I got away with it than anything. That I somehow managed to sneak into his office and raid his filing cabinet without him having ever suspected.

“You need to be more careful.”

“I was.” *Obviously.*

“You know what I mean,” he says, voice as serious as ever. “You’re not invincible, as much as you like to think you are. No one is.”

I’d roll my eyes again, but my head is starting to throb.

“You scare me sometimes, Vale.”

Well, that makes one of us.

Fortunately, I have just enough restraint to not voice that retort.

“Sorry,” I say.

Shaking his head, he faces forward once more and drops a hand to the gear shift. “You could at least try to sound sincere, you know.”

My phone goes off with a text alert before he can say anything else, and I dig it out of my front pocket, giving the lock screen a cursory glance before it fades to black once more.

“Seth?”

“Yeah.”

“Wondering where you are?”

I make a soft sound in my throat.

“I’ll take that as a yes,” Quentin says dryly. I hear the distinct sound of him shifting gears and feel a slight jolt just before we’re moving.

Not bothering to reply, I turn the phone face-down in my lap, squeezing it with my scarred hand.

“Vale.”

“Don’t start.”

He sighs. “Fine. But you really should put that poor boy out of his misery.”

I slide him a pointed look. “What did I just say?”

He holds up a hand, thankfully backing off.

It’s a short drive from the school to the abandoned Crowley Iron Furnaces. Only a couple miles away. We spend most of the short drive in comfortable silence.

“So, the restraining order. Yes or no?” Quentin eventually says. “I can put in a call tomorrow and get the ball rolling, if that’s what you want. Or I can just reach out directly to—”

“No,” I say simply, without hesitation. “You’re right, it’s too risky. All either route would do is draw attention back to the case, which is the last thing I need right now.”

It's a long moment before Quentin speaks again. "I should've kept better tabs on him. For that, I'm sorry. This should've never happened."

"There was no logical reason for you to do that. This is just shit luck. You couldn't have predicted it."

To that, he says nothing, but I know he heard me.

The road stretches out before us, empty and dark, save for the sweep of headlights. Soon enough, woods give way to giant cornfields along either side of us.

Slowing the car to a crawl, Quentin steers us into a small easy-to-miss turn-off.

I fling open the passenger door as soon as the car comes to a stop, letting in a rush of chilly air into the SUV, and what sounds to be the muffled bass of some rap song playing from shitty truck speakers somewhere in the distance.

My rib cage expands as I jump out, stretching my limbs, inhaling the sweet, earthy scent of wood and leaves burning into the night air. My nipples bunch under my baggy muscle tee, and I catch the hoodie Quentin throws me.

"Should I expect you home tonight?" Quentin asks loud enough to be heard across the front seat.

Gripping the top of the SUV, I duck down slightly to poke my head in to say, "Probably not."

He shakes his head but is well familiar with this song and dance. Our relationship might not be of the typical parent and child variety, what with him being only fifteen years older than me, but there is a level of respect and trust between us that most don't have.

I know, in a way, it's because I feel like I owe him. I resent that feeling, but it is what it is. Could be a lot worse.

Hell, it *has* been a lot worse

I might be really bad at the whole grateful thing, but I'm not so far up my own ass that I can't see how good I have it.

And it's all because of him.

And Aston...

I quickly slam a steel door against that train of thought.

"I'll call if I need a ride," I tell Quentin, knowing it's what he needs to hear.

He nods, a silent thank you if there ever was one.

Just as I go to shut the door, he stops me.

“Hey, Vale.”

“Yeah?”

“No matter what happens, I have your back. Okay?”

My fingers tense around the doorframe, and I just stare at the man who saved me in too many ways to count.

Throat suddenly dry, I nod. Knowing without a doubt he means that.

“Him being here...back in your life...it doesn’t have to change anything.”

My eyes narrow, because it almost sounds like he’s...warning me. And not just stating the obvious.

“You saying I probably shouldn’t go hunt him down and have beers over our shared trauma?”

Quentin’s mouth tightens at the corners, bleaching his lips. “All I’m saying is if it’s true what Jennings’ wife said about his memories, I can’t imagine it would take much to unlock them. You get what I’m saying?”

Clamping down on my back molars, I nod. “Don’t poke the beast. Got it.”

In other words: steer fucking clear.

As if I hadn’t already vowed to do just that...

Quentin nods back, short and sweet, then throws his hand on the gear shift. “Now, forget this shit and go celebrate. You kicked ass tonight, kid. Penn State’s gotta be foamin’ at the mouth right now.”

“They better be.” Seeing as I’ve got a full-ride there next year, and don’t plan on wasting my rookie season warming the bench.

Throwing the door shut, I turn around and head for the dirt path cutting through the fields, leading toward where all the commotion is coming from. Behind me, I hear Quentin get back on the road, his tires kicking up gravel.

You can’t make out the giant-ass bonfire from the road, not with the cornfields so tall and dense this time of year. But just over the tops of the stalks, a splash of embers explodes across the night sky, smoke billowing, expanding, and disappearing, guiding my way.

Beyond that, there’s the faint outline of the stone stacks making up the retired furnaces, slowly coming into view as my mind replays our conversation.

“Perhaps we should just...let it go. At least for now.”

“For all we know, we’re worrying for nothing.”

And yet, somehow I already see it for the lie it is.

I don't normally make a habit of burying my head in the sand and relying on luck or fate to intervene. Of letting problems—threats—linger like loose ribbons waving in the air. Of relinquishing control to a fickle, uncaring universe.

But I have nine months until I graduate. This time next year, I'll be living halfway across the state, playing college ball, and making a name for myself.

It will be here before I know it. I just have to make do until then.

And nothing—I mean nothing—is going to get in my way.

Least of all, the one person with the power to destroy *everything*.

If I'm lucky, he won't remember me at all.

If I'm lucky, he'll never get the chance.

For both our sakes, I hope so.

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CHAPTER 6

ASTON

“THIS IS SO STUPID. We’re gonna get caught. Why are you *like this*?”

Ignoring Eden’s seemingly never-ending stream of commentary, I bring the binoculars back up to my face, squinting as I dart my eyes all around the party.

Someone was just dropped off. I heard a door open, slam shut, and a couple minutes later, the car drove off. Couldn’t see what kind it was over the cornstalks surrounding us, or who it was that got out, but my skittering heart has me hoping it’s Vale. *Finally*.

Talk about being fashionably late.

But I suppose he’s earned that privilege, being the star quarterback of a winning team and all.

There’s a huff, then, “Where did you even get those?”

“Hm? Oh, these old things?” I say distractedly, realizing he must be talking about the binoculars looped around my neck. I’m practically crawling out of my skin with anticipation as I wait for the newcomer to appear. “They were Gerty’s.”

“Gerty? Hold up, you mean my *grandma*. *Gertrude*? You raided her shit too?”

I roll my eyes, not bothering to lower the binoculars. “Don’t sound so outraged. She’s been dead for how many years? She’d probably be glad someone’s finally getting use out of her things.”

“Have you never heard of boundaries?”

“Mhm,” I say noncommittally, burrowing into my hoodie. It got a lot chillier once the sun went down, and we’re too far from the fire to benefit from it.

When I say nothing more, Eden says, “That’s it? That’s all you have to say.”

“Excuse me for taking life by the horns.”

Valey, Valey, Valey, where are you?

I speak around a yawn. “Come on, you and I both know boundaries don’t really exist. They’re just empty platitudes meant to make you feel in control. Kind of like when someone dies, and you say, ‘Sorry for your loss. If you need anything, let me know.’” I roll my eyes. “No one actually *expects* to be asked to do anything. It’s just a thing you say to be nice and feel like you’re contributing somehow.” I scoff. “As if I’m *actually* going to drop my plans to come over and watch your kids. Be so fucking for real.”

A long moment passes where just music and laughter fill the night.

“Right...” Eden whispers. Then, “Are you sure you’re not just a klepto?”

Blinking, I lower the binoculars, and frown over at Eden. Whereas I’m on my knees, creeping through the floppy stalks, he sits crisscross applesauce, face downcast, peeling a fallen husk. “Kleptos steal. I borrow,” I tell him.

His fingers still, and he lifts his unimpressed gaze to mine. “Borrowed implies you return the things you took.”

I gesture at my chest. “I’m still alive and kickin,’ aren’t I? Didn’t realize I was living on *borrowed* time. Ha, get it. *Borrowed*, because we’re talking about—”

“It also implies permission.”

I scrunch up my face and turn my attention back to the party. I inhale deeply, then—

“Nahhh.”

Eden mutters something *very* unflattering under his breath. I’m just about to lower the binoculars to scold him when a commotion draws my attention across the clearing.

I suck in a breath, straightening. “Ohmygodohmygod, there he is!”

Eden grumbles something I can’t make out—nor do I care to ask him to repeat it.

My new brother is so *chatty* compared to my last one, and I just don’t have the spoons to sponge up every. Single. *Thing* that comes out of his precious mouth.

Leaning forward, I poke my head through the stalks as far as I'm willing to risk it. I use my elbows to part the drooping leaves, giving myself an uninhibited view of Vale's grand entrance.

Firelight from the raging bonfire dances over his chiseled profile and exposed biceps as he crosses the clearing and greets his jock buddies with back slaps and hand clasps.

Meanwhile, I'm practically melting into the dirt.

Because as delicious as he looked in his tight little football uniform earlier, I can't deny that I wasn't low-key *dying* to see what he was hiding under those bulky shoulder and chest pads. Heck, it's half the reason why we're currently hiding in a cornfield, spying on a party we weren't invited to.

And let me tell you—I am *not* disappointed.

No siree.

How could I be, when he struts in all fashionably late looking like a wet dream in dark jeans and an oversized black muscle tee, a burgundy hoodie slung over his shoulder.

So loosely fit and stretched out around the shoulders, the cut off shirt not only puts his toned arms on full display, but exposes his entire side to me anytime he lifts his arm. Gifting me a tantalizing peek of well-defined lat muscles and smooth tan flesh swirling with dark ink. A little more swish to the side, and I'd get a flash of a nipple.

Talk about a *tease*.

If I wasn't still so gobsmacked by the mere sight of him after all these years, I'd probably feel a *teensy-weensy* bit self-conscious in the face of all that glorious muscle.

Ha! As. If.

All the easier for him to throw me around when he has his wicked way with me, methinks.

I drag my teeth over my lip, putting a pin on *that* visual for later.

Next to me, Eden shifts impatiently, and I'm dimly aware of him saying, "There. You saw him. Happy? Can we leave now?"

The pulse-thudding music that was playing is cranked up, crackling from the truck parked over by the stone stacks. I don't recognize the song. I don't typically listen to rap. But I can't deny the energy it exudes isn't a tad addictive—all violent and primal, making me feel downright *bad ass*.

I watch as a tall, broad blond dude wearing a backwards baseball hat lumbers up to Vale, shoving a red Solo cup at him. Vale glances down at it before taking a long sip, and even from all the way over here, I don't miss the little scrunch of his face.

Not a fan of beer?

Can't say I blame him, if it tastes anything like it smells. I wrinkle my nose just thinking about it.

The guy who handed it to him punches him in the shoulder, grinning around whatever he says that gets an eye roll from Vale. I vaguely remember him from the game, catching the balls Vale would throw. He's still in his jersey. *Shrute, #42.*

"Mom texted," Eden tells me. "Wants to know how it's going. She also wants us to bring her something back."

"Tell her it's packed, but we'll try," I murmur distractedly.

After I overheard some girls in the parking lot following the game talking about a bonfire happening in the fields—or rather at some place called the *furnaces*—I tugged Eden back, demanding he give me all the deets while his parents walked on ahead.

Apparently it's where the team always goes after a game, be it to celebrate a win or mourn a loss. And where the team goes...Vale goes...

And where Vale goes...

Eden warned me that we wouldn't be welcome. It's for the popular crowd only. But I just waved off his silly concerns and began plotting our mission.

If there's one thing I've learned since moving in, it's that Tillie is desperate for Eden to get out more—make friends, have a social life... instead of spending all his time hiding away in his room, being all emo and anti-social and secretive.

And Walt is whipped as *fuck*. He gives into pretty much whatever his wife wants. Especially if it's something that benefits his son.

But allowing their underage son and mentally unstable ward to attend a kegger...yeah, I didn't think they'd be too keen to agree to that.

So, once we got home, with a little bit of coaxing and *pretty, pretty please-ing*, we managed to convince Tillie to hand over the keys to her Beetle, so he and I could go get ice cream.

Eden only recently got his license, and being that he's a minor, he has to be off the roads by eleven. We probably only have another hour, if that.

Just then a slim figure approaches Vale from behind.

I growl at the sight.

Eden sighs.

“Who the fuck wears khakis and a polo to a bonfire?” I mutter, lip curling as I watch what’s-his-name slinking up behind Vale, wrapping his twiggy arms around his waist. A very snappable arm at that.

The *boyfriend*.

In the midst of everything—everything mostly consisting of me trying to hide a boner from the impressionable townspeople—I’d forgotten about the little...creatin.

It might just be wishful thinking, but I swear Vale stiffens, a flicker of *something* playing over his harsh, firelit profile—and not a *good* something. But a something that is further confirmed by the way it takes him a half-a-second longer than it probably should to lower the cup from his mouth and greet the guy he’s allegedly dating.

I gasp. “Is that an *eyebrow piercing*???”

I’m so fucked. So fuckety fucked.

Eden shushes me and smacks my arm, but I barely notice now that Vale’s finally, *finally* facing my direction head-on for the first time since that too-brief moment at the game. Except this time, I get to take my time cataloging every inch of his face unbeknownst to him.

If I thought he was gorgeous all sweaty and flushed and streaked with black paint under his eyes...

He’s downright lethal when cleaned up. All harsh, rigid lines and high sculpted cheekbones; smoldering dark eyes and pouty lips I want to chew on.

Throw in tattoos and piercings, and at this rate, Eden’s going to have to pick my jaw up off the floor and wipe me down because *Hot. Damn.*

Dat face.

Dat ass.

Dat whooollleeee package.

The tell-tale buzzing of a phone cuts into the night. “Shit,” Eden mumbles, hurrying to answer it.

I whip my head around. “What are you doing?” I whisper-shout. I shake my head and make slashing motions with my hand. *Don’t pick up, don’t pick up, don’t—*

He picked up.

Pushing to a stand, he rakes a hand through his hair, turning his back to me as he answers. I strain my ears to hear what he's saying.

"Uh, no, they're out of th-that." A beat, then a smidge louder, he says, "I'm...not. I just—we're *fine*, I promise." Another longer pause as he listens to whatever Tillie is saying. "Yeah, he's..." He narrows his eyes at me. "Not any weirder than usual," he says dryly.

My jaw drops. *Rude!* I claw at the air with my hand, snapping my teeth together.

He shakes his head, hanging it, letting his hair fall across his cheeks. "Okay. Yeah, we're, uh, leaving n—"

"We can't leave," I blurt in a harsh whisper. We should still have a half hour left before we have to head out. And a *lot* can happen in half an hour.

Eden's jaw works, and he peers at me from under his lashes.

I cock my head. *He's got really pretty lashes. Long and thick. They'd—Focus!*

Shaking my head, I mouth, *Please*, giving him my best puppy dog eyes. These suckers have gotten me many perks over the years. Combine them with another kind of *sucker-ing*, and it's all but impossible to tell me no.

Not that any sucking of the mouth variety will be happening here. Legalities aside, something tells me my new brother wouldn't take so kindly to the idea.

With a scowl, Eden lowers his head and mumbles into the phone, "Can we please stay?"

Whatever Tillie says has his shoulders balling up tightly, and his eyes growing hard as they lift to mine in a surprisingly vicious glare. "No, Mom," he says through his teeth, "he's not forcing me. I do have a mind of my own, you know?" A pause, then—

"There's a girl here I like, okay?" he rushes out, the words running together.

My eyes bug, and I gape at him.

That...

That is *not* what I expected him to say.

"Are you happy?" he says to her. Jaw working, face shiny and red, nostrils flaring, he nods shortly. "Great. Will do. Promise. Bye."

Once the call's disconnected, he locks the screen, rucking up his oversized Anthrax hoodie to shove the phone back in his pocket. He mumbles something under his breath, and I catch words like *regret* and *pay*.

When he realizes I've yet to say anything, he glances over with a frown. "What? Was that excuse not good enough for you?"

I blink. "You...you're *straight*?"

He curls his lip at me. "I only said that so she'd let us stay out a little longer. And it worked."

"But..." I look around at a loss. "Why not at least make it *believable* and say it was a boy?"

His eyes narrow. "What makes you think I'm not straight?"

I give him a droll, pointed look that says, *Really?*

He scowls, shifting in place. Clearly uncomfortable. Despite the defensiveness in his body language, his eyes...they're swirling with an emotion akin to curiosity. And something else...something I can't place.

Something that has images of what I discovered in his room the other day surging to the forefront of my mind.

And if the beet-red hue of his cheeks is anything to go by, he knows *exactly* what I'm thinking.

"Swear to me you won't tell."

"Depends..."

"Depends on what?"

"What I get out of it."

"Fuck off," he grits out quietly, pulling me from the memory. "Maybe I'm bi. Ever think of that?"

Ignoring that, I say, "Honestly?" I lift a shoulder. "You *do* have the perfect lips for sucking dick. So can you blame me for assuming?"

Now, he's the one with his jaw on the floor, said full lips parting like they've been summoned to do their thang. Sputtering and red-faced, he goes to whirl around and storm off, when I reach over and stop him with a tug on his sleeve. "Don't worry. The only lips that will be touching my dick in the foreseeable future are Vale's."

Eden stumbles. Ripping out of my hold, he turns to face me, his expression one of horror. "Your *brother*???" he all but shrieks.

Oh shit.

Our gazes snap together, eyes wide and panicked.

There's a rustle from somewhere way too close. "Did you hear that?"

Eden grabs me by the wrist and yanks me to a stand with far more strength than I figured he'd be capable of. We sweep our dark surroundings, my binoculars falling from my hands to dangle in front of my chest. Closer

than before, there's a crunch and crackle of sticks and withered leaves. And a loud whisper—

"I think someone's over here."

Uh oh.

Eden slumps, arms hanging lifelessly at his sides. I encircle his wrist with my fingers and start dragging him between stalks away from the party, and hopefully away from whoever was about to stumble upon us. Finding one of the many narrow paths woven throughout.

Just when I think we're in the clear, there's a yelp just as Eden's arm is ripped from my hold.

Momentum carries me forward a few steps, before I stumble to a stop.

"Well, what do we have here?"

Whirling around, I find a hunched, pale, trembling Eden sandwiched between two smirking, towering walls of muscle.

"Oh, hello, boys," I greet sweetly, straightening to my full height. "Fancy running into you here. Come often?"

And because I can't help myself, I wag my brows at them. "Get it? *Come often?*"

The Black guy who I recognize from the game as someone Vale would often pass the ball to—and the first player from their team to reach Vale when the final whistle blew, all but tackling him to the grass—flits a bemused look at his glassy-eyed, rosy-cheeked friend.

White and bulkier than his buddy, with freckles and frizzy red hair, I don't remember seeing him earlier. But based on the tight-fitting gray shirt he wears, with the burgundy and black Archers logo I recognize from all over the place in this town, I'm going to assume he's on the team too.

He sure is big enough to be.

He's also the first to say something—revealing he's the one who spoke before too.

"You're Jennings' kid, aren't you?" he says, eyeing Eden up and down. "What are you, like, twelve?"

Eden's cheeks darken, and he quickly shakes his head, his shoulder-length, tangled hair swinging side to side. "I—"

"He's with me," I cut in confidently, jutting my chin out. "And he's seventeen." *Almost...* His birthday's not until next week, but I don't tell them that.

The Black guy arches me a look. "And you are?"

Just as I go to open my mouth to introduce myself, we're joined by several others, only one of which I recognize.

"Yo, what's up?" Behind Shrute, with a manicured hand splayed over his chest, is a girl with long wavy auburn hair, wearing a black and burgundy track suit.

Cheerleader, I silently surmise, when I notice two other girls dressed just like her crowding her back. I dimly remember seeing them bouncing around, yelling, and throwing each other up in the air during the game. They're still in their uniforms, unlike the guys. God forbid we forget their role in life.

Not taking his dark, glittering eyes off me, the Black guy answers, "Found a couple party crashers spying on us."

Shrute starts to laugh as his gaze darts between Eden and me. I lift a hand, wiggling my fingers at him in a wave. "Howdy."

He cocks his head. "You don't go to Grady."

"Not ye-et," I sing.

He frowns, but recognition seems to bowl over him a second later, and his eyes widen. Face blanching.

Interesting...

Narrowing my eyes, I watch as he leans toward the Black guy, and whispers something in his ear.

His brows spike. "That so..." he murmurs, his grip on Eden going slack. The redhead frowns at them, brow knitting. Unlike his buddy though, he tightens his hold on their poor little hostage.

"Hey!" I bark, taking a step forward. "You're hurting him."

The thick fingers around Eden's slim shoulder are bone-white. Too white. And Eden's face is pulled tight in a wince, his other, now-free shoulder hiked practically to his ear.

Gingersnap eyes me up and down with a familiar, dangerous sort of grin. "Oh yeah, and what are you gonna do about it?"

Even from a couple feet away, I can smell the whiskey wafting from his breath and pores. My mouth waters, and not in a good way.

Forcing a small smile, I casually meander my way into his space, not taking my eyes off the bleary narrowed ones I hold captive. I vaguely register someone talking—telling *Murphy* to let *the kid* go. But I pay whoever it is no notice.

Tilting my head, I hum softly under my breath as I approach the side of him not blocked by Eden. I lift a finger to drag around his insanely thick neck, his creamy white skin hot and clammy and *squishy*.

One...

Two...

Just as he tenses, and before he can snap to his senses, I quickly push up on my toes and lean my mouth against his ear. Whisper-singing the next part. "...he's a comin' for you..."

He stiffens. "The fuck?"

Next thing I know, I've got two sweaty, meaty hands gripping me by the collar, practically yanking me off my feet. Putting me nose to nose with red shiny crossed eyes and a sea of mottled freckles.

I'm laughing as he shakes me, and someone shouts something.

I think it's in warning.

Too bad for Gingersnap here, he doesn't realize the warning's not for me...

But *him*.

Grinning wildly, I lean up all close to him and stare into his eyes as I wait for him to notice the sharp point of a knife prodding ever so slightly at his belly. I'd like to think his reaction time is a *teensy-weensy* bit better when he's sober, because if not, somebody's gotta tell Coach they've got some dead weight on their hands.

I prod a little deeper, as calm and cheery as ever.

There it is.

His eyes flicker and flare. *Finally. Jesus H. Christ on a stick, does he want me to gut him like a fish?*

Jocks, I tell ya. Some of them really do live up to the stereotype.

He looks down between us, his whole body going utterly still.

A satisfied purr rumbles from my throat. "Touch him again," I murmur, "and you'll be gathering your intestines from the dirt." And because I'm so close, and it's been *weeks* since I've had any semblance of physical affection...not since good ol' Brucey petted and stroked my hair while I sucked him off in the storage closet...

Well, can you blame me for giving this chin a lil smooch?

It's *right there*, you know?

And he's so still, so pliant, *so completely and totally at my mercy*—

"What the fuck is going on?"

And just like that, everything grinds to a halt.

Even the crickets that were chirping up a storm all night seem to go, *Oh shiiiiittt, son*, and scatter.

I don't have to look to confirm who that deep voice belongs to.

Now that the little spell I was under has effectively been broken, my senses return with a vengeance. And I can *feel* him—his sudden proximity a thrumming live wire that has the little hairs on my neck standing upright.

A breathless smile overtakes my face. "Vale."

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CHAPTER 7

VALE

I'VE GOTTA hand it to the little psycho.

It took me far longer than it should have to notice I was being watched. Stalked.

So caught up in forcing pleasantries when I arrived, and still reeling from my conversation with Quentin, it wasn't until Seth joined me that I felt it.

The eyes boring holes into my head.

Admittedly, I truly didn't expect him to ambush me so soon after reappearing in my life. So soon after I vowed to avoid him. Especially, when I still didn't know for sure if he even recognized me.

But this is Aston we're talking about. It's not like he had a lobotomy since the last time I saw him. I wouldn't be so lucky.

I should've known better than to assume he'd outgrow his...ways. Or to trust the universe to not screw me epically.

How he learned I'd be here—hell, how he even learned about the Furnaces—doesn't take too much of a stretch to figure out. It had to be the Jennings kid.

It's not like it's a secret we hang here. Partying at the Iron Furnaces is a Grady Prep upperclassmen tradition, going all the way back to when the school was instated. Which was only a year after this plant was closed, and iron and steel production was shifted closer to the city. The beginning of the fall of Crowley as a booming industrial town.

Rather than give Aston the attention he no doubt came for, I'd used Seth for cover as I did a quick, perusing sweep of my surroundings, busying myself with a lingering kiss to his head.

He would spy from the shadows like a coward...

Shoving all thoughts of Aston to the back of my mind in favor of turning my focus on my boyfriend, I'd led Seth toward the privacy of the shadowy stacks. Figuring getting my dick wet would relax me some. But no sooner than he dropped to his knees and freed my cock, we heard it. A panicked shout.

And somehow I just *knew*.

Before I even registered what I was doing, I had my dick tucked away and my sweatshirt thrown on to free up my hands, and I was storming past the fire, gaze locked on the people converging at the mouth of the main path cutting through the fields. The one I followed from the road, bisected deep with tire-formed craters from all the cars and trucks that have come and gone over the years.

The one I follow now.

Narrow, man-made pathways indicated by old, trampled stalks and shoeprint-mottled dirt branch off every which way. Some lead back to the main road, but most come to a dead end, like the one currently setting the stage for tonight's source of entertainment.

My steps slow as I draw closer, brow furrowed in curiosity as the scene playing out comes into view. All the while, I'm dimly aware of Seth catching up to me, crowding my back, murmuring questions that flutter aimlessly around my awareness like cobwebs to be swatted away.

I spot Murphy first with his back to me. Even with nothing but the stars, moon, and pulsing light of the fire to go by—and the handful of lit-up phones recording—he's impossible to miss with that shock of frizzy orange hair.

Standing off to the side of his wide frame, I spot Fletch easing back behind Casey who's got his hands out like he's trying to calm a cornered animal. He's saying something, but I only catch snippets of it.

"Calm down."

"He's sorry."

"...drunk...didn't mean to."

"...an idiot."

Intermingling with this, other words traveling in a hush through the crowd vie for my attention.

"Ashwood."

"Crazy."

“Knife.”

“Motherfucker.”

“Knife.”

“Knife.”

“Knife.”

And I mumble under my breath, “Are you fucking kidding me?”

This has to be a joke.

Almost six years.

Six years of fucking peace destroyed in a matter of hours.

Shouldering my way through the bodies clogging my path, I hardly spare them a glance. Some start to bitch as I knock them out of my way but seem to think better of it when they realize who it is.

Slowly, but surely, my presence is noted by the others, and the crowd parts like butter. Granting me a direct path to where I now notice a fourth figure, shorter and slighter than the rest. But not the short and slight one responsible for the drama unfolding.

Jennings’ kid. Whatever his name is.

I frown, eyes glancing right over him, sweeping past Murph’s hulking figure. His back is angled to me just enough that I don’t immediately see who’s on the other side of him.

But when I do, I see red.

What the actual fuck?

I round Fletch and Casey just as Aston leans up, neck craned as far back as it can go.

And what the does the little lunatic do?

He presses a kiss to Murph’s chin. A kiss.

And for the second time tonight, impulse steals the reins from me faster than you can say, *Idiot*.

“What the fuck is going on?”

The demand rings out harshly into the night, effectively silencing everyone. I come to a stop several feet behind Aston, ensuring his back is to me, and cross my arms and wait. My heart racing faster than it has any damn right to.

And all I can think is—

I thought I’d have more time.

To prepare.

To have an escape plan in place, in case of emergency.

To figure out what the fuck I'm going to do—say—when we inevitably cross paths.

Just...time.

Was it really only hours ago that I was warming up for the game?

Leave it to my human wrecking ball of an ex-foster brother to uproot everything in record time. So much for any hope of him maturing during his time away. If an insane asylum couldn't wrangle him into submission, it's doubtful anything will at this point.

Murph snaps out of his stupor first. Blinking wildly, he shoves Aston off him, throwing himself back and furiously wiping his face. Aston's back is to me, but near his thigh, I catch a flash of metal, just before it disappears. His shoulder shifts, like he's shoving whatever it is in the pocket of his jeans.

A quick scan of Murph as he staggers drunkenly away shows no sign of blood.

That's something at least.

Knowing him, he won't even remember this come tomorrow. Though I'm sure this will be blasted all over socials for him to watch and get pissed off about later.

I try to find it in me to care. I know I should.

I know I *do*...

But probably not for the right reasons.

Luckily, there's no service here for anyone to livestream. As for any photos or videos taken... I make a mental note to deal with that later.

Because right now? Right now, Aston St. James finally decided to grace me with his attention. And I don't miss the way he finger-combs and fluffs his hair before turning around—primping himself like this is a date, and not a fucking shitstorm in the making.

Just don't poke the beast.

There's still a chance he doesn't know you—remember you.

Don't give him anything.

Just as soon as Aston's gaze lands on my face and he greets me with a blinding smile, I swing all my attention to the Jennings kid, who looks like he's seconds from either stroking out or shitting a brick. "What the fuck are you two doing here?"

His mouth parts, closes, and he stutters as he tries to get words out. "I-I—we—I mean—"

A lanky arm clad in light blue cotton comes around him, hugging him protectively. My brow twitches at the sight, my chest tightening with some foreign feeling.

Or rather, a feeling I haven't felt in a very long time. One that has me balling my hands into fists so tight, my nails dig into my palms hard enough to leave marks.

"You shouldn't be here," I say flatly, coldly.

The crowd shifts. Nervous titters fill the air. I drag a glare over the various gawking faces, and some actually have the brains to scurry off. Those who don't are quickly ushered off by a couple guys from the team.

And then there's the girls.

I glance over at the four cheerleaders still lingering, all named Alicia except for one.

Alicia Michaelson, Alicia Graves, and their self-proclaimed ringleader, Alicia Devereaux.

Together, they make up what the school—even teachers—refer to unironically as the Alicias. Your typical high school power-hungry, mean girl clique who feeds on drama and the ridicule of those seen as beneath them. Which is just about everyone.

Sensing me watching her, Devereaux glances over. She doesn't lower the phone she uses to record what's unfolding, but her trademark smirk does soften somewhat, edging into something a little less cruel and far more devious. Flirty, even, at having caught my attention.

Ignoring it like I always do, I give Casey a pointed look, and he nods, turning to whisper in Thea's ear, before giving her a quick kiss and squeeze of her ass.

"Shots!" she yells, grabbing Devereaux, and all but dragging her and the other Alicias away, despite the former's initial protests. In the end, the lure of alcohol wins out. That and the fact Thea's not scared of Devereaux in the least, unlike most girls we go to school with. Something, I think even the queen bitch herself appreciates.

Murph stumbles after them, practically face-planting in his rush to get out of here. Over the breeze rustling the field, I hear him mumble about needing a strong drink after that.

"Vale?"

Fuck.

Forgot about Seth.

Turning toward him, I murmur for his ears only, “Go on. I’ll meet back up with you after we deal with this.” He hesitates, but I give him an encouraging nod, lips pressed into a tight, unforgiving line. The closest thing to a reassuring smile I’m capable of right now.

He pushes up his glasses, nods, and scurries off.

I blow out a breath and rake my fingers through my hair.

A low whistle fills the air, and I tense.

Not about to entertain whatever *he’s* about to say, I turn to Fletch. “What happened?”

Tugging his earlobe, he shrugs. “Murph and I were taking a piss, and—”

Casey snorts. “Together?”

I glance sharply at him, and he rolls his eyes, not even bothering to hide his smirk. He’s drunk. Otherwise, this would’ve already been handled. Another reason why I keep him close. He might come off like an airhead, but he’s a hell of a mediator. Can diffuse almost any situation.

“Fine, we were gonna smoke a blunt,” Fletch amends.

Figures.

I don’t bother lecturing him. Not my place. If they want to risk failing a drug test, that’s their prerogative. It isn’t as if we haven’t been through this before. At best, he’ll get a slap on the wrist. At worst, he’ll be benched a game or two.

“But Murph heard something,” he goes on. “Voices. So, he went to investigate, and I followed. Found these two making a break for it.” He chuckles a little nervously. “We were just messin’ with them. I swear. Murph just—”

“He was hurting my brother.”

An eerie stillness washes over me, and I fight a shiver that has very little to do with how cold it is away from the fire.

On the outside, my reaction is probably not that noticeable. But inside... inside, my pulse jackknives as memories surge forth, threatening to crash over the present, and suck me down into their murky depths.

I distract myself with focusing on how...different, but also familiar his voice is. Smoother, and only a little deeper than it was last time I heard it. At least, last time I heard it under normal circumstances, and not the high-pitched, childish, hysteric way he spoke before the cops dragged him out.

Still, beneath that, there’s a...pointed sort of softness to it that feels...

Dangerous.

And full of meaning I'd rather not try to decipher.

"Brother?" Casey says at the same time Fletch holds a hand up and says, "Whoa, okay, that wasn't me. We were just messing with ya." More nervous laughter escapes him as he directs his next words at me. "Murph, man. You know how he gets when he's drunk. Dude just got carried away."

"Yep, Eden's my brother. My newest one," Aston announces proudly, and pointedly, paying no mind to Fletch's shitty excuses. "In fact..."

Fuck.

Well, that answers that.

Question now is...how *much* does he remember?

"Whatever," I interject loudly. "He's too young to be here. And we don't even know—"

"Is it true you were a patient at Ashwood?" Casey blurts suddenly, cutting me off.

If Aston was going to call me out on my bullshit, my best friend's point-blank, and arguably insensitive question, effectively nips that whole concern in the bud.

For a long moment, no one says anything. The tension filling the silence is so thick, it's stifling. Makes it hard to breathe evenly and not betray my rapidly growing unease. All the other sounds that had fallen to the background suddenly seem louder.

The pulse-thudding music.

The rustling of leaves.

The faint spikes of laughter and crackle of firewood.

It all returns in stark clarity, taking center-stage.

"What do you know about that?"

Casey shuffles awkwardly, telling me this time the danger lacing Aston's misleadingly soft tone doesn't go unnoticed. "Um. Forget I said anything. That was rude. I'm drunk."

Again, the silence in the wake of his words is near-painful. With every second that passes as I wait to see how Aston will react, the dread sitting like a pit in my stomach sinks deeper.

As a kid, I'd mastered the art of reading him. He was unpredictable at times, sure—more often than not as we got older—but there was a pattern to it if you were paying close enough attention.

This version of Aston though is a wildcard. He might as well be a stranger. And that's not even taking into consideration what Quentin disclosed on the drive here.

Finally, Aston breaks the silence, an obnoxious burst of laughter exploding out of him.

Irritation wars with the prickle of unease it triggers. The last time I heard him laugh, we were covered in blood, with a freshly butchered corpse laid out between us.

Eyes wide, Casey slowly pivots his head toward me. And mouths, *What the fuck?*

Clamping down on my molars, I give a little shake of my head, before aiming a glare up at the stars winking back at me. Taunting me with the illusion of closeness—giving me the impression I could rip them from the sky with my bare hands.

Because who else is to blame, other than the cosmos, for this sick joke.

"Relaxxxxx," Aston drawls once he manages to compose himself. "So, you heard I was in the looney bin. It's the twenty-first century, babes. The world's shit. We're all a little cuckoo for Cocoa Puffs." He sniffs, and in my periphery, I catch him inspecting his nails. "Some just more than others."

I don't miss the way the Jennings' kid—*Eden*, Aston called him—grows even more tense, and I wonder if he's afraid of his *new brother*. I have no doubt he was forced here. Blackmailed somehow. Tonight is far from the first time he had a run-in with one of the guys from the team. He'd never willingly walk into the lion's den.

Aston doesn't know that though.

And even if Eden did tell him... Well, it clearly wasn't enough to make Aston reconsider bringing him. No, that would require exercising some sympathy. When he's only ever been capable of experiencing a basic level of empathy.

And that makes a hell of a difference. I would know.

"You had a knife," Fletch murmurs, drawing me from my musings.

"And did I hurt anyone with it?" Aston fires back.

"Well, no. But—"

"What if I was carrying a gun?" He twirls his finger in the air. It's only then I notice what's draped around his neck—binoculars.

What the fuck?

“Don’t think I didn’t spot that bulge Murph was sporting. Unless you want to tell me he’s got a spare *member* growing from his hip that was just happy to see me.”

Casey snorts, while I wrench my gaze to a gaping Fletch.

“He’s got his gun on him?”

His lips fumble with a response that won’t come, and he rapidly shakes his head. Then, finally, he manages to get out, “I-I have no idea.”

I scowl. “Go fucking find him and confiscate that shit. Hand it over to one of the DDs. He’s drunk off his ass. Him accidentally blowing his or someone else’s brains is the last thing I—we—need.”

Not picking up on my near-slip, he nods stiffly, and leaves.

“A twink like me’s gotta protect himself somehow,” Aston drawls. Arms crossed, nose turned up at the sky when I turn to face him, he looks ever the melodramatic brat he was as a kid.

The Jennings kid at his side mumbles something under his breath, too quiet for me to make out, but it has Aston dropping his arms and turning on him with a gasp. “Eden! Watch your mouth. You’re lucky it’s so—”

I turn to Casey. “Can you, like, get them out of here? Make sure they don’t get lost.”

He nods.

“Wait.”

Plastering on a look of bored indifference, I turn an arched, expectant brow on Aston, finally giving him a little taste of what he wants by meeting his gaze head-on.

A spark of surprised satisfaction briefly widens his green eyes.

Yeah, I’m not fucking scared of you.

As if he can read my thoughts, his lips twitch with the makings of a smile.

Eyes glittering with a mix of challenge and something else—something hot and dangerous that I refuse to acknowledge—he sucks his bottom lip into his mouth and dips his chin just enough so that he has to peer at me through his thick lashes.

It should look ridiculous—this whole sweet and naive flirtatious act. But I know the truth. And all it serves to do is make me see red.

It’s a taunt. Nothing more. Nothing less.

When he’s yet to say anything, I clip out a short, “What?”

Running his teeth across his plush bottom lip, he saunters toward me. Two feet separate us.

Then, one.

Then, inches.

He's so close now, that if I wasn't holding my breath, all I would smell is *him*.

And that's the very last thing I need right now, when I'm barely managing to keep the memories at bay. Barely able to ignore the way my cock twitches at the sight of his shiny full lips up close. That lean, lithe body, broader and only slightly taller than he was years ago. That pale delicate neck just begging for my fingers. My teeth.

It makes me want to throw up. This instantaneous attraction to the last person on Earth I should be lusting after. This...primal, blinding surge of *want*, trampling what I know to be true and logical.

Makes me want to grab him by the hair and force him to his knees and punish him.

Makes me want to snap his neck while my cum is still clinging to his lips, my dick still out and hard and slick with his spit... and the last thing he sees before the light fades from his eyes.

Either he's oblivious to what his proximity is doing to me—to the twisted thoughts and cravings circling my mind like sharks—or he doesn't give two shits.

My bet's on the latter.

If the twinkle of laughter shining from his sage eyes is anything to go by, whatever he senses lurking behind my stony exterior seems to greatly amuse him. Like this is all just a fun game to him—like we're picking up right where we left off years ago, with him staking claim on the next roll of the dice.

"Thank you," he eventually says.

"For what?" I mutter stiffly, ignoring how tempting his full lips look.

"Well, for coming to my rescue of course," he says innocently, batting his eyes. "Do you always just—" He makes a flicking motion with his fingers. "—swoop in and save all the boys?"

My eyes narrow.

I didn't save him.

If anything, I prevented a massacre.

Before I can think better of it, I find myself responding, “Only when I get something out of it.”

His brows fly up, and I’m distantly aware of Casey coughing to mask his startled laugh.

“That so?” Aston murmurs so quietly, I’m certain the words aren’t meant for me. Then, “Tell me, *Vale*.”

Fucking hell. Biting the tip of my tongue, I will my expression to remain blank.

“What *do* you get out of it?” His mouth twitches, and I can practically hear the two words he’s biting back. *This time*.

I give a bored, unimpressed once-over. “Honestly?” Our eyes lock. “I just didn’t want my best linebacker to risk getting expelled for kicking your ass. The team can’t afford to lose him if we have any chance of winning States this year.”

Not interested in the least to hear his response, I spin away from him. But not before I catch his lips part and brows scrunch, telling me that was the last thing he thought I’d say.

I inhale a much needed breath through my flared nostrils. Despite the fact he’s nowhere near me now, I swear I catch a lingering note of sweetness trailing on the breeze.

Like candy.

Like sugar.

But there’s something else there too, tainting it.

Something metallic.

Bitter.

He calls something out after me, but whatever it is gets washed out by the roar filling my ears.

Rounding the corner, I stalk back the way I came, being careful to avoid the tire-formed trenches.

Up ahead, the fire blazes on—embers dancing in the night. Drunken laughter and pounding music welcome me back to a world that feels more foreign than ever.

A world that no longer feels like *mine*...

Smoke trails on a gust of wind blowing through, burning my nostrils. Not unlike that sweet, yet bitter and metallic scent I haven’t thought about in years—the scent that’s haunted me, catching me unaware as I hovered on the edge of sleep.

A scent I know that isn't actually here right now—doesn't actually cling to him *now*—but is present all the same.

Souring the air around me. Spoiling it.

It closes in on me, surrounding me, *smothering* me.

It makes me restless.

Jumpy.

Out of control.

Makes me want to turn around.

Makes me want to hunt Aston down and make him pay—make him *hurt*.

For all the things no one else can pay penance for.

Only him.

Only the one who was there.

Only the one still breathing.

Blackness tinges my vision as I stride purposefully for the keg. I hate beer—especially this cheap sour-tasting shit—but right now it'll have to do. I'm too impatient to search for the liquor that I know is being passed around.

I'm vaguely aware of an approaching figure and have just enough wherewithal to relax so I don't flinch when Seth's arms come around me. He croons something in my ear, pressing cool, sticky, wet lips to my neck.

My jaw ticks, nostrils flaring. Gulping down my cup of foamy piss water in two long pulls, I crush the cup and toss it, replacing it with Seth's chilly, damp hand.

He says something else, slurs it really. *Must've got into the good stuff while I was gone...*

But whatever it is, it gets lost in the pressure continuing to steadily build. Pressure that needs to be released.

I lead him back to where we were before when we were so kindly interrupted—back before I *stupidly* let myself get involved, when I knew better. I *knew* better.

I could've easily done nothing and just focused on the promise of a hot mouth on my cock. But no, I just had to throw myself into Aston's path.

Now, I all but shove Seth behind the stacks, deep into the shadows where no one passing us can see. I crowd him against the stone wall, grip his throat, and grind against him. I'm so hard, I could cut through the steel these furnaces used to produce.

Seth makes breathy little whines and moans, fingers scrambling at my arms. My back...

Diving beneath my shirt.

With a grunt, I force him to turn around as I make quick work of pulling myself out. Seth, not hesitating in the least, shoves his stupid pressed khakis down right along with his boxer briefs.

While he gets himself ready, I dig out a condom from my wallet, ripping the wrapper open with my teeth.

It's in the forties tonight, and yet I'm *sweltering*. Even away from the blazing fire.

Sweat clings to my temples.

My heart is racing.

My flesh feels too tight for my bones.

But I don't waste time ridding myself of the sweatshirt.

When Seth's pleading and assuring me he's ready—spit-soaked fingers slipping free of his hole with a wet *squelch*—I don't waste a second, shoving into him without any sort of warning or preamble. Bottoming out.

I don't wait for him to adjust. I take him with deep, rough thrusts that have our flesh smacking loudly and obscenely. Whether or not he's enjoying it doesn't even occur to me.

I just need this thing...this *wrongness* out of me before I put my fists through the stone wall we fuck against.

Burying my face against Seth's neck, I clench my teeth together to trap the ragged sound trying to escape my throat.

I wish he smelled like beer, I think.

Beer would be preferable to whatever sugary drink is working through his system right now, wafting from his pores, making it impossible to think of anything but *him*... Aston.

And everything I've tried to bury these last six years.

All while I fuck my boyfriend, it's Aston's lips I see.

Aston's throat.

Aston's hands.

I don't even bother trying to shove the images back. Nor do I try to convince myself I'm not sick in the fucking head for getting off on it—the violence, the fantasy of taking the power from Aston, making him beg and cry for me to stop while simultaneously moaning from the pleasure-pain of being at *my* mercy.

I know I am. Sick, that is.

Disgusting.

Wrong.

Moans and grunts surround me, but it might as well be coming from miles away—from bodies that aren't mine or the one I rail into.

"Do you always just swoop in and save all the boys?"

I didn't fucking save you.

I didn't.

Childish laughter fills my head. Singing...

The giggles laced with hysteria as he rocked back and forth.

The past bleeds through the present, eroding and distorting the fantasy, reminding me who he is. Not just some pretty stranger I met in a field who sparked interest in a way so few rarely manage to do...

But a walking reminder of the worst moments of my life.

The blood that coated his hands, his face, his half naked body...

The way it splattered everywhere as he sunk the jagged shard of glass in Rick's chest. His stomach...

Over and over and over again.

More memories converge, rushing in and out of order, and I see those lips shivering around soundless pleas.

See hands coming toward me...slim fingers...

Those eyes, big, bright, and shining.

Please. Pleasepleaseplease...

He was just a kid, for fuck's sake.

But so was I.

So was I.

CHAPTER 8

VALE

THE PAST

THE ROOM they put me in is cold, and smells of bleach.

I tug at the clothes they gave me after cleaning my hand. They're too big on me—the shirt baggy and wrinkled. The hems of the sweatpants pooling around my dangling feet.

They're itchy too. And they smell funny. Like Louise's washing machine when she forgot to switch the clothes to the dryer. Only these are dry and stiff.

I kick my foot out, pointing and flexing it.

Even the socks I had on had blood on them. So, they took those too. Bagged them up.

There's a knock on the door. A woman enters, followed by a man. He hangs back, while she crouches in front of me, her lips stretching upward just like that caseworker's when she took me from my grandma's house. Just like that female cop earlier, who sat with me on the way to the hospital and told me I'd be okay.

I didn't understand why the caseworker smiled that day. My grandma handing me over to CPS was not a happy thing, as far as I could see it.

I was eight then. I didn't know better.

Do you really know better now though?

My mind drifts to earlier, in that room. Aston's grin. His laugh. The blood covering his arms and chest and splattering his face like raindrops.

No...I'm not sure that I do.

"Vale? Did you hear what I said?"

I blink, and lift my head, meeting the lady's searching eyes head on. I say nothing.

Her mouth thins and she nods, as if she stumbled upon the answer herself.

She goes on to explain that she's my new caseworker, introducing the man behind her as a detective. If she's waiting for a response from me, she's not going to get one.

Selective mutism. That's what CPS told the Baders when I was left with them.

After my parents died, I didn't talk for almost a year. My grandma didn't outright say that was why she got rid of me, but I figure it had something to do with it.

It wasn't until two months into living with Rick and Louise that I finally found my voice again. Or rather, felt like using it. That's what the therapist who evaluated me when I was younger didn't understand.

I can talk.

I just don't see the point sometimes.

Just like I don't see the point in listening either.

Like now.

As the lady steps away, still talking—the man adding his two cents here and there—I watch the way my toes turn white when I curl them—white like Rick's shirt was when I threw myself on his back.

It was no longer white by the time Aston was done with him.

My gaze drifts to the bandage wrapped around my palm, hiding the grizzly looking gash a nurse sewed up earlier. I don't remember how many stitches, but it was a lot. I almost spoke up when she brought out a needle to numb me, but then I thought better of it.

When I'm alone, I'll inspect it some more. I'm finally starting to feel the heat. It pulses. Makes it hard to curl my fingers.

I can't help but think about how this is the first time since my parents were alive that I needed stitches.

"How old did you say he was?" The woman tries to be quiet, but I'm quieter. Which means I hear better.

“Thirteen,” the guy murmurs, and there’s no missing the tightness to his voice.

There’s a heavily weighted pause.

“But...” she starts to say.

Then, “Oh. I see.”

Pity oozes from her voice like sludge, and my brain latches onto it like a starved animal, gobbling it up. My mind’s racing with ideas faster than I can catch them. Ways to use this—use her...

It gives me something to focus on as the itchy burning sensation in my hand slowly worsens as the numbing stuff wears off, and the friction from the gauze becomes unbearable.

I’m bored.

I need this bandage off.

I need out of this room that reeks of bleach.

More than anything though, I need a fucking shower.

In the back of my head, I hear a high-pitched squeal. “You cursed!”

I imagine Aston pointing a finger at me, his eyes all big and wide in that way they get when something shocks and amuses him.

It’s funny actually, now that I think about it. It’s the same face he made tonight when the cops stormed in, and he brought his blood-soaked hands to his mouth, trying and failing to mask his giggling. Eyes so wide, I could make out the whites all around.

My stomach tightens painfully.

I grit my teeth, and seal my eyes shut.

But it doesn’t help.

All I see is him.

All I ever see is him.

Six months ago, it didn’t bother me.

Now, I’d do anything to scrub it from existence.

Rick might be dead...

Aston might’ve been taken away...

But my living nightmare is here to stay.

And he’s the star of it.

Rick made sure of that.

CHAPTER 9

ASTON

*"I Touch Myself" by the Divinyls
came on the radio today.*

[song lyrics redacted due to copyright laws]

*I've never felt so seen.
So understood.
So validated.*

PRESENT DAY

OCTOBER

"I'VE GOTTA SAY, this is quite an impressive rap sheet for someone so young."

Sprawled out in a leather armchair, I pop the bubblegum left over from my Blow Pop and give Dr. Benson, Grady Prep's school psychologist, a winning smile. "Yeah, I've been told I'm kind of a lot."

From behind his mahogany desk, he flips through my file that *finally* arrived, as if he hasn't spent however long he's had it, scouring and memorizing everything there is to know about lil ol' me.

Come on, I wasn't born yesterday. I know he's been chomping at the bit to get my life story. Seeing as I'm not the most reliable of narrators... making our first two sessions all but pointless.

"Let's see..." he begins reading out loud. "Complex PTSD on account of prolonged abuse with a comorbid psychotic disorder not otherwise specified."

My brows flare lightly. I'm surprised. Usually, my therapists aren't so... forthcoming. Last time I asked to see what was written—you know, as should be my right—I was told they didn't want to "trigger an episode."

In other words, they were worried I'd flip my shit and claw their faces off.

As if.

It's gonna take a *little* bit more than telling me *what's* wrong with me to set me off.

Dr. Benson is still going, reading my chart aloud like he's telling me a bedtime story. "Including but not limited to the presentation of delusions of grandeur—"

I roll my eyes. I'm not delulu, I'm fabulous. It's called having confidence. Sorry not sorry.

"—paranoid and disorganized thought and behavior patterns," he goes on. "High, unpredictable emotional lability that can lead to unprovoked violent outbursts..." He drags off with a pointed tone, flicking me a glance at me over his thin-wired frames.

Unprovoked, my ass.

He clicks his tongue, turning his attention back to my file. His eyes dart all over the page, eating it up. "Attachment disorder...with RADA scores indicating high disinhibition, and an inability to form meaningful, lasting relationships with others, on account of severe emotional neglect during his formative years."

Groaning, I throw my head back to stare at the ceiling.

"A history of depression and anxiety. Panic attacks when confined to small, enclosed spaces..." His voice trails off so he can take a breath, before continuing. "There's also evidence of an underlying personality

disorder,” he goes on, ticking off his fingers as he recites: “Narcissism. Obsessive tendencies. Promiscuity.”

I gasp. *Rude!*

Don’t they know slut shaming is so not fetch?

“A general lack of regard for his own health and safety, as indicated by past instances of self-ha—”

“*UGH*,” I explode. “Can we not?”

Scratch what I said. Maybe I don’t want to hear all this.

I throw up my hands, barking out a harsh laugh. “You’re a glorified guidance counselor, not Dr. Phil.”

Unfazed by my outburst, he cuts me a pointed look from under his lashes. “And a seemingly *selective* lack of remorse for his actions,” he goes on, slapping the folder closed. Straightening, he leans back and cocks his head, folding his arms across his chest. “Not to mention a history of significant dissociation resulting in lost periods of time and gaps in memory.”

Staring dead into his judgy eyes, my lips twitch, and I shrug as if to say, *What can you do?*

He arches a brow. “And here I thought this job would be boring.”

And there it is.

Despite his best efforts to appear more mature with his gold-wired glasses, sweater vest, and slicked back dark hair, thanks to Chatty Cathy, the guidance office secretary, I know he’s only twenty-six. And this is his first job in the field. He’d only received his Ph. D last spring, from UPenn, and just so happened to be lucky enough to stumble upon an opening here thanks to the previous school psychologist starting her own practice.

My smile edges into something dangerous as I lower my chin to my chest, peering up at him through my lashes. “You won’t fix me.”

“Who said I wanted to?”

“So, I’m a lab rat then?”

“Never said that either.”

I shake my head. “You’re all the same.”

“Therapists? Or men?”

I tense at that. “Careful,” I whisper, meeting his gaze, this time not bothering to hide how annoyed I’m getting. My smile remains as I tilt my head. “You don’t want to...say the wrong thing.” I widen my eyes,

chomping hard on my gum, ensuring I look as insane as my file implies. “I might go...*boom*.” I mouth the final word, bugging my eyes.

Dr. Dickwad’s lips twist like he’s fighting a sneer, or maybe a smile of his own.

Is he laughing at me?

Well, fuck me, that’s new.

Sitting back, I gulp down my gum and clench my jaw, gripping the arms of my chair, my shoulder and neck muscles tensing.

Yeah, I don’t like this. I don’t like this at all.

He’s supposed to monitor me, as per the conditions of my enrollment. *I.E. weekly check-ins every Monday in lieu of my first period.* That’s it. I already have a therapist and psychiatrist I check in with, who oversee my treatment. But I could tell from the moment I walked into this drafty office that Dr. Leopold Benson was going to be a problem. The young, green ones always are—they just can’t help themselves. They take one look at someone like me, with a history like mine, and suddenly they’re an expert, determined to prove themselves and do what was never done before.

Cure the incurable.

Removing his glasses, he sets them on a stack of papers, and leans forward, clasping his hands atop my closed file. “Look, Aston. I’m going to be perfectly honest with you here. I don’t care about your past.”

I cough to mask my snort. *Bullshit*. Everyone cares. It’s all anyone fucking cares about.

It doesn’t matter that I was a minor when I killed someone, or that it happened because I was pushed to my breaking point. For whatever reason, no one can just let it go. My past. What I did. The *why* of it all...

They just keep pushing and prodding and *poking*.

Dr. Benson must see the skepticism written all over my face, because he’s quick to reiterate, “I don’t. From what I’ve read, I actually...pity you.”

I flinch.

Wow. Okay.

“The system failed you.”

I clutch my chest and gasp. “It *did*?”

“Big time,” he goes on as if I didn’t say anything. “But that’s no excuse for your behavior going forward. *That’s* where I come in. That is my job. To understand your needs and your triggers, and to see how we can best

accommodate them in order to ensure the safety of our student body and faculty.”

I let my hands thump to my lap, and glance away, jaw tightening. *Right...*

“Does that bother you?”

“What?”

“That it’s not your safety I’m concerned with.”

I turn a narrowed look on him. He says it casually enough. Yet, I can’t help but feel like I’m being tested.

Slowly, I shake my head.

He hums, eyes flashing with some kind of awareness. “Interesting.”

“What?” I bite out, sneering. “Does it surprise you that I don’t actually want to fuck this all up?”

His brows spike, and I scowl through a wince, silently berating myself for walking into his trap.

Shake it off. He’s trying to evoke a reaction. Don’t give him the satisfaction. Don’t give him anything more than what can be obtained from that file. Let him draw his own conclusions.

“It says a month prior to your release, they lowered your Zyprexa dosage. And upped your Ambien and Zoloft.”

Not expecting him to change the subject so abruptly, it takes me a moment to respond, “Yeah, and?”

“Why?”

I shrug. “Apparently, I was getting a little *you know*.” And I stick my arms out in front of me, let my head droop, and groan.

He arches a brow, clearly not very impressed by my impersonation of a zombie.

I spread my hands. “Antidepressants be like that sometimes.”

“Zyprexa is an antipsychotic.”

I cock my head, with a scrunch of my face. “Really?”

“I can’t tell if you’re joking or not.”

I click my tongue. “The world may never know.”

Obviously, I know what fucking Zyprexa is, douchebag.

I’ve only sampled just about every crazy med on the market before finding one that worked for my brand of crazy. And with minimal side-effects to boot.

You know, before it *stopped* working.

Talk about finding a needle in a needle stack. If it's not weight gain, it's weight loss. If it's not insomnia, it's sedation. If it's not anxiety, it's euphoria (I'm a fan of this one, if I must say myself). If you don't want to kill yourself, it will find a way to kill you...and so on and so forth.

You get the picture.

And to be honest, unless I'm throwing my guts up or rocking in a corner trying to claw my way out of my skin, I've more or less gotten to the point where I hardly even notice when the meds are fucking me up more than helping me. Much less notice when the docs change things up.

It's not like I've ever had any say about what's being pumped into my body, so why bother worrying about it? It was happening whether I liked it or not.

Heck, if I *do* notice, it's usually only after the fact. When I suddenly wake up one day, feeling like me again. After having never even realized I'd lost myself to begin with.

"I wonder..." Dr. Benson starts to say, pulling me from my thoughts.

When he doesn't elaborate, I roll my eyes and look away, seeking out the clock on the wall. "Look, Doc. I'm well aware of what's at stake here, and why I have to keep seeing you, and taking my meds, and blah blah blah." My voice is strained, my smile even more so when I turn my focus back on him. "You have nothing to worry about, 'kay? I'll be God's perfect little angel. Scout's honor."

And with that, I grab my bag from the floor and jump up.

"Aston, we're not fin—"

The bell rings, and he closes his eyes.

"Sorry, can't be late for chemistry!" I say cheerfully. Throwing the strap of my bag over my shoulder, I head for the door. "Give the powers that be my regards. Kisses!"

HIGH SCHOOL.

At first glance, it wasn't at all what I imagined.

But, then again, attending a fancy ass private school in the middle of nowhere wasn't exactly what I had in mind when Tillie dropped the news on me.

“*What exactly are they preparing you for, the priesthood?*” I’d said to Eden the night of the Bell Game, when I first laid eyes on the gothic monstrosity otherwise known as Grady Preparatory Academy.

“*No, idiot. College.*”

Okay, so he didn’t actually call me an idiot, but I know he was thinking it. His exasperated sigh and melodramatic eye roll said as much.

Still...going on three weeks in, and I’ve yet to be fully convinced that this isn’t all a front for more nefarious dabblings.

Tucked deep in the woods along the edge of town with its sprawling castle-like exterior, Grady Prep isn’t giving *collegiate* so much as it’s giving *I want to suck your blood*. With its mottled brick siding and jutting spires stabbing the sky; ominous archways and narrow cathedral windows... if it’s not the priesthood they’re secretly readying us for, it can be only one other thing: vampirism.

Immortality or celibacy...

Oh, how will I ever choose!

Someone bumps into my shoulder, causing me to stumble forward, shoes skidding and squeaking over the glossy wood floors. “Watch it, loser,” some guy I’ve never even seen before says.

I grit my teeth, fingers clenching the straps of my backpack as I right my balance.

He smirks when he passes, knowing full-well he ran into me, before turning away and strutting off into a classroom.

Okay, so Grady Prep might *look* fancier than your average high school—implying a sense of decorum and maturity behind its iron doors. *And evil plots! Can’t forget that*—but when you get past the tan-burgundy-navy-white palate making up our uniforms, past the dark ornate wood paneling and spiral staircases and maze of corridors and ever-present smell of wood polish, leather, and moth balls...

It’s still very much a typical high school. Right down to the jocks who knock my books from my arms, and the hoity-toity girls who curl their lips at me and make snide comments under their breath.

Heck, just thinking about it warms my fragile little heart with sentiments of, *I belong! I fit in!* This shit be *awesome*.

Sure, it would’ve been a lot cooler if I got to be the one throwing a football at some loser’s head, or flipping my hair back with a scoff—*As if!*—as all my friends spoon-fed me praises and talked shit about me behind

my back. But I'm not at all surprised by the way things turned out. Some people are just not cut out for popularity, and I so happen to be one of them.

Just ask those at Ashwood. Be it an asylum or some lavish prep school smack-dab in the middle of rural Pennsylvania, it's all the same. The adults hate me. My peers ridicule me.

Gotta love the consistency though.

What they don't know, though, is I'm not easy pickins'. No siree. I've been studying. For years. Taking notes, watching movies... Asking questions upon questions.

Some patients and orderlies resisted my inquiries, but most didn't. They wouldn't dare try to brush me off. Because under all that hate and ridicule lies something far more vulnerable. Something that ultimately puts me on top and gets me what I want, even if they won't admit it out loud.

Fear.

So, I don't let the name-calling get to me.

I don't let the scornful looks sent my way hurt my fragile affection-deprived heart.

I know it comes from a place deeper than they can even fathom, and I've long given up on the futile endeavor to learn why humanity has such a penchant for contradiction. Especially when it comes to fear.

There's a serial killer in the house? Okay, let's go upstairs.

See that dark, creepy alleyway over there? Let's go check it out.

Oh, your pulse is racing? Your hands are sweating?

Psh. That's not your body warning you of danger. It's probably just gas or something. You're *fine*...

I swear, some people wouldn't know what fear is until it slaps them fully across the face.

(Hello! Hi! It's me! I am *slap*, but you may call me Aston.)

Now that the day's over, I unwrap a cherry-flavored Blow Pop, shoving the sucker in my mouth. Apparently eating in class is a big no-no, gum included. Something I discovered my first day, when Headmaster Locke caught me blowing bubbles in the library during my free period, and promptly made me spit it out.

Which of course drew the attention of everybody in my vicinity, one in particular I was hoping to just casually observe from my little stake-out spot between the stacks.

Way to make me look like a total stalker, asshole.

Now, digging out my Walkman—another stupidly forbidden thing during school hours—I re-hook the retro cassette player on the belt-loop of my khakis, slide the bulky headphones back up over my head, and hit Play.

What Blow Pops and music ever did to offend the overseers of academia, the world may never know.

Cranking up the volume, I promptly tune out the world, and strut for the front of the school, sucking on my lollipop, bopping my head to my favorite Heart song—“Crazy On You”—blaring in my ears. Navy lockers line the walls on either side of me, only intermittently broken up by posters advertising the Homecoming dance and Halloween carnival happening later this month.

Today marks the start of my third week here since I started school, and I still can’t get enough.

The smells.

The sights.

The lip-curls.

Holding books in my arms like a regular old scholar!

My eyes drift toward the groups of guys huddled by the water fountain. Jocks. Football players. Cheerleaders hanging off their arms and everything.

And then there’s *him*.

The quarterback.

He doesn’t have a cheerleader though. No, he has a chess player instead. A total nerd who managed to wiggle his way through the ranks, all the way to the top, all because he’s sucking the dick of the King of the school himself.

Vale Riviera.

I smirk as the name rolls around my head.

Rivierrrrra.

I won’t lie—it’s got a nice ring to it.

Aston Riviera.

“Hey, Myers! Nice blowie,” someone yells out, loud enough to be heard through the music. My eyes meet the laughing blue gaze of Vale’s best friend. The guy who showed Eden and I the way out of the cornfield the night of the Bell Game after Vale had stormed off.

Big, pretty, blond, and not very smart. Casey Shrute.

I catch Vale just as he shoots his friend a weird look, almost like he’s reluctantly amused, but also irritated. It’s the only other look I’ve seen him

wear other than abject boredom.

With my thumb, I lower the volume on my Walkman just in time to hear Casey say, “Sorry, I meant Blow Pop. My bad.”

Barely paying him any notice, I tug the lollipop from my mouth, and meet Vale’s dark, hardened gaze as I give a nice salacious lick of the bulbous candy. I punctuate it with a wink.

His eyes widen ever so slightly, before what little light in them exists seems to be snuffed out, taking any softness to his chiseled, perfect features with it.

Too late, babycakes. I saw that. I twist my lips together to hold back a smile.

“God, get a clue, would you?” a voice sneers.

I roll my eyes.

Alicia Devereau.

Thinks she’s hot shit because she’s captain of the cheerleading squad and her daddy’s head of the school board.

I snap my teeth at her before facing forward once more and popping the lolly back into my mouth. *Bitch*. If anyone needs to get a clue, it’s her. It’s the twenty-first century—there are tutorials for how to extract a stick from one’s ass.

Not to mention the whole *Heathers* rip-off situation going on with her and the other Alicias. Something I’d be absolutely *gushing over*, if it weren’t for the unavoidable fact that I’m nothing but a Martha Dumptruck in their eyes.

Definitely not the role I would’ve chosen for myself...

But it could be worse, I suppose.

She could’ve adopted me as her Gay Best Friend™.

Mentally finger-flicking my festering resentment to somewhere in the next millennium, I crank the music back up, and continue on my merry way. The song’s just ending, fading before it switches over to another, so I can just make out the words trailing behind me. “...did he even look in a mirror when he got dressed today?”

My steps stutter to a deadly stop. *Oh, no, he didn’t*. Turning on my heel, I whip the sucker from my mouth and blindly hit Stop on the Walkman, so that when I land a seething, slitted glare on Vale’s nerdy little so-called *boyfriend*, and say loudly, “Excuse *me*?” I can hear the way the hall plummets into silence.

Between the various clubs and practices that await these overachieving brown-nosers, you wouldn't even know that classes have let out for the day. That's how many students still linger, and who are fortunate enough to witness this little spectacle.

Seth juts his chin up, and I don't miss the way he subtly inches closer to Vale. It makes my blood boil. Whether it's a futile, pathetic attempt to mark his territory, or he's just looking for protection, I can't say. Though, a small part of me does hope it's the former, because if it is... that means he has something to be insecure about.

And he'd only be insecure if he saw me as a threat to his relationship.

Now, why oh why would he feel that way, unless...

I shift my gaze to Mr. Tall, Dark, and Terrifyingly Handsome looming over him with his arms crossed, currently watching me with a look I can't decipher. At first, it looks a lot like that ever-present boredom I've come to associate with him. That stone cold apathy that, as a child, was oddly endearing. But at nineteen, having clearly not outgrown it, combined with his devilishly good looks...

Is it just me or is it sweltering in here???

I bite my lip, fluttering my lashes at him. And while he doesn't react externally, either his black eyes are a mirror, or someone's an itty bit enamored by what he sees.

Okay, enamored might be a bit of a stretch. I might be, like, clinically delusional, as we've already established. But I'm not *totally* lacking in the self-awareness department. Otherwise I *never* would've made it this long before shooting my shot with him.

(Observing him from a calculated distance for research purposes doesn't count.)

It's been no easy feat, waiting and hoping for him to come to me—patience isn't exactly a virtue of mine, you see. But I can understand why he might be a little reluctant to welcome me back into his life, given how we left things, how long it's been, et cetera, et cetera...

So, I did the nice, mature thing and gave him a chance to come to terms with it all on his own.

Or, at least, give me some kind of sign that he's not as unaffected by my presence as he pretends.

Vale's gaze flicks down, pulling me from my thoughts, and reminding me what prompted me to turn back and make a scene in the first place.

I glance down at my outfit, seeing it from his eyes. It *shouldn't* stand out as anything special, in theory, because uniforms. But what can I say? I took some creative liberties.

Where the brown Oxfords are standard, same as the tan chinos...

The socks peeking out from the rolled up hems...not so much.

But what's fun about fun socks if you can't even see them? These ones in particular I'm quite fond of. They're mid-calf, orange, and with little pink hearts on them. Representing two of my most favorite days of the year, one of which being Halloween, which is just a few weeks away.

Moving up from there, it's, again, same as what all the other dudes are wearing: navy blazer with the burgundy and silver Grady Prep insignia on the breast, a tucked, crisp white button-down, and a burgundy and silver striped tie.

I finger the tasseled ends of the cashmere scarf draped loosely around my neck—orange to match my socks, with little gold beads. I'd stolen it—I mean, *borrowed*—from Granny Gertie's collection.

Okay, so the fit might be a little...loud. A little *clashy*. But, yeah, see, this whole uniform thing? It stopped being cute after the third day, when I realized once again, my individuality was being stifled by an institution. So, in the time since, I've done what I can to spice it up without totally violating the rules.

Rules, rules, rules.

I swear I've only traded one prison for another by coming to this place. Difference is, here, I can more easily find a way to *bend* the rules. And that makes it fun.

No more tush needles or padded rooms for me.

A throat clears. Whispers follow.

Oh, right, I'm supposed to be making a scene.

Where were we...

"I'll have you know, Seth," I say sweetly, "I did look in a mirror. Several actually. Throughout the day. The real question is, did *you*?" I wave my lollipop at the gelled... thing on his head. "When you decided that hairstyle looked good."

Someone nearby whistles low. "Ooh, burn."

I tip my head in the general direction of where it came from, and curtsy. "Thank you."

Seth's coloring deepens into a worrying shade of maroon. Behind him, with his gaze locked on mine, Vale's lips move as he mutters something under his breath. Try as I might, I can't make out what he's saying. But it's clearly meant for the leech at his side, because whatever it is he says has Seth closing his eyes and taking a deep breath.

And that?

That pisses me off.

My smile twitches, edging into something dangerous. Menacing and feral. A retort claws its way up my throat—something very witty and not at all stupid, something that will surely get me into a heap of trouble... If not with my team of wardens, who've probably got bets going around about how long I'll last before sabotaging everything, then with Vale certainly.

Oh, how easy I could fuck everything up for him...

Everything he's built here. This *life* he's carefully curated for himself, where he's not some malnourished mute kid following his foster brother around like a lost puppy, but some big shot football star. One who's got everyone fooled by his wooden smiles and uncanny ability to know just what to say and do to steer conversations where he wants them.

If I thought Vale was a bit...odd at times when we were kids...quiet and observant in an eerily apathetic way. It's got nothing on the version I've come to know these last couple weeks. He's like some kind of chameleonic android, able to slip through social situations like melted butter.

One moment, he'll be this quiet unobtrusive force content to blend into the background, content to observe, nodding when expected, cracking the smallest smile if he's so inclined to humor whoever it is he's decided is worth his time to entertain.

And the next, he'll be taking full command of the situation. Without any effort whatsoever. All it takes is a word. A gesture. A subtle shift in energy. And everyone around him just...falls back. Submits.

Like now, when a voice rings out, "What's going on out here?"—effectively shutting me up before I can ruin everything— and, faster than I can blink, Vale's got his mask back in place as he turns toward Headmaster Locke. Flanked at the headmaster's sides are Walter and some female faculty member I don't know.

"Nothing, sir." Vale says this pleasantly enough, but there's no missing the quiet underlying authority that leaves no room for doubt, when he adds, "Just settling a small misunderstanding."

I blink as students around us disperse instantly, returning to whatever it is they were doing moments ago, as his words held some secret, subliminal command.

What the hell? Did I zone out and miss something?

It's as if nothing happened. And either I'm fucking crazy—er, crazier than I already am—or the air is thinner, noises louder, sights brighter... It's as if time stood still, and now, with some freaky telepathic command, Vale's managed to get it to rewind and reset.

It's fascinating. Intriguing.

Does *he* even realize the power he wields?

Something tells me he does. And fuck if I don't want to pet his hair and feed him grapes while he confides in me all his secrets.

"Aston."

I glance at Walter. Something tells me that's not the first time he tried getting my attention. Behind him, Eden shuffles awkwardly, sending shooting glances between Vale and me. "Um, yeah, what he said."

Walter frowns. "Who?"

"Huh?"

Muttering under his breath, he shakes his head, glancing away. *Okay, so that time, I definitely zoned out.* "Come on," he says. "We're leaving."

With him gone, I find Eden watching me warily, and I feel my cheeks heat. I bug my eyes at him and mouth, *What?* To which he scowls, rolls his eyes like the teenage diva he is, and turns to follow dutifully after his dad.

I chance one last look back, half-expecting Vale and his group of loyal followers to no longer be standing there. But an empty spot isn't what I find, and I can't say it's much better.

His friends are gone, but he and Seth are still there. No longer facing my direction, Seth's now all up in Vale's space, arms looped around his neck. Something in me deflates at the sight of a pair of large veiny hands splayed loosely across the small of his back.

Throat thick, I lift my gaze to find Vale staring me down over where Seth's got his head buried in his nape. Flutters erupt in my belly, batting away the icky feeling that was there only a split-second ago. Because until today, until this whole thing, I was lucky if I even got a single passing glance from him all day.

It was as if our little moment in the cornfields never happened. As if it meant nothing to him. As if my return to his life meant nothing...

He remembers me. I know he does.

It doesn't help that we don't share any classes. His locker's a whole hallway away from mine, lumped with the rest of the football team. So other than lunch, surrounded by his fellow jocks and that horrible growth currently nuzzling his neck, probably crying because I insulted his hair, we might as well exist on two different planes.

Not right now though. Right now, we're not only sharing the same plane, we're the only ones here.

I feel my lip twitch with the beginnings of a rueful smile. My gaze growing molten with satisfaction. And still, he doesn't look away. Doesn't pretend that he doesn't notice me.

Finally.

I mean I knew I'd get it *eventually*—a sign. A signal.

Poke and prod, and little mice will always reveal themselves, no matter how hard they try to scurry by unnoticed. They always do. They can't help themselves. They're too nosy, too reckless, too tempted by danger.

His dark gaze reveals nothing, but that's okay. The weight of his prolonged attention, unsettling as it might be—the dude doesn't even blink—is enough for me.

With a renewed sense of purpose, I chomp down on what's left of my candy and toss the stick on the ground between us before turning on my heel with a flourish and sauntering confidently after Eden and Walter. Blowing through the doors to outside and disappearing into the glaring afternoon light.

Tick-tock, little mouse.

Your time's just about up.

CHAPTER 10

VALE

I'M OVER IT.

This day.

This week.

This year.

High school.

Seth...

All of it.

The day passes as mundanely as any other day, with one bright exception:

It's Friday. Game day.

Despite my shitty mood, I don't make a spectacle of it. I flit from class to class, giving my teachers and peers just enough attention to keep up with the status quo. Obediently playing my part in this little production called *high school*.

The one I created to fit my needs and nurtured over the years. The one that will ensure I achieve the future I've laid out for myself.

It used to be easy, keeping up pretenses. Easy as breathing. Seamless as sleeping. Requiring no more energy or forethought than it would to flip a switch from *On* to *Off* and back again.

Now, not so much.

I'm...bored. Of the act. Of pretending I give a shit.

And I'm impatient. Antsy. A hair trigger away from dismantling everything for no other reason than to create a challenge for myself to overcome.

I don't have to wonder as to why that is, or rather *who* is responsible...

Just the knowledge—the deep-seated awareness that Aston St. James is somewhere in this building—is enough to set my teeth on edge.

Suddenly I'm eight years old again, helpless to resist his gravitational pull, with no logical explanation as to why, or any idea how to break free of it, once and for all.

What is it about Aston?

Why him, when no one or nothing else?

Beyond frustrated, I blurt loudly, "Can I have the bathroom pass?"

The room quiets at my interruption, Mrs. Cheshire's voice cutting off mid-sentence. I can't even find it in me to care enough to toss an apology or smile her way. This...itch in my brain is too strong, too insistent. A bone-deep restlessness that comes with a boredom so pervasive it's sometimes a wonder I haven't offed myself.

Mrs. Cheshire's smile falters a fraction, and something sizzles in my chest at the brief show of irritation flickering behind her glasses.

But she's quick to shake it off.

Too quick.

I clamp down on my molars, willing back the irrational anger her restraint churns up. Fuck if I'm not jonesing for a fight—for a reason to drop the act, just once.

Let me show them who I really am.

"Sure, Vale," she says pleasantly, nodding toward the little table off to the side of her desk. I feel several pairs of eyes tracking me across the room when I get up, but it's nothing new. Again, it's just...noise.

While I know I *can* fade into the background, I'll be the first to admit I don't *want* to.

Not because I have something to prove, but because to pretend I'm not better than these bottom-feeder, hormonal-driven nobodies, who think fulfilling some checklist of accomplishments laid for them by their parents—accomplishments that in the grand scheme of things amount to *nothing*—will somehow make their lives meaningful...

Well, it's not only a disservice to myself, but a waste of fucking energy. Energy that could be better spent making *my* life meaningful, instead of dwelling on how theirs *isn't*.

I quickly sign out and grab the thin red rectangle of wood that says PASS in big, bold, black letters across the front. I loop the frayed rope attached to it around my wrist and head out into the hall.

Flyers for the carnival and Tunnel of Horror—a haunted attraction held in the old coal mines that the junior class puts together every year for Halloween to raise funds for their senior trip—are already posted along the walls, in the gaps between lockers, and hanging over the doorways peppered down the hall.

It's another one of those traditions the school goes gaga for every year. Hell, the whole town.

I pass the first set of bathrooms, shooting for the stairwell instead, jogging up the two flights it takes to get to the top floor.

It's unspoken knowledge that the bathroom in the west wing on the third floor is where you go for a smoke, a line, a fuck, or whatever it is you want to do that requires a bit of privacy. It's the creakiest of creaky rooms in the entire monstrosity that is Grady Preparatory Academy, so anything short of screaming bloody murder wouldn't be heard beyond the thick, heavy door.

Most students avoid it, claiming it's haunted. That some poor schmuck hanged himself from the exposed pipes back in the '70s, and after one such pipe burst last year...well, idiots took that as a sign to stay away.

In reality, it's just old as fuck. Old and outdated, with a sewer system that's probably older than Mr. Laurent, my English Lit teacher who's gotta be pushing one-hundred. It's the only bathroom in the entire school that was never upgraded. And after what happened last year, no attempt has been made to fix it up

As always, I ignore the OUT OF ORDER sign taped over the wooden door, pushing my way inside. Only to freeze mid-step, when my gaze lands on the shadowy figure lounged against the windows across the room.

"Well, well, well," a disembodied voice says smoothly, echoing in the cavernous space. "If it isn't Grady Prep's very own Cinderella. I was just thinking about you. 'bout time you showed your face. I've gotta admit, your secret spot is a little more drab than I anticipated for someone of your status. Revisiting your roots in the slums, are we?"

Fuck.

Of all people to run into in here...

Aston's floppy light brown hair looks darker in the dim lighting, all the gold the light would normally highlight washed out by the shadows. It's a dreary fall day, and the high floor-to-ceiling windows he sits against are made of an opaque, bumpy glass that filters in hardly any light.

What he just said finally registers. My nose flares, defensiveness rocketing up my spine and holding me rigid. “Are you fucking following me?”

Sure, I’ve caught him staring at lunch—the only time of day I couldn’t completely avoid him.

And then there was that day in the library. Hell, there’s been a *few* times I’ve caught him slinking behind the stacks.

But for him to know this is my *secret spot*, as he so idiotically put it, means he’s been doing far more than casually snooping around. I don’t come up here every day, but enough that he figured out this is where best to trap me.

“You make it sound so...creepy. I just wanted to make sure you’re okay.”

To that, I say nothing.

Aston leans forward, away from the light, so that I can just make out the tilt of his growing smile. And the red stain to his lips. Only this time, it’s not from one of the lollipops he’s always sucking on, but from the chocolate-covered strawberry he currently has impaled on the point of his butterfly knife.

Not taking his eyes off me, he brings the fruit to his mouth, and bites just the tip, his long fingers clasped loosely, carelessly around the handle of the knife.

Clearing my throat, I look away.

“Want one?”

A quick, fleeting glance shows a tin of mostly half-eaten chocolate-covered strawberries extended toward me; no doubt stolen.

“Where’d you get those?” I hear myself ask before I can stop myself. Taking a step forward, I let the door fall shut behind me.

He grins victoriously, and my neck prickles, spreading a chill across my skin. I can’t tell if it’s just irritation, or something...else.

“That’s neither here nor there,” he says with a little flick of his free hand. With that same hand, he pushes back his hair from his brow. It’s a useless endeavor if there ever was one. It just flops right back over.

“So, where’s your Prince Charming?” He taps his chin. His sage eyes sparkle with a mix of excitement and something sharper. Brittle, almost. “Come to think of it, I think this is the first time I’ve seen you without that horrid growth attached to your hip.”

“Don’t talk that way about him,” I find myself saying, voice tight with barely restrained ire.

His lips are still tipped up in that seemingly ever-present smirk of his. “Don’t talk that way about him,” he mocks lowly in a poor attempt to imitate my voice.

I grit my teeth. “You’re fucking deranged.”

His eyes flare, and I brace myself. Now that we’re alone for the first time since we were kids, if ever there was a time for him to drop the act, it would be now. Especially after what went down the other day in the hallway.

Yet, color me fucking surprised—*not*—when instead he tips his head back and laughs.

The sound has a chill racing down my spine and I fucking hate it. Hate the effect he so clearly still has on me despite it having been years. Despite spending the better part of the last three weeks refortifying my resolve to steer clear of him, strengthening the walls keeping the memories out. Something I can normally do with ease.

“That’s it?” he says loudly. “That’s all you’ve got?” His chuckles are slow to fade, and he’s still grinning when he drops his chin to his chest, meeting my gaze through the fringe of his lashes. “Come now, Valey,” he says much quieter. “No need to be shy. You don’t have to hold back with me.”

My jaw ticks. “Fuck this, I’m out.”

Turning on my heel, I grip the pass tightly in my hand, welcoming the slight burn from the wood digging into my skin. I’m just about to throw open the door and leave, when his voice rings out.

“WaitnoI’m sorry,” he says in a rush, and I hear a shuffle followed by a dull thud. I turn my head just enough to peek a look over my shoulder.

He’s standing now, arms hanging at his sides, fingers twitching by his thighs. The knife is still in his grip, and there’s a stain on the side of his light khakis from where his fingers smeared chocolate and red juices. He doesn’t seem to notice. That or he simply doesn’t care.

I find my gaze drifting down to his bright-ass socks. Orange again, but this time with pink stripes instead of hearts.

“Don’t go,” he says in a soft, high-pitched voice, almost like that of a child’s.

My brow furrows as I turn to face him fully, assessing the change in his demeanor. His eyes are wide, nearly bulging, making him look like one of those creepy kewpie dolls.

I cross my arms over my chest, arching him an expectant brow.

He forces a laugh and shrugs his shoulders. "It would appear that I've forgotten my manners." He presses the hand holding the knife to his chest and says, "Let's start over. I'm Aston, like the car." His mouth twitches ever so slightly as he points the knife at me. "And you're Vale, like a wedding veil, but spelled V-A-L-E."

Ice fills my veins as I'm thrown back to when I was eight years old, hearing those exact words from my new foster brother. I wasn't talking, so he filled the silence for me.

Aston's watching me expectantly with a steady, unfazed gaze. It should be unsettling, but I'm still too caught up on what he just said and trying not to show it.

"Right," I mutter.

"Do you remember me now?"

As if I could forget.

He cocks his head. "Or rather...you done pretending you don't?" There's a seriousness to his tone now I don't like.

My jaw ticks and I decide to change the subject rather than entertain his questions. "Why aren't you in class?"

He blinks into a small frown. "Well, I was, but it was awfully boring. At least at the asylum, someone was always either starting a fight, or having a life crisis, or there was an orderly who'd sneak me away to...well, you know." He makes a crude gesture with his fist and mouth.

My nose wrinkles. *The fuck?*

He does that freaky bug-eye thing again. "Oh! That's one of those things I'm not supposed to say out loud, right?" He covers his mouth in a mock show of regret. His eyes twinkle, telling me he's fighting a smile.

I watch him even more curiously now. I know what people have been saying about him, my so-called friends included.

Hell, Casey calls him *Myers*...as in Michael Myers.

Word about what happened the night of the Bell Game, at the Furnaces, spread quickly. And like with all high school gossip, people were swift to twist and exaggerate what actually happened.

Combine that with everything else going around—the rumors surrounding his time at Ashwood Asylum, what led him there—and his seemingly inability to fly under the radar, and just be...*normal*...

He's built quite the reputation for himself. All in a matter of weeks.

And while I've never been one to give much credit to high school gossip, especially given what parts I actually *do* know about his history to be true...

The longer I watch him, the more I can't help but wonder if perhaps I was wrong. That this *isn't* an act—that what Quentin implied about his mental state was actually true. And he's well and truly batshit crazy.

Dropping his hands suddenly, he twirls the knife around next to his head as he starts pacing in front of the row of sinks. "All these rules, rules, rules," he says, tipping his head back with a great sigh. "How do people live like this? It's exhausting. Don't do this, don't do that." He tips the knife back and forth, dragging his heels, then toes as he starts pacing backward now too. "Don't say this, don't say that."

He stops, whirling around suddenly to face me. He throws his hands out dramatically. "I'm trying!"

I blink and glance around, wondering if he's still talking to me.

He purses his lips.

Then, bringing the knife to his mouth, nibbling on the flat side of the tip, he watches me for a long silent moment, eyes furrowed with some unreadable emotion. His tongue pokes out, gathering the chocolate and fruit juices still clinging to the blade.

Jesus.

"You're gonna cut your tongue out," I say flatly, grateful it's just dark enough where I stand that he shouldn't get a look at my dick hardening in my khakis.

He's the one to blink at a loss this time. He pulls the knife away from his face, staring at it like he's just realizing it's there. "Well, that would be sad."

A short, disbelieving laugh punches its way up my throat, expelling in the form of a grunt before I can stop it. He clearly hears it, and his face softens with this freaky sort of demur look about it.

"What?" I ask suspiciously.

"You like me."

My brows spike. "*What?*"

His mouth stretches up on one side, giving him a roguish look as he drops his chin and slinks his way toward me.

Fuck.

My feet start carrying me backward, much to my dismay. What's with him and his ability to fluster me? Making my body do things before my brain catches up. First, at the Furnaces. Now in this drafty bathroom.

And back then.

Don't forget back then.

"Valey, Valey, Valey," he sings.

"Don't call me that."

"Don't call me that," he mocks in a baby voice.

My back finds the wall with a thud, and I suddenly find myself less than an inch away from Aston. The last person on Earth I need to be up close and personal with. He's standing so close, I can feel his breaths on my chin.

"You're so big now," he says, darting that wide, unhinged gaze all over me. Like he's taking it all in, eating me up. Feeding off my energy. Not my fear, because I'm not afraid.

I'm pissed.

"Remember when we were kids? Brothers?" he gushes suddenly, smiling dreamily. He reaches up and pokes my cheek with his pointer finger. It's the hand gripping the knife, and I feel my eye twitch at the sight of that sleek, silver blade so close to my face. "You were so tiny. So small and cute. Quiet too, like a little mouse." He starts chittering.

I stiffen, my vision momentarily blacking out.

I force a hard swallow, jutting out my chin as he leans up into me, brushing his nose over my jaw. He sniffs and I clench my fists at my side.

Sweet. Candy. Sticky.

He cocks his head and blinks into a frown, his full lips squishing up as he meets my gaze directly. "But you're not so little anymore, are you? Still quiet, but it's a good quiet." He nods as if confirming it for himself. "A *smart* quiet."

His gaze drops, teeth appearing to bite down on his lip as a salacious grin slides up his face. "Big everywhere, I see." He tilts his head, brows arching. "Hard too."

Rage blacks out my vision, and the next thing I know, I've flipped our positions. I've got a hand wrapped around Aston's throat, and I'm pinning

him against the yellowy, popcorn-textured wall I was just resting my back against.

His laughter reaches my ears, prompting me to tighten my grip on him until it stutters out.

“Don’t. Touch. Me.”

I can barely get the words out through the gnashing of my teeth. I can feel the vein in my temple throbbing, and I’m pretty sure my face is just as red as Aston’s is slowly turning.

He’s not scared, though. If anything, he looks...enraptured. Shocked in the best kind of way. The sight of those bright gray-green orbs swirling with happiness inches away from me sends a spark of heat rocketing through my body, but I’m quick to snuff it out.

Nope, nope. This is so fucked.

Heavy pants work their way out of my nose, and my heart pounds in a way it never has before. Not from what I can recall, and I recall *everything*.

“And don’t fucking look at me like that,” I tell him quietly, roughly. “When I walk out of here, you’re going to forget this conversation ever happened. You’re going to forget my name, and forget we ever, ever knew each other. Understood?”

Something dark skitters across his eyes, and my mouth ticks up cruelly. “Don’t like that plan? Well, too fucking bad.”

Easing my hold on his neck, I smirk when he sucks in a couple harsh gasps. I reach down and grab the wrist of the hand still holding tight onto the knife, and I bring it between us at chin level.

Biting my nails into his pale, bony wrist, I shake his hand. “Is this supposed to scare me?”

He doesn’t say anything. Doesn’t even glance at the blade between our faces. He merely watches me. As if nothing else exists.

“Go ahead then,” I say. “Stab me. Slit my throat. Gut me.”

I regret the words as soon as I say them. Rather than flinch away from my words—from the reminder of what he’s done—Aston rolls his lips in like he’s fighting a laugh.

My gaze volleys between his. “Jesus Christ, you really are crazy, aren’t you?”

“What?” he says, his voice raspy from being choked out a moment ago. “It’s *funny*.”

Disturbed, for more reasons than one—some of which I’d rather not look too closely at—I step back, releasing him. Slowly shaking my head, I keep backing away.

He’s no longer smiling. In fact, his face dulls into something utterly blank. Devoid of any identifiable emotion. It happens so abruptly, I’m left wondering what the hell triggered it.

Me releasing him?

He scratches the back of his head with his free hand, while he closes the butterfly blade with a nimble, well-practiced flip of his fingers, before shoving it in one of the pockets lining the inside of his blazer.

And for the first time since he blew his way back into my life, I feel... wary, I think.

Nervous in a way I’m not accustomed to.

There’s only two other times I can remember feeling this way so vividly. The night we were separated. And the time Quentin learned my secret.

“Do they know?”

I tense. “Know what?”

His too-knowing sage-green eyes find mine. When he doesn’t immediately say anything, I think, *this is it*.

This is the moment it all comes crumbling down.

The moment I lose everything.

“Do they know where you come from?” he says, tilting his head, those full, pouty lips of his for once not stretched taut with a smile. “Do they know the truth about you, Cinderella? Does your Prince Charming know?”

I feel my jaw pulsing, but I don’t give him the satisfaction of a response.

He makes a small noise of acknowledgment in the back of his throat. Nodding, he says, “That’s what I thought.”

And with that, he steps away from the wall, making his way past me, and back toward his spot by the windows.

Turning, I watch as he climbs back up on the radiator, resuming the position I found him in. Legs dangling over the ledge. Metal tin in his lap. A soft glow around his head like a halo.

The bell rings suddenly and I realize I’ve been gone far too long. Mrs. Cheshire is probably wondering where I am.

Without another word, I pick up the bathroom pass from the floor. I must’ve dropped it earlier when my anger took over.

That makes three times now since Aston's come back into my life that I've lost control over myself like that.

This is why you need to stay away.

He jeopardizes everything.

Behind me, I hear Aston humming a familiar tune, "One, Two, Buckle My Shoe," and I freeze. Something tells me the lyrics playing out in his head are not the ones belonging to that stupid nursery rhyme.

Does he...remember?

Bile surges up my throat, and I squeeze my eyes shut, quickly forcing it back down along with the memory of his misplaced laughter and high-pitched voice—

"Five, six...Stick! Stick! Stick!"

I shake my head.

Don't think about it.

A pipe creaks loudly, followed by the whine of the door as I push it open.

"Hey, Vale," Aston says quietly from behind me.

I pause, keeping my gaze trained forward.

"Bury it down all you want. But the truth always comes out. Midnight will strike, and the glass slipper will fall off." He pauses, then with a stifled giggle, he says, "It is written."

Sucking in my cheek, I bite down the urge to slam the door shut and let my rage take the reins once more. Only this time, I wield it like a sword.

"Are you threatening me?" I utter tightly.

"No," he says, serious once more, in that misleadingly soft voice. "I have nothing to gain from spilling your secrets. I'm far too curious to see how this all plays out."

And for whatever reason, be it delusion or sheer desperation, or some combination of the two, I find that I believe him.

"It is odd, though, don't you think?"

Glancing over my shoulder, I find him with his head cocked. "What?" I say, though I'm not so sure I want to know.

"That somehow, we found our way back to each other. After all these years. Without even trying." His mouth crooks up, and something sinks in my gut at his expression.

He looks...hopeful? Excited maybe?

Genuine for once?

Which is something I'm still not sure he's even capable of. I thought he was once. I was a fool.

I force a hard swallow. "Just a weird coincidence."

He hums. "Maybe." He dips his head to look up at me through his thick long lashes. "Or we were always meant to be together."

My whole body stiffens, my jaw ticking, but I try not to let him see that he's getting to me.

"Tell Prince Charming I'll be seeing him," he adds softly, almost as if it's an afterthought.

"Don't touch him." Hell, even to my own ears, I don't sound all that convincing.

He huffs a sound of amusement. "Believe it or not, but I have no interest in *him*."

This time, the electricity racking up my spine is near-combustible. Before he can pick up on just how volatile of an effect his words have on me, I storm out of the room.

The heavy door swings shut behind me with hardly a sound.

It's been twenty-one days since Aston St. James swept back into my life, and while I knew it was only a matter of time before he made a move—shattering this delicately balanced stalemate we found ourselves in—I can admit that I began to have my doubts.

Not only did I wonder if perhaps he didn't actually remember me, at least...not consciously...I began to think maybe I was wrong about *him*. And he actually didn't give a fuck about me at all. What happened to us. What he did...

That whatever Headmaster Locke disclosed to Quentin about his mental state was...well, not a complete exaggeration—he did threaten someone at knifepoint after all.

But perhaps he wasn't as reckless and unhinged as my memories led me to believe.

I even began to question if maybe Quentin's wishful thinking wasn't so wishful after all, and that Aston really did want to move on—start over—and forget I exist. That the night of the Bell Game was a fluke. That he remembered...remembered enough... and decided pushing for more wasn't worth the risk to his freedom.

Even more outrageously, I wondered if perhaps *I* conflated his impact on my life...my psyche. Clinging to the twisted memories I had of him as

some kind of...coping mechanism.

I should be furious that none of those possibilities is actually the case.

Hell, I should be terrified and worried and stressing the fuck out now that he's made it crystal fucking clear he's just been biding his time. Waiting for me to lower my guard. All but laying out a trap to ensnare me the second the opportunity presented itself.

I never would've thought he had the restraint. The patience.

I should be anything but...pleased.

Pleased that he's no more done with me than I am him.

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CHAPTER 11

VALE

THE PAST

I'M SHAKEN out of a deep, black sleep—the kind where nothing exists.

A warm, sweaty hand is slapped over my mouth just as I go to scream. It's small, about the same size as mine, and when it's thrust against my teeth and smushed against my tongue, I taste something sweet.

Candy maybe.

My eyes bulge from my head, but it doesn't help. I can't see a thing, except for a stripe of faint light stretched out under the window. I've been living here long enough now to know it's just a nearby streetlamp peeking in.

My breaths are choppy, nearly drowning out the hissed voice in my ear.

"Shh!"

I whimper, and he tightens his grip on my face to the point I can't even breathe. He's practically laying on top of me, holding my squirming body down.

He shakes me. Hard. "Stop!"

Spit hits my ear, and my face tries to scrunch up. Gross.

"You need to be quiet!" he grits out in a hush. "You'll wake them up."

My body trembles. It feels like fire's licking up my throat, and if I could, I'd be grinding my teeth. But instead, my jaw just throbs against the heel of his palm with nowhere to go.

I seethe hotly against his hand, digging my short nails into my palms, wishing it was his wrists instead.

He pants in my ear and seems to be waiting for something. So I hold still, remembering what my dad told me when he took me hunting last year. "Hold still. Watch. Don't move a muscle."

I asked him why, and he said the best predator knows how to be patient. "Let it come to you."

My new foster brother is far from being a clueless deer walking to its death, but for whatever reason, it does the trick. My patience wins out, and suddenly I can taste air again.

Turning my head, I glare at what I assume is Aston's face. Now that my eyes are adjusting, I can sort of make out the outline of his body. See the change in shades of gray as he moves away from me.

But he doesn't leave the bed.

It's a twin and not very soft, but I've mostly gotten used to it. I miss my bed though. I wonder what happened to it.

"Sorry," Aston mumbles quietly, and I feel more than see him settle onto his back. His shoulder knocks mine, and I tense. "You were whimpering. Could hear you through the wall. Thought you were gonna start screaming."

Blinking, I try and fail to see him more clearly.

"Bad dream?"

I say nothing.

It's a long moment before he speaks, his voice so hushed it's a struggle to hear him.

"I used to get them too. Was it about your parents? The crash?" he whispers.

Again, I don't speak. I chew the inside of my cheek.

How did he know about that?

This isn't the first time he's spoken to me, but it is the first time he's being...nice. Nosy.

I scowl at the thought and roll my head away from him to face the window. I can just make out the faint lines of light between the blinds.

It's been two months now since I moved in with the Baders.

Before this, I was with my grandma for four months. But she was old, and I was apparently too much for her to handle, and my only other living

family now that my parents are gone, is an aunt who lives in Texas. Not sure why they didn't try her. I didn't ask.

"Do you talk at all?" Aston asks after a while.

I almost forgot he was here.

I blink at the blinds, wondering if I'll ever talk again. Sometimes it just seems so pointless. Hold still. Watch. Don't move a muscle.

Aston squirms, growing restless, and I purse my lips.

There's a huff, then, "Fine. Whatever. Be weird." I feel him sit up, but he seems to be hesitating.

Turning my head, I find his shadow angled toward me. Sense his gaze, like maybe, somehow, he can see me perfectly fine.

The thought has me hackles rising.

"Just make sure you're quiet like this all the time, though, 'kay?"

I frown, not sure I know what he means.

"You can't be screaming and carrying on during the night," he whispers. "You'll wake him up."

Who? I almost say, but of course, I know who he means.

Rick.

So far my foster dad seems okay. He smells like the beer my dad used to drink, but he smells like it all the time. Like he takes baths in the stuff.

He smokes a lot too, and his teeth are yellow, and he's got a gut so big he looks pregnant.

But he's...nice, I guess. He tells me I'm a good boy and pats my head or shoulder when he passes by sometimes. Louise just ignores me, unless my caseworker's visiting. She doesn't talk much to Aston either, but he doesn't seem to care.

Rick, though...

Aston hates it when I get his attention.

He's been here longer than me. Not sure how long, but long enough that he clearly doesn't want me here, sharing his home with me. Sharing any kind of attention. Sharing the food that we don't always get because they don't have the money to buy groceries.

At least when Rick isn't around, Aston leaves me be, for the most part.

Or at least, he did.

I'm not sure I like this any better than the mean looks I normally get.

Curling my shoulders, I wait for him to say more or finally leave. The bed shifts, creaking faintly, but then it stops. And it's quiet.

A beat passes before he speaks. "If you're having bad dreams or scared or somethin', just knock on the wall, okay?" he says slowly. "I'll come stay with you. Make sure nothin' gets you."

My eyes have adjusted enough by now that I can see his body turn and an arm come up to where he taps the wall just above the headboard.

I'm not scared, I want to tell him.

He's the one who had to come in and shake me awake.

This isn't the first time I've been told I was crying or screaming in my sleep, though it's been a while since it's happened. Not since my parents died.

Night terrors.

That's what they said they were called. Not nightmares, because those kinds of bad dreams you remember.

I don't ever remember my dreams. Good or bad.

I'm not sure I dream at all.

"But if you ever hear me knocking..." he goes on, pulling me out of my memories. There's something to his tone, a stiltedness. It's almost like he's... warning me of something. Speaking in code. "Just ignore it and go back to bed."

My face pulls down in a deep frown. And before I can stop myself, I blurt in a raspy voice, "Why?"

He stills, and my mouth opens, only nothing more comes out.

"So, you do talk," he murmurs so quietly, I feel like the words aren't for me.

I try to swallow but can't.

He huffs again, but this time it sounds almost like a laugh.

I wait, wondering if he'll explain.

A car passes by outside, despite how late it is. Or early...

The whooshing sound seems to pull Aston out of his head, and once it's passed and it's deathly quiet once more, he says, "My room isn't right next to theirs like yours is. And my bed's on the other side of the room. He won't hear me. You might though, so just ignore it. Because he will hear you."

Again, I frown. He's...confusing.

"He'll be really mad, okay? If he hears you, he'll hurt you."

At those three words, I freeze.

But...

“I mean it, Vale,” he says, and a hand grips my wrist, squeezing so tight, it hurts. I try to shake him off, but he just tightens his hold. I’m a year older than him, but he’s taller, stronger, his fingers long enough to wrap around my whole wrist.

And I’m small. Smaller than I’m supposed to be at this age. A late bloomer, they said at my last physical.

Aston could break my bones if he wanted.

“He’ll hurt you.”

I blink a couple times, and again, I hear myself speaking, my voice light and fragile like it could shatter. “Does he hurt you?”

A long moment passes. His fingers clench around my wrist, and I can feel the thud-thud of a pulse. His or mine, I’m not sure.

“No,” he breathes. “He doesn’t, because I’m a good boy.”

And I’m shaking my head before I even realize what I’m doing, because no, no he’s not...

Last week, when Rick was trying to get me to talk, asking me how my day was, if I was liking my new school... Aston threw a glass at the wall above Rick’s and my heads.

Aston had smirked, though his eyes remained weirdly blank. Rick exploded, shouting expletives before stomping toward him, grabbing his arm, and all but dragging him out of the room.

Before they disappeared around the corner, Aston met my gaze over his shoulder, and for one brief moment, I saw... something. I don’t know what.

It’s like he was trying to tell me something. His eyes pleading...

But then he was gone, and I was sure I just imagined it.

He asked for it...

He wanted his attention.

To be punished.

If he was scared and asking for my help, he wouldn’t have misbehaved in the first place.

“I’m a good boy when I have to be,” Aston says quietly, slowly, like he knows exactly what I’m thinking.

Climbing off the bed, he moves like a ghost across the room. The door opens with the quietest of clicks, the wood creaking faintly.

Just before he slips through and disappears, I hear him say softly, “Just keep being a good little mouse. Not a peep. If you need anything, you come to me. No one else.”

And then he's gone.

And all I'm left with is the heart pounding in my ears.

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CHAPTER 12

ASTON

*Stick an arrow in my ass and call me Shnookums,
because Cupid is on the prowl tonight, baby.
And he ain't stoppin' until he gets a little
somethin' somethin' for himself.*

PRESENT DAY

“WATCH WHERE YOU’RE GOING, FREAK!” a girl screeches when one of my wings bats her face.

“Watch the merchandise, bitch!” I sass back, whirling away with a snap of my fingers.

Rude much?!

Adjusting the gold laurel leaf crown sitting prettily atop my head, I resume my journey to the kitchen.

When I overheard there was a party happening tonight—Halloween costumes required—I figured what better opportunity than this to dust off my calendar and make my grand debut into high society.

And what a glorious debut it’s been so far. I look *ah-mazing*.

“Hello, hello,” I say, waving and giving little curtsies as I slink through the crowd of gawkers rearing back to make room for my wings. “Lovely

night, innit? Oh, heyyy, 'sup girl. Love the dress!”

That is the fugliest dress I’ve ever fucking seen.

“Oh, look at those scary claws!” I snap my teeth around a growl. So *ferocious!*

Heavy bass thumps through the walls, vibrating the floorboards and rattling the hung-up picture frames. I don't know whose house this is, but I think I recognize one of the girls in the photos as part of Alicia's clique. Maybe one of the other Alicias. They're all the same to me.

“Hey, hi, hello. Hope you're all having fun. Your costumes are *fab*. Don't forget—no glove, no love. Make smart choices. Say yes to drugs, no to hug—shit, I got that backwards. Don't— Freddy!” I gasp. “Hey, boo. Lookin' sharp.” I blow a kiss. “I'll see you in my dreams tonight.”

He blushes and looks away, biting back a shy smile.

Entering the kitchen, I ignore the rap blasting through the house, instead humming and mouthing the words to “Somebody to Love” by Jefferson Airplane as I go about making myself a drink.

A little bit of this... I pour a couple glugs of rum. ...*and a whole lotta that.* I empty what's left of a carton of pineapple juice into my cup.

I read pineapple juice makes your cum taste sweet, so the more the better, methinks.

Not that I have had tasting cum! It's actually pretty sweet on its own. I've tried it.

Now, Clark, on the other hand...his cum was pretty gross. But sucking him off got me extra bubblegum for my crafts when Bruce wasn't around, so it was a sacrifice I happily endured.

I wonder if Vale's cum is sweet.

I sigh at the thought, taking a hearty sip of the liquid goodness. Imagining it's *his* liquid goodness.

Vale, Vale, Vale.

Why am I not even surprised that's where my head went? If my brain was a museum, three-fourths of it would already be covered in shrines to Vale DuPont, completely eradicating all the passions and trinkets that came before, like a quick-spreading infestation of the most tantalizing kind.

Oops, scratch that, I mean *Riviera*. He's Vale Riviera now. My bad, my bad. One day I'll get it to stick to my wacky noggin.

I'll be honest though—with each passing day since I've been out of Ashwood, it's getting harder and harder to remember there even *was* a

before.

Or rather, an in-between.

Like the past six years were just one long fever dream. One so tragically empty of the boy with the cute stern face and the nearly black eyes. The boy I once tasked myself with protecting. My little brother, not in age, but size. My best friend. My sun and my moon and my stars.

He's bigger than you now, a voice reminds me.

Much bigger.

I grin wolfishly around the rim of my cup at the thought.

Those arms...

Hubba hubba.

They could easily pick me up. Throw me over his shoulder. Hold me up as he pounds into my ass with that huge cock I got a glimpse of yesterday, pressing against his chinos..

And it wasn't just big, it was hard!

I can't wait to see it and feel it and taste it...

And those *hands*! Holy Cher Horowitz, those hands.

I reach up and brush my thumb over my neck, recalling the feel of that monstrous grip squeezing my throat. Basking in the memory of our little creepy bathroom rendezvous.

He somehow managed to not leave bruises; the reddened fingerprints have long since faded. But I wish they didn't. I wish— The sound of a screen door opening draws me from my little reverie, and what do you know—the object of my new obsession has finally graced us with his presence.

Slipping around the refrigerator, I keep out of sight as none other than the big handed, big dickd Vale Riviera enters the house.

About damn time he showed up. Counting on him being here was the only reason I let Eden off the hook tonight, only using him for a ride.

You see, I'm on a mission. A mission that would straight-up *scandalize* my sweet, virginal baby bro, given that I'd have no choice but to leash him to me for the night.

We all saw what happened at the Furnaces. The boy's a magnet for handsy jocks. Heck, just last week, I had to scare off two football players I'd caught harassing him at the water fountain.

And I didn't even have to pull out my knife!

They saw me coming, smiling oh so sweetly their way, licking my lips and rolling my hips, and they scattered like bugs.

I would've been a *tad* offended if Eden didn't proceed to rip me a new one for not minding my business...again...reminding me why I was over there in the first place: to protect his virtue and honor and butt.

Speaking of butts and scaring people off...

Of course Vale didn't show up to the party alone. Peeking around the fridge, my nose wrinkles at the sight of that prim, whiny drag of a butthead boyfriend gripping his arm. The urge to storm over there and shove him away is strong.

Mine! I imagine myself barking, snapping my teeth at him as I clung to Vale's side. Kind of like those seagulls in that cute, sad fish movie calling dibs on their snack. *Mine, mine, mine!*

"I told you I didn't wanna come," Vale says, turning around. I quickly duck behind the fridge before he sees me. "Don't get all pissy that I'm not happy. You didn't have to bring me."

There's a huff, then, "You could at least pretend."

I have to strain to hear them over the music.

"Why? What's the point?"

I picture what's-his-face turning all red and stomping his foot. "What's wrong with you today? First, you forget it's our anniversary, and then..." I tune him out as he goes on and on about all the woes he's been suffering. All the while waiting and praying for him to spontaneously combust.

A boy could dream.

"I'm sorry," Vale says, not sounding sorry at all. I make a face and mouth into the empty space, *What?* I roll my eyes and shake my head.

A sniff, then, "Let's just have a couple drinks, say hi, and then we can leave. Okay?"

A beat passes, in which I assume Vale nods, because then there's a wet, smacky sound that makes me wish I didn't just chug all that rum and pineapple juice.

"*Seriously???*" I grit through my teeth. The cup creaks under my crushing hold, moisture splashing my knuckles. *Does he have no sense of decorum? No shame? No—* "Did you hear that?" Vale says.

I freeze. *Uh oh.*

There's a petulant sigh, followed by more kissy sounds, and a muffled exchange of words I can't make out.

My lip curls, and I'm just about to say to hell with my own shame and decorum, when the arrival of girls chanting "shots!" cuts their little moment short, saving me from sabotaging everything..

And not a second too soon.

I finish my drink in one long gulp, crush the cup, and toss it somewhere behind me, slipping from the room before I draw anyone's attention.

Fire licks at my throat, and it has nothing to do with the lingering burn of liquor I just guzzled down. But rather everything to do with the memory of them touching—the sounds they made when they kissed.

This time, I barely notice the stares and sneers of my jealous peers as I head in the direction of the thumping music and flickering shadows consuming the front of the house.

Bodies swarm around me, cloaked in an array of disguises, bumping and grinding to the music. My heart pounds in time with the heavy bass—a deafening war drum in my chest, summoning me into battle.

What does he even see in him?

Did yesterday mean nothing?

I don't stop my furious march across the house until I reach a dark corner in the packed living room to sulk and plot my next move.

He felt it too. I know he did. He was hard. He wanted me...

And yet he was just kissing *him*.

How? How could he?

Blinking rapidly, I fist my hands at my sides. My skin feels stretched thin—too thin. Caught in a maelstrom of rage and jealousy unlike anything I've ever felt before, I'm practically vibrating.

Am I overreacting? Maybe a little.

Do I fucking care? Nahhhh.

And I especially don't want to try and make sense of why I feel so...so triggered right now, despite the cacophony of voices in my head belonging to therapists, past and present, and years' worth of conditioning urging me to do just that.

Reflect.

Identify

Modify.

But just because I have the tools to slow my roll, doesn't mean I have to use them. Not anymore, not if I don't want to.

My doctors. The orderlies. Tillie...

Rick.

They're not here.

I'm free.

And I've never been as acutely aware of that fact until now, standing on the cusp of right and wrong. Good and bad.

I was a good boy. He said so...

I was good, I was good...

A bolt of pain shoots through my head. Grimacing, I swipe the drink out of someone's hand, ignoring their protests as I take a long pull of the fiery liquid. Welcoming the burn.

I don't want to be good tonight.

Good never got me anywhere.

Across the sea of dark bodies, the *happy couple* appears, hanging back under the lights in the entryway, drinking and mingling with their friends.

Won't be happy for long...

My mouth ticks up over the rim of my cup.

Fuck therapy.

Fuck all these rules, rules, rules.

Fuck Seth and his stupid polos and the spindly claws he's got hooked in my man.

Cupid's villain era is here...

And he's taking no prisoners.

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TRANSCRIPT OF RECORDED INTERVIEW

DL: JUST TO CLARIFY. THIS PARTY WAS HOSTED BY THE DEVEREAU GIRL, CORRECT?

VR: YES. IT WAS HER HOUSE. HER PARENTS WERE AWAY.

DW: MISTER SAINT JAMES WAS INVITED?

VR: NOT QUITE... BUT THIS WAS BEFORE.

DW: BEFORE?

VR: THE FIRST MURDER, BACK WHEN HE WAS...WELL, NOT ACCEPTED. BUT TOLERATED.

[PAUSE]

DL: HOW INTOXICATED WERE YOU THAT NIGHT, WOULD YOU SAY?

VR: DRUNK ENOUGH TO...BE STUPID. BUT NOT DRUNK ENOUGH TO NOT KNOW WHAT I WAS DOING. I REMEMBER IT ALL.

DL: AND MISTER SAINT JAMES?

VR: AS FAR AS I COULD TELL, HE WAS ABOUT AS BUZZED AS I WAS.

[PAUSE]

VR: LOOK, WHAT HAPPENED THAT NIGHT WAS A MISTAKE. DRUNK OR NOT. ONE I'LL LIVE TO REGRET NOW FOR THE REST OF MY LIFE.

DW: BECAUSE YOU TWO GOT CAUGHT, OR— **VR:** BECAUSE I'M NOT THAT GUY. OR RATHER, I DON'T WANT TO BE THAT GUY. I... I MESSED UP. I HURT HIM.

DW: MISTER SAINT JAMES OR...

VR: NO. SETH.

CHAPTER 13

ASTON

“THERE YOU GO. That’s a big boy. A *good*, big boy.”

A muffled groan slips from Seth’s slackened lips.

I grunt, hefting his upper half onto the bed. “Emphasis on big.” I hold up a hand, and back up. “Not that you’re fat. You’re actually pretty skinny, I’m just really out of shape. And even if you were fat, there’s absolutely nothing wrong with that. All bodies are beautiful.” I stare at his relaxed face. His droopy eyes. That cute little button nose...

D’awwww.

Focus!

“Fuck, what am I even *saying*? You’re not *beautiful*. There’s nothing beautiful about you, or cute, because you stole my man, and that just ain’t cool, dude. Not at all. What were you thinking? Does bro code mean nothing to you?”

He makes a soft sound, and I pat his head. “There, there, Sethy. It’s okay. I’m here to right your wrongs.”

It takes a lot of grunting and heavy breathing, but I finally, *finally* get his not-fat ass onto the king-sized bed. Once I have him rolled onto his side, I give his butt a little squeeze—What?! I’m looking for his phone. Plus, it’s a nice ass, even if it belongs to a *traitor*—then grope his sides, patting around until I find a bulge.

Not *that* bulge.

God, get your head out of the gutter.

I sing my favorite Heart song under my breath as I take his lifeless hand, pushing his thumb over the sensor to unlock his phone. “Thanks, babe,” I say, dropping his hand. He doesn’t make a peep.

Shifting onto my back, I turn on his phone camera and lean against the headboard, sliding down until both our faces are in frame.

“Say Cheese!” I grin wide, squishing my cheek up against Seth’s chilly nose and take the picture. Sitting up, I find Vale’s contact and send that baby on over. I then quickly send his contact info to myself.

There!

I delete the thread, as well as the photo I took and sent, erasing all evidence that I’d tampered with his phone—*thank you, Google*—and toss it on the floor.

Now, I wait.

“It’s abysmally pathetic, you know,” I say after a moment. “Truly. Subjecting yourself to a one-sided relationship.” I tsk, and flit a sideways look at the sleeping boy next to me. “Talk about desperate. You’ll thank me for this one day.”

Music continues to play loudly from the first floor; an occasional cheer rising up the stairs. I’m not sure whose room this is, but it looks hardly lived in, telling me it’s a guest room. From the floor, the phone starts ringing. I ignore it.

Tonight has worked out *superbly*, if I do say myself. Not long after I’d calmed down enough to start plotting, an opportunity presented itself that was just so perfect, I couldn’t help but see it for what it was:

A sign from the universe telling me, *yasssss*.

Because it was there, just beyond the DJ booth, that I spotted a cute little fellow with a goatee that even Captain Hook would be absolutely *envious* of, in the sneaky process of popping a little pill in a girl’s drink when she was turned away.

Kismet, right?

While Hookie Boy wasn’t all too happy to have gotten caught, he was quick to change his attitude when I made him a deal.

(This is probably the part in the story where you’re wondering if I’m redeemable, right? Well, spoiler alert, I’m not.)

Fast-forward one too many drinks on little Sethy’s part, one of which having been doctored by yours truly, and another seemingly never-ending half-hour of waiting and watching and more *waiting*...

The door bursts open.

Showtime!

I snap my head up just in time to see Vale coming at me. And boy, is he angry.

“Hey, pumpkin!” I chirp brightly as he grabs me by the shoulders in those massive footballer hands of his. I don’t think he even realizes how tightly he’s holding me. Definitely tight enough to leave bruises this time. My chest turns all goopy at the thought.

His steely gaze shifts past me to where his sweet little Prince lies passed out in the fetal position. His jaw ticks, and I cock my head with a frown.

He doesn’t look... worried, like one would expect after finding out their soon-to-be ex-boyfriend was drugged and held hostage.

He looks rather annoyed. Inconvenienced, even.

“Did you touch him?”

“I touched his butt.”

He glares at me.

I shrug. “I was looking for his phone.”

He rolls his eyes, so I do too. He wrinkles his nose, so I wrinkle mine.

“Stop.”

“Stop.”

He stares at me, and I stare back. His gaze flits down, then back up, and he says, “What the fuck are you wearing?”

“I’m Cupid. *Duh!*” I say, spreading my arms to show off my cute little toga I made with a sheet. Behind me, a pair of white flimsy wings jut out from my back. They’re held by clear tape hooked under my pits. I found the wings along with the cuffs for my wrists and gold laurel crown currently sitting atop my hair in the bottom of an old trunk down in the basement.

Something tells me my girl Gertie was quite the kinky gal back in her day.

And to top it all off, all up and down my arms and on my cheeks, I stuck little pink and red heart stickers. Just so no one would mistake me for any little ol’ angel.

His dark brows arch. “I gathered that. Why?”

I blink at him. “Why not? It’s a costume party, Vale. Where’s yours?”

He studies me with a look I can’t place, and I can normally place a lot of looks. But there’s something about Vale that’s always been hidden from me. Even back when we were kids, randomly thrown together in the same shitty foster home.

His hands drop away all of a sudden, as if he just remembered he was holding me. I sigh at the loss, watching as he spins to face the door.

No, it doesn't escape me that he never answered my question.

My gaze drops, taking in how well he fills out his jeans. Just the right amount of tightness to give that firmly sculpted ass some much-needed *oomph* compared to our school uniforms.

Not quite as delicious as spandex though, I think, reflecting on how he looks playing football. I've attended every game since that first one.

Garbled mumbling from behind me has him whirling around, and my brows spike at the new view before I can help myself.

Not that I *would*...

"Fucking Christ. Stop."

I pout and glance up to find him glaring at me, arms folded across his chest. With only a short-sleeved black t-shirt on, I can make out every taut line of his muscles. Every teal-hued vein branching out down his forearms.

Sex god. He went as a sex god.

Wetting my lips, I bat my eyes. "Stop what?"

His nose flares, and his lip curls. "You know what."

"I really don't."

He lunges forward, grabbing me by the throat. Just like he did in the bathroom yesterday, only this time he doesn't try to steal my air from me.

"Stop looking at me like that." When he speaks, I catch a whiff of alcohol on his breath. *Tequila*, I think. No wonder he's so feisty tonight.

"Like what?"

"Like you wanna eat me," he all but growls.

My mouth twitches. "Do you want to eat me instead?"

He looks me up and down, not even bothering to mask his disgust.

It shouldn't bother me, not when it's a look I've seen aimed my way so many times before this. I'm no stranger to the sneers and wrinkled, upturned noses. Like I'm no better than the dirt on some rich bitch's Louboutins.

On my feet, or on my knees, it's always the same. I'm scum. Nothing more than a hole to use, abuse, and throw away like yesterday's trash.

And until now, I was okay with that. So long as it was my idea, and it got me all the things in the world I wanted, I was peachy keen about it.

And I can't even quite say it *does* bother me that Vale, of all people, is looking at me like he is now.

On one hand, I want to be a good boy and do everything in my power to wipe that revulsion from his eyes. To drop down on my knees and let my throat do the talking.

I've always been so much better at show than tell after all. When I talk, the words just tend to get all mixed up, fogging the truth of my intentions.

On the other hand...

"Or would you rather hurt me?" I whisper into a sly grin. "Make me pay for what I did to your sweet little boo over there." I cock my head. "He's cute. Is he cute under the button-ups and khakis too?"

Vale's mouth thins, and I can't help but admire the sculpted lines of his face. Like he was carved out of stone. He looks so much older than his nineteen years—it'll be twenty in just a few short weeks, my little Scorpio baby—and so very little like the mousey boy who so foolishly intervened all those years ago.

At least, that's what I was told. Amnesia, remember? Everyone's second to least-favorite trope. The first being what's about to go down because I'm nothing if not thorough when it comes to yumming on yucks.

"He smells good," I whisper, anxious energy coursing through my limbs, settling my skin abuzz. "Like some fancy cologne. Is that what you like? Fancy things. Fancy car, fancy school, fancy boyfriend, fancy life."

"Shut up."

My heart thrashes around in my chest. "I could be fancy for you. Tell me what you like, and I'll find it. I'll get it. Anything you want."

Heat flares in his gaze, before icing over. "What's wrong with you?"

I reach forward, tiptoeing my fingers up his chest. He sucks in a breath, just as I arch my neck, pressing it further into the curve of his hand. "You should know."

He tenses.

My lashes flutter. "Tell me, Vale *DuPont*." Something cracks in his expression, and I know I'm getting warmer. Closer. I'm nanoseconds away from breaking him wide open. "How is it that you got to live the Cinderella fairytale, while I was left to roam the gutters with the other rats?"

He seethes, and I push up on my toes, getting right in his face. "Do you remember what it feels like? The blood. The—"

He slaps me across the face.

Hard.

I think it catches him off guard more than it does me, but still. Owwww.

“Well, that wasn’t very nice, Valeykins,” I say, pouting as I rub my cheek. Poking my tongue around, I’m not surprised I taste a hint of blood.

My dick gives a jolt. *Fuckkkkk.*

His eyes are so dark, I can see my reflection in their glassy pools. He looks possessed. *Fucking sexy.*

“Touchy, are we?” I whisper. “And to think, I’m the one with the so-called temper.”

He shoves me, and the next thing I know I’m flat on my back with one pissed off quarterback seizing me by the neck. I’m beginning to think he has a fetish for this.

Air wheezes out of me as he pinches my cheeks with one hand, while the other remains clamped around my throat, holding my head in place as he adds pressure, squeezing my windpipe with bruising force. Cutting off my oxygen.

He’s gripping my face so hard, I’m pretty sure my teeth are about to burst through my cheeks. Like my brain’s about to pop out of my ears.

I claw at his arms instinctively, and my legs try to kick out from under him, but it’s no use. He’s so much bigger than me. And it’s not even like I want to escape. If anything, I just want to curl them around him to keep him here. Never let him go.

But he won’t let me do that.

Not that I think I need to.

He doesn’t seem to be going anywhere anytime soon, if his brutal hold on me and the boner jabbing me in the stomach are anything to go by.

Ah, so the other day wasn’t a fluke.

He’s as fucked in the head as me.

It’s a full-on assault to my senses as he dips down, crushing his nose to mine. Iron floods my mouth and he’s all I see, all I smell, and all I hear.

And he’s the only thing I can *feel*.

His strong thighs straddle my hips as he grinds that big dick of his against my stomach. I can feel my skimpy little toga loosening from his rough, desperate movements. I arch up, thrusting, seeking more friction in the only way I can. Which is not very much.

My lips chase his, desperate to bridge the barely-there gap, but he pulls back suddenly, before I ever get the chance, releasing me completely. But he still sits on me, so my pitiful whine of protest is simply just that: pitiful.

Vale's lips are parted, looking fuller somehow, despite never having kissed me. His eyes are hooded, cheeks are flushed. Messy dark brown hair flops over his brow, and I realize this is the most unkempt I've seen him since blowing back into his orbit.

He's normally so put-together. So in control.

Except for when I piss him off apparently.

"Don't stop," I rasp, licking my lips.

Somewhere in the back of my mind, it occurs to me, and not for the first time, that I once thought of this guy as my brother. Shouldn't that make this kind of...weird? Gross? Now that we're finally here, doing the nasty.

Heat flares up in those bottomless pits for eyes, and I feel a breathy smile stretch across my face as I spread my arms across the bed. Surrendering to the big, bad football player.

No. Nope. Definitely not.

This is fucking *hot*.

My fingers bump into something, and it takes me a second to remember we're not alone. I quickly roll my head to glance over at the figure sprawled out on the far side of the bed. I give his foot a shove, waiting for him to jolt awake.

Nothing.

Turning my head forward once more, I start to say something to Vale, when he climbs off me.

Panic and desperation roll through me like a tidal wave. "Don't—"

My words are quickly choked out by a grunt as Vale flips me over onto my stomach. The air whooshes out of me as I grapple at the duvet. I feel the fabric wrapped around me pulling, and then all at once, it's gone. Ripped away from where it was covering my bare ass. Exposing my skin to the chilly air.

Vale bites out a curse when he realizes I was naked under my costume.

I roll my head, peeking over my shoulder. Wiggling my butt, I say, "Can I at least keep the wings?"

Rather than answer me out loud, he smacks my ass. Hard. Harder than he hit my face.

I hiss, bucking forward into the mattress, prompting a dark chuckle from him as he smooths a hand over my throbbing flesh.

Holy hotness, Batman.

Then, suddenly, there's a hand reaching between my legs, brushing up over my balls so unexpectedly my stomach caves in, and I find myself arching up for him. All but shoving my greedy hole in his face.

He gives my dick a firm squeeze, his hand warm and so, so big. At the same time the other one comes down hard on my other cheek. Not as hard as the first *thwack* but still scorching.

A moan punches out of me, breaking off into a gasp. Unintelligible nonsense scrambles out from my parched throat as he hums in appreciation. "This what you came for?"

Squeezing my eyes shut, all I can do is nod.

Pretty sure I'd nod to just about anything right now.

"So fucking needy," he mutters, almost like he's talking to himself. I'm dripping like a faucet, yet he makes no move to use my pre-cum as lubricant. He jerks me dry. It's as if he doesn't want this to feel good for me...as if he wants it to hurt.

At the same time he strokes my cock, he spreads one cheek, stealing a peek of my hole. "Such a little slut for it, aren't you?"

I try not to squirm.

"A pretty little hole for a pretty little slut," he says almost mockingly. Then without warning, or any prep, he thrusts a finger in me.

My chest seizes. Eyes bug. If it wasn't for him holding me down, I'm certain I would've flown right up out of the bed.

"Shh," he whispers, stroking my inner walls with a thick, punishing finger. It burns like a mofo, but gun to my head, this is the best burn I've ever felt in my entire life. "You're gonna be good for me now. You know this is what you deserve." His finger twists and crooks, glancing over that little sweet spot all too fast before he's pulling out.

"Vale," I whine, and I'm not even ashamed of it. Not one bit. I wiggle my ass, trying desperately to thrust it up at him at the same time he circles his fingers around my balls and squeezes. I manage to grunt out a single word. "More."

It *hurts*. Fuck, does it hurt. This need inside me. This emptiness. The vice on my sac. The echo of his slaps, of his dry finger thrusting inside me. It all hurts so fucking good and so fucking bad, I no longer know up from down. Right from wrong...

Not that I ever gave such follies much consideration to begin with.

“Jesus, look at you,” he says, releasing my balls, sliding back up between my ass before letting go of me completely.

Tears crest my eyes as I white-knuckle the paisley printed duvet. Beneath me, my dick weeps into the scratchy fabric like a poor old widow mourning her long-lost love. Lonely, inconsolable, and so, so tragically deprived.

Another hard smack to my ass has red-hot delicious pain shooting up my spine.

“You like it when I hurt you, don’t you?” he says, trailing his fingers over my bruised, beaten flesh. “You like being at my mercy, you sick little freak.”

I bite the blanket, grinding desperately into the bed.

“That’s it,” he whispers. I hear the glorious sound of a belt coming undone. The soft *click* and *zip* of his fly. “Show me how badly you want it. You’re aching for it, aren’t you? Look at that pretty pink hole, fluttering about, begging to be filled.”

Yes, yes, yes!

A dark, wicked chuckle fills the room, and then I hear a loud spit a second before I feel wetness dripping down the cleft of my ass. Rough, angry fingers rub it around my flesh, sinking into my tight heat.

I’ve never felt so simultaneously connected and disconnected from a lover. I’m nothing more than an object to him. Property to be used and abused.

But when he grabs my hand, pinning it next to my head, and blankets that big, fully clothed body over me, crushing my wings between us, and knocking against my quivering hole with the blunt head of his cock...

I realize I’ve never felt so damn owned either.

A whimper escapes me as he nudges at my hole the ever faintest bit. I sense his arm moving, like he’s jerking himself. I wiggle, and he lowers his weight enough so that I can’t move.

But he still doesn’t push inside me.

He’s playing with me.

Torturing me.

He turns his head, licking a stripe up my neck. He hums, nipping my skin with his teeth. “You’re a sweet little thing, aren’t you?” He says the words so quietly, I can’t even be sure they’re for me. “Sweet under all that filth.”

“Vale,” I whine into the bedding.

“Mmm, like sugar,” he murmurs, sucking a bruise just below my ear. His fingers clench around mine, grinding my bones together. “Sweet and tempting but will rot you from the inside out.”

I shake my head. “N-no, I’ll b-be g-good. So good, so, so good for you, *please*,” I babble.

“That so? You think someone like you can be good enough for me?”

My knees quake. I can barely hold myself up. “Y-yesss,” I half growl, half cry, shoving my hips back, and earning a sharp nip of his teeth.

“You want me to fuck you?” he growls into my hair, dragging his tip roughly back and forth over my hole.

I manage to roll my head to the side, eyes cracked to slits. “Yes!” I gasp.

A wicked chuckle rumbles into my sweaty hair. “I don’t know...”

I whimper, my entire body trembling.

“I think I need you to beg for it. Scream for it. Let the world know just how much of a slut you are.”

“Anything!” I croak.

He hums. “Yeah? You’ll scream for me, *sugar*?” he taunts, sounding as cruel as his fingers feel.

Eyes flying wide open, I go to respond when I collide with a droopy, glassy set of blue peeking down at me from the head of the bed.

Oh, hi there, I think, a breathless smile creeping up my flushed face.

“I’ll scream so loud,” I moan, not taking my eyes off those watching us. “Everyone will know who I belong to. Please. Please fuck me Vale. Make me yours.”

Behind me, there’s a grunt and a curse. And just enough pressure that he sinks inside me. But only just.

And I’m babbling and moaning and *dying* for more...

“*Please*,” I beg shamelessly, screwing my eyes shut as I try futilely to impale myself fully. “Please do it. Please fuck me. Fill me. Hurt me. *Vale*. Pleasepleaseple—”

Vale tenses. Jerks. And then buries a roar in my neck, teeth bared against my skin.

I go utterly still, my eyes springing back open just as hot warmth shoots inside me. I’m not even sure if he’s made it even an inch inside me. I feel it streaming down the inside of my thighs. Pooling at my balls.

He didn’t even fuck me.

He didn't even *fuck me*.

I'm dimly aware of him pulling back and using my hot, tingling flesh to wipe the cum off his cock. Using me as his own personal rag.

"There," he says flatly. And before I know what's happening, he reaches around me to shove his cum-soaked fingers in my mouth. Deep enough to hit the back of my throat and make me gag. "Happy now?"

I sputter when he releases me, all while trying to catch every drop he's so generously given me.

"Enjoy it, because it's the last taste you'll ever get of me."

Blinking heavily, I barely register his words as I use my boneless arms to push up off the mattress. Nearly stumbling to the floor when I find my feet. A quick glance down shows my cock is red-raw, shaft glistening with sticky pre-cum. The hue matches my sneakers.

Behind me, I feel wetness dribbling out of my sore yet barely used hole.

"Now, get dressed and get the fuck out of my sight."

"What, no snuggle?" I mumble, running my fingers through my hair.

Fuckkkk, is this what blue balls feels like?

I can safely say I'm not a fan.

A hand whips out, gripping me by the jaw, wrenching me around to face him.

I stumble forward, my chest bumping against his. He's still dressed, while I'm over here, in nothing but my flimsy angel wings and red high-tops, skin flushed and bruised, covered in sweat and cum.

Cum that isn't *mine*.

Black, murderous eyes glare down at me, and I gulp before I can stop it. My tender throat screaming in protest.

Chills break out across my neck as a prickle of awareness scrapes along the back of my mind the longer I stare into those vacant orbs. Flashes of images flicker over my vision, but like always, that night is mostly shrouded in black.

Maybe I messed him up more than I thought. Something twinges in my gut at the thought. My eye twitching with a pulse of pain.

But before I can dwell on it, Vale blinks, and whatever weirdness was there a second ago is gone, and I'm being shoved away like I'm nothing more than a useless, discarded rag doll.

He grabs the white, wrinkled sheet from the ground, balls it up, and throws it at my chest. Without a word, he stomps toward the door, only

pausing when a muffled moan sounds from the bed.

His hand clenches around the doorknob, and he hangs his head before glancing over his shoulder. I follow his gaze to where little Seth struggles to move. His eyes are cracked to slits, head drooping like it weighs a thousand pounds.

“Mmrr,” he says. Moans, really.

“Great,” Vale mutters.

I cast another glance toward the door, my brows knitting when I catch the tick in Vale’s jaw as he scrubs his hands over his hair. His gaze is trained on the ground, but he suddenly seems miles away, lost in thought.

I take that as my sign to go. I didn’t quite get what I wanted...but I got something? No use pressing my luck.

Patience, little grasshopper.

I’m also just...well, confused.

Something feels...off.

Quickly, quietly, I wrap the sheet around my waist, knotting it against my hip bone where it starts to sag. Running a hand through my hair, I adjust my crown, wincing when my fingers catch on a knot.

Without another word, I easily side-step a mute Vale and throw open the door. Leaving whatever *that* was—that...feeling, that...churning sensation—behind.

This must be what being drunk feels like. Buzzed. That’s all this is, I tell myself.

And if I’m feeling a little more...used than usual...

By the one person I never expected to treat me that way...

Well, then, so be it.

He’s drunk too, a voice reminds me. *You also drugged his boyfriend,* sooo...

And I breathe a little easier, nodding to myself.

He’ll come around.

Plus, it’s not like that wasn’t hot as fuck. The fact I’m still half hard proves as much. And there’s also the whole Seth of it all. Like come on. Vale cheated *right in front of him*. Barely conscious or not. There’s no way their relationship will survive this.

So, yeah, it’s definitely the booze making me feel all weird and spacey.

Loud, heavy rap music bowls me over when I emerge from the bedroom, intermingling with the raucous noises of the party still going on

strong below.

A couple people lingering by the stairs turn their wide eyes my way when they notice me strutting toward them, gazes dropping to my bare chest. I smirk and give them a wink. They're lucky the sheet is bunched enough around my waist it hides my lingering arousal.

They all but throw themselves out of the way, allowing me to pass by.

More stares greet me as I make my descent, weaving through the bodies loitering along the stairs and down the hall. An open bottle of rum just sitting unattended on an end table grabs my attention, so I grab it, bringing the lip to my mouth.

Not like there's any point stoppin' now.

Music is blasting from the surround-sound speakers, tickling my ear drums. With each resounding thud of the bass, I'm surprised the foundation doesn't collapse.

Some people laugh when they notice me. Some sneer. Some look horrified by the sheer sight of me.

My skin tingles. Chest feels all warm. Cheeks hurt from sucking in a smile.

I can feel their eyes boring holes into my exposed skin, tracing the bites and bruises that no doubt litter my back, my neck, my arms as I pass them.

My grin turns rogue at the thought, at the images I have in my head.

Did they hear us? Did they hear the way I begged him?

Can they see the wet spots in the sheet from Vale's cum leaking down my legs?

He might not have fucked me, but he sure did make a pretty mess of me.

Just as I reach outside, I hand the near-empty bottle to some greasy dude smoking a joint.

With a wink, I say, "Thanks for having me."

Leaving him gaping after me, I skip down the steps, throw my arms out, grin up at the moon, and howl.

CHAPTER 14

VALE

WHAT THE FUCK did I just do?

Kicking the bathroom door shut, I flip the light on with my elbow and haul a barely conscious Seth toward the tub.

The heavy sound of “6 FEET UNDER” by GRAVEDGR plays from downstairs, loud but muffled as it shakes the floor and rattles the fancy light fixture above the sink. Each pulse sends flickers of yellowy light over the room like it’s a fucking disco ball.

The walls are blood-red, and for a second, my vision blurs, seeing double, as that red seems to reflect off my fingers.

Dropping Seth unceremoniously into the tub, I turn the shower on, letting it run cold. Hopefully, it’ll shock some life into him so I can get him the fuck out of here and forget this night ever happened.

With a sigh, I scrub my hands down my face and head toward the sink.

I grip the counter, dropping my head, resting all my weight in my clenched fingers. Looking up through my lashes, I take in my reflection. The hard planes of my face. My dark tousled hair. My nearly black irises.

I watch as my jaw works and I narrow my gaze, unable to help myself from remembering the way Aston looked up at me only minutes ago. Wondering what he saw in me to prompt that delicate gulp against the heel of my palm. That flicker in his gaze.

For a split second, he looked almost...scared.

Petrified. Like a cute, ruined little kitten.

So unlike the annoying little shit who’d drugged my boyfriend. The guy who’s made it his mission to provoke me.

He looked like my brother, I realize. Soft. Innocent. The one I remember. The one that came...before.

It's a lie. An act.

The ends of my vision turn black as memories invade.

Three... four... you better lock the door...

His childish singing echoes, thrashing around my skull.

Please. Pleasepleaseplea—

Images of Rick flash across my mind as I squeeze my eyes shut and drop my head. His snarling face. That heavy gut jiggling above his open fly. The grubby hands reaching for my neck, his even grubbier dick swinging about.

My nose flares as disgust and something else, something red-hot, sparks a fire in my chest.

I don't realize I've let go of the sink and pulled out the knife from my pocket—the one I swiped from the bedroom floor where it fell; God knows where he hid it—not until I've already broken skin, right over where I cut myself all those years ago on a shard of glass.

Just over the meat of my thumb, I watch as ruby red droplets bubble up from the small nick and fight the urge not to squeeze my hand around the sharp slick metal.

"V-Vale," a voice whimpers behind me, but I barely hear him.

Not under the blood roaring in my ears.

My mouth ticks up as I glance up, taking in my reflection once more. Dad's warning from so many weeks ago tumbling through my head.

So much for not poking the beast, I think with a slow shake of my head.

I almost want to laugh at the thought.

Even if worse comes to worst and Aston's memory is somehow sparked by what just happened...

Would anyone actually believe him? Especially after all these years.

Another plea comes from behind me, this one clearer, louder.

Straightening to my full height, I close the butterfly knife and slip it back in my pocket. Turning, I stride toward the wet, boneless heap in the clawfoot tub and cock my head.

Music pulses through the walls, in time with the steady beat of my heart.

Seth's blue eyes are bloodshot to hell, pupils no bigger than a pinprick. He's awake, but he's still out of it. I turn off the icy water pounding down

on him from the showerhead.

Does he remember what happened? I wonder, replaying the scene in the bedroom. Remembering the slitted eyes that stared back as I taunted and made a mess of Aston, unable to look away.

Seth's head droops as his eyes flutter shut again, but at least he's able to carry some weight this time when I heave his sopping wet body to a stand.

"Someone's had a bit too much to drink, huh?" I say.

His little moan tells me he agrees, and I give his cheek a couple pats. A drop of blood from my finger smears across his jaw, turning pink from the chilly water clinging to his face.

Tucking his head to my chest as I wrap an arm around him, I guide him toward the door. His feet drag, but some part of him must be online, making it so I don't have to pick him up and carry him again. Not that he's heavy, but my arms are tired.

Hell, my whole body is, now that I've satisfied some of my baser needs.

"Cabin Fever" by Corpse starts playing as we make our way down the hall, loud enough to drown out the battle going on in my head.

I get a couple side-eyes and wary smiles, but I'm not too worried. It's not like they know for certain what happened in that room. It's not like anyone tried to stop it even if they had heard or suspected something was amiss.

The door wasn't locked. Someone could've come in at any point to see what was going on. Put a stop to it.

Or at least tried to...

But they didn't.

And it's not like Seth will remember this night to give any sort of credible account should it even come up.

Just like Aston doesn't remember what happened all those years ago.

The night I saved his life.

The night I stole his future.

The night I damned us to a lie.

This is what you get for poking first, sugar.

CHAPTER 15

VALE

THE PAST

“I’M WORRIED,” Quentin says from the other side of the wall.

It’s late. Way past what my new dad would probably call my bedtime, despite me being fourteen now. So late, I figured he’d be asleep too. He’s usually out by eleven at the latest. Earlier on days where he’s pulling long hours at the office.

He’s a lawyer—a defense attorney. He protects criminals.

Or rather, he protects those accused of crimes. Whether or not they actually are guilty doesn’t really seem to matter from what I’ve gathered.

After all, it was only last year when he visited me in the group home for the first time, asking me questions about what happened at the Baders to “build his case.” A case where basically the state itself was being put on trial for failing to protect two of its helpless wards.

He felt bad about it, he confessed to me later. Said he was just doing his job, but it was the one time he really hated what he does.

“The system failed you. Terribly,” he’d told me.

I just stared at him, waiting for him to tell me something I didn’t already know. Just because I don’t talk much, or really at all these days, not when people are around at least, doesn’t mean I’m stupid.

Back in the hallway, a rustle of paper sounds from Quentin’s office, followed by a harsh exhale. “I get that. But it’s been over a year now, and

there's been no...improvement. Hell, I'd take him regressing at this point. There's just...nothing."

Ah.

This again.

"I think...I think it's time."

My jaw clenches, right along with my fists at my sides.

Figures.

Shaking my head, I'm about to turn around and head to my room, start packing my things, when his next words halt me.

"I know, Marv," he says tiredly. "I know I got too close to this. I know you didn't agree with my decision to adopt him. What can I say? I feel sick over that case. Over what happened to those boys—both of them. Yeah, yeah, I know. But come on, you and I both know that fucker deserved what he got, and CPS barely got a slap on the fuckin' wrist for their role in it. It was blatant neglect on their part."

It's a moment before he speaks again. "Yeah, I know. But that's the point. It shouldn't have been so easy to clear their name. They're protected by so many layers of fine print, it'll be a miracle if they ever have to pay for their fuck-ups. The least I could do is try to give one of its victims a fair shot at life, seeing as the other one got royally fucking screwed and you and I both know it."

Aston.

I suck on the inside of my cheek, staring straight ahead at nothing.

Did he get screwed though?

Last I heard, my foster brother was locked away in a mental hospital. I'm assuming nothing has changed. He made a mess that night. Lost his shit.

I can still hear his laughter.

Hear him singing.

"One...two...he's a comin' for you..."

The sounds of choking. Of shattering glass.

My hand burns...

There's so much blood...

"And that's precisely why I don't want to do this anymore," Quentin exclaims. Dad, my brain corrects automatically, despite it never sticking.

All thoughts of Aston and that night fade once more to the background.

I'm still not used to the idea of having a dad again after all these years. Not that Quentin has asked me to call him that, even after the adoption was made official last month. I think it would make him happy though, if I did. Maybe he'd think that means I'm moving forward, or whatever.

Then again, at this point, I think he'd be happy if I said anything at all...

"I don't—" Marv must cut him off, and I picture him shaking his head as he goes on, "No, no, I'm not retiring." He chuckles quietly at his own joke. "Let's not get ahead of ourselves. I just...I think it's time for a change of pace. A fresh start for us both."

I perk up at that.

Us both?

"I was actually in touch with an old buddy of mine from where I grew up. He' was just promoted to Headmaster for the same academy we graduated from." He chuckles wryly. "Can't say I ever saw myself going back to Crowley, but Mom's still there, even if she's in a home and doesn't remember me.

"It's a good town," he continues. "Small. A little run down. But it's safe. Great schools. And Grady Prep has a killer football program on top of its stellar curriculum. Hell, it could be good for the kid, getting him involved. Give him a chance to finally let off some steam. God knows he could use it—use something."

I look down at my hands. Football...

A couple years ago, Aston and I found one, half-deflated, at the park down the street. We threw it around for a bit, trying and failing to get it to spiral or whatever. Aston really liked throwing it at me—going long—and then chasing me to tackle me.

Later, when the sun went down and the park closed, he told me I could keep it if I wanted.

So, I did.

Sometimes in my bedroom, late at night, I'd hold it to my chest as I tried to ignore the knocking in the room next door. I'd often find myself waking up with it in my arms, kind of like how little kids hold stuffed teddies to their chests.

I miss it.

Just another thing I lost that night.

Another thing taken from me...

It's quiet for so long that I begin to wonder if I missed Quentin hanging up.

But then in a murmur I have to strain extra hard to hear— "Sometimes I feel like he's a ticking time-bomb."

I still.

"And it's not just because he won't talk. He's just so...distant. So hard to reach. There's something..."

Off.

A voice I haven't heard in years rushes forward—faint and murky, like it's from a dream.

"Something's wrong, Hugh. He's my child, but he doesn't feel like mine. Something's just...off about him."

"What happened that night..." Quentin goes on so quietly, I nearly miss it. I strain closer to hear him, shoving away the memories to focus on the present. "Something about it just... never sat right with me."

My eyes widen, my pulse quickening ever so faintly. There's a buzzing in my fingers. Flutters in my belly.

"I don't know," he mutters. I squint, pressing my ear nearly right up against the door, next to the small gap where it rests against the door jamb. "I don't know what I'm saying. Forget I said anything," Quentin rushes out roughly. He clears his throat. "Regardless, I just hope Ashwood does better by that boy than CPS did. But God knows when it comes to kids' mental health in this country, it's fucked."

I blink a couple times, feeling like I missed something.

There's a squeaking sound telling me Quentin's lounging back in his desk chair. "Yeah, go. Sorry for calling so late. Just wanted to make sure you heard it from me first." A pause. "I'll talk to Vale. See what he thinks. Last thing I want to do is uproot his life even further, you know?"

I take a quiet step back, processing everything that I overheard as Quentin makes his goodbyes.

There's a thud—likely him tossing his cellphone on his desk. I hear a muffled groan, like maybe he's covering his face.

Biting my lip, I turn my head, eyeing the hallway from which I came.

I'd come down for a glass of water, and to go outside. It's something I started doing when I came to live here. We're far enough away from the city that there's hardly any light pollution. Sometimes, when it's warmer, I lay in the grass and stare up at the stars, connecting the dots in my head.

Other times, I bring with me the journal my therapist gave me. I've yet to write in it, like she wanted. What's the point? If I wanted to say something, I'd talk.

So instead, I draw. Not that I'm any good, but sometimes it feels good to just get it out. Dreams that only come when I'm awake, in flashes and desires. My memories. Stuff I wonder about when I'm bored. It seems too risky to put words to, so I use symbols instead—let my drawings speak for themselves.

And then when I finally get up to go inside to bed, I stare at the page, ingrain whatever I drew to my memory, and then I rip it all up and chuck the pieces in the woods.

No one can see.

Quiet as a mouse.

My lip curls, and I shake my head.

Too preoccupied by my thoughts, I slip up—hit the corner of table with my hip. A vase teeters and I tense, cringing, hissing through my teeth.

“Vale? That you?”

My eyes widen, and I quickly hunch my shoulders, making myself appear smaller. I had a growth spurt over the summer. Proper nutrition does wonders for puberty. Finally, I look my age.

But in moments like this, I resent it. It's made me clumsy.

It's annoying.

Footsteps sound across the floorboard on the other side of the wall, and then the door opens, revealing my adoptive dad.

He's young. Barely even thirty. He would've only been fifteen when I was born...not much older than I am now. He's handsome, I suppose, with medium brown skin and thick, black hair he usually carefully styles. Tonight, though, it hangs messily over his forehead, like maybe he was yanking on it.

It makes him look that much younger.

He eyes me through the shadows with a scrunched look behind his thick black-framed glasses. “You okay? Need something?”

I just stare at him.

His mouth thins and he nods, pinching his nose.

Wetting my lips, I count to three, and then I say, “I think it's a good idea.”

He stills. Slowly, his hand descends from his face. His eyes are wide with what I imagine is shock.

“Moving,” I clarify. My voice is a little rusty—crackly and stilted—but clear enough to understand. “I don’t want to be here.”

Here as in the city. Miles away from where I lived in squalor. From where I was abused and left to starve to death.

Quentin’s eyes widen impossibly more, and then he’s nodding. “Okay then. I’ll get the ball rolling tomorrow.”

I give a single nod back.

Turning on my heel, I start making my way back toward my room, when his voice halts me.

“I don’t know how much you overheard...but just know, I’m glad you’re here.”

I slow to a stop, cocking my head.

“It might’ve started out as guilt...taking you in. Fostering you. But that’s not why I adopted you.”

Stewing on that for a second—on the fact it still makes zero sense to me as to how adopting me assuages him of feelings he has no claim to; he’s not the one who neglected and abused me—I also consider how...interesting it is that he isn’t making a big deal out of the fact that I just spoke my first words to him. It’s been a year since we’ve met. Four months since I came to live with him, not long after the trial ended.

A month now since he legally became my guardian...

My father, for all intents and purposes. Young that he is.

I turn my head, eyeing him over my shoulder. “I know.”

He arches a brow, and I shrug.

I level him with a knowing look. “You were lonely.”

Leaving him standing there gaping, I quickly make my way back to my room, softly closing my door. Stepping back from it, I watch, waiting to see if he’ll follow. Interrogate me.

Maybe about what I meant, how I knew that.

Or maybe about that night from over a year ago.

Maybe further back than that.

My eyes narrow as the seconds pass without a peep. Not a single footstep headed my way.

My gaze drifts away from the door over to where the mirror above my dresser stretches out across the wall. I cock my head, eyeing my round, pale

face. My dark, nearly black eyes. My thick brown hair that is definitely in need of a trim.

My pulse pounds steadily, visible in my reflection from this angle. Thumping through my skin, reminding me I'm alive, even if I look a little plastic and fake standing like this.

So still.

Gangly and awkward.

I frown, and straighten, pulling my shoulders back. Lift my head and work out the tension in my neck.

I smile.

Soften it.

Eh, I'll work on it.

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CHAPTER 16

ASTON

Dear Diary,

Pumpkin patches 10/10

Hayrides 0/10

Why did no one tell me how prickly straw is?

XOXO

-A

PRESENT DAY

THE SUNDAY FOLLOWING the party crawls by at a snail's pace, and to say I've been insufferable to be around as I counted down the seconds to when I'd see Vale again would be an understatement.

If I didn't give myself an ulcer, I definitely gave Eden at least two.

Even going to the pumpkin patch—my first time! I bought the biggest pumpkin I could find. It's got this deep crease down the middle of one side making it look like it has butt cheeks. His name is Gourdon, and he's my

pride and joy—and working on my new garden, cleaning out the beds and whatnot to prepare for the coming winter, wasn't enough to distract me.

More than once, not only Eden, but Tillie, demanded to know what was going on when I could hardly sit still or focus, Tillie even going so far as to ask me if I messed up my meds. And all I could do was stare at her wide-eyed and twitchy, shrug, and tell her I was just happy.

Which wasn't a lie. I'm very happy currently. Life in Crowley is going splendidly thus far, if I do say myself.

When Monday morning finally arrives, Tillie all but shoves me out the house before I can so much as get say good morning to a sleep-rumpled Eden shuffling down the steps—he's got a dentist appointment this morning, so he'll be going in late—shooing me off with a reminder to behave.

She tells me this every day before school, though usually she isn't in such a blatant rush to be rid of me. She also doesn't usually tack on a rushed, "And please be safe," before all but slamming the door in my face.

Have I been that obvious?

Whirling around with a dramatic flourish that sends the tasseled fabric of my scarf rippling in the breeze, I take the stone-cobbled path leading to puke-green station wagon waiting for me in the driveway.

"Morning, Pops," I chirp merrily upon plopping myself in the passenger seat. Walter looks about as pleased by my proximity as I feel on the inside.

"We needed to leave ten minutes ago," he says by way of greeting.

I spread my hands helplessly. "You'd think uniforms would make it easier to decide what to wear, but you'd be surprised." Not to mention my hair decided today of all days that it wanted to stick up every which way.

With a shake of his head, he turns the key, kicking on the grumbly engine. And with it, the radio. It's set to some heavy rock station, which surprises me. Even more so when he cranks up the volume, though perhaps that's just to make a point he's not in the mood for any chit-chat, rather than an indication he's a fan of this song.

Who knows though? Wouldn't surprise me if there's a rebel without a cause hiding beneath all that tweed, wriggling to get out and stir up some chaos.

Daddy dearest just screams tragically repressed.

Rolling the window down halfway, I lean my head on the lip of glass, blinking away the wind assaulting my face as I try not to focus too much on

the fact this is my first time alone in such tight quarters with Tillie's husband.

With autumn now in full swing, painting the town in shades of red and gold, the scent of sweet death is in the air, crisp and pungent. It reminds me of the library we had at Ashwood—a small corner of the rec room—all leather-bound books and yellowed pages, dust clinging to just about every untouched surface.

Some days, I'd sit by the barred window overlooking the courtyard, flipping through the pages of an old book, imagining I was a scholar at Oxford studying for his next big exam. There was a big maple tree just outside, and it would shake and rustle, thwapping its branches against the window as if trying to get me to come out and play.

I often imagined sitting out there instead, under that tree, with my back to the trunk and my knees pulled up to my chest, toes sinking into the earth. A book in my lap, its pages fluttering in the breeze.

There would be no orderlies standing around, eyeing me up, waiting for the next time I wanted something, or needed to be dragged to the Pit.

There would be no timer ticking down the minutes to when the buzzer would go off, summoning us back inside.

I'd be free.

Walter slows the car to a crawl, flipping on the blinker. Wind tosses my hair around, and something wet splashes my cheek. A glance up shows thick gray rain clouds gathering above the trees, making the leaves look even more vibrant. Like they're on fire.

Just as I go to reach out and collect the drops on my fingers, a new song comes on the radio—starting off more mellow than what was previously playing.

Haunting.

And achingly familiar.

It's instantaneous, the way my body responds.

Devastating, even if on the outside, you'd be none the wiser.

My stomach bottoms out, like someone reached inside me and tore open a seam I didn't know was there. A seam that was holding vital parts of me together.

The hollowness in the wake of such an unexpected blow to the infrastructure that keeps me sane has me mentally grappling for some kind of handhold. Anything to keep me from tumbling into oblivion.

Spots dance along the edges of my vision. A cold sweat breaks out across the back of my neck.

As if watching outside myself, I see a pale hand thrust toward the dash, fingers scrambling for the buttons on the radio.

I'm dimly aware of someone speaking. But the roar flooding my ears is too loud to make any sense of it.

It's not until there's an explosion of static filling the car—loud and grating—that I snap back into my body with a gasp.

I blink a couple times, trying to catch my bearings.

Next to me, Walter clutches the steering wheel. It takes moment longer than it probably should to notice we're no longer moving.

He pulled over.

Slowly, slowly, he reaches for the radio, lowering the volume. He adjusts the tuner to a channel that gets a signal—another rock station, but fortunately not the one we'd just been listening to.

A throat clears. "Not a fan of The Animals?"

I give a short shake of my head.

"Should I turn around?"

Another shake of my head.

Vale, I remind myself, grabbing hold of his name—the promise of seeing him soon, even if it's just from afar—like an anchor in a storm.

Everything will be okay when I see Vale again.

There's a loaded moment where I feel like Walt might say something else, but whatever it is, he must think better of. Instead, he shifts the car back into Drive, and pulls away from the curb.

Nothing more is said for the remainder of the short drive, giving me ample time to get my shit under control.

I force myself to focus on the sights, imagining myself as a member of the houses we pass that are all decked out for Halloween. Imagining what it would've been like if Vale and I grew up in a home that put pumpkins out on the porch. Hung wreaths on the door. Cloaked the hedges with lights and cobwebs.

Several houses have these monster sized skeletons standing guard in their front yards, that I simply adore and covet desperately.

If they weren't so damn expensive, I would've already bought a dozen to put in our front yard. But, alas, I can't even afford *one* currently, much less an army. But Tillie said maybe we'll get one next year.

Those words alone were enough to snuff out my disappointment and replace it with something far more asphyxiating: hope.

A year is a long time for me to behave.

Minutes later, we turn up the private gated road leading to Grady Prep. It slowly reveals itself as traffic inches forward steadily, dark and gloomy as ever. A castle buried in a sea of red and orange-tinged trees, the hazy, buttery sun peeks out from behind, casting the weathered brick in shadows. I could almost weep at the sight.

Do they grieve their fallen prince inside?

Does Cinderella wait for me in his tower?

My mouth kicks up into a predatory leer at the thought, one that is tinged with a little more edge than normal.

Bouncing my knee impatiently, I wait for Walt to pull into his spot. I don't even wait for him to shift into Park before undoing my belt and reaching for the door handle, flinging it open. I've got my feet planted on the pavement, and am just about to jump up, when his voice stops me.

"Aston."

At the unfamiliar sound of my name falling from his lips, I cock my head. He rarely ever speaks directly to me. Much less with that...tone.

Worried.

Twisting my body to look over my shoulder, I say oh so politely, "Yes?"

His lips are pursed as he stares off at some unseen spot through the windshield, and the longer he remains silent, the more impatient I get. Agitated.

"Hell-oh-oh?" I croon with more bite than usual. "Earth to Walter." I even snap my fingers for good measure.

He gives his head a little shake, flits me a look, before returning his sights ahead. His hands squeeze the leather steering wheel. "Forget it. It's nothing."

Eyes wide, I mouth, "Ooookay."

Such a strange fella.

With a shake of my head, I climb out of the car, slamming the door behind me without a backward glance. I slip the headphones over my ears. Pat Benatar's "Love is A Battlefield" kicks on when I hit Play, silencing the sounds of cars pulling in behind me, and the chatter from the students trickling toward the doors, and the lingering weirdness I'd much rather pretend doesn't exist.

Pulling a cherry Blow Pop from my pocket, I unwrap it and pop the candy in my mouth. Sucking furiously on it. A quick glance at my phone shows it's ten to eight.

Perfect.

Despite running late, there's still enough time to visit my little mouse before the bell.

Strutting my stuff up the steps, head held high, I mouth along to the music playing in my ears. A teacher I don't recognize stands guard outside the doors I enter through. She curls her lip at me, and I blow her a kiss.

See? Everything's just fine.

Inside, the school seems to be bustling with more activity than usual for this early in the day. A couple cheerleaders brush past me, disappearing into one of the classrooms. They're carrying a black banner, and I catch the words *Tunnel of Horror* scrolled across it in big white, goopy lettering.

Which reminds me—Halloween is in less than two weeks. Same day as this month's full moon according to my astrology app.

With the coming Hunter's moon, prepare for a tide of revelations in its wake. The end of a cycle is upon you, and you'll be thrust into a new one whether or not you're ready. Now is not the time for impulsive spending, or new relationships. It is a time to gather and stock your resources as you prepare for the winter ahead.

I scowled when I read that this morning.

What do the stars know? Now is the perfect time for a new relationship. It means couple costumes on Halloween. Duh.

Go home, Mercury or whatever. You're drunk.

I twirl the lollipop in my mouth, bopping my head to the music as Pat wails about being young, and weathering the battlefield that is love.

She's not wrong. It's rough out here for us hopeless romantics, especially these days, where it's apparently much cooler to be stoic and aloof.

I mean, just look at my boyfriend.

(Does he know he's my boyfriend yet? No. But *obviously* that's where we're headed, so might as well just skip the bullshit.)

With black eyes colder than ice, and muscles about as rigid as the flat line of his mouth, Vale DuPont is nothing if not the anti-thesis of romance.

But oh, how he makes my little heart melt.

Riviera, I correct myself. *It's Riviera now. Rivierarivierarivi—*

Oh! Speak of the sexy devil...

There he is.

Cue the romantic swell of music, the glittering lights, and the slow, panoramic swing of the camera gently zooming in on him—it's go time.

Smack dab center in my line of sight, lit up under the sterile fluorescents like the God that he is, Vale stands with his back to me, facing a flyer-crowded cork board, hands shoved in his pockets.

I bite my lip as my steps slow, my gaze scoring ravenously down his body. Everything else around me disappears. I only have eyes for him.

He sure does make these dreadfully dull uniforms look good, his navy blazer stretched across his broad back, and his pressed chinos molding to his ass like a second skin.

Yum.

Rolling the Blow Pop around in my mouth, I lower my bulky headphones, so that the music playing is muffled against my neck. Then, with a tug on the straps of my backpack, squeezing them in my fists, I surge forward with all the confidence in the world.

I bypass my homeroom, my locker, and my buddy Darwin.

Twenty steps.

Fifteen.

Ten.

Several bodies suddenly cut across my path, and I rear back, stumbling on my heels. Scowling, I shoot them a glare, following them with my gaze until they're fully out of sight, and my path is clear once more.

Bingo.

My body's primed like an arrow drawn back, and I'm just about to burst through the empty space separating us, when Vale turns.

But not toward me.

"Oh, no he didn't," I mutter under my breath.

Annnnnnn signal the perfectly timed record scratch.

He appears out of nowhere—literally, because as far as I'm concerned Seth fucking Harris no longer actually exists. He can't. Not anymore. Not after I dealt with his home-wrecking ass Saturday night.

But lo and behold, there he is, sauntering up to *my* boyfriend.

I freeze in place, mindless of my peers shoving and shoulder-checking past me.

"What. The. Fuck," I seethe.

Vale's profile is to me, and he's got his head bowed. He doesn't seem to have noticed me standing here, a handful of steps away, no doubt with steam shooting out of my ears.

He's saying something, but it's too quiet for me to hear, and his lips are moving too fast, too subtly for me to even stand a chance of trying to read them.

And standing there, facing him like the arrogant, oblivious twat that he is, Seth hunches his shoulders, and jacks a thumb behind him. He murmurs something too.

My eyes bulge.

He wouldn't...

But he does.

Vale nods, and waves a hand, gesturing for Seth to take the lead. And then they're gone, heading down the South hall, disappearing around the corner.

Whipping around, I stomp back the way I came, back toward my locker.

Darwin is still standing there, facing his open locker as he gathers his books for homeroom. The warning bell's going to ring soon.

I yank out my lollipop. "Can you believe this shit?" I shrug off my backpack, letting it fall to the ground with a loud *thunk*. "The *nerve...*"

Shoving the candy back in my mouth, I pin it between my teeth as I angrily twist the dial on my locker, putting in the combination until the handle gives. Throwing it open, I turn off my Walkman, tossing it along with my headphones on the top shelf, before shoving my bag inside.

After I grab what I'll need for second period—it's Monday, so that means therapy instead of history—I slam my locker shut and tuck my books under my armpit. Tugging the sucker out of my mouth, I huff, and cut Darwin a look, pointing the candy at him. "I shall cut out his eyeballs and wear them as earrings."

Turning on my heel, I go to storm past, the pocketknife I stole from Walt's den after I lost mine at the party in my sock a solid, delicious reminder that I have the upper hand. Silly, stupid *Seth* never stood a chance.

Should've just ended him the other night. That's what I get for being nice.

I get about two steps when I halt in place and twist my head over the shoulder.

"Darwin," I bark.

He sighs and cuts me a dry look over his wire-rimmed glasses. “What?”

I bug my eyes at him. “You’re supposed to grab me and stop me. That’s what friends do. Friends don’t let friends cut out the eyeballs of their boyfriend’s crazy exes who can’t take a fucking hint. *Even* if said crazy ex deserves it.” I wave the hand holding the lollipop. “But I digress!”

Darwin scowls and pushes his glasses up his nose. “We’re not friends.”

He’s cute, in that shy, nerdy kind of way. In another life, where Vale didn’t exist, and I wasn’t a borderline-sociopath with a knife kink and a penchant for theatrics, I could totally see Darwin and I ending up together. We’ve got that whole locker-sharing, reluctant friends, forced proximity cutesy power duo thing going on.

It’d be a somewhat boring, but sweet story. And sure, we’d probably have to take turns topping—which I’m not totally against trying, for the record, though I was hoping my first time would be with a certain two-timing football player—and it would be...healthy...I guess.

I frown and drop my gaze to the laminate flooring.

A throat clears softly, followed by the gentle click of a locker closing. Loafers shuffle into my line of sight and I blink, look up, and smile sweetly.

Darwin shakes his head. “And my name is Devin.”

The bell rings just as he pushes past me. Spinning on my heel, I call out after him, “I totally knew that!”

Hmm, I don’t think he heard me.

I look around me, taking in the students dispersing the hall, their faces blurring into streaks. A weird buzzing fills my head, rattling my teeth and making my eyes itch.

I rub them. Blink a couple times. When I open them, I find myself alone.

The buzzing—no, the ringing cuts out. The silence that follows, heavy. Pointed. Suffocating.

Fuck.

That was the bell. I’m late.

On autopilot, I quickly make my way to the guidance office. Willing back that familiar, sticky *wrongness* creeping over me once more, slowly consuming me, rotting my good mood in record time, and leaving nothing but black ichor to sluice through my veins.

The last thing I need right now is the good doctor to think I’m having an episode.

Or at least, on the verge of.

I mean, so what if Vale and that wretched creature are still together?

So what if I deluded myself into thinking what happened at the party meant he picked *me*? That what we did meant something. That *my* Vale is still in there somewhere, just older and a little scarier. But, like, in a sexy way.

So what if I lost my knife, and Walter makes me feel weird, and there's certain songs I can't listen to, apparently, not without losing my shit?

Now is not the time to give up. Hope is not lost. Vale's probably just testing me.

Yeah, yeah, that's gotta be it.

Probably figures I'm not serious. I'm not always good at showing when I am.

I just have to remind him what he means to me, remind him he's *mine*...

No...that I'm *his*.

I don't know what it is about Vale...I never did. Not back when we were kids. Not when he was just a memory, one I'd cling to like a life preserver when not even a straitjacket or drugs could keep my mind from floating into forbidden territory.

Not now, when he acts like he wants nothing to do with me. When he plays whack-a-mole with my heart. When he looks at me like he can't decide if he wants to eat me or kill me.

But he...he settles something inside me. He soothes that sticky black *wrongness* somehow. That wrongness that would have me falling, sinking, forever lost.

He doesn't eradicate it, no. If anything, he speaks to it. Tames it.

It's as if some part of me knows I'm safe enough to let go with him...

That I was born to be at Vale's mercy.

Made to be *his*.

CHAPTER 17

VALE

A WHISTLE BLARES, and we're off, cleats kicking up grass and mud as we race across the field.

After a long, shitty day dodging rumors, dodging Seth, dodging Aston... It's exactly what I need.

Hell, it's the only reason I didn't dip out early—as tempted as I was. Because to do so would've meant no practice. School rule. And if there's one thing that can settle me when I get in a mood like this, it's football.

Quentin knew even before I did—before puberty well and truly set in—how badly I'd need an outlet. Something to channel the aggression that builds inside me when the boredom and apathy grow to be too suffocating.

Signing me up for a sport, football in particular, something I was already drawn to, encouraging me to give it a try...it's one of the best things he ever did, not just for me, but for the poor oblivious fucks of this town.

Now, grunts and heavy breathing fill the chilly air, clashing with my thundering pulse, with the squishing thumps of our feet pounding the damp earth. The bright glare of the sun catches on the steam wafting from our overheated bodies and puffing from our mouths like smoke.

I skid to a brief stop when I reach the white painted line before shooting off the way I came, only vaguely aware of the rest of the team doing the same. Heart pounding, chest clenching with my carefully measured breaths, I pump my legs as hard as they'll go. Chasing that high only extreme exertion can provide.

On either side of me, Fletch and Casey run just as hard. And while I strain like hell to keep up, it doesn't bother me too much that they're faster. They should be. I'm a quarterback; they're my best running back and wide

receiver. I'm competitive, but not stupid. The day I beat their asses—the day I have more stamina than them—will be the day I need better players.

Eventually, Coach Simpson blows the whistle, and we all stumble and skid to a stop, panting heavily, many more than others. A couple of the younger guys—freshmen who managed to bypass JV right to varsity—gag and curl over, heaving bile all over the grass.

"Looks like you've got yourself an admirer," Casey says by way of greeting when I join him at the benches, grabbing his water bottle.

Shielding my eyes from the sun that finally decided to make an appearance after a long, dreary day of on and off rain showers, I reach down for mine and bring it to my mouth, popping the sports cap with my teeth. "Yeah. Well aware," I mutter.

Throwing my head back, I shoot the lukewarm fluid down my throat, pointedly ignoring the eyes boring into me from the nearest set of bleachers.

I'm honestly surprised it took him this long to show up at one of my practices. Between this and the fact he managed to crash a party...I have to assume his new warden loosened his leash a bit.

Or he's gotten braver, more creative in his scheming as time passes.

Casey huffs at my side. "He's certainly a weird one. Not sure I believe all the rumors about him though. I could take him. Easily."

Everything in me turns rigid. The plastic bottle creaks in my grip, and for a moment, my vision reddens, veering toward black.

"Hell, I imagine so could Thea," my best friend goes on, clueless as ever. Chuckling under his breath, he takes a knee to re-tie his cleat.

Jaw clenched, I duck my head, and spray water all over my sweaty head. We've only been out here for a half hour, but Coach decided to make the best of the chilly afternoon by making us run suicides in our gear. And because of the rain earlier, we're covered with mud all over our shoes and compression pants. But I try not to think about it.

The mess...the dirt caked under my fingers...the mud and grass staining my clothes...

My legs burn, but no more than usual. I relish it, the strength coursing through my veins, sharpening my body into peak shape. I know I'm not invincible, but in moments like this, barely out of wind and high off the endorphins rushing through me, I feel like I could be.

Jamming the sports cap closed with the heel of my hand, I toss the bottle on the grass, and shake out my head, spraying water all over the

place.

“Hey!” Casey shouts with a laugh, jogging back a few steps to get out of the way.

Straightening, I reach up, slicking my hair back. All the while, I’m keenly aware of the eyes raking over my movements from the stands, utterly shameless in their open perusal of me.

The base, useless part of me preens at the attention. But on the outside, I remain as cool and unaffected as always.

“Prick.” Casey chuckles, giving my shoulder a shrug. “Stop teasing the poor kid.”

I roll my eyes, lowering my shirt from where I was wiping my face.

“Pretty sure I can see drool dribbling down his chin.”

“Stop looking.”

“Why? He clearly has no shame. Why should I?”

I shake my head.

There’s a weighty pause, then, “You jealous?”

Tensing, I sear Casey with a withering look before I can help myself. “Why the fuck would I be jealous?”

His mouth twists and he takes a step back, raising his hands in a show of surrender. “Whoa. I’m just screwing with you, man. No need to get your jock in a twist.” His words say one thing, but the shakiness to his laugh says another.

Still, despite that little chink in his composure, betraying the baser part of *him*, his gaze moves with a mind of its own. Trailing down my neck, my arms, where the pads don’t cover...lingering on the faint scratch marks Aston had given me when I was choking him out.

I arch a brow when Casey’s blue gaze springs to mine. “Problem?”

He clears his throat and glances away, narrowing his eyes at some distant spot. “I heard some rumors. About the other night.”

“And?”

He spreads his hands, thinning his mouth. “Just sayin’. If you’re gonna cheat on Seth, maybe be a little less obvious about it. Or, I don’t know, break up with him like we all know you want to, instead of fucking him over in the first place.”

I blow out a harsh breath and shake my head, muttering, “First Q, now you.”

Casey’s brow furrows.

“How the hell do you know Seth didn’t give me these marks?”

“Seriously?” Casey says with a scoff. He gestures to my neck where the shoulder pads mostly hide what Aston did to me. But he definitely saw them earlier in the locker room when we were changing. All the guys did, but they know better than to ask—well, everyone but the closest thing I have to a best friend.

“You’re gonna try and tell me after all this time, Seth Harris, champion fucking chess guru or whatever, has got a little freak buried under those chinos and button-ups?”

A soft snort punches out of me at that, softening some of my hostility, and I’m reminded why I keep Casey around in the first place—why he’s someone I consider a friend, and not just because of what he can do for me.

He’s...funny. Some of the shit that flies out of his mouth without any second-guessing amuses me. It also just so happens to be a bonus that his utter lack of filter, when harmless, is good fodder. He smooths my edges, prompts me when I need it... You know, shit like that. For when I...forget myself.

It also helps that I don’t have to say much to convince him of things, even when he gets lucky and hits the nail right on the head.

“Look,” I say in my usual, easy-going manner, “what happened at Alicia’s party the other night was a mistake. I got shit-faced. Things got out of hand.” I shrug and shift a sideways look at the bleachers as I finish firmly, “But it’s being remedied, and won’t ever happen again.”

Aston perks up at having finally captured my attention.

Fucking idiot.

He’s wearing red heart-framed sunglasses—who the fuck knows what poor little kid he stole those from—and is sucking away on another Blow Pop. One he pops free of his mouth to wave it at me, before blowing me a kiss with his other hand.

Jesus fucking Christ.

If there was any doubt that how I acted Saturday night didn’t scare him off, or piss him off enough—hurt him enough—to make him want nothing to do with me...they’re nonexistent now.

If anything, just as I figured, he’s taken it as some kind of permission, rather than the warning it was.

If I let this go any further...

At my side, Casey tries and fails to choke down a laugh.

Clearly, there's no point denying that Aston and I...hooked up, or whatever. Not to Casey, at least. I've heard the rumors thrown around today, and it's not like Aston's being subtle about it or doing anything at all to tamper them.

But at least if I have my *best bro* on my side to help with damage control, I stand a better chance at getting on top of this and putting said rumors to rest before it gets even more out of control.

If there's one thing I can rely on for certain, it's that Casey is loyal to a fault. He'll spin any story I want him to. And our collective word against the school's newest and far from reputable pariah will go a long way in pivoting the general perspective.

Plus, I helped him last year when it got out that he was smoking weed. I pissed in a bag for him and everything. Spoke up for him to Coach and the school board so he wouldn't get cut.

He owes me, and he knows it.

"He's fucking insane," I mutter, looking away from the bleachers. Grabbing my helmet, I'm about to shove it back over my head, when I pause, leveling Casey with a serious look. "Seth and I broke up, okay? It's over."

His blond brows fly up. "When?"

"This morning. Before the bell." *It was bound to get out eventually...*

He whistles low under his breath. "How'd he take it?"

I shrug. "As well as you can imagine." *Understatement.*

Casey snickers.

"But here's the thing," I go on, lowering my voice for effect. "He blacked out at the party. Doesn't know I cheated on him."

Casey's eyes widen. "For real?"

I nod. It's a total lie, but I'm sticking to the story I fed Seth, despite his insistence.

Seth most definitely remembers some things...

More than I truthfully thought he would.

"He drank too much, more than even I did. He was passed out in the ensuite bathroom when I found him afterward."

Casey's eyes bug, mouth parting. "In the same room that you and..." He jerks his head toward the bleachers.

I nod.

He cringes, and looks away, wiping his palm across his mouth.

I wonder what he'd think if he knew the truth...

"I denied the rumors, so..."

Casey nods, working his jaw. He kicks the grass, eyes trained thoughtfully on some unseen spot on the ground. "Gotcha."

"This is why I don't fucking party, man," I say seriously.

"Yeah, yeah, I know."

"I lose control. Fuck shit up." I wince and shake my head for good measure. "I never, in my right mind would have..." My voice trails off.

He winces right back and scrubs the back of his sweaty blond head. "Yeah."

Except you did, a voice pipes up, reminding me.

And a few shots of Patrón are nowhere near enough to strip me of my restraint.

It was all him.

Aston.

Provoking me, teasing me, bringing up the past...

He knew *exactly* what fucking buttons to push to flip my switch.

Like hell was I gonna let him have the upper hand.

Like hell was I gonna let him get away with it and walk away.

Like hell I wasn't going to take a little of what I'm owed.

"He's cute though," Casey says casually. "Aston, I mean. If you like that sort of thing."

I give him a *what the fuck* look and he spreads his hands as if to say, *What?* He visibly fights a laugh.

"I like my guts in my stomach, thank you," I say dryly. "That's what I'm into."

He guffaws like what I said was ridiculous. I just stare at him.

"Dude, come on. You don't actually believe those rumors, right?"

"Says the one who calls him *Myers*."

He just laughs. "So, he's got some mental health shit going on. Who doesn't?"

Casey's chuckle turns a little uneasy the longer I don't say anything. "Wasn't he, like, being abused when he did it? Sounds like self-defense to me."

Sucking in my cheek, I study my closest friend. The fact he knows abuse was involved tells me he must've done some researching of his own. "I don't know what to believe," I eventually tell Casey.

But that's not true.

It's probably the biggest lie I've told yet.

But telling him the truth—admitting that I'd lied the night of the Bell Game, that I did know Aston. I *lived* with Aston...I was *there* that night...

It isn't an option. Not unless I want to incriminate myself.

Fortunately, it's at that moment that Coach yells for us to hit the field and get in position to run some drills. Fletch jogs past us backward, shouting, "Let's go, boys!" before woofing and beating his chest and falling into a couple of other players.

Next to me, Casey pumps his fist near his crotch, making a crude gesture at the rest of the guys running past. They all laugh and howl like the idiots they are.

Shaking my head, I grab my helmet.

"Regardless of how it all went down, I've got your back, man," Casey turns to me to say, tugging his helmet over his head. From behind his face mask, he meets my gaze, and nods firmly. "Consider the rumors—" he pretends to blast a bomb between his hands, mouthing what I assume is supposed to be the sound of an explosion.

Without waiting for a response from me, he turns and jogs over to where the others start lining up mid-field.

Clenching my helmet between my hands, I press it against my chest and squeeze, feeling my muscles ripple and strain along my arms. I cast one last look over to the bleachers, not at all surprised to find my deranged ex-foster brother still there, still watching me, still looking as cheerful as fucking ever.

He cocks his head, rolling the Blow Pop obscenely around his mouth so the little white stick wags around. With the sunglasses covering his eyes, it leaves me little to work with.

What's going through that fucked up head of yours? I wonder not for the first time today.

As if he heard my silent question, he reaches up, sliding the sunglasses down his nose, and even from down here, there's no mistaking the exaggerated wink he sends my way.

My jaw snaps together, and I narrow my eyes before whipping around, putting my back to him. I shove on my helmet and jog toward the O-line to take position.

Something heavy and dark presses down on me as I crouch and call out the play, not unlike that lapse of rage that possessed me earlier, when Casey made that throwaway comment about being able to take him.

It slithers hotly through my veins, boiling my blood.

Over my fucking dead body.

No one touches him.

No one fucks with Aston St. James but *me*.

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CHAPTER 18

ASTON

*SETH HARRIS IS A SNIVELING
LITTLE WHORE!
HE WILL RUE THE DAY HE DARED TO
BREATHE THE SAME AIR AS ME.
HOMEWRECKING SKANK!*

I KNOW what you're probably thinking.

Stalker much?

But I can explain!

You see, I didn't *plan* on following Vale. At least not today.

And correct me if I'm wrong, but I'm pretty sure actual stalking—like the hide in your trees, Peeping Tom, photos plastered all over the walls, *I'll fucking kill you if I can't have you grr* kind—emphasis on that last one—takes a bit more forethought and strategic planning than what I'm realistically capable of.

Not to mention diabolical intent.

Even on a good day, but *especially* on a day like today, where I kind of just want to marinade in my misery and listen to Celine Dion on repeat while I stare morosely at the ceiling.

Self-awareness, baby. It's the name of the game. And yours truly is nothing if not an opportunist, and everything *but*...

Well, you get the picture.

Anywho, I digress. Let's scritch-scratch this record back.

So there I was after last period let out, shuffling pathetically down the hall like the sad sack of shit I am, "All by Myself" playing in my head on a loop—it *was a really bad day, okay??* —when miracle of all miracles, Casey motha-fuckin' Shrute skips on by. Yelling something about something to someone, and I catch words like *practice* and *field*...

And it was as if a little lightbulb exploded in my head, freezing me in my tracks. Eyes wide, I stood there for a solid three seconds wondering how something so simple—so obvious—didn't even occur to me in the weeks I've been here.

Of course Vale had football practice.

And *of course* I needed to go watch it.

That's what good, supportive boyfriends do, even when they're on the outs.

But, if anything, it was remembering what happens *after* practice that really sealed the deal for me and kicked Plan B of my operation into gear.

Sing it with me, folks: *locker room*.

The magical place equally feared and revered by queer boys everywhere.

Roll in the spotlights and singing angels, it's time to bow-chicka-wow-wow all up in— A whistle blows, piercing the chilly fall afternoon, snapping me out of my fantasy.

My Blow Pop is nothing more than a wadded piece of crunchy gum, so I chomp down, ripping the stick out, and toss it somewhere behind me. Mashing my teeth until the gum's nice and gooey, I blow the occasional bubble as I watch the guys converge toward the bench where their coaches stand.

Some guys take a knee. Others hunch over, hands to their thighs as they heave for air.

Then there's Vale, standing there in the center, tanned, muscular arms crossed over his padded chest. Untouched. Unfazed. Truly, a god amongst his people.

Damn, my baby is fiiiine.

Pinching the arm of my sunglasses, I slide them down to the tip of my nose to get an unobstructed view.

Save for that one water break when he finally spared me some attention, he's made it a point to avoid looking this way.

His friend had stared. Some of the others too, not that I paid any of them much mind. I only had eyes for Vale.

And for a very brief moment in time, he only had eyes for me.

Just like the other night.

I shift in my seat, toes curling when I clench. The bench cold and hard as fuck on my still sore cheeks.

Imagine if he fucked me for real...

Would I even be able to walk???

I blow another bubble, so big it momentarily blocks my view before popping—loudly.

A couple of players glance my way, though I doubt they heard my gum snapping from way down there. But other than the cheerleaders hanging out off to the opposite side of the bleachers where I sit, there's no one else around.

I wonder if they know who I'm here for. They have to, right? The rumor mill was a spinnin' beautifully today, something I would've cherished most graciously if my little mouse hadn't all but spit on our great love story by canoodling with the enemy this morning.

This must look pretty damn pathetic then, huh? Me following him around like a lost little puppy, waiting for just the barest of scraps, knowing everyone and their brother probably knows what we did the other night.

God, you must hate me right now. Where is my sense of self-worth? Where is my dignity?

Someone below cheers, followed by more whoops and hollers. Not Vale though, nope, no siree. If anything, he stands taller. Holds himself more rigidly, his coal-black eyes hard and unflinching as they glare from a sea of light and joy.

Gosh, I'd just love to squish those cheeks, stretch them out, split that sexy mouth into a grin. Watch those cold eyes erupt into icy, black flames.

"Alright, boys, hit the locker," I hear shouted, followed by a strong, synchronized clap. Whooping, they all jump up and start running for the tunnel across the field.

Vale hangs back when Coach waves him over. Heads bowed together, they chat over a clipboard, pointing at whatever's there. Finally, Coach claps him on the shoulder. Vale nods before jogging off to join the others.

He doesn't look my way again.

But it's okay. He doesn't have to. Soon, he won't have any other choice. I've made sure of that.

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CHAPTER 19

VALE

“THAT SON OF A BITCH,” I say through clenched teeth, white-knuckling the black grated doors on either side of my gear locker.

Somewhere behind me, someone slams theirs shut, the clang of metal ringing out, echoing off the surrounding lockers. Shoes squeak against the linoleum—the team beginning to shuffle out.

As usual, I was the last to leave the showers.

The metal creaks in my grip, and my chest heaves, neck tendons straining, pulling so tight, it’s a wonder they don’t snap right along with the hinges on the doors.

I’m going to kill him.

I’m going to rip his pretty head from his tight little body.

A hand clasps my bare shoulder, and I whip around, not even bothering to see who it belongs to first before grabbing the wrist in a bone-crushing grip.

“Whoa.” Fletch’s eyes widen when confronted with my slitted gaze, and he holds up his free hand. He’s already fully dressed in a muscle tee and gym shorts. “You good, bro?” The corner of his eye twitches, the only obvious sign I’m hurting him.

My teeth mash, fingers flexing with the aggression aching to break free.

So much for working it out in practice.

It’s no matter that Fletch is taller and wider than me. I could easily break his bones in an instant if I wanted. Humans are so much more fragile than most realize.

Instead, I release him and shove him back a couple steps. “I’m fine,” I say tightly as he shakes out his wrist, not bothering to hide his wince this

time. “Just realized I forgot my keys in my locker.”

He whistles under his breath, dropping to the bench to put on his Jordans just as Casey pipes up. “Fuck, man, that sucks. You want a ride?”

I turn my head, leveling him with a sneer. “And leave my car here?”

Once it hits five P.M., the doors to the school automatically lock from the outside. Not that my keys are actually *in* my locker, but I’m not about to tell them that Aston of all fucking people snuck in here at some point, no doubt snooped through all our shit and swiped the keys to my Audi.

And who knows what the fuck else.

Casey’s brow furrows as he studies me. “The gates get locked once we leave,” he reminds me. He tugs his black Archers hoodie over his head, leaving the hood up. “Your car will be safe for the night.”

I give him a deadpan look. He knows me better than that. “I’m not fucking leaving my car here.”

And that would stand regardless of the fact that it’s Aston who’s currently holding my R8 hostage.

These rich pricks might take their belongings for granted, but I don’t. I take care of what’s mine.

“Just get out of here,” I say gruffly, turning my back on them.

I haven’t even gotten a chance to change yet. I’m still in nothing but a towel, having only noticed my locker was in complete disarray *after* I fucking showered. So blinded by my need to wash the sweat and grime off the second Coach dismissed me, I barely spared it a glance earlier when I stripped down.

I angrily swipe up my phone, making a mental note to get a lock for my locker. “I’ll call security and have them let me in the school.”

“Are you sure?” Casey hedges, grabbing his bag, and throwing it over his shoulder.

“Yeah, it’s fine. I still have to get dressed. Don’t let me hold you up,” I mumble dismissively.

I bring up my contacts and pretend like I’m about to call the pager number we’ve all got programmed. It wouldn’t be the first time one of us needed to be let inside the school after hours.

Not that that’s even happening this time...

“Come on,” Fletch mumbles. “He’s a big boy.”

I fight an eye roll, biting my tongue. But, hey, at least one of us can read the room. The sooner they all get out of here, the sooner I can get this little

confrontation over with. And preferably with no witnesses.

Not that I think Aston would be so stupid as to enter the locker room with half the team still lingering about anyway.

But then again, he's always had the patience of a gnat.

I blow out a harsh breath and bring the phone to my ear. And I wait.

As expected, the guys are quick to gather their stuff and mumble their goodbyes. I wave them off, drumming my fingers impatiently against the side of my locker.

Slowly, then all at once, the receding footsteps and chatter disappear completely with the soft gasp then click of the locker room door closing behind them.

Finally alone, I lower the phone along with what little remained of my facade.

I should've fucking known Aston was up to something. I wonder when he managed to sneak in here. It had to be before practice, seeing as I would've definitely noticed if he disappeared then reappeared.

Now that I think about it...

He didn't show up to practice until we'd already been two laps into our mile run around the field. He must've made a detour here—watched and waited for us all to disperse from the locker rooms so he could make his move.

At least he's not a total moron.

The idiot's got enough of a target on his back already. If the team caught him, he'd be fucked. Hell, if they so much as catch wind he was in here, they'd be insufferable.

Sure, they're cool for the most part about me being gay. For one, they need me. I'm their star quarterback. The town is small and a little backwards, but when it comes to football, Crowley doesn't mess around.

And two...

I scare them.

Just ask Bobby Thompson, our previous starting quarterback who graduated last year.

With a broken arm.

Let's just say, after that, if any slurs are getting tossed around, it's nowhere near me.

It probably also helps that I don't *act gay*. You know, except for the rare occasion when I've got a dick stuffed down my throat, or my tongue

wrapped around another dude's tongue.

But at least I make it easy for them to pretend I'm not a raging homo—for the most part—unlike Aston who can't code-switch for the life of him.

Which, ironically enough, is probably the only thing I *can* respect about him. Even if it gets him killed one day, because he has no sense of self-preservation what-so-fucking-ever.

Of course, that would mean I didn't end him first.

Regardless, it doesn't mean some of these fuckers don't turn into dodgy-eyed morons any time we hit the showers. Doesn't mean I never noticed the disgusted side-eyes anytime I'd let Seth kiss me in the halls or grab his hand and walk out with him after games.

Just because they do the bare minimum to tolerate me, doesn't mean they'll offer Aston the same grace. Or any at all. His presence in here alone would be grounds for retaliation.

Hell, I've already caught wind of the mocking whispers from some of the more vocal, idiotic members of the team when they didn't realize I was lurking in hearing distance.

I pull up my texts, not surprised to see one from Quentin waiting for me.

Steak alright for dinner?

A glance at the corner of my screen shows it's twenty to six.
I quickly type out a response.

When is it not?

He replies with two thumbs ups.

Biting the corner of my lip, my thumb hovers over the keyboard. I should tell him what I told the guys. Let him pick me up. We only live a couple of miles from school.

Fuck it. I could just walk. The nights are getting chilly, but it's nowhere near unbearable.

And yet...

Running late today, fyi. Coach needs me to watch tape.

Quentin replies back immediately.

ETA?

I pinch the bridge of my nose, thumb and finger digging into the corners of my eyes.

What the fuck am I doing?

It's at that moment I hear a sound. So soft, that if I didn't know any better, I'd chalk it up to the pipes or my imagination.

But I do know better.

And my imagination is nothing if not a desolate wasteland.

Mouth ticking up bitterly, I quickly thumb out a reply to Quentin and turn the screen dark.

A half hour is being fucking gracious, and I know it, but I don't think too deep as to why I allow myself this much time to deal with him.

I tell myself it's for Quentin's sake. I want to ensure I have plenty of time, so I'm not leaving him hanging with two cooked meals.

A piercing whining sound fills the air, and I clamp down on my back teeth, nostrils flaring.

Slowly, I turn around, just as Aston rounds the corner, dragging his knife lazily over the lockers. In his other hand, he twirls a key ring around his finger, the fob jangling against my silver house key.

He's got his head angled down, floppy caramel hair curled over his brow, and he peeks up at me through his lashes. "Looking for these?"

I hold out my hand. "Give it."

Shaking his head, slowly at first, then faster, he murmurs, "Uh, uh, uh. I don't think so."

"Aston," I grit out warningly.

His lips rise, and his teeth flash, pinning the full candy-stained flesh. "Love it when you say my name, baby."

"Give me the fucking keys," I growl, taking a lunging step toward him.

But he's quick to jump back, thrusting the point of his knife at me to ward me off. I halt, rearing back on my heels. Mouth pulled into a tight, unrelenting line.

He tilts his head, a smirk creeping up his face.

My narrowed gaze flicks to the sharp point glinting under the fluorescents, and it hits me that my keys weren't the only thing he took from my bag. It's the same knife he left at the party the other night.

"Thanks for keeping this safe, by the way," he says, as if reading my mind. He twirls the butterfly knife around with practiced ease, sparing it a considering glance. "Getting my hands on one of these wasn't easy."

“Well, now you have it back,” I say tightly, my tone flat. “Now, give me what’s mine.”

His gaze hungrily eats up the blade spinning faster and faster in his hand, and then it snaps to mine at the same time he abruptly halts the knife’s momentum, his eyes wide and bright with vicious excitement. “But I’m just getting started, little mouse.”

A throbbing takes up residence in my temple. “Don’t fucking call me that.”

He wets his full, sinful lips, pouting. “But it suits you so well.”

I stare at him, my jaw ticking in time with the pulsing next to my eye.

He stares back, sage eyes twinkling.

My gaze narrows as I study him more closely. Waiting...

Waiting...

Nothing.

That or he’s a better actor than I originally thought.

He takes an abrupt step forward, then another, slinking toward me, knife swirling lazily through the air like he’s readying himself for a duel.

And I let him. I let him think he has control here, taking a step back with each forward one of his. Standing at my full height, arms crossed, shoulders bunched tightly, I keep the bench between us at all times as we circle the small boxed-in space.

His lip twitches like he’s holding back a laugh. “You know, you kind of broke my heart this morning.”

“That so?”

“Uh huh.” He lifts his shoulder, tugging his bottom lip between his teeth, rounding his eyes all puppy-like. “I thought we shared something really special the other night.”

I smile, and it’s anything but warm. “Funny. I hardly remember it.”

His steps falter the slightest bit, eyes flashing darkly, his grip on the knife handle turning white.

There you are.

He might’ve been able to delude himself that we left things on a better note than we actually did, but I know the truth. And I’m more than happy to remind him.

I tip my head to the side. “What’s another hole, right?” I mock gasp. “Oh wait.” I press my knuckles to my lips and shake my head. “Does it even count when it’s just the tip?”

His smile flattens completely, face smoothing into something as hard as glass. “Probably not something to brag about.”

“What can I say? I remembered I had standards. We’ll blame the tequila for my momentary slip.” I inhale. “Wasn’t about to waste a load though. A sock, you, what’s the difference?”

His jaw ticks, his face reddening.

I push my bottom lip out, drawing my brows together. “Something wrong...*little mouse?*”

His mouth stretches open in a vicious snarl, teeth bared, and he lunges for me, swiping the knife through the air.

I spring up onto the bench with two feet and then slam down in front of him just as the knife whistles through the air. Thrusting my hand out, I seal my fingers around his throat and throw him up against the lockers.

A sharp burning sensation rips down my forearm, and I hiss through my teeth, bowing forward, putting us flared nose to flared nose. The clang of metal from the impact of his body echoes across the room.

He flinches back into the lockers, rattling them further.

His pale green eyes bug out inches away from me. We’re so close, I can make out each individual blood vessel threaded through his corneas swelling, threatening to burst.

He claws at my arms, and it doesn’t escape me that in our struggle, my keys and his knife went flying across the floor.

But not before slicing me in the process.

I glance down at the wound bubbling up red along my arm and tilt my head. “Now that...” I look up, meeting his panicky gaze. “That wasn’t very nice.”

His slim body jolts against mine, his gaze growing distant. Beneath my towel, my dick fills, and I moan, lean forward, and turn my nose into his cheek. Inhaling.

So sickly sweet...

Like a fucking cavity, rotting me from the inside out.

I pull back and with a curious sort of fascination, watch him struggle to breathe.

Sweet, and wicked, and so, so utterly defenseless.

With a sigh, I release some of the pressure on his neck and step back just enough for him to curl forward, gasping and coughing.

I look down at my arm, twisting it this way and that. The cut is about six inches long, and surprisingly smooth. Razor-thin. Not too deep either, despite the blood dribbling out, running in rivulets between my knuckles.

Feeling eyes on me, I look up, colliding with Aston's reddened gaze boring into me. He gulps, gasping, his lips shivering, but he doesn't look away. He doesn't try to apologize for cutting me or beg me for mercy. Doesn't start panicking or run off screaming.

No, he fucking drops to his knees.

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CHAPTER 20

ASTON

“LET ME,” I purr, batting my lashes.

Gathering Vale’s loosely curled fist in my hands, I hold his cold, dark gaze hostage as I lift it to my waiting mouth. With this head tilted curiously, he looks more predator than man, watching me like a wolf would a rabbit, his demeanor exuding a bored, impassive sort of confidence. One that tells me I’m only able to do this because he allows it.

He knows I don’t stand a chance against him.

I know I don’t stand a chance against him.

The thought has me smirking against his sticky skin.

“Mmm,” I moan, lapping and sucking at his skin. The bitter tang of his blood splashes against the back of my throat as I gulp.

The greedy beast in me begs for more, and who am I to deny him?

Vale’s eyes flare, his jaw twitching with restraint. “That’s right,” he utters tightly as I continue lapping at his skin. “Clean up your mess.”

I smirk knowingly at him, before dropping a pointed look to the prominent tent in his towel, where his erection strains against its terry cloth prison. Begging to be freed. Begging to be worshiped.

Lucky for him, I’m already on my knees.

And this sinful bloody offering has got me famished for some *hole-y* redemption.

Mouth. Butt. Belly button—I’m not picky.

Aston Saint James is here to serve.

Pressing painfully against the zipper, my own dick salutes in solidarity.

“You’re sick, you know.”

“Mmm. And yet, you love it,” I murmur, my eyes fluttering shut as I drag my lips across his sticky, damp flesh. More hungry, satisfied sounds escape me as I reverently suckle at the knob of each knuckle. I lick and kiss my way up his wrist. His veiny forearm. Tracing the blood to its source with barely restrained desperation.

When I sense movement, my eyes fly open just in time to watch as the towel loosens from around his waist, to drop, pooling around his feet.

Fuck yeah, now we’re talking.

His heavy, flushed cock juts out mere *inches* from my face, the rosy tip glistening with the pre-cum weeping from his slit. My mouth waters with the need to taste it. To smear my lips with it, just like his blood. The messier the better. I want to be splattered in all things Vale.

Dragging my teeth through his blood, I reach out, gripping his cock at the base. He tenses, his abs visibly clenching. His hips give a small thrust, as if he can’t help himself.

Fingers shove through my hair, wrenching my head back far enough to hurt.

“Did I say you can fucking touch me?” he growls.

A whooshing floods my ears faster than I can take my next breath. It’s as if his words are hands, shoving me over the ledge of a cliff where a black, bottomless abyss awaits. His face, the locker room ceiling...they shrink as they grow farther and farther away. As I fall, and fall, and—

Something tugs my hair. Hard. And I gasp, rocketed back to steady ground. “I asked you a question,” he barks.

I flinch, my entire body trembling. “Wh-what?” Licking my lips, I rear back slightly at the unexpected taste of iron, only to remember and latch on with a feral sort of desperation.

There’s another sharp yank on my hair. “Look at me.”

So, I do.

His eyes narrow, their attention far too sharp and invasive for my current liking. But whatever magic held him before, now holds me, and I can’t tear myself away.

“When you’re on your knees for me, your attention is mine,” he says slowly, dangerously, his voice deeper than it was a moment ago. “You got that?”

My brow wrinkles with confusion, but I find myself nodding jerkily. In doing so, my fingers, the ones still encircling his dick, tighten reflexively.

With a scoff, he physically pries them off, shoving my arm away.

“W-wait. P-please,” I find myself stuttering out, my voice raw as I scoot my knees together, straightening my spine. I forcibly bat my lashes at him, steeling my hands together. “I’ve been so good. I—”

He sneers. “You’ve never been good.”

I still.

Blink a couple times.

My fingers curl into bone-white claws locking together, my vision darkening once more. And I’m suddenly acutely aware of the blade spun open a few feet away from me, my body coiling as it readies to lunge for it. When, suddenly, I’m yanked to a stand by the hair, feet tripping beneath me as I stumble forward with the strength he uses to swing me toward the bench.

Shoved onto my back, caged in by thick, powerful thighs straddling my chest, I find myself staring wide-eyed up at the gorgeously dark haired god glaring down at me under a halo of light. Miles upon miles of golden skin still glistening from his shower loom over me—muscles bulging and rippling in all the right spots, just begging for my fingers to squeeze. My teeth to bite. My tongue to map out.

If the withering glare he aims down at me when I make to clutch his waist is anything to go by, that won’t be happening. At least not today. His next words confirm as much. “Don’t even think about it. This is for me. Not for you. Understood?”

This, as in...

I’m about to ask, but there’s something in his hard, expectant stare that has me biting my tongue. Instead, jaw working, cheeks blazing hot, I give him a stiff nod in agreement.

Satisfied, he grabs my wrists and wrestles my arms between his thighs to pin them to my sides. Effectively restraining me. My mouth dries, vision sharpening.

“That’s better,” he says gruffly, grasping his cock at the root. The sight stirs hunger low in my belly, sending waves of heat to my groin. As if sensing it—or perhaps to confirm that I’m still on board with what’s happening before he goes any further—Vale reaches back with his free hand to grip me through my khakis. Eliciting a sharp audible intake of air from my lungs.

I'm rock fucking hard, and with the added pressure—brief that it ends up being—I can feel the cool, sticky dampness of the shifting fabric. *Is there a wet spot?* I wonder. By the way Vale rubs his fingers in a circle over where my tip is, and the deep pleased rumble from his chest, when he tosses a glance over his shoulder, I'm guessing yes, yes there is.

Before he removes his hand, he decides to torture me one last time by roughly dragging the heel of his palm down toward my swollen balls.

I gasp thrusting my hips up, before whining pitifully, "*Vale*," when his hand's suddenly gone.

Leaning over me, he uses those same fingers to grip me by the hair again instead. "Such a needy little slut you are." Fisting my tousled hair in his fist, he uses the other hand to stroke himself, jerking it toward my face. As much as my cock throbs—as much as I mourn the loss of pressure, of friction, of attention...

This works too.

This *totally* works.

Crouching over me just enough to bring the head of his cock to my chin, he scoops up the mess left from lapping at his injured arm, before dragging it to my mouth.

"Open."

I instantly do as he commands, sticking my tongue out as far as it will go.

Above me, Vale's eyes are hooded, the intensity with which he bores his attention down on me, almost too much to bear. It's anger and lust. Outrage and hunger. Horror and desperation. A maelstrom of emotion that what we're doing shouldn't warrant.

But fuck if I'm in any position whatsoever to make sense of it, even if I wanted to.

And I don't.

All I want is to *taste*. To feel. To...

Start over.

My vision shakes around the edges, darkening so that once again it's as if I'm looking down a long tunnel. And at the end of it, it's Vale's rigid cock, fisted tightly by fingers I know could snap my neck if they wanted to. All due to the tight muscle attached to them, the ones I follow up his body, from his veiny forearms to bulging biceps to his firm pecs, his prominent Adam's apple, his strong jaw and perfectly chiseled face. A face that is

currently pulled taut with the same tension I feel in my chest. My throat. My bottomed out gut.

I've still got my mouth propped open, tongue out and waiting like a dog's. I can feel myself shaking with the need to say his name. With the need to move. But I'm frozen, completely at his mercy, cursed to wait for however long it takes for this trance we're both trapped in to release us.

His jaw ticks visibly, neck tendons jumping. Then, finally, *finally*, he shakes off whatever's got him hesitating—whatever put that menacing glint in his gaze—and he lowers himself, guiding his thick, rigid cock over my tongue.

My mouth closes around it instinctively, cheeks hollowing as I suck him deep. His fingers release my hair to give my cheek a rough tap. "I didn't tell you to do that. Open."

Fuck.

Blinking rapidly, I do as he says, my chin trembling.

His eyes narrow on the nervous-looking movement, and he looks *pissed*.

Not that I *am* nervous, for the record. I just want to make that very, very clear.

Vale bares his teeth down at me, nostrils flaring. "More."

I stretch my mouth as wide as it can go, until my vision blurs and my jaw cramps. With no warning, he shoves deep into my mouth, slamming into the back of my throat. My eyes bug, my body jolting with my gag as tears rush forth to spill down my cheeks. Saliva pools around his flesh, slipping from the stretched corners of my lips.

If my jaw could clamp down it would. Lucky for him, my mouth's too stuffed for me to accidentally—or intentionally—bite his dick off.

Now, that would be a travesty.

Biting his bottom lip, he grips the side of my head, holding it still when my body revolts, practically convulsing with my wet, stifled coughs as I thrash against the bench.

"You can take it. I know you can." If he's trying to sound encouraging, he fails. He sounds *bored*. Indifferent.

A hot tear races down my temple, toward my hairline, and he uses his thumb to smudge it, rubbing into his skin.

"Breathe through your nose," he commands softly.

My nostrils flare, my face growing so hot I wouldn't be surprised it's veered into violet territory. Try as I might to re-route the air to my nose, my body doesn't seem to want to cooperate. My brain all too aware of how... helpless I am.

I'm not panicking. I'm not. I want this.

When he finally takes pity on me—that or he realized I can't exactly pleasure him if I lose consciousness—and pulls out, it's only long enough for me to cough sloppily around the fat head of his cock before he's shoving back inside.

"Careful," he says on a hiss when my teeth accidentally scrape along his silky, salty flesh. I nod jerkily, widening my mouth.

"See? I knew you could do it. Knew you could take it. It's all you're good for anyway." His lips rise in a smile that is anything but kind or reassuring as he eases back, before snapping his hips and thrusting deep into my throat once more, bringing about another startled gag.

Spit floods my mouth, spilling out from the stretched out corners of my lips, trickling down my chin.

"I'm going to fuck your throat so raw, you won't be able to speak for a week," he tells me in a voice so deep and gravelly that he barely sounds human. "That'll teach you not to fucking touch my shit."

Again and again and again, he pounds into my mouth.

Fucking my throat without mercy.

My entire body trembles and I can't help but squirm beneath him. While my erection had started to deflate at the loss of oxygen to my brain, now that he's got a steady, but brutal rhythm going on, and I've somewhat adjusted to the full-scale assault to my tonsils, I find myself hardening to full-mast once more.

God, what I'd give for him to reach back and free my dick. Hold it. Stroke it. Milk the cum out of it while I use my mouth to milk him of his.

But this is for him. Not me...

The thought should turn me off—anger me even. But it doesn't. If anything I feel oddly...relieved. And maybe even a little confused by that fact.

Which of course makes my head feel all fuzzy. Not necessarily in a bad way...this time. I don't really know how else to explain it, other than to confidently say I want more of whatever this fuzzy *rightness* is.

I don't want him to stop. Or ease up. Or start questioning himself.

I just want him to *feel*...

And I want it to be with me.

“Fuck. You,” he squeezes out through his teeth, punctuating each word with a powerful snap of his hips. His heavy balls smack wetly against my drool-soaked chin with each thrust. And my own tingle hotly from within the confines of my too-tight clothes. “Fuck you so fucking much.”

At first, I think I just imagine it—the soft gasp of a door opening.

But then Vale freezes, his cock in my throat.

“Is someone in here?” a deep male voice calls out.

Nononono. We’re not done yet!

But it’s clear after only a couple seconds that Vale’s going nowhere, and rather than feel panic, I only feel relief. And a sick sense of pleasure. My eyes crinkle with the smile restrained by the salty thickness prying my mouth open. Against the underside of his cock, I wiggle my tongue around, slithering it over his flesh.

Not taking his blackened gaze off mine, Vale yells out, “Just me changing, Coach.” I don’t think it escapes any of us—*Coach* included—how rough his voice sounds. Or the fact his coach makes no move to enter deeper into the locker room.

There’s a beat, and a squeaking footstep. “Okay. Thought I heard something. Just wanted to check.”

With a villainous tilt of his mouth, Vale fucks gently in and out my mouth with shallow thrusts. A stark difference to the punishing punches of his cock from a moment ago. “Yeah I’ll be out soon. No need to wait around.”

My eyes flutter shut, a shudder wracking my body as a quiet moan rumbles quietly up my throat. My cheeks are blaze—they’re probably as red as my favorite candy. As red as the blood pooling in my belly right now...*his blood*...

Will I have his cum in there soon too?

I want to be full of him. So very, very full of all things Vale. I want no part of me left untouched.

A throat clears. “O-okay. See you tomorrow.”

Cheese on a cracker, take a fucking hint!

“See ya,” Vale says lightly, not fazed in the least as he forks his fingers through my hair, tipping my head back. With the new angle, he can slide in all the deeper.

I can't decide if I'm grateful or disappointed when the footsteps quickly retreat, and the door seals shut with a click.

Vale chuckles lowly, and my eyes pop open. "You think he heard you choking?" He murmurs, tilting my head. He trails a finger down my hollowed cheek. "Gagging, like the hungry little cock-slut you are?"

My responding groan vibrates up over his steely length, eliciting a barely-there hitch of his breath. One I could've easily missed if I wasn't paying so close attention to how wrecked he looks standing over me right now.

I can only imagine the sight we *both* make.

"You're gonna swallow it all, you got that?" he says gruffly, picking up his thrusts once more. "Every fucking drop."

I nod obediently around his cock.

Gripping the back of my head, he holds it up off the bench, sliding himself out just enough to create a gap between us. "Stick out your tongue. I want to watch."

I do as he says, blinking innocently up at him.

He grunts. "Would you look at that, you do know how to be a good boy after all."

His entire body pulls tight, muscles clenching, straining. His balls draw up, his dick throbbing on my tongue. "Fuck. *Fuck*, sugar, I'm coming," he croaks, followed a moment later by the first spurt of his jizz exploding from his glistening tip. Streaking across my face, hot and silky, and *fucking delicious*.

And before I even realize what's happening—

Oh fuck.

Oh fuck, oh fuck, oh fuuuuucckkkkk.

I'm busting my load in my school-issued khakis like a total loser.

Be it the noises coming from him...his taste...

The stark hunger in his eyes as he watches his cock shoot jet after jet of cum into my waiting mouth.

Or, perhaps, the simple utterance of his little pet name for me, groaned so sweetly, so brokenly...

Whatever it is...it has my body jerking, toes curling tightly enough to send a cramp shooting up my leg. "F-f-fffffuck," I groan, rolling my eyes back. "Yes, baby. Give it to me."

With a harsh sound that is equal parts grunt and snarl, Vale uses his grip on my hair to wrench my head back, giving me no choice but to gaze adoringly at his harsh, gorgeous downturned face—that black, ravenous gaze I could sink into and never find my way out.

So. Fucking. Hot.

I make sure to stick my tongue out as far as it will go to catch every drop of his release, just like he said. Because I'm a good boy. For him, I can be good.

Only him...

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CHAPTER 21

VALE

MY VISION BLACKENS, swirling...

Flashing.

Something bad is coming...

Pleasure crashes over me, clashing with the simultaneous horror. The taste of iron coats my tongue, and I can no longer tell if it's real or the past creeping forward, slowly consuming me in a blaze of fire and blood.

"I'm sorry, Vale... I'll make it feel good...close your eyes..."

Distorted echoes of childish pleas intermingle with present-day Aston's throaty moans; my past and present colliding, fighting for dominance. If I wasn't so lost to the endorphins rushing through my system, lighting up my nerve-endings—if I wasn't so consumed by the sight of my cum jetting out across his face, pooling in his waiting tongue—I have no doubt I'd be choking the life out of him right now.

Sure about that?

I snarl at the unwanted voice in my head, and squeeze my dick, wringing it out. Watching outside myself as I rub it all over his face, scooping up what missed his mouth, and feeding it to him.

"Show me."

Tilting his head back, he cradles his tongue around my creamy release, presenting it to me.

"Good," I say tightly. "Now swallow." Even to my own ears, my voice sounds...wrong. Distant.

Aston does as I say, gulping with an audible click. He suckles at my head—my slit—and all along my still-hard shaft. Lashes fan over his flushed cheekbones, and my throat feels impossibly clenched suddenly.

Grinding my teeth, I fight a shudder. And when I realize my touch on his hair has eased up, I abruptly yank away from him, shoving myself off him, and turning my back on him to put some much needed distance between us.

Aston coughs gently, mumbling something I can't make out.

With jerky, rushed movements, I get dressed, ignoring the way my fingers buzz and my heart pounds in my ears. Tension hangs thickly in the air in a way you'd think impossible after having such a mind-blowing orgasm.

Behind me, I hear Aston get up, and of course he lingers, oblivious as fucking ever to the stark change in atmosphere.

What is he waiting for, a thank you?

Or perhaps he's hoping I'll take pity on his dick and return the favor...

Fat fucking chance.

I'd rather chew glass. Just the thought of putting my mouth anywhere near him makes me want to bash my fist into something. Quite possibly his skull.

Once I've got my socks and shoes on, I grab my keys from where they'd fallen on the ground. I'm about to reach for my bag when I catch him approaching the knife he'd dropped earlier.

I manage to beat him to it.

Whirling on him, I fist his tie, right at the base of his throat, shove him up against the lockers, and point the tip of the blade at his chin. He freezes, eyes rounding.

There it is.

His fear smells as sweet as I imagined it would. Sweeter than his needy cries and silky skin. Sweeter than how I imagine he'd taste... all dripping and tight and *hot*. For *me*...

No!

Enraged by my unwanted thoughts, I growl, "Stay the fuck away from my shit. And stay the fuck away from me."

Despite the wariness flickering back at me, his lips twitch, like he can't help but try to lighten the moment by playing with fire. He tilts his head. "You sure you want that?" His voice is raspy—evidence of the abuse he happily took.

I can't decide if I'm more pleased or annoyed that he gets off on the humiliation. The hurt. The *fear*. Leaning forward, I angle the knife

downward and add just enough pressure to his throat to break skin.

He pupils expand, and he captures his bottom lip between his teeth. Visibly fighting a shudder.

Yeah, he likes this.

My spent dick twitches in my shorts.

Ignoring it, I arch my pierced brow. “What else left is there to do to you?”

His jaw hardens when he processes what I’m saying.

I shrug and arch my brows in a silent sort of, *What can you do?*

Looking him up and down, I inhale deeply. “It is a pity. You’re fun to play with.”

When he visibly squirms, his hip brushing mine, I cock my head, flitting a glance to his crotch without really seeing anything.

Curling my lip cruelly, I return my gaze to his and say, “Aw, is someone feeling a little neglected? If only you had someone here who wanted to help you take care of that.”

His eyes widen, flashing with surprise that is quickly replaced by a glittering, victorious sort of smugness. It mirrors the smirk tugging his lips, and if I wasn’t so suddenly aware of how close we stand, perhaps I would’ve tuned into the alarm bells going off sooner.

His lips are *right. There.* Those full, glistening, pouty lips that only moments ago were wrapped around my cock. As if sensing where my head went, Aston pushes up on his toes and leans forward, puckering up and— A hand appears—my hand—palming his face and shoving him away. Horror at what almost just happened has me taking several steps back and biting back a string of curses.

“We’re done,” I mutter tightly at the same time he says something. “What was that?”

“I said you’re too late anyway.”

I frown, searching his face. While that smugness still radiates from his eyes, there’s also something else there, something reinforced by the flush blooming over his cheeks.

Nerves? Shame?

He shrugs and looks down. “Embarrassing, I know.” He blows out a breath and flicks his fingers dismissively. “What can I say? That was *hot.*”

For a long moment, all I can do is stare at him.

“You didn’t,” I whisper faintly, my grip on the knife tightening.

Though the words aren't for him, he hears and responds to them all the same.

"Oh, trust me. I did." His nose wrinkles, and he reaches down to tug at the crotch of his khakis. His *wet* khakis...because the spot that was there before has tripled in size.

How did I not...

I mentally replay through what happened. An image of him sprawled out beneath me, flushed and squirming, lashes fluttering. The little moans and whimpers breaching his throat as he held his mouth open expectantly.

I take a step back, then another.

A dangerous stillness has fallen over me, one that is as familiar as it is foreign. Foreign because it's been so long since I felt like this.

"See?" he says, fingers fumbling with his fly.

"Stop."

But he doesn't seem to hear me as he continues to mumble under his breath, "...sticky. Ugh...no regrets. None whatsoever...except—"

Something bad is coming...

One second I'm standing here, frozen, and the next—

I was wrong.

I was wrong.

Something bad wasn't coming...

It was already here, happening right under my nose.

"I'm sorry...please, I'm so sorry..."

"You promised!"

A yelp pierces through the heavy black fog surrounding me. I blink and find myself crouched and hovering over a curled-up Aston on the locker room floor. He's got his knees curled up to his chest, arm shielding his face.

And my fist...it's pulled back. The sharp metal of the blade glinting in the light.

"Don't!" he gasps. "Don't, I'm s-sorry, please I-I—"

I push to a stand, chest heaving. The knife clatters to the ground, and I slam my hand against the locker, making him flinch as the sound echoes across the room.

A sage eye cracks open, peering up at me over his arm. "V-Vale?"

Slowly, slowly, he eases up to a seated position, not taking his impossibly round eyes off me as he scrambles back against the locker I just punched. His nose is intact. No blood, save for the smears of mine on his

sleeves and the thin line going down his neck from where I pierced him with the knife before everything went to shit.

I didn't hurt him.

It's as baffling as it is a...relief. Fuck, it's a relief.

He hugs himself, shoulders hunched. Looking so much smaller than he did a second ago. Vulnerable, and...broken.

"We're done," I repeat, and even to my own ears my voice sounds hollow. Robotic.

His lips purse, and there's an unsettling sheen to his wide eyes. Even though he's now staring straight ahead, it still makes looking at him unbearable, so I rip my gaze away, and head for the only exit.

Never should've stuck around...

My steps slow to a stop when I reach the door, hand splayed over the wood.

"This never should've happened," I say in that same flat voice. I don't even have to raise my voice, it's that fucking quiet in here. "Stay the fuck away from me. This...us...whatever you think this is...it's never going to happen. If you know what's good for you, you'll fucking back off."

Why I don't immediately leave, I've no clue.

Perhaps to give him a chance to push me one final time. I'd be justified in hurting him then, wouldn't I? To ignore me after that wouldn't just be stupid, it would be suicidal.

Hell, maybe that's exactly why I hesitate. Give him an opening. *Show me who you really are under all the bullshit. Show me you remember.*

But he says nothing, telling me all I need to know.

He doesn't remember what he did.

Or he does, and it's not enough to make him want to die.

"You won't ever leave me, right?"

"Valey, Valey, Valey..."

Somehow I end up outside. In my car. My tires kick up gravel, the engine roaring as I floor the gas.

Without having had made the conscious decision to do so, I find myself speeding down a familiar stretch of dirt road toward the abandoned industrial park a few blocks down from Aston's neighborhood. Utility poles and weathered *Do Not Enter* and *No Trespassing* signs litter the way, passing me in a blur, melding with the dreary atmosphere and rain picking up momentum.

Angry music blares from my speakers, unraveling what threads remain of my rapidly slipping control. But it might as well be playing from mile away, muffled by the distance stretching out inside my head, pulling taut like a rubber band.

Past.

Present.

I'm at the center, bracing for the impact when they inevitably collide.

Snarling viciously through my teeth, I swing the Audi right, cutting through the overgrowth into what was once a parking lot for the Crowley Lace Factory.

It's empty, as it almost always is. I don't even have it in me to be relieved. There's no way I would've been able to turn around, not now, when I'm barely holding it together.

The door slams shut behind me.

I hardly notice the rain slanting down, splashing my cheeks, as I stride purposefully toward the crumbling red brick building standing dormant and abandoned against a gunmetal sky. Rocks and broken glass crunching under my heavy strides. Not that I can hear it under the heavy rainfall, the roar in my ears, or the past whispering words from a time I've tried so hard to shake.

"Promise me you'll remember I love you."

"I'll protect you. Just know that."

I cut through an archway separating two sections of the building, emerging into a courtyard crawling with weeds and vines. The clock tower comes into view, its peeling teal-painted turret pointing proudly at the sky, the time frozen at a quarter past seven.

Like the other abandoned parts of town that I've explored over the years—the mines, old factories and industrial plants such as this...a motel just up the roads that was once a honeymoon hot spot for tourists looking to fuck it out in a heart-shaped tub...

I used to venture here a lot. I know every access point. Every broken window. Every loose board. And given how much graffiti there is—how much garbage and destruction are inside—I know I'm far from being the only one who's broken in over the years. The rusted chains and bolts on the doors might as well just be decoration at this point.

Luckily, I've yet to ever run into anyone here.

On autopilot, I storm through the various rooms and corridors, my boots splashing along puddles that have gathered from the holes in the ceiling. A staircase. A walkway. Then, finally, my destination.

The whiskey I'd brought with me last time is right where I left it, hidden behind crates stuffed with file folders, barely touched. A thin film of dust coats the bottle. Unscrewing the cap, I bring it to my lips, throwing back several searing gulps. Welcoming the liquid fire burning a path down my throat, flooding my stomach with an aching sort of warmth that has saliva flooding my mouth.

I wish I could say it was from the alcohol, and only the alcohol. And that I haven't been fighting back nausea since the moment I realized Aston came in his pants. The moment I realized just how fucked not just our situation is, but how fucked *I* am. Not only in the head for thinking I could... what? Rewrite history by pinning him down and forcing my cock down his throat.

But fucked in the sense that I'm *screwed*. Because I *liked* it. I *enjoyed* watching my cock disappear into his mouth. The feel of it, so sweltering, so tight when he instinctively hollowed his cheeks.

The way tears and drool pooled out of him as he choked, face red, nostrils flaring for air.

His garbled moans. His whimpers.

I was blinded by it—how *good* it felt to have him under me, at my disposal. A toy for the taking and breaking.

All I could think was, he's *mine*.

Mine to hurt.

Mine to touch.

Mine to make a pretty little mess of.

It's the least he deserves... a voice whispers now, same as earlier.

And when all was said and done, I thought just maybe...maybe that was all I needed. And then I had to go and be tempted by his lips. By his tight lithe body rubbing against mine. By the visual he planted in my head when he said *too late*, and looked down so bashfully at his cum-soaked pants.

He came for me. Untouched.

A ragged sound wrenches from my throat, breeching my lips in a thunderous roar. Glass shatters against the decorated wall of the factory, the pungent scent of the whiskey I'd been drinking and just wasted by throwing across the room, filling the space and flooding my nostrils. I'm no longer in

my own body as I whip around and grab whatever else is in reach. Kicking and throwing and *screaming*.

I wasn't supposed to like it.

He wasn't supposed to like it.

And I especially wasn't supposed to crave *more*...

Not from him, never from him. Not from the guy who can't even have the fucking decency to remember what he did to me.

What he was made to do...

The voice in my head sounds suspiciously like Quentin's from so long ago—back before he knew fucking better—and I snarl as I storm across the room, my scalding gaze locked on what looks to be a crowbar. Grabbing it, I twirl it around, before gripping it between my hands like a bat, taking it to the nearest intact window, shattering it with a roar.

I just wanted the upper hand...

I just wanted to break him.

And instead I gave him pleasure. I made him feel good.

Stumbling to my knees, I drop the crowbar, and stare at my reddened palms. My fingers tremble. Hell, my whole body quakes.

This isn't me.

These aren't my hands.

This isn't my body.

This isn't who I am.

How is it fair? How is it fair that *I* have to live with it, while he just goes about his fucking life as if *nothing*. *Happened*.

My lungs fight for air, my heart pounding. Fuck, I'm so *angry*.

I squeeze my hands into fists, bringing them to my head. Covering my ears. Screwing my eyes shut, I do nothing to ward off the jagged shards of memories exploding from my brain, not unlike the bottle I threw earlier. I imagine the whiskey sluicing down the walls of my mind, streaking through the paper-thin barrier keeping the past at bay. Burning marks that will never heal.

"Just close your eyes. Pretend you're somewhere else."

The floor tilts. My skin crawls. Whispers fill my head. I'm dimly aware of my phone vibrating in my pocket—Quentin, likely wondering where I am—but I ignore it.

"I'll make it feel good. It won't hurt. I won't hurt you. I won't, I won't..."

The stale echo of smoke fills my lungs. The factory flickers in and out, the present losing the battle against a fractured past.

Smoke curling up from an ashtray.

Plaid couch. Hand on my shoulder, nudging me to lay down. A crack through the ceiling. Air, cool on my— The click of a camera.

Wetness, warmth on my— Click.

Clickclickclick—

I should've known this would happen.

The second Aston dropped to his knees—the second I let him put his fingers to my hand and lips to my knuckles, resolve and spite sitting like heavy jagged weights in my gut, I knew I'd come to regret it.

And yet it didn't stop me.

I didn't just play with fire when I let Aston put his mouth on me. I doused myself in gasoline and eagerly lit the match as if I was in deference to my undoing. Self-immolation of the most ludicrous order. All the while telling myself—after telling *him*—that it was for *me*...this act was for *me*... this...this *sacrifice*. This thing that disguised itself as revenge. Closure. Justice.

Reclamation of what was stolen.

He owed me...

A sob.

A plea.

Trembling, icy cold fingers, replaced by rough, large hands— “No,” he cries. “You promised. You promised.”

Slap!

A whimper.

The world moves.

I'm on the floor now.

Clickclickclick.

There's a hand in mine, squeezing, gripping, and I roll my head, lashes fluttering heavily.

Eyes gray-green like the plastic butterfly I found on the road. They're all I see. I let myself get lost in them.

“Won't let him hurt you,” he says, and it comes out slow and warbled.

He flinches.

His eyes crease.

The bones in my hand creak.

Grunts. Breaths. The quietest of whimpers, because he's quiet as a mouse, sosososo quiet, he never cries, never yells...

So fucking blinded by my need to *ruin* him—punish him—I missed what should've been obvious. Just like I missed what was happening behind closed doors all those years ago.

It was never Aston's power over me I had to worry about.

It was our past.

Our secrets.

Our *lies*...

The ones I hide behind.

Like his betrayal...a betrayal that was as much beyond his control, as what had been done to him.

He disappears.

His eyes are open, but no one's home.

Earth to Aston...

His face slackens.

He looks peaceful.

His body jolts. Jolts again. And again and again and again.

But he's no longer here. Just a body.

Like the fact that what happened earlier did nothing to eradicate the way my body craves him, despite what we went through as kids...despite what he had to do...despite how fucked up beyond words this entire situation is.

Like the truth, the one I never wanted to face, and thought I could shove down and outrun forever...

"You're mine, little mouse. You'll always be mine. And I'll always be yours."

Click.

Clickclickclickclickclickclick—

And I have no idea what to do with any of that.

CHAPTER 22

ASTON

ONE, two, three...

It's fine. Everything's fine. I've got this *all* under control. Everything's going exactly according to— "SOMEBODY SEDATE ME!"

Hands—way too many hands scramble to hold me down.

"Aston. ASTON. Can you hear me?" *I know that voice. What is she doing here? And why can't I see her....why can't I see anything but—* Wide, desperate black eyes find mine through the blur of bodies converging on me all at once. A hand stained red thrusting through to reach for me.

Blood. So much blood. It's everywhere...

I try to reach back. I buck and kick and claw at the arms caging me in.

And I scream. Violently.

"VALE!"

I scream for him, and I reach for him, and I scream and I scream and I scream.

Why can't he hear me?

Why is no one LISTENING— Hold up.

(Checks notes.)

Just kidding! Yeah, so, that didn't actually happen...yet.

Awk-ward...

Still curled up in a ball where Vale left me, I finally manage a swallow—the jagged rock of emotion sitting there finally budging just enough to allow me to do so.

The silence in his wake is heavy. Deafening. The kind that feels like a threat.

My ears ring, the roar from moments ago shoved aside by a high-pitched whine. A sound I can't even be certain isn't just in my head, and not the product of my heightened senses tuning into the fluorescents overhead. Fluorescents that feel like fiery blades against my corneas when I blink blearily up at them, searing black holes into my watery vision.

My knife. Where is my knife?

Rolling onto my hands and knees, I start to crawl shakily across the crushed carpet— No, wait, that's not right.

I lift my head, blinking furiously at my surroundings, trying to rid the blur.

Blink, and the walls are melting—lockers and paint dripping to reveal paneled wood.

Blink, and the bench I was just laid out across is now a bed—a twin bed with a too-thin, lumpy mattress and a creaky headboard.

Blink, and the glare of the lights blinding my vision are flickering swirls of red and blue.

A weird sound punctures the air—not quite a whimper, not quite a groan—and for a moment my vision blackens out completely. Pain shooting through my skull like someone took an ice pick to my eye.

I stumble, arms buckling, and I curl forward, forehead pressed to the floor. Ears crushed between my clenched hands.

I'm not there. It's not real.

My pulse quickens, and I fling my eyes wide open to stare blankly at the dark hardwood floor. I inhale deeply, shakily breathing it in—the grime and lingering sweat that permeates the room—grounding myself.

"Get it together," I mutter under my breath.

Once my head no longer feels like it's going to burst like a gusher, and my heart's slowed to a reasonable pace, I push up off my hands and fall back on my heels. Air expelling harshly from my lungs in a single gust.

I spare a quick paranoid look around, ensuring no one witnessed the embarrassing display. It's one thing for people to think you're an unstable maniac prone to violent, unpredictable, *scary* outbursts...and another for them to catch you rocking in the fetal position, unable to distinguish nightmare from reality.

I rub my hands down my thighs and blow out a long breath. Then, with a self-reassuring nod, I glance around, slumping when I find my knife spun

out just a foot away, the blade pointed toward the exit. In the direction of where Vale disappeared.

I swipe it up by one of the handles, closing it with a *snick*. And then I peel myself off the hard, unforgiving floor, using the wood-paneled wall for lev— Nope. Wait. That's a *locker*. Because I'm still in the locker room.

I'm not...*there*.

Grumbling curses under my breath, I wipe my eyes with trembling fingers, wincing when another bolt of pain shoots through my skull.

It's fine.

Everything's fine.

Lifting my head, I blink blearily at the cold, sterile room around me. It's as if Vale collected all the warmth and color and took it with him when he stormed out.

Is it just me, or is it so much smaller in here now?

How does air even circulate in a place this tiny?

Where are the windows???

Switching the knife to one hand, I use the other to dig my phone out of my pocket. I bring up Eden's contact, ignoring the way my fingers twitch and stutter over the keyboard as I thumb out a text to him letting him know I'm ready to be picked up.

Not bothering to wait for a response, I lock the screen, and go to put it away when I catch sight of the very visible wet spot blooming over my crotch.

Nausea rises so swiftly, I rear back into the wall—*locker*—from the force of it. Torso caving like someone punched me in the gut, knocking the air out of me. I nearly crumple to the floor for the second time in as many minutes.

The phone creaks in my grip.

The blade whips out with a loud *click*, metal glinting off the light.

Minutes...

How has it only been minutes since I had Vale's cock shoved down my throat?

Minutes since he held me at knife-point looking all sorts of debauched, his taste still lingering on my tongue, so much sweeter than the ugly words he spewed...

My underwear still warm with my release—not sticky and cold and chafing like it is now—and his cruel sneer hovering only inches away from

my tingling lips.

Minutes since I opened my big fat mouth and ruined everything.

Again.

To be fair...if I knew me jizzing in my pants would piss him off *that* much, I would've tried a little harder to, you know, *not jizz in my pants*.

Okayyy, so at the very least, I would've refrained from taunting him with it. Especially after he made it oh so very clear that *my* pleasure wasn't on the menu.

Hell, if his next actions proved anything, me getting off to him throat-fucking me was a straight-up *offense* to his very existence.

One second, he was slowly backing away, as I fumbled to unzip my fly to show him the mess he caused. *See, see! Look what you made me do.*

And the next, I had what felt like two-hundred pounds of solid muscle all but tackling me to the floor, and the sharp point of a knife gunning for my face. Eyes so cold, so black, so...so *terrifyingly* empty bearing down on me, threatening to shatter my bones into dust with a mere *look*.

"Vale, don't!"

The yelp and plea that had burst free was as unbidden as the way my arms instantly lifted to shield my head. It's been years since I last got my ass kicked, but the body remembers even when the brain does all it can to wall those memories off.

Not that I thought it would actually make a difference. Any of it.

Like *stop* and *please*... the word *don't* is just as useless. Fighting back just as pointless. Nothing more than just another weapon to be used against me.

The phone still clutched in my hand vibrates.

EDIEPOO 🐱 🎀 🐟 💕

5 min

Blowing out a breath, I roll my shoulders back and crack my neck, before padding over to where I'd stashed my bag, along with my blazer, in an unmarked locker. Closing the knife I don't recall making the conscious decision to open, I tuck it safely in the side pocket of my bag along with my phone.

I'm just about to tie the jacket around my waist when a thought occurs, inspiration striking and taking hold of me, driving my movements faster than I can see reason.

Circling back the way I came, I make a beeline for the gear locker with *Riviera* taped across the top.

Jackpot, I think when I find a neatly folded pair of gray joggers just *begging* to cuddle my butt and thighs and all the bits in between. I bring them to my nose, inhaling deeply.

Mmmm, that's the stuff.

No thoughts, head empty...I drop trou, cummy briefs and all, and swap them out for buttery soft cotton that feels like Heaven on my skin and smells equally divine.

There. Much better.

Feeling more like my ol' self already, I gather my discarded bottoms, spare Vale's locker one last longing look, before forcing my feet to carry me away from temptation.

Because as much as I itch to do *something*... like leave Vale a little gift—a token from our tryst in the form of cum-stained briefs—something for him to remember me by...

Something to bring him back to me...

Alas, with comfort comes clarity—a double-edged sword in the form of gray sweatpants.

Before today, I wouldn't have thought twice about it. But as much as I want to shake off the lingering weirdness, this *wrongness*, and forget what just happened—forget that look in his eye before he snapped himself out of whatever...or *wherever*...held him hostage—I can't.

Whatever that was...

It was big.

It was bad.

Just not big or bad enough for me to return the sweatpants.

Can you blame me???

They fit like a glove.

And by glove I mean I have to roll them, like, three times around my waist just so they don't drag, and manually hold them up when I walk, because gravity.

Which is how Eden finds me minutes later, when I emerge through the sliding front doors of the field house, one hand anchoring the pants, and the other shielding my face in shame. My backpack is slung over my shoulders, bouncing against my butt as I awkwardly shuffle toward the idling baby

blue Beetle. And yes, my heart sunglasses are firmly back in place, despite the fact that clouds have moved in once more, masking the evening sun.

Angry screamo music greets me when I throw open the door and toss my bag in the backseat. I feel Eden gaping at me, but I ignore it for the moment in favor of getting myself settled.

“What the fuck happened to you?” he says after lowering the music. “Is that *blood???*” he practically screeches.

I go to reach for the cut Vale left me with, only registering the slight sting of it now, when my gaze catches sight of the red smears decorating my once pristine white sleeves.

Groaning, I throw my head back against the seat. “You don’t wanna know.”

A long moment passes where it feels like Eden might say something—maybe push me to talk. But just when I think maybe, *just maybe*, my new brother isn’t as immune to my efforts to bond with him as I thought...

He cranks the music back up, shifts into Drive, and peels from the lot.

Drumming my fingers on my thighs, I stare straight ahead, lost in my own thoughts, trying to make sense of it all. Make sense of *Vale*...

And this nagging feeling I can’t shake that I’m missing something.

Something beyond the darkness filling those holes in my memories, the ones I pretend aren’t there.

“*You’re sick, you know.*”

“*Did I say you can fucking touch me?*”

“*You’ve never been good.*”

It’s not until we approach a familiar intersection, that I snap to attention, the heavy fog threatening to drag me down releasing me, and I break the silence with a loudly gasped, “WAIT!”

Luckily no one is behind us when he panic-brakes at a green light, brakes squealing.

“Wha—”

I gesture wildly, struggling to untangle my tongue. “Turn!”

Luckily, I don’t have to clarify which direction I want him to go. He releases an exasperated sigh. “*Seriously?* You swore it’d be just that one—”

“Just do it!”

Growling and muttering under his breath, he flips the blinker and does as I say.

Heart pounding, I whip off the sunglasses, folding and clutching them in my lap, my puffy red eyes forgotten. My knee bobs as I track the distance without really seeing anything, counting each block we pass until finally the gold ornate sign reading Royal Oaks appears.

Without any further prompting from me, Eden cuts the wheel, taking us into the affluent neighborhood where Vale lives. His house—correction: his *mansion*—is as far from the main road as you can get, separated on either side from his neighbors by stretches of dense forest. And across the street is a utility building, or whatever they're called, one that is just big enough to hide this car from view.

Something I may or may not know after we staked his house one afternoon.

(Don't give me that look! Recon, remember?)

Once Eden's parked, I waste no time unbuckling, throwing the door open, and scrambling out into the brush.

Annndddd promptly moon Eden in the process.

"Fuck," I mutter, reaching down, yanking the pants back up. Cheeks blazing, I turn my head with a cringey smile. I can't make out Eden's face from here, so I just wave an apology in the general direction of the windshield.

I hastily tuck my shirt and add another roll of the pants for good measure. I won't be winning any Best Dressed superlatives with this fit, but desperate times and all.

Shuffling over to the small brick building, I hug the corner, and poke my head out just enough to peek across the street.

At the sight of the open garage, my heart sinks. His new daddy's fancy SUV is there, but the spot next to it is vacant, telling me Vale's not back yet.

Recalling the way we left things, I can't help but feel like *I'm* the reason he hasn't yet made it home. Unless he had other plans...

Uneasiness chips away at the little peace I'd managed to rebuild since tugging on Vale's sweatpants. Swallowing tightly, I strain my ears for sounds of an approaching car.

Any second now...

Eventually, those seconds spent holding my breath turn to minutes struggling to remember *how* to breathe.

I don't even notice the sound of a car door opening and closing, not until a hesitant hand glances off my shoulder, and a softly murmured,

“Aston?” manages to poke through my daze that I realize Eden’s come after me.

Whipping around, I roughly wipe the back of my hand under my nose and force a couple swallows, eyes blinking rapidly at the blurred ground.

“Are you...are you *crying*?”

“I’m fine!” I squeak...much too loudly.

Eden shushes me, dragging me by the elbow back to the car. He opens the door for me and everything, all but shoving me inside. Having killed the engine when he parked, we’re left in complete silence for a long moment after he joins me before he finally speaks.

“What happened?” This time, when he asks, he sounds almost like he....cares. Almost like he’s...worried.

Sniffing, I grab my sunglasses from where they fell near my feet, and shove them back on my face. I run my hands through my hair, wincing when my fingers get stuck in the knots.

Yikes...

Probably should’ve looked in a mirror at some point before fleeing the locker room. Until this moment, I forgot just how much Vale was yanking and tugging on the strands.

My throat burns.

Where is he?

Why isn’t he home?

Where did he go?

“Should I call Mom?” Eden asks quietly.

I’m shaking my head before he even finishes asking the question.

Fuck me, was it really just this morning his dad asked if he should turn the car around in that same nervous tone?

What a fucking day, and to think it’s only Monday...

After a long moment, Eden sighs and starts the car back up.

The drive home is silent, filled only by the intermittent *click-click-click* of the blinker, and the low grumbling hum of the engine.

It’s not until we turn down our street that I finally find my voice, words spilling out unbidden. “You can’t tell Tillie.” I don’t have to specify what I’m talking about.

A loaded beat passes. “I know. I promised you I wouldn’t.”

Right...

The night of the Bell Game. Driving home from the Furnaces.

Eden might not know all the gritty details, but I did have to clarify one thing to him—that Vale wasn't my *real* brother.

Poor guy seemed to be *real* concerned with that little detail.

I also had to make Eden swear he'd keep Vale's and my connection to himself.

I may or may not have used a certain secret of his against him...

Did resorting to blackmail earn me any favors in the friendship department? No. But again...desperate times and all. Story of my life.

Speaking of desperation...

"She'll send me back," I blurt, the inside of the car seeming so much smaller suddenly. My loud, harsh pants are all I can hear for a long moment.

And then the engine cuts out. The car dings, the overhead lights coming on.

I blink, looking around the dimly lit driveway. Somewhere between leaving Vale's neighborhood and reaching ours, the street lamps kicked on.

"She's not going to send you back," Eden says tiredly.

"She will," I insist, nodding strongly. "If I fuck this up, I'm gone."

A long, heavy moment passes. "Aston..."

I whip around to face him. "Yeah?"

His troubled gaze darts all around my face, and I'm grateful for the sunglasses hiding my eyes.

I'm fine. Everything's fine. Everything's— "Nothing," he mutters after a long moment, ducking his head, hiding behind a curtain tangled hair. "Just..." He flicks his fingers toward me. "I'm here if you want to... talk or whatever."

My chest expands. "Really? You mean that?" My voice cracks embarrassingly, but there's no containing my wide, watery grin.

With a scowl, he peeks up at me, eyeing me with a wary look.

Which makes me grin even wider.

Wide enough to make him wrinkle his nose and rear back.

Tone it down!

Don't fuck this up!

Finally, reluctantly, he gives a stilted nod. And before either of us even realize what's happening, I'm throwing myself at him.

Only...there's a seatbelt strapped across my chest. One I forgot about.

Grumbling, I quickly unbuckle it, ignoring the way Eden cowers and scrambles back as I all but crawl across the glove compartment and smother

him with *love*.

And for a moment, I forget all about what happened in the locker room.

All about Vale and his unknown whereabouts.

All about the pants falling down, baring my ass to anyone who might be walking past the passenger side.

I forget all about wood paneled walls and creaky doors and stupid rock songs from the '60s... and figures towering over me, so much bigger and stronger than I could ever hope to fend off.

And I forget that I can lose all of this...everything...myself...at the drop of a hat.

Eden mumbles something into my shoulder I can't make out, which only encourages me to squeeze him tighter. Tight enough to make him wince and wiggle aggressively to get some distance.

Once he succeeds, squished up against the driver's door, he scowls up at me, eyes narrowed into a glare. "I'm gonna regret this, aren't I?"

I nod. "Probably."

And boy, ain't that the truth.

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CHAPTER 23

VALE

“YOU’RE QUIET TONIGHT.”

I blink and look up from my plate.

Across the table, Quentin arches an amused brow as he bites off a piece of broccoli from his fork. Something tells me this isn’t the first time he’s tried to get my attention.

Swallowing the chunk of juicy red steak I was chewing—steaks we were supposed to have last night—I reach for my glass of water and take a few sips, washing it down. Clearing my throat, I say, “Yeah, just got a lot on my mind.”

He hums, brown eyes squinting in thought. I stare him down point-blank, not giving anything away.

“Would it have anything to do with why you didn’t come home until well after midnight last night?” he asks, more curious than annoyed. I think I even detect a bit of concern. His gaze flicks to my bandaged forearm. “Or that?”

I feel my jaw start to tick, pulsing in time with the faint throbbing where Aston cut me yesterday. I quickly shove some mashed potatoes in my mouth, hoping Quentin doesn’t notice.

“I take that as a yes,” he says slowly, and I can practically hear that quick lawyer mind of his working.

Swallowing the potatoes, I glance down at my plate as I slice off another tender piece of filet, the serrated knife scraping loudly against my fork, piercing the heavy expectant silence.

I was wondering when he’d bring it up.

After I eventually exhausted myself out, I unlocked my phone to find two missed calls and several missed texts, most of which from the man sitting before me now. I told him the truth, or the partial truth, in the form of a single word, one I knew he'd understand. *Air*.

In other words, I needed to blow off some steam and get my emotions under control before I did something stupid I couldn't come back from. Luckily, he knew better than to start on the steaks until I got home, so he just whipped something else up for himself to eat.

While I wouldn't have felt guilty about it, if he had it all cooked and laid out, I don't like waste. He knows this. Knows I get irrationally angry when I go to restaurants and see plates piled with food getting taken back to the kitchen to be tossed.

Doesn't take a genius to know where that little quirk came from.

Quentin's gaze drifts from the bandage to the faded scratches going up each of my exposed arms, eyeing them with scrutiny. Those aren't from yesterday though, but it is the first time he's seeing them. He'd been out of town on business since Thursday and just got back yesterday afternoon.

I bite back a curse, silently berating myself for not throwing on a long-sleeved shirt, if only to avoid questions. But then just a quickly, I remember why I didn't.

Hiding the marks just feels wrong—like I'm somehow admitting defeat.

Okay, and maybe a small part of me wants the visual reminder of what happened. Not the part where it felt fucking amazing, but the part that came after. The part that led me to trashing an abandoned building and questioning if the life I'd been so set on having was worth it, all because of a fucking blow job.

Across the table, Quentin sets his fork down and grabs his cloth napkin from where it was hidden on his lap, bringing it up to pat the corners of his mouth. Setting it off to the side of his mostly clean plate, he leans back, crossing his arms. Waiting with a stern, yet patient, expectant arch of his brows.

It's an expression I've grown quite familiar with over the last five years. Even back when he first took me in, when I still didn't talk, he never treated me like I was less than. Or as someone not worth his time. Even when he didn't know me, but especially after he *did*.

And for a mute foster kid, orphaned at the fragile age of eight and thrown into a system that almost only ever benefited the evil in this world,

that meant everything. Even to someone like me.

It's probably half the reason why I rarely ever felt the need to keep things from him.

He's consistent and reliable, and I know for a fact he won't be burdened by his own biases. He's a lawyer first, a human second. And maybe that might rub some people wrong, but for me, it's a relief. A comfort.

Because no matter what sort of trouble may have tempted me over the years, he's always made an effort to understand where I was coming from. Never judged. Never condemned. Just tried to understand *why*, so he could help me figure out the best and safe way to achieve what I want.

Even back when I didn't talk much, he'd have me write everything down. Make a pros and cons list. Then we'd analyze the shit out of it, examining it from every possible angle.

And then, when all was said and done, he'd simply sit back, nod, and say, "*Just be smart*," trusting me to... Well, not so much to make the so-called *right* choice, but to make the one that presented with the least amount of negative fallout.

He gave me the tools, but he left it up to me to make the choice of whether or not I use them, and *how* I use them.

He taught me how to see the bigger picture.

What is my end game?

What are the possible ways this could go bad?

How can I work setbacks to my advantage?

And most of all, he gave me room to be myself. Within reason.

I'm reminded of all that now as I stare down my adoptive dad, debating how much to confide in him. He's smart though. He has to know what this about. Or, rather, who.

"Aston remembers me."

And just like that, all curious amusement from a moment ago winks out. His eyes harden and he straightens, leaning forward the slightest bit, telling me it's no longer *Dad* I'm talking to, but the lawyer.

"You talked." Not a question.

I suck in my cheek and nod, not giving him any more than that.

Images from our last two interactions flash across my head.

That infuriating mouth that never seems to stop moving, parted in pleasure, lips perpetually red and swollen.

That pale, smooth patch of skin, sloping down from his neck, blooming with blotches of discoloration.

That perfect peach of an ass with that tight pink ring in the center, begging for me to fill it.

It looked so tight, I think, recalling the other night.

He was so fucking greedy for my cock. Like a feral little beast.

I've no doubt if I rolled him over Saturday night, let him touch me as I played and fucked with him from the front—or didn't restrain him yesterday and let him give as much as he took—I'd have scratch marks all up and down my back, my chest too, to go along with those on my arms...

Bruises too, mirroring the ones I no doubt left on his ass cheeks.

Maybe even some bites thrown in there. He's such a mouthy little thing after all.

He'd have destroyed me, if I let him.

Desecrated every inch of my body, leaving nowhere untouched. Making sure the whole fucking world knows he was *here*. And he wasn't going anywhere.

Possessive little shit.

My mouth curves as I acknowledge my hypocrisy. *Not enough to get me to regret it though...*

"How much does he remember?" Quentin asks after it's clear I'm not about to fess up anything. Drawing me back to the present.

"Hard to say." I lean back and cross my arm, tilting my head, and meeting my dad's gaze. "But something tells me he's not as stupid or crazy as he pretends to be."

To my surprise, Aston was absent from school today. I didn't really know what to make of it, and I'll admit it made me a little uneasy.

Sure, I was dead fucking serious yesterday, when I told him to stay away. And I know I scared him—I saw the terror, the realization gleaming in his round, wet eyes; how he trembled and gasped...heard his whimpered pleas...

I just didn't think it would be that easy. Getting rid of him...

I shift in my seat, ignoring the restless urge making me want to go find him. Make sure he's still here. *Someone would know if he wasn't coming back, right? The Jennings kid, perhaps.*

"You think it's all an act."

I shrug at Quentin's statement. "It's...something. I just don't know what." I glance away, working my jaw, hating that I have no fucking solid answers when it comes to this—when it comes to Aston.

"He's hard to read," I admit reluctantly after a moment. "Just when I think I can write him off as a non-threat, he goes and does something that contradicts everything. Throwing me back to square one." I shake my head. "If this is all a game to him, and he's not actually as crazy as he wants people to believe... Why? What is his motive? Is he just doing this to fuck with me, or—"

"Or he has something else up his sleeve."

Teeth clenched, I nod, hating this.

Hating how distracted I've become from the real threat here. Not Aston himself. But his memories. *Memories I could've triggered yesterday...*

Is that why he wasn't at school?

Did he have a mental breakdown and get sent back to Ashwood?

A long, quiet moment passes.

"You need to be careful," Quentin says quietly.

I snap a glare across the table. "I am."

His lips thin into a hard line, telling me he's clearly not buying it.

I tip my head in a show of concession. "I'm trying, okay? He's just... he's fucking infuriating. It's like he knows exactly what buttons to push." I clench my fist, drawing a shooting pain up my arm to where he cut me.

Quentin's eyes fall shut. "Vale—"

I exhale sharply. "I know."

"You were supposed to stay away from him. Not—"

"Poke the beast, I remember."

But he poked first...

How the fuck was I supposed to let what he did to Seth go unpunished? How the fuck was I supposed to act like what he did was in any way, shape, or form acceptable?

That's what we're blaming for yesterday now? The voice in my head scoffs. That's why you got him naked in the first place? Why you all but fucked him...twice, now?

Gritting my teeth, I look away. "He caught me off guard. Being here... back in my life. Confronting me... I really didn't think he remembered me. Weeks went by, and *nothing*."

“He was feeling you out,” Quentin says softly. “Waiting for you to let your guard down.”

I nod, having already come to the same conclusion.

I walked right into his trap, and ever the passive, woe-is-me victim, Aston managed to orchestrate a domino effect that ended with me being the bad guy. *Yet again.* Well, that’s if what I did yesterday sent him back over the edge, that is.

“I’m going to call Bryce. We’ll handle this,” Quentin says sternly, pushing his chair back.

I snap my head up, eyes going wide as they follow him across the room, toward the hallway.

“Wait.”

He pauses.

My brows knit. “What are you going to do?” I ask more curious than anything. I don’t point out that I might’ve already handled it.

Quentin looks over his shoulder. “I’m going to do what I should have the second I learned who would be attending school with you. Even if I have to lie.”

I frown. “You’re going to get him expelled.” It doesn’t escape me that even I considered it, on multiple occasions. But it’s one thing for me to get him shipped the fuck out of here, and another for Quentin to handle it.

“He can go to Crowley High,” he says. “He’ll still be living here, for however long that lasts, but there will at least be far less chances for you two to run into each other if he’s attending school across the river.”

He goes to leave—probably to go call Locke from his study—when I stop him again.

“Don’t,” I say before I can think better of it.

Quentin stands under the archway with his back to me. To the foyer he says, “Why not?”

I’m not done playing with him.

It might be too late.

This is my fault as much his.

Not what he did back then, but more recently. I’m not so far up my own ass to not acknowledge that I could’ve walked away at any point.

Swallowing back all those reasons, I instead say carefully, “It’ll make him suspicious. More paranoid than he already is.” I pause meaningfully. “You said it yourself—don’t poke the beast.”

A long moment passes where Quentin remains quiet and motionless.

I can practically hear the wheels spinning in his head. Feel the words that sit on his tongue.

He knows.

He's always known.

What I'm capable of...what lurks inside me like a landmine, just waiting for someone to stumble into it.

How much Aston meant to me back then, and the impact his actions had on me...

He's always fucking known.

And he's always known to never speak of it.

Quentin clears his throat and slowly turns on his heel. He crosses his arms over his crisp, white button-down and says casually, "You worry it might crack open his memories."

I stare at him, and my mouth twitches. "I thought we already established he remembers."

"You know what I mean."

Sucking in my cheeks, I watch him for a beat.

Then, reaching forward, I grab my glass of water and bring it to my lips, not taking my eyes off his as I casually take a sip. Wordlessly pleading the fifth.

He pushes his lips out, nodding, looking at some distant spot over my head. "This isn't good, Vale. If he remembers—"

"I know," I quickly and succinctly cut him off, lowering the glass to the table. "But I'm not too worried about that," I lie.

He huffs a short humorless laugh. "And why not?"

Grabbing my knife and fork, I go about sawing off some more juicy meat. "Because if there's one thing about Aston Saint James I *can* be certain of, it's this."

I bring the chunk of steak to my mouth, pause, and look over it to find my dad watching me warily.

"He doesn't need me to dig his grave. He's perfectly capable of doing that all on his own."

If anything, yesterday, I just showed him where to start digging.

ASTON'S MISSING from school the rest of the week, and try as I might to feel relieved, I can't.

Relieved not because I think he's gone for good...

No, I already know he'll be back. He's been *sick*, apparently. *More like sick in the fucking head.*

But relief because I finally found a weakness. That for as mentally shattered as he already is—allegedly—there's still something in him to break.

I should be *ecstatic*...and I am. I've got him right where I wanted, held like a fragile little bird in the palm of hand.

All it would take is a good, firm squeeze...

And, yet, it's not relief I feel.

No, it's something much more complicated...dangerous.

Something that ensures this will end in bloodshed.

Excitement.

CHAPTER 24

ASTON

IT PROBABLY COMES as no surprise, to anyone, in the history of *ever*...that Vale's avoiding me again. Not even a missing pair of sweatpants was enough to draw out Mr. Don't Touch My Fucking Shit Again. Which says *a lot*.

What might come as a shock this time, though, is that I've been avoiding him right back.

Then how do you know he's really avoiding you, Aston?

Great question. Thanks so much for asking.

Well, for one, I might've not been *actively* seeking him out, now that I've returned to school...but I do have eyes. As does he. And seeing as mine like to sometimes wander without my permission, I know that it's been days since they've touched.

Nine days to be exact.

Not since he was crouched over me in the locker room with his arm pulled back, knife raised and primed to slash my face, eyes so black, so cold, so *soulless*...I found myself cowering on instinct.

I mean, have you *seen* that man's guns? Forget the knife. Dude could kill me with his bare hands and not even break a sweat.

And for another...

Well, I maybe, sort of, kind of...texted him.

I know I know I know! What was I *possibly* thinking?

But hear me out—

According to Eden, who heard it from some guy named Peter, who heard it from some girl named Marsha, who heard it from her cousin's cousin's boyfriend's sister's babysitter, who heard it from—

Okay, *fine!*

Eden heard it directly. I just thought it'd be more fun and less lame if you thought my mysterious absence was the talk of the school. Alas, it was not.

But what my absence *did* do, was spark a rather interesting interaction between my new brother slash *bestie*...and some rando who took a sudden interest in my whereabouts.

I mean, really, Vale? Do you take me for a fool?

Eden thought I was jumping to conclusions. *"You don't know that!"*

"Why else would someone who I've never talked to, someone whose name I couldn't even begin to try and put a face to, randomly come up to you demanding where I am?"

"I don't know!"

"EXACTLY! Because he hired someone to do his dirty work!"

"That's CRAZY!"

"I KNOW! ...WHY ARE WE SHOUTING?"

"I DON'T KNOW, YOU STARTED IT!"

Sure, after what happened last Monday, how Vale and I left things, how *he* left *me*... it is admittedly pretty far-fetched to think he changed his mind. Or even felt bad for...whatever that was. Something his asking about me would imply...

This is Vale we're talking about after all. Even as kids, he wasn't the worry-wart type, unless it somehow benefited him. My memories might be spotty at best, and downright *missing* at worst...but I do recall that.

If u were so worried about me, u couldve just hunted me down urself, little mouse.

He didn't text me back—hence how I know for sure he's avoiding me. Shocker, I know. And according to Eden, seeing as he was looking over my shoulder when I finally caved and made use of that number I swept from Seth's phone, Vale's got something called his "read receipts" off, so whether or not he even opened it is a mystery.

I can't decide if I would've preferred *knowing* he read it and chose to ignore it, than just assuming that's what he did.

Now, it's Wednesday, my third day back.

Peace out pits of despair. Hello, purgatory.

Try as I might to shake off the funk last week's incident put me in, I'm still feeling the lingering effects. Sure, I finally got out of bed...finally left the house. Put on real clothes and brushed my hair and stopped listening to Air Supply's "All Out of Love" on repeat—

Something we all have Eden to thank for, now that we've finally settled our beef like *men*. And by that, I mean Eden let me braid his hair while I sobbed and unloaded everything on him.

Okay, so not everything.

Just the key parts.

Starting with how Vale and I met...

"‘IT WAS A QUEER, SULTRY SUMMER—’"

"Weren't you, like, six?"

"Seven. Keep up. Anyway—"

"And isn't that the opening line of *The Bell Jar*?"

"I know. Fitting, right?"

His face bunches. "Since when do you read anything but *Cosmo*?"

I give him a blank stare. "Do you want to know how Vale and I met, or not?"

He rolls his eyes. "I never ask—"

"Anyway..." I drag out pointedly. "So, it was a queer, sultry summer. No, wait, it was spring. Definitely spring." I tilt my head. "Can spring be queer and sultry too, or is that only reserved for summer?"

"Aston," he growls. Yes, *growls*. It's fucking adorable. And I tell him as much as I squeeze the ever-loving cuteness out of him.

When I finally release him, I open my mouth, ready to dump all the lore on him when something stops me.

My mind just goes...blank.

Words...what are words?

I know how Vale and I met... I do.

There's a kitchen.

There's a boy.

There's the scent of old cigarettes.

And I'm—

Angry.

I'm angry. Why am I so angry?

No...that's not right.

Why am I so...so...sad...

“Aston, come say hi to your new brother Vale.”

I don’t want a new brother. I want—

“Aston?”

Something jostles my shoulder, and I blink slowly to find Eden watching me warily, his head tilted to the side.

Wait, no, my head’s the one tilted to the side.

Snapping my mouth shut, I straighten and allow myself a few more rapid blinks.

“You don’t have to—”

“On second thought,” I say, my voice faint, my lips hardly moving, *“can we just fast-forward to when I moved here?”*

Eden searches my gaze with a frown, but rather than question it, he just nods and waits for me to collect my thoughts.

I blow out a breath and begin.

“It was a queer, sultry September—”

“Oh my god,” he groans, flopping back on the bed.

My bed...because hanging out in his room would require leaving mine, which is not something I plan on doing anytime soon.

“Cough. Cough. I’m sick,” I’d told Tillie when she found me buried under my blankets Tuesday morning with no intention of getting up and ready for school. It didn’t take much convincing, seeing as I’d skipped dinner the night before.

I vaguely recall her disappearing and returning with two tiny white pills and a glass of water. I didn’t even ask what they were—I never do. Were they cold medicine? Sedatives? Poison? Who fucking knows? What would be the point in worrying about it?

So, I just swallowed them dry, threw myself back under the covers, and let the gentle fingers combing through my hair lull me to sleep.

Okay, so I probably just hallucinated that last part. Let’s be so fucking for real.

Who *did* end up petting my hair eventually, however...or, rather, who I woke to perched on the edge of my bed two days later, tugging on my knotted strands relentlessly until, finally, I burst out of my blanket cage with a roared, *“WHAT?”*...

Was Eden.

Arms stuffed with snacks, a hair brush, and a collection of DVDs—

Yes, DVDs. Because the digital age has *ruined* everything. So for the sake of the *vibes*, for all that I fucking missed out on as a child, either suspend your disbelief or take it up with Jesus.

—one of which I recognized instantly by its pink, lime green, and teal stripes... He told me to get my ass up, get showered, because we had *plans*.

Those plans being a movie marathon in bed, watching all my faves. And, eventually, even some of his, when our day together extended not only into a sleepover, but a whole extended weekend spent playing hooky and hanging out together in my room, before I finally broke down in his arms.

“*La la la*. I can’t hear you,” Eden says now over my detailed, and admittedly graphic retelling of Monday’s locker room tryst.

I sniff. “Oh, don’t be such a *prude*, Edie-poo.”

He scoffs, lowering his hands from where he’d been plugging his ears. “Please don’t call me that.”

“The poo part? Or the Edie?”

“Both.” He scrunches his nose. “Edie makes it sound like you’re calling me erectile dysfunction.”

Surrounded by a sea of pillows and rumpled blankets, Eden and I sit cross-legged facing one another as I continue unloading everything on him. Everything that transpired between Vale and me since moving here, that is.

Like me, he’s wearing a kimono. Something I only had to *slightly* bully him into. Whereas I opted out of clothes underneath—save for underwear, of course; I do have some dignity—he wears a black oversized Iron Maiden t-shirt, gray thermal sleep-pants that cinch at the bottom, and bulky white socks under his.

The lime green floral print interwoven with purple thread makes his hazel eyes pop even more than they normally do, drawing out the threads of green. As does the silver sparkly gel eyeshadow he let me smudge around our eyes. Surprisingly, without much of a fight. But I suppose at that point, after having let me brush and braid his hair, he was all out of steam.

“What?” he says later, long after I finished catching him up on what happened between Vale and I, making me realize I’m staring again. Only this time, he actually calls attention to it. His cheeks are pink, but his narrowed gaze remains locked stubbornly on mine.

I bite my lip and shrug. “Nothing. Just...you’re, like, really pretty.”

He curls his lip at me. “Are you quoting *Mean Girls* again?”

I round my eyes. “What? No. No. I mean it. But...” I lower my chin, voice deepening with my sincerity, “You do think you’re pretty too, don’t you?”

He hangs his head, cheeks darkening. He mutters something under his breath.

“What was that?” I’m pretty sure I can guess—call it a hunch—but I want to be certain.

He huffs, and lifts his gaze to mine, eyes glimmering with some unreadable emotion. “I said boys aren’t supposed to be pretty.”

I roll my eyes. “Says who?”

He spreads his arms, the wide kimono sleeves billowing. “Society?”

I stick out my tongue, pretending to gag. “Society says a lot of stupid things that aren’t true.”

His lips purse like he wants to say something but is struggling to get it out. Whipping his head to the side, he blinks rapidly at something out my bedroom window, suddenly looking miles and miles away.

I could push him to tell me, to talk about what I *know* he’s been struggling with. Maybe normally I would, but these days I’m not feeling so...normal.

So, instead, I reach out. Curl my fingers under his chin, and nudge his head even more to the side, tipping it slightly. He sucks in a breath, his cheeks deepening in color. From this new angle, his lashes look longer than ever, fanning his high cheekbones.

His dark hair, having been loosely, messily braided, hangs toward his shoulders, the ends just barely brushing. Baby hairs curl all around his temples. The shirt he wears—black and baggy—droops low, exposing the delicate column of his neck. The faint swell of his Adam’s apple.

“What are you doing?” he murmurs, lips hardly moving.

“Looking.”

“For what?”

I hum. “Not sure.”

Frowning, he removes his head from my hand, and leans back slightly, eyeing me curiously. And with something else I can’t quite pinpoint. Hope, maybe?

“Why are you being nice to me suddenly?” I ask, surprising us both. Sure, Monday, he threw out the offer...but to actually act on it? Hell, to go

above and beyond in making an effort to cheer me up and get me out of my head?

He wants something.

My chest twinges at the thought.

And yes, I'm well aware how hypocritical of me that would be to complain if that is the case.

Eden's jaw tightens with his audible swallow, shoulders dropping. In his lap, he wrings his hands. Shrugging, gaze downcast, he says, "I guess I just got used to you harassing me all the time. And..."

"And what?" I rush out impatiently, feeling my heart speed up.

A moment passes, then, "You looked really sad when I picked you up Monday." His face reddens impossibly more. He still won't look at me. Instead, he focuses on some loose thread in his pants that he twists and twists and twists around. "It doesn't...suit you."

"Sadness?"

"Yeah."

Oh.

He finally lifts his gaze, our eyes locking once more.

"Can I tell you a secret?" I say, my voice raspier than usual.

He nods, eyes flitting around my face.

"You look sad all the time."

He frowns.

"It doesn't suit you either." A small smile quirks my lips, probably the most genuine one I've given in a very, very long time.

My body seems to buzz with this knowledge—this awareness I can't escape—and I can feel my hands growing clammy. My throat swelling. And still, I don't let it send me running. Send me hiding. For once, I let someone see what no one else gets to.

Something I can't even bring myself to draw out when I look in the mirror.

Perhaps it's because Eden's so...so *good*, while I'm anything but.

He's pure and sweet and innocent in a way I never got to be. And that makes him...

Safe.

Until now, I've only ever felt that with Vale. And to some degree Tillie, and that took years.

But there's something about Eden...something that has my insides twisting up with this...strange, yet familiar yearning. A devastation I can't quite put a pin on but am all too aware is there. Inside me, this...this *hole* in my chest that has existed for as long as I can remember.

"I always wanted a brother," I hear myself whisper from a great terrible distance.

Eden's eyes go big and round, his lips parting. Something flashes in his gaze, something I can't bring myself to inspect close enough to try and figure out.

So, before he can drum up a response, before this moment can get anymore *heavy*, I whip around, grab the laptop, and click Play on the next movie queued up.

It's not until much, much later, when we're reclined against a mountain of pillows, watching *Jennifer's Body* on the laptop propped between us, that Eden whispers back out of absolutely nowhere, with no preamble whatsoever, "I didn't want...a brother. But now that you're here..."

THE BELL RINGS, yanking me from the memory.

Fifth period.

Lunch.

Just like the last two days, I can't bring myself to enter the cafeteria. Sure, I've caught sight of Vale since returning to school, but only from a distance. And each time, I found myself spinning around and booking it in the opposite direction before I could even really process *why*.

There's just this...this prickle at the back of mind I can't ignore, urging me to be patient. Play it cool. Make him miss me a bit before executing my next move.

At least, that's the excuse I'm going with until this weirdness passes, and I'm back to my normal self. Because when I get like this—when my brain gets noisy, and I start doubting myself—things can quickly turn sour.

Very, very sour.

More sour than the stench I carried last week, when I didn't get out of bed for three days.

If I was still at Ashwood, it'd be no biggy. They have procedures in place for this sort of thing. Losing my marbles at the slightest inconvenience is expected.

But out here, in the wild, wild west that is civilized society, it's more critical now than ever that I practice some self-restraint. Keep my guard up. And not succumb to whims of fancy.

My meds might mellow me out ninety-nine percent of the time, warding off the thoughts that would have me spiraling face-first into a padded cell. But there are some things nothing can touch.

What those things are...I have no idea.

That's the conundrum of it all—it's the not knowing that keeps me sane.

That much I *do* know.

If I look too closely, I'm as good as cooked.

So, for now, I wait.

It's torturous, sure but my freedom—not to mention my carefully planned future with Vale where we live happily ever after—quite literally depends on it.

As the hallways empty out, I find myself wandering toward the library as planned, only to change my mind at the last second when I come upon the stairs.

Don't do it...

Don't do it...

I do it. Why? Beats me. Maybe I'm not as helpless against tempting fate as I thought.

I jog up two flights, cut a sharp right, and—

"Vale," I breathe.

The bathroom door swings shut behind me. Frozen, I stare wide-eyed at the stony profile of the figure standing over the sink.

I wish I could say I've been avoiding this bathroom just as much as I've been avoiding Vale elsewhere, but the truth is... I've spent many a time here since returning to school, listening to music, angrily scribbling in my diary, and *maybe*, just maybe hoping against all logic and rationale that Vale would show. Despite knowing how unlikely it would be for him to ever step foot in this bathroom again.

Not unless he *wanted* to risk running into me...because he's been just as lost without me as I am without him.

Vale hangs his head as his fingers whiten around the sink's edge. He looks a little...stressed.

Chewing my lip, I flit a glance over my shoulder, debating what to do. I know what the smart thing to do would be, the thing I've been doing since

Monday anytime I nearly ran into him...

But if the last few months proved anything, it's that when it comes to Vale, I'm a tad bit stupid.

Stupid in lo-ove, more like...not that it makes any difference.

Let's be real—it was only a matter of time before I got fed up with this limbo we've been in. With this *not knowing*...

Yeah, yeah, not knowing is good for me. Well boo-fucking-hoo. Two things can be true at once—I read that somewhere once. Or heard it. Maybe from a therapist?

Abruptly pushing away from the counter, he marches this way. No, toward the exit. I try to get my feet to move, but it's no use. I'm as helpless to flee as a butterfly trapped in a spiderweb.

With his head still down, face downcast, it's impossible to even guess where his mind's at. If I didn't know any better, I'd think I finally mastered the art of invisibility with how unfazed he seems by my presence.

As Vale draws near, I hold stock-still, bracing for him to slip past me without a word.

Does any part of you miss me? I ache to ask.

Does any part of you crave me like I crave you?

Were you worried?

Are you sorry?

Do you regret it?

My fingers clench into fists at my sides, my eyes falling shut. I'm practically vibrating with the restraint it takes not to reach for him. Save for my thudding heart and Vale's measured approaching footsteps, it's so quiet it's uncomfortable. The tension—the anticipation as he draws near—so thick, I feel like I can't catch my breath.

Just as he goes to brush past me—*brush* being considerably generous, given how much of a berth he's able to give me to slip past—and I inhale, opening my mouth to say something, the tell-tale click of the PA System pierces our little bubble of silence. Followed by a series of low toned beeps.

Vale lets out a string of curses, and I whip around to face his back, about to ask what's wrong, when a robotic voice fills the room, reciting an automated message.

“Attention, all faculty and students. This is not a drill. Please follow lockdown procedures. Lock all doors, turn off lights, and remain quiet and out of sight. Stay in your location until further notice.”

My eyes widen as the message is repeated, followed by another long droning beep.

Vale expels a harsh breath. Then, for the first time in nine days, he graces me with his voice.

“What the fuck did you do now?”

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CHAPTER 25

ASTON

*The haters will say that what happened today was
contrived.*

I, however, say #blessed.

HIS QUESTION RINGS out into the silence, echoing across the cavernous room as I process it.

Just to be certain, I tap my chest with the tip of my fingers and ask, “Who, me?”

He looks over his shoulder, searing me with a glare. “No,” he says drolly, “I’m talking to the other lunatic in here who has this annoying habit of doing stupid, illegal shit to trap me in a room with him.”

Yikes... Someone’s feeling sassy today.

Guess he wasn’t hoping to run into me after all... Frowning at the thought, I look down at my feet.

With a harsh exhalation of air, he slams his hand against the wall—no, the light switch—killing the fluorescents. Then, he reaches for the door, only to falter with a short derisive huff. “Figures.”

“What’s wrong?” I whisper.

“Lock doesn’t work on this door.”

“Oh.” A beat passes. I blink stupidly at the floor. “That’s not good, is it?”

Footsteps draw near, coming to a halt in my line of sight, inches away from where my own Oxfords point. He says nothing for a long moment, clearly waiting for something. His attention tugging on my gaze like magnets, until I have no choice but to peer up at him.

If he’s concerned about the fact there’s no way to keep whoever is responsible for the lockdown out of here, he doesn’t show it. In fact, his face—his eyes... they reveal nothing.

Literally.

I can’t even say they’re carefully devoid of any emotion, because to claim it’s done carefully implies it’s done with willful intent.

Something tells me that’s not what this is.

Something that has a whole lot to do with that weird prickle in the back of my mind, the one that’s been there since last Monday, urging me to run.

This time, though, there’s no accompanying knife sailing toward my head.

No heightened emotions.

And it makes me brave.

More like stupid...

Straightening to my full height, I tilt my head curiously, eyes scouring his like they’re searching for jewels in a barren cave. Something sparkly that breaks up the blackness. But the deeper I look, the more that darkness seems to stretch—vast, endless, and utterly empty.

A tantalizing chill skips merrily down my spine as a smile twitches along my lips.

The fear is still there, yes, teasing at my awareness—at my pitiful sense of self-preservation. But I find that it doesn’t hold a candle to the relief I feel at finally being the center of his attention once more after days of being neglected, abandoned like a piece of yesterday’s trash.

He stares at me for a long beat, before abruptly turning away without a word. He crosses the room and takes a seat on the radiator, the very same one I usually chill on. Like that day he barged in here while I was helping myself to a little mid-afternoon snackie.

Hands planted on either side of him, he stares down at his dangling legs. Unlike when I sit there, though, his feet scrape the floor—a soft scuffing sound that fills what would be silence otherwise.

Nudging the tip of my tongue between my teeth, I make clicking sounds as I slink my way over to join him.

His head shoots up, a glare halting me in my tracks. There might as well be a neon sign flashing over his head that says, *Not another fucking step.*

“Right...” I whisper soundlessly, creeping backward, hands raised in a show of surrender.

I don’t stop until my back hits the wall. Sliding down to my haunches, I hug my knees, staring at the silhouette now haloed in light, thanks to the glare of daylight behind him.

Moments pass without either of us speaking. I keep waiting for the door to blast open—my imagination getting away from me, now that I no longer have Vale’s close proximity distracting me from what’s going on outside this bathroom.

I’ve yet to hear a scream or a gunshot or an explosion.

It’s just...quiet.

Unsettlingly so.

“So...” I say, dragging the word out. “How are you?”

Nothing.

O-kay, I mouth. I clear my throat, about to mention the sweatpants I stole, when I think better of it. It’s not as if I have any plans to return them, so why draw attention to it?

Instead I ask, “Did you get my text?”

Again, no response.

“I know you put that kid up to it. Were you worried I wasn’t coming back?”

Seconds pass, and just when I’m about to say to hell with this lockdown and take my chances, Vale speaks. “More like hoping for confirmation that you weren’t, so that I could stop looking over my shoulder every second of the day and get on with my life.”

I barely have a chance to gloat—*take that, Eden!* I *knew* Vale was behind it—when what he said fully registers.

It stings, sure—if what he’s saying is even to be believed, that is—but ever the eternal optimist, that’s not what I focus on.

“Well, shucks, Vale. I had no idea how much my presence weighed on you. And here I was thinking all my effort wooing you was for naught.”

“Oh, is that what we’re calling it?” He scoffs lightly. “And it’s kind of hard to ignore someone who’s lurking around every corner, stalking my

every move, and doing stupid shit like drugging my boyfriend to use as bait to lure me out.”

“*Ex*,” I grit out. “He’s your *ex*-boyfriend. Something you forgot to mention last week.”

He grunts. “You thought we were still together, and yet that still didn’t stop you. So, really what difference would it have made if I told you?”

None. But I don’t say that.

Silence pervades once more, tense and heavy, made more so by the fact that there’s been no indication as to what’s going on beyond these four walls.

And the more time that passes, the more acutely aware I become of the fact that for all intents and purposes I’m stuck here. In this too-small room that didn’t feel so small earlier, or any of the other times I’ve been here before.

If anything, the knowledge that we can’t lock the door sets me even more on edge. At least if I could lock myself in here, like we were instructed to do over the loudspeaker, I’d feel a little more in control.

The irony of it all doesn’t escape me.

A forced proximity situation like this is what wet dreams are made of after all—something I’m sure I’ll be grateful for later. Right now though? Right now, I can’t help but acknowledge just how easily this would-be fantasy could fracture into a nightmare. Not because of Vale, but because of whatever threat Parent Trapped us.

I grip my ankle, plopping down on my ass, exhaling in relief when I feel the hard line of my knife tucked safely in my sock.

A knife won’t do you any good if there’s a gun.

I squeeze my eyes shut, count each breath, knowing eventually the seconds will run out and the world will resume spinning and I’ll no longer be confined to this room. This wall. This...

Well, shit on a stick, is it possible to feel claustrophobic from within your own body? Yes? Great. Then I can’t be held responsible for what I blurt loudly into the room.

“I’m sorry!” The words leave me in a crackled rush, my eyes flying wide open, mouth opening as if I could somehow suck the words back.

Something plummets in my stomach, bringing a wave of nausea, when I find the windowsill empty.

“Vale?” I mutter numbly, eyes darting around so fast, everything’s a blur.

Oh, no. He was never even here, was he? Oh, fuck. Fuckfuckfu—

A throat clears, much closer than it should be, and I whip my head to the side, eyes skating up the long legs of the figure leaned against the wall, standing between the door and my crouched form.

Oh.

When did he move?

A shaky breath leaves me.

“Why are you sorry?”

I blink rapidly. *What?* Then I remember.

“For...for ruining things,” I say, the words stuttering out before I even realize what it is I’m saying.

He shifts his weight around. He starts to say something but hesitates. “What are you talking about?” There’s something about the way he asks this—almost a...wariness. But it’s hardened, like he’s bracing himself for something, rather than nervous.

“L-last time. In the locker room. I...I don’t know what exactly made you snap—” *Liar.* I flinch, wincing as a sharp pain in my head momentarily blinds me.

Fabric rustles. Heat washes over my shoulder.

Giving myself a little shake, I inhale sharply. “I’m just I’m sorry,” I say in a single, nonsensical rush. “I can be...pushy sometimes.”

He makes a sound between a grunt and a snort, and now I’m the one snapping my head back to look at him. “Did you just laugh?”

“No,” he says, his voice as flat as his expression.

Hm, maybe I just imagined it.

Just like I must’ve imagined him moving even closer to me.

“Why are you standing there?” I finally ask, frowning. My gaze drifts past him to the door, and a fluttery feeling has my stomach swooping, and not with dread this time.

My mouth opens and closes a couple times, but something holds me back from asking what I really want to know—if he moved for *me*. To protect me. To reassure me.

Did he sense me tweaking out?

Surely not...

I glance at his face, not even surprised to find him looking pointedly away from me. Other than a slight tensing to his jaw and neck tendons, he looks as relaxed as ever with his arms crossed and his head tipped back, gaze aimed at the ceiling.

Vale mutters a curse, shifting around restlessly. He keeps cutting looks to our only exit—well, aside from the windows, that is. But it's a three-story drop, so it might as well not even count. I can practically hear the thoughts swirling around his head. The way he's probably debating just bolting, like I was before—the lockdown and whatever caused it be damned.

While a small part of me shrinks at the pitiful feelings that knowledge evokes...

The rest of me is, well, a gooey sentimental mess.

Because a small part of *him* clearly can't leave me. And that's a win if there ever was one.

"What's wrong with you?" he demands out of nowhere.

"Um." *Crap, did I zone out again?*

Was I thinking out loud again?

He makes a vague gesture at the empty, gray-hued bathroom. "You've got me trapped in a room with you—"

"I didn't do this."

Going on as if I didn't speak, he says, "—and you've barely said more than a few sentences. Or tried anything. I just...I don't fucking get you."

My brows slant inward. "Get...what about me?"

He drops a glare on me, looking pissed and accusatory. As if I should already know what it is he's talking about.

Spoiler alert: I really don't.

His gaze bores into me for another long moment before he tears it away with a shake of his head. "Forget it. I don't know what the fuck I'm saying." He runs a hand through his hair, and mutters something under his breath I can't make out, before abruptly pushing away from the wall and heading for the door.

Heading toward danger.

I'm scrambling after him before I even realize what I'm doing, grabbing his arm like it's not the appendage of someone who's more likely to snap my neck than ever press his lips to it. "Wait, don't!"

He turns his head toward me.

“Don’t leave me,” I croak, my eyes beseeching his hardened ones. I gulp, and give a quick shake of my head, tugging on his arm to drag him deeper into the bathroom. At first, he doesn’t budge.

But then he does. He lets me draw him away from the door.

Breathing heavily, I don’t stop walking us until my back hits something. The wooden siding of a stall. Nor do I take my hot desperate eyes off his.

My head throbs in time with my thundering pulse, but I barely notice. The ache, the blackness edging along my vision, the way sweat has made a home across my neck...

It’s all just background static to my senses as I home in on the warm point of contact where my hands curl around his strong, corded forearm.

For a moment, we stand frozen facing on another.

Not breaking his gaze, I feel my lips move, repeated words uttering quietly from my throat. “Don’t leave me.”

Memories poke at my awareness—warped echoes of conversation. Of pleas.

His tongue pokes out to wet his lips when his gaze drops to my parted lips. My mouth dries, and my fingers flex over his arm. He slants his head, and either I’m straight-up hallucinating, or the distance between us really is shrinking, narrowing into the pinpoint that is his descending mouth.

My grip on him spasms as I’m awash in his familiar woodsy scent. I suck in a sharp breath—

And just like that, the moment’s over.

Ripped from me, not unlike his arm when he tears himself away. He moves almost inhumanly fast across the room to where he faces me with his back to the sinks.

With a scowl, he shakes his head, glaring at me once more like what just happened is *my* fault.

I scowl back at him. *Rude*. He’s the one who tried to leave during a lockdown.

Why that pisses me off so much, I don’t know. All I know is this anger feels so much better than what I was feeling a moment ago—hell, what I’ve been feeling since the moment he left me sitting on the locker room floor, trembling and practically hyperventilating—so I latch onto it. And it feels *good*.

“Fuck you, Vale,” I spit. I’m not even sure it’s even *him* I’m angry with. But I don’t want to look too closely as to what’s really pissing me off.

His eyes flare with surprise, before narrowing into slits. “Excuse me?”

Danger radiates from him, but it does nothing to temper the blood boiling hotly in my veins. I stalk toward him, relishing the way his eyes narrow, flashing with violence. The way his posture turns to stone. “You heard me. I said *fuck*. *You*.”

A hand shoots out, gripping me by the throat, hauling me up against him.

Nose to nose, he snarls, “Now, now, sugar. That wasn’t very nice.”

He’s so close, I can taste the faint traces of toothpaste and coffee on his breath. A weird combination—one that should be gross—and yet I crane forward with a feral snap of my teeth, desperate with some primal driven need to get a taste for myself.

His eyes dart all around my face, taking in my bared teeth and hot, tingling cheeks and my blazing glare aimed right at him. Some emotion gathers like a storm in his eyes, darkening his expression, making him look all the more imposing.

And down-right sexy.

Beautiful even.

Dangerously so.

His hold on my throat is tight, but not so tight I can’t breathe. Or speak. And when I finally manage to form words, it’s the last thing I ever expected to say that tumbles free.

“I would’ve stayed away.”

His brows flare.

“You told me to stay away, and I *did*,” I squeeze out thickly. “I would have backed off like you asked.”

“Bullshit,” he says simply, his gaze leveled with mine.

Ignoring that, I go on, “But you...*you* just had to go getting my hopes up by asking around about m—” His hold on me tightens, sealing my airway, and stealing my voice. In doing so, I’m lifted practically off my feet, and my fingers come to his forearms, gripping and scrambling for dear life.

“I told you,” he says slowly in a voice devoid of all emotion. “I wanted confirm—”

“*Bull. Shit*,” I seethe inaudibly, throwing back his own words. *I know a liar when I see one.*

His eyes widen a fraction, like maybe he read my mind.

I jut my chin at him over his curled fingers, silently daring him to try and fool me. He'll fail. He has to know he'll fail.

He eyes me up and down, before nodding as if confirming something for himself. "Hm."

That's it. That's all he has to say for himself apparently.

Mirth fractures his gaze into diamonds as a smug smile plays on his lips. Even amused, he looks positively evil. Like a predator eyeing up his prey...that prey being *me*.

Even still...it does nothing to hide what's behind it.

A whole lot of nothing.

He suddenly releases my neck with a little shove. I stumble to find my balance, bringing my fingers to my throat. A glance at the mirror behind him shows some redness, but I doubt there will be bruises.

My gaze springs back to his. Before I can even process all that just happened, and muster up some kind of response, the PA System crackles to life, and an automated voice announces it's all-clear. Lockdown over.

My gut sinks, and I don't miss the way Vale's mouth tightens ever the slightest. Like he too might be disappointed our...moment or whatever has come to an end.

But it's probably just wishful thinking.

Regardless, he doesn't immediately tear himself away. For a long moment we stand frozen in place, simply staring into each other's eyes. Searching for something so far beyond my grasp, I can't even find it in me to make an effort to reach for it. Whatever it is.

Heck, I can't even find it in me to crack a flirty joke.

It's as if every weapon in my arsenal to wall myself off has abandoned me, leaving this...sad, needy, pathetic person I barely even recognize. It makes me twitchy. Has me clawing my nails into my palms. Has me itching for my knife.

Vale's brow knits, and his gaze drops to my lips, a troubled look creasing his features. It's there and gone so fast, but I know what I saw.

And it hits me suddenly.

Was he going to kiss me before?

I can still feel the phantom pressure of his fingers around my throat—their scalding heat. Their deadly promise.

I can still taste his breath on my tongue.

Kissing Vale...it's not really something I ever let myself hope for, not until last week when I really thought for a moment we might.

And fuck me, it hurts.

Aches something fierce.

Because now that my anger's faded, and I'm stripped raw of anything else to protect me from the truth, I can't help but feel like I...like I *lost* something.

Again.

Vale opens his mouth like he's about to say something, only he must think better of it, because he just shakes his head, and mumbles something under his breath I can't make out.

And then, far too soon for my liking, he's turning away, taking what feels like the air filling this room with him.

It's not until he reaches the door, his hand gripping the handle, that he pauses.

I wait for him to look back. Say something.

But he does neither.

His back rises with his deep breath, and then he's gone, the door swinging to a quiet close behind him.

And I'm left alone with nothing but his lingering woodsy scent and the image of his face tattooed across my mind to hold on to.

Nothing but my still-pounding pulse and the ghost of his touch to prove he was even here at all.

CHAPTER 26

ASTON

HALFWAY THROUGH MY NEXT CLASS, I'm called down to Headmaster Locke's office, somewhere I haven't been since my first morning when he introduced himself as my new warden.

Since then, if I've seen him, it was only in passing in the halls, and he'd barely spare me a glance.

Not today though, today his attention is laser-focused on me.

And not just his...

I glance at Tillie and Walter seated against the wall to my right. Tillie's face is red and pinched with anger. Walt just looks tired and...disappointed?

Their presence isn't the most worrying thing though.

No, that's reserved for the officers standing before me, gesturing at the baggies of what I presume is marijuana laid out on Headmaster Locke's desk.

"We got an anonymous tip that a student was dealing," one of the officers tells me. He has a thick black mustache and a dimpled chin, setting him apart from the blondie babyface cop next to him.

I search between all the eyes watching me, confused as fuck as to why I've been brought into this. "Okay..."

"Do you know where we found this?"

I shrug and shake my head, earning an exasperated huff from someone in the room.

"I told you, Officer, this has to be a misunder—" Tillie's protest is cut off.

"As per protocol, we did a search. The dogs led us to—"

I blink. Dogs?

And then it hits me—

“Wait, is this why we were in lockdown earlier?” I interrupt in a rush. After it was lifted, the bell rang not long after, indicating the end of lunch. I wasn’t really paying attention to anything anyone was saying after what happened, too caught up in my own head. Seeing as we were cleared to return to class, I figured it was just some kind of false alarm.

Or a drill, despite what the automated message said. It would defeat the purpose after all, if they told us it wasn’t real.

“Like I said, we got an anonymous tip,” the officer with the mustache says.

“Well, it wasn’t me,” I say without thinking. “I wouldn’t even know who to call, to be honest.” I don’t miss the odd look the two police officers exchange. But I keep going. “Not to mention, if someone was dealing pot, I wouldn’t really consider it any of my business, you know? I’m new here, and everyone knows no one like narcs.”

“Aston,” Tillie says in a familiar exasperated tone.

I round my eyes, looking around at the various confused and annoyed faces. “What?”

“You’re not here because we think you’re the one who called,” Headmaster Locke says with forced patience, mouth pressed into a hard line.

“Oh.”

“As I started to say...the dogs led us to *your* locker, Mister Saint James” the officer with the stache goes on to say. “We found all of this in your backpack.”

I follow the finger he points to the stash of drugs on the desk and lick my dry lips. “I see.”

“You see?”

I nod. “I’ve been set up.”

Again with the odd, awkward exchange of looks. “Mister Saint James... lying won’t get you anywhere. You understand this is grounds for expulsion, don’t you?”

At that, I snap my gaze to Headmaster Locke who observes me with a grave look upon his face. *Oh shit.* I swing my attention to a visibly frustrated Tillie who looks about to explode.

I bore my pleading gaze into her. “I didn’t do this.”

Her features soften a bit. “Aston, I know that.”

“I swear. I wouldn’t even know the first thing about dealing, much less how to smoke, or who even to *buy* it off—oh. Wait. You believe me.” I nod. “That’s...that’s good.”

I wring my sweaty palms together.

Surprisingly, it’s Walter who speaks up to say, “I’d have to agree with my wife here. Aston couldn’t have done this. Bryce, you and I both know how closely monitored he is. Nothing about this makes any sense.”

“I agree,” another voice pipes up, and I whirl around in my seat.

“Dr. B? Where the heck did you come from?”

He rolls his eyes from where he lounges against the back wall. “I’ve been here the whole time.”

Huh.

“So what you’re trying to tell us, is someone—another student presumably—broke into his locker, planted drugs, and then called it in...” the officer with the mustache who’s been taking lead on this says skeptically.

Headmaster Locke sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. Shrugging, he says, “Some students, I will admit, aren’t too happy to have him here.”

I make a face at that. I mean, he’s *not* wrong... But way to make me sound like a total loser to everyone.

“Aren’t there cameras or something?” Tillie asks.

It’s Walter who answers. “Not where his locker is, no.”

“We have to keep in mind that Aston’s been institutionalized for the last five and a half years. He’s...well, pretty naive when it comes to these sorts of things,” Dr. B says reasonably.

And by reasonably, I mean *rudely*!

I throw a hand up. “Well, jeez, just air out all my dirty laundry, why don’t you?”

“Is that your professional opinion?” the blond officer asks as if I never spoke.

“Yes, it is. I’ve been meeting with him weekly since he started school here, as per the conditions of his continued enrollment. And from everything I’ve observed and learned so far, I don’t think Aston has the... skill set to do this.”

Wow. What a fucking douche. I’ll show him. I’ll be the best damn drug dealer that ever—

“...nor any motive for dealing drugs to his peers,” he continues while I stew away. “If anything, he does all that he can to avoid most of them. He has no interest in gaining their approval, so unless there’s some financial—”

“He has an allowance,” Tillie cuts in. “Whatever he wants or needs, within reason, he gets.”

“Or steals it,” Walter mutters. Only it’s said right when no one else is talking, so everyone hears.

Tillie swats him. “From the *basement*, he means. He takes things from the basement.” She meets my gaze, and smiles. “Which you are more than welcome to.” She sends a scathing look to her husband who has the decency to at least grimace.

Choosing to ignore that, I look straight at the officers. “It’s true. I’m spoiled rotten.”

The one with the mustache grunts in acknowledgement, before turning to his partner and pulling him aside so that they can talk quietly amongst themselves.

I glance at Tillie who gives me a nod, a smile of encouragement, and a thumbs up.

Next to her, Walter’s got his gaze on the clock somewhere above my head. I imagine the final bell for the day will be ringing soon. We’ve been here for what feels like forever.

Finally, the cops turn their attention to Headmaster Locke. “It’s your call,” Officer Blondie says.

Headmaster Locke and I silently face off for a long, long moment. I give him my best puppy eyes, hoping he sees my innocence for what it is—genuine. As much as I benefitted from this little misunderstanding, what with getting trapped in a bathroom with Vale of all things...

This time?

I can’t take credit for it.

If anything, I owe whoever did this a fruit basket.

Not for getting me expelled! If it’s decided I’m guilty after all, and they kick me out, then no...no, they will certainly *not* be getting any fruit basket from me.

“Fine.”

I perk up.

Headmaster Locke waves me away. “You’re free to go.”

And a fruit basket it is...

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CHAPTER 27

VALE

“YO, DID YOU HEAR?”

Shrugging off my button-down, I glance over at Fletch approaching the bench. “Hear what?”

He balls up his blazer, chucking it into his gear locker. “They found drugs in that little psycho’s locker.”

I frown, my movements slowing. It didn’t take long for word to spread that the lockdown was for a drug search. There aren’t any lockers on the third floor, which is why we didn’t hear anything. Usually, though, they’d check out the bathrooms too. But I didn’t give it much thought because I had other things on my mind.

Like how, once again, in spite of everything, I found myself humoring Aston. Not only that, but getting close to him...far closer than I knew better than to get. When instead, I could’ve just fucking walked out, or at the very least ignored him. He was...contrite enough—something I wasn’t expecting, and for reasons I’m...well still kind of at a loss on. And he said it himself—he would’ve backed off.

Yeah, fucking right.

Still, I can’t help but feel like maybe there was some truth to it. Who’s to say he would’ve returned at all if he didn’t figure out it was me who stupidly sent some underclassman to go get answers from Eden? If he didn’t suspect I wasn’t yet done with him...

Not that *that’s* why I risked it.

Fuck, who am I kidding? That’s exactly why I did it.

I knew he’d put two and two together, or at least I...hoped. If only to prove I haven’t been entertaining the whims of a total imbecile.

Aston might come off like a total airhead at times, especially these days, but he's smart. Cunning. At least the Aston I remembered was...the kid who could charm and manipulate others without any effort. The Aston who'd do what it takes to not just survive, but—

No. Don't think about that.

Nothing's changed just because—

"Vale? You good, man?"

I give myself a mental shake. *Right, Fletch was saying something.* "Yeah. Yeah, just fighting off a migraine. What were you saying?"

Fletch eyes me with a look I can't place. "Your little psycho."

I roll my eyes. "He's not *my* anything."

"Right..." he says, dragging the word out. "Well, word is they found drugs in his locker."

My attention snaps to him at that. "What?"

He yanks his shoulder pads on over his muscle tee, and it occurs to me I'm still half-dressed. Coach will be on our asses to get outside any second.

Plopping down on the bench, Fletch bends over to put on his cleats. We're not alone, but the others are chatting amongst themselves, and aren't paying us any attention. "Yeah, bro. They yanked him from class. Never came back."

Fuck.

"They found drugs in his locker?" I say in disbelief. Sure, I figured the lockdown was somehow Aston's doing, despite his insistence he had nothing to do with it. But to set himself up like that...

"Yeah, like a pound of weed, man." Fletch chuckles, shaking his head. "Poor dude."

My brow furrows. Sensing my confusion, he arches me a brow. "What, you actually think it was his?" He scoffs, and finishes tying his laces, before jumping to a stand.

"He was set up," I murmur.

The lockdown wasn't his doing...

I glance down at my hands, not really seeing anything. "Did he get expelled?"

"No clue. Like I said, he never came back. S'far as I know, no one's seen him since."

Fuck.

“But I wouldn’t be surprised. I mean, how can you prove it wasn’t him?” He shrugs, and scrubs his hand over his buzzed hair. “It’s no secret he creeps a lot of people out, teachers included. They’re probably happy for a excuse to get rid of him.”

Jaw stiff, I nod, unable to conjure up a response to that.

With a slap on the shoulder, he says, “See ya out there.”

On autopilot, I finish getting ready for practice. All the while wondering if I lured Aston back, only to lose him anyway.

PRACTICE DOES little to quell the festering rage inside me. If anything, it just stokes the fury, heightening my aggression and my need to *do something*.

I hate feeling fucking helpless, but that’s how I feel.

All through running laps, then drills, in preparation for Friday’s big game—Homecoming and Senior Night wrapped all into one—my mind wanders to all things Aston.

Where is he? What’s going to happen? Is he coming back? What the fuck was I thinking earlier?

And the most concerning, depending on who you’d ask...

Who the fuck is responsible for this?

It’s fucking aggravating. Why do I even care?

A whistle blares. “Riviera! What the fuck are you doing, trying to break his spine?”

Growling under my breath, I jump to a stand and spit out my mouth guard. Behind me, some second-string is groaning and rolling on the green. Casey finds my gaze as I pass, eyes widening in silent question. *You good, man?*

No. No, I’m not good. I’m so far from good, I should be nine circles deep into hell.

I don’t know where my ability to shut out the noise and focus fucked off to, but hell if I can find it in me to worry about that right now.

Coach jogs over to me by the bench. “You gonna tell me what the hell’s up with you today?” he says, keeping his voice low enough so the others lingering don’t hear.

Mashing my molars, I shake my head and reach down for my water bottle.

All while I chug it down, I can feel Coach staring at me. Studying me. I fucking hate it, but I'm also not so far past gone that I don't know my behavior's got to be raising some concerns. This isn't me. Coach knows this isn't me. And he also knows, thanks to Quentin, when to essentially....pull the plug.

I know it's coming before he even says the words.

"Take off early today. Get some air. Some sleep."

My eyes close, and I suppress the urge to protest. To bite out something cruel. To punch him in the fucking face.

"Vale..."

Jaw working, I nod.

He sighs a breath of relief. And then, to add some brevity, he jokes, "Unlike these idiots, I'm not worried about your game. You deserve a break."

I don't fucking want a break.

I just want—

He slaps my back. "Get outta here."

Despite knowing it's for the best—at this rate, I'm more likely to snap someone's neck than be of any use to the team—I still find myself storming off the field, fists balled at my sides. I can feel the eyes boring into me, and it takes everything in me not to whirl around, and find all the faces they belong to, line them up, and drive my fist into each one.

Fucking Aston.

This. This is exactly why I've tried to keep my distance. Why, from the start, I knew it was imperative I steer clear of him. He's a fucking parasite. An infection I can't sweat out no matter how hard I try.

Maybe I just need to try harder...

After the quickest shower known to man, I throw on a pair of gym shorts and a hoodie, and grab my shit, only pausing to check my phone. I tell myself it's not because I'm expecting a text, but when I find nothing but a single unread message from Quentin telling me he's going to be late getting home tonight, and to fend for myself for dinner, I find myself gripping the phone so tight, the case creaks, threatening to snap off.

Locking it, I shove it into the side pocket of my bag, exchanging it for my keys.

Outside in the parking lot, I'm so preoccupied with trying to get myself under control, I don't immediately register the steps pounding after me, or my name being called. Not until I've reached my Audi and a hand grips my shoulder.

Assuming it's either Casey or Fletch checking in on me, I growl low in my throat, and spin around, readying to deck them. They *know* better. "Do you have a fucking death wi—" My voice cuts off mid-sentence when I come face to face not with either of my annoying best friends, but the shocked and worried brown gaze of my ex-boyfriend.

The breath leaves me in a whoosh, and I drop my arms.

"Seriously?" I mutter.

Shaking my head, I look around the empty lot, wondering where the fuck he came from. Why is he even out here? Debate club or chess—whatever he fucking had today, because it's always something—wouldn't be letting out for another half hour or so. I know this, because I'd typically drive Seth home after practice. "Look," I tell him stiffly, "it's not really a good time right now."

"Are you okay?" Seth asks, ignoring me. "I saw you storm out. You looked...upset."

Biting back a snappy retort, I refocus on his face and tell him, "I'm fine."

His lips purse, telling me he clearly doesn't believe me.

Jacking a thumb behind me, I say, "But I really gotta—"

"Can we talk?"

I rest my hand on the roof of the car, fingers flexing into the smooth, chilly surface. "I just said—"

"My house is on the way," he says quickly, as if I somehow forgot in the week and a half since we broke up. "We can talk as you drive. I just—" He cuts himself off and looks down at the pavement, wetting his lips. "Please, Vale. I just want to...better understand what happened. We got cut off by the bell before we could talk it out, and I just...I've had a lot of time to think."

I roll my eyes. *What more is there to fucking say?*

I'm about to say as much when movement across the lot catches my attention, prompting me to straighten.

Aston emerges from the side doors of the school—the faculty entrance—with not just Jennings but his wife and kid too. He's got one arm

clutching his bag to his chest, and with the other, he waves around a Blow Pop as he talks animatedly. The woman—Jennings' wife. Matilda, I think I recall Quentin calling her—shakes her head and reaches over to ruffle his hair before joining her husband's side.

Why the sight of such a simple affectionate gesture has me seeing red, I have no fucking clue.

As if sensing the surge of rage tainting the air, Aston snaps to attention, his gaze swinging wildly around before coming to land on mine.

He lowers the Blow Pop, his mouth parting as his steps slow. Whether or not his new little family notices and hangs back, I couldn't say. I only have eyes for him.

"Vale?"

I tell myself to look away. To get in my car and get the fuck out of here. But something glues me to the spot.

What happened? I think stupidly, as if he could read my mind.

And yet, I still find myself scanning his face—what little I can make out from all the way over here—observing his demeanor...looking for some sign, anything, to indicate what happened with Headmaster Locke and the cops.

He's leaving with his family, and not cuffed in a patrol car, so that's a good sign. He's eighteen after all. It's not just expulsion from school he'd be facing.

The kid—Eden—having realized Aston stopped, backtracks, and grabs his arm to drag him along. Again, there's this...flare of senseless rage I feel squeezing my chest and darkening the edges of my vision.

Eden, having noticed the direction of Aston's stare, frowns when he spots me. No, *scowls* like he's pissed.

Did Aston tell him about me? About us...about last week, what I did...

"Vale." This time, my name is bitten out with a snap of fingers and impatient stomp.

Right. Seth...

Fuck me.

Remembering why he came over here, I'm not really thinking things through when I snap, "Fine. Just...get in the car."

Glancing at Seth, I don't miss the way he perks up, a satisfied smirk twisting his lips as he rounds the car. Nor do I miss the smug look he shoots

across the hood and past me, over to where Aston was standing just a moment ago.

Obviously, he wasn't oblivious to Aston's arrival...to our little stand-off. If anything, now Seth just looks all the more determined to chat and... prove something.

Aston allows Eden to drag him away, but his face is twisted over his shoulder. I can't read his expression from here, but it doesn't feel quite so much as the vicious glare I've come to associate with him anytime Seth is involved...

But something darker.

Something that looks a lot like betrayal.

Maybe even...hurt.

It's for the best, a voice tells me, and despite how furious I still am—for no other reason than I just...don't know what the fuck to do, and I feel more out of control than I have in years...

I also realize maybe this *is* for the best. One last nail in the coffin that was this brief interlude of insanity, where I let desire rule over logic and risked burning down everything I'd built. Especially if he was kicked out, and this is the last we see each other...

Though I'm not so sure that's the case given how happy he seemed before he spotted me, all but skipping out of the school.

Either way...letting him believe this is something it's not might go a long way in getting him to move on. And this time...*this time*...

The passenger door slams shut, yanking me from my thoughts with a teeth-grinding grimace. *Petty asshole*. I spare the station wagon Aston disappeared into one last look before turning away and climbing behind the wheel.

I forgo turning on the radio, leaving Seth and I with just the low hum of the engine to fill the tense silence as we race down the backroads of Crowley toward both our houses.

Seth allows a minute and thirty-eight seconds—I counted—before shattering the quiet.

“What is it about him?”

I'm not sure what I expected him to say, but I can't say I'm surprised. I can only imagine how that scene looked from his perspective. Whatever initially had him stalking me across the lot, and begging me to talk, seems to have taken a backseat.

Though I can't imagine it wouldn't have circled back to Aston eventually. Given the circumstances leading up to our break-up.

"I don't know what you're talking about," I say calmly.

"Yes. You do." He pauses. "You can lie and pretend all you want that what happened the night of the party didn't—"

"I told you..." I say warningly.

"No. I know what I saw. What I remem—"

Slapping the steering wheel, I cut Seth a harsh look. "What you *remember*? Do you remember throwing up all over the bathroom floor? Do you remember me pulling over on the way home so you could throw up some more on the side of the road?"

He opens his mouth. Closes it.

Only one of those scenarios is true but fuck if I'm about to backtrack and admit everything now. No, far from it.

He was right earlier, when he said we barely got a chance to talk before the bell rang the morning I ended things. I figured that would be the end of it. He seemed convinced at the time...but I clearly underestimated just how tightly Seth would cling to that night...and how necessary it is now, maybe more than ever, that I set him straight.

"He texted you from my phone," he says slowly, in a dangerous tone I'm not accustomed to hearing from him.

Frowning, I mentally replay that night. How after pulling into his driveway, I didn't immediately get out and gather his unconscious body from the backseat—even I knew how crucial it was to maintain the air of giving a damn. Especially after what happened, and what I knew I'd be doing the next time I saw Seth.

I made sure, before leaving him, to check his phone for any evidence Aston tampered with it. But he was smart enough to not only delete the texts he sent, but the photo he took of them.

"That's impossible," I finally say.

Seth lifts his chin. "I spoke with the phone company. Got them to recover anything that might've been deleted. Aston might think he's so smart,"—Seth's lip curls cruelly—"but let's face it. He's not only developmentally stunted, he's a complete and total retar—"

I crank the wheel, whipping the car off to the side, and slam on the brake. Faster than Seth can process what's happened, I've shifted into Park,

have the seatbelt off, and am lunging across the seats to fist his collar and slam him against the window.

Eyes wide, he drops his jaw to gape at me.

“I’d be very, very fucking careful how you finish that sentence.”

His throat dips with a swallow.

I tilt my head. “You have no idea who you’re fucking with.”

“Aston doesn’t scare me,” he sneers, trying and failing to hide the quiver in his voice that tells me otherwise.

My mouth twitches, and I stroke my thumb over his hammering pulse, adding just enough pressure to be uncomfortable and make his eyes flutter wide. “Who said I was talking about him?”

He swallows tightly.

“You don’t want to do this,” I tell him. “Trust me. Just drop it and walk away before someone gets hurt.”

His lips purse, jaw quivering.

“What we had...it was good.” And the thing is, it’s not even a lie. Being in a relationship with Seth was easy. Until it wasn’t. It was good...until I got bored.

“Then why couldn’t you stick it out for the year?” he utters quietly.

Ah. And there it is again.

See, here’s the thing about Seth. After what happened, he was...upset, understandably so, despite my insistences that nothing in fact happened at the party.

But it wasn’t so much that he wanted the truth, so that he could come out of this as the good guy... No, he just wanted something to hold over me. Something to blackmail me with.

Because he spent the rest of that weekend convincing himself that *I’d* be the one begging for another chance. Not because I have real feelings for him...but because he genuinely believed I needed him more than he needed me.

Correction: this relationship.

“*Why else would you stick with me for this long, if not because it benefited you somehow?*” That’s what he said the morning I told him I didn’t *want* to work things out. It didn’t matter to me that he could “forgive me” if I was just honest with him.

He had no fucking clue just how much I not only don’t give a damn about him, or keeping up pretenses—pretenses he’d started to catch on to,

unbeknownst to me—but just how far I’m willing to go—to lie—to protect myself.

And like that fateful night years ago, once again, Aston’s at the center of it all.

“Because, Seth,” I finally respond, “I told you. I don’t *want* to.”

He scowls. “Did you even care for me at all?”

“Sure. But that doesn’t mean I owe you anything.”

Something flickers in his gaze, sharpening it.

“Just like you don’t owe me anything.” I arch a brow. “But that isn’t to say, actions don’t have consequences.”

“Are you threatening me?”

I paste on a smile. “No. I’m just stating facts. If you know what’s good for you, for the sake of your future at Columbia, you’ll drop it. Walk away. Forget all about us.”

His eyes widen in understanding, jaw growing hard. “This is his fault,” he whispers. “We’d still be together if not for—”

“No. That’s where you’re wrong, Seth.” Releasing him, I smooth his collar, and fix his hair, before returning to my seat.

It’s not until after I’m buckled and pulling back onto the road leading to his development that I finish simply, “I used him as much as I used you.”

TRANSCRIPT OF RECORDED INTERVIEW

DL: DID THEY EVER FIND OUT WHO PLANTED THE DRUGS IN HIS LOCKER?

VR: NO. BUT LOOKING BACK NOW... WELL, IT DOESN'T REALLY MATTER, DOES IT? THERE'S NO WAY TO PROVE IT.

[PAUSE]

[PAPER SHUFFLES]

DW: JUST TO CLARIFY FOR THE RECORD, THE LOCKDOWN HAPPENED JUST BEFORE HOMECOMING WEEKEND? A WEEK BEFORE HALLOWEEN.

VR: THAT IS CORRECT.

[PAUSE]

DL: IN THE DAYS LEADING UP TO THE HARVEST CARNIVAL, DID YOU AND MISTER SAINT JAMES HAVE ANY MORE RUN-INS?

VR: NO. NOT UNTIL HALLOWEEN NIGHT.

DL: WHY'S THAT?

VR: BECAUSE WE WEREN'T FRIENDS? AND AT THE TIME, I HAD NO INTENTION OF CHANGING THAT, MUCH LESS PURSUING A RELATIONSHIP WITH HIM.

DW: SO YOU WERE AVOIDING HIM AGAIN?

VR: LIKE I SAID, I NEVER HAD ANY INTENTION OF PURSUING ANYTHING WITH HIM. FRIENDSHIP OR OTHERWISE. CAN YOU BLAME ME AFTER EVERYTHING I'VE TOLD YOU SO FAR?

DW: SO, WHAT CHANGED?

[PAUSE]

VR: IT'S DIFFICULT FOR ME TO...PINPOINT THE MOMENT I GAVE UP.

DL: GAVE UP?

VR: FIGHTING THE INEVITABLE. HE GOT UNDER MY SKIN, WHAT CAN I SAY?

CHAPTER 28

ASTON

Dear Diary,

Homecoming was this weekend.

A big football game, where they bestowed people with crowns and celebrated senior football players and cheerleaders, followed by a dance in the school gymnasium.

I did go to the game. Watched Vale win some award and take pictures with his daddy... pretended it didn't hurt.

They won. Of course they did. Vale's a force to be reckoned with on the field. I don't even have to understand the rules to know that.

As for the dance...

I tried to convince Eden to go, but he wasn't having it. Admittedly, I didn't try very hard to sway him. Once I

learned Vale wasn't going— Take that, Sethica!!!

—it just seemed pointless.

And it's not like Homecoming is even a big deal. Apparently all the cool kids go to the Furnaces to party instead. According to Eden, Grady Prep's semi-formal in February is the big one. Even bigger than prom for some reason.

At the rate things are going though...I doubt I'll be attending that one either. Not unless I can bully Eden into it, and I'm not even sure that I'd want to. Double dates? Totes. But a pity date with my lil bro...

Well, I'd like to keep what cool points I've amassed.

Which, admittedly, isn't as much as I'd like.

On the bright side...at least Seth and Vale are still broken up.

Watching them drive off together last week? Yeah, that wasn't fun. If not for Eden, I probably would've went off the rails completely. Instead I plotted and journaled and plotted some more...

And what do you know? Come Monday, Seth was nowhere to be found, and Vale's single status was still very much in place. I can only assume he killed poor Sethy, chopped him into tiny pieces, and scattered them in the woods.

*At least...that's what I would've done had I got my hands
on him after seeing him ride off with my man.*

*Yes, he's still my man. We've just hit a sort of...rough
patch. It'll smooth over in no time, especially now that
Seth is gone.*

XOXO

-A

*JK, Seth is very much still alive.
He was back in school today. Ugh.
Lucky for him, I've had time to cool off.
It also helps that he looked like utter shit today.
Like...dude's clearly going through it.
If anything, I might actually have room in me to pity him.
Just a smidge.*

BOREDOM AND UNCERTAINTY—TWO states of mind I try desperately to avoid
at all costs.

Especially when they're determined to spit-roast me.

After days pass without any progress in the *Make Vale Mine*
operation...

Progress some stupid, naive part of me decided, somewhere along the
way, must be imminent—a forgone conclusion—after what happened last
week.

...I can feel my hopes sinking.

And with it, my mood and my ability to regulate it.

As if you do a spectacular job of that on a good day...

Gasping at my brain's rude commentary—commentary I never asked for, thank you very much—I all but stomp the rest of the way to my locker. The final bell for the day just rung, drawing an anticlimactic close on yet another uneventful day at Grady Prep.

Okay, so it wasn't totally uneventful.

I did have a little run-in with the Alicias today, which turned out to be the highlight of my week.

There I was in the cafeteria—yes, I've resumed eating with the masses—minding my own business as I watched Vale from afar, picking away at cold chicken...something, when a three-headed shadow fell over me.

“WHAT'S YOUR DAMAGE, ALICIA?” I bite out, apropos of *nothing*...nothing other than having my space violated by her catty, snooty, *gold-shitting* presence.

Getting fucked gently by a chainsaw would be more pleasant.

Startled by my very loud, unprovoked—see also: *proactive*—outburst, the Queen Bitch herself actually has the gall to look self-conscious when the room plummets to silence, and all eyes shift our way.

Puh-lease.

I know a fake-out when I see one.

True to form, not even a second later, a familiar sneer has settled back in over her face. Arms crossed, she taps her heel. “My *damage*, freak, is that you can't sit here. This is *our* table.” She flicks her perfectly manicured fingers. “Now, scram.”

My brow furrows, and I twist to look across the room to where the football players gather around their usual table. The table the *cheerleaders*, as in Alicia and her little posse, typically cling to as well.

Vale's there, right where he was moments ago, when I was so *rudely* interrupted...reclined against the wall, a bottle of water rolling between his hands, looking as regal and untouchable as ever.

Unlike before, though, when he doing all that he could to ignore my blatant staring, he's now blatantly watching me in return. Expression devoid of any decipherable emotion. Anything that could tell me what he's thinking.

There's the *tap-tap-tap* of a heel. “Are you deaf on top of being crazy? I told you to get.”

“No, you didn’t,” I mutter.

The tapping stops. “What was that?”

Puffing out my cheeks, I twist in my seat to face her, ensuring she sees my eye roll. “I said, *no*...you didn’t. As in you didn’t say *get*, you said *scram*.”

Her face reddens. I can practically see the steam pouring out from her ears.

“And since when do you know how to eat lunch without a heaping side of validation?”

She blinks stupidly.

I tap my chin thoughtfully. “Or does getting your ego stroked by dumb jocks have too many calories now too?” I nod. “Makes sense, given how inflated your head already is. I’d cut back too if I were you.” I smile sweetly. “Gotta make sure you can still fit that thing in whoever’s ass you’re up this week. Mr. Porter’s, right? Or have we already moved on from that one?”

Alicia #2 and #3 gasp as once, because I’m pretty sure they share a brain.

And because it’s so quiet in the cafeteria, and because I’m talking so loud...loud enough to ensure a certain far-away someone can hear and marvel at my wit...I don’t miss the low whistle from a nearby table, and the mumbled, “Fucking brutal, *brah*,” earning them a wink and a kissy face from yours truly.

I’m dimly aware of chair legs screeching across the floor, and a collective gasp that warns of fast-approaching trouble. But just as I register Alicia lunging for me, claws out and ready to strike, a pale muscular arm catches her around the middle.

Wide, mirthful blue eyes belonging to none other than Casey Shrute find mine. “You’ve got balls, Myers. I’ll give you that.” Wrestling a thrashing Alicia into some semblance of submission, he all but drags her out of the cafeteria. His girlfriend Thea chasing after them.

“You’ll pay for that!” Alicia screeches my way. The other Alicias are quick to clamor after them, ever the dutiful minions.

I snap my teeth at their retreating figures.

Good riddance.

A glance over my shoulder to where Casey seemingly teleported has my chest sinking when I find Vale is no longer there.

In an unexplainable panic, I shove up to a stand, hands clutching the edge of the table. I sweep my wide, unblinking gaze over the room.

It's not until I catch sight of his retreating back disappearing through the exit closest to his table, that I expel the breath I'd been holding.

The disappointment that crashes over me is as instantaneous as it is *crushing*...

AND SOMETHING I haven't been able to shake since.

But he looked at me.

He looked at me.

That's better than nothing.

Hence, that being the highlight of my week.

It's like we've gone backward. Back to how things were before that fateful party.

No, scratch that. Back to how things were before that first day in the bathroom, when I finally got him alone.

And with Halloween only a couple days away, and the Harvest Carnival I keep hearing so much about...

Well, I'm finding it increasingly hard not to be a total Grinch.

Halloween's one of my favorite holidays after all, and something I was *really* looking forward to this year, now that I finally get to experience it the way it's meant to be experienced...

But given the dismal state of my love life, can you really blame me for not getting into the holiday spirit?

I know I didn't imagine our connection.

It can't have all been for nothing...it just can't.

Opening my locker, I'm so distracted by my wallowing, I don't immediately notice that something's amiss. Not until I've set my books on the shelf, and something white catches my eye as it falls to the floor.

The chatter and clanging of lockers surrounding me fades even more to the background, replaced by a high-pitched whining in my ears as I reach down, watching in slow motion and as if outside my body, as I scoop up the folded piece of paper.

My heart pounds.

My breaths grow shallow.

And with surprisingly shaky fingers, I carefully open it. Chewing my lip as I take in the hastily scrawled words waiting for me.

SATURDAY. CHAMBER OF MIRRORS.

DON'T LET ANYONE SEE YOU.

I blink rapidly, lips fumbling for words as my carriage rises with my deep inhale.

Is this...

I look around, eyes big and wide, searching for some kind of confirmation, when my gaze lands on Mr. Tall, Dark, and Handsome himself strutting across where the hallways intersect.

My mouth dries. *Could it be?*

I mean...it has to be...right?

Just before he disappears around the corner, Vale turns his head, his gaze locking right on mine. Like he was waiting for me. And just like that, all worries from a moment ago—all doubts when it comes to him; all niggling uncertainty—retreat to whatever dark corner in my mind they came from.

And it hits me suddenly—that...*wrongness* I felt. That hesitancy. Those warning bells that have been growing steadily louder, warning me of an impending *episode*, if I didn't get my shit together. That pervading *weirdness*.

I was just getting tired of doing the chasing!

That's it.

It was his turn, damn it.

I needed a *sign*...

And now I've got one.

Heck, not even a sign. An invitation. One that leaves no room for argument.

He wants me. My little mouse wants me.

He doesn't *hate* me.

And Seth? Seth??? Seth fucking who?

(Yeah, I'm still salty over that. I mean, he LEFT IN HIS CAR WITH HIM. Right in fucking front of me.) Pressing the note to my chest, I bury my teeth in my lip to contain my manic grin as I gaze down at the note once more. *Chamber of Mirrors*, I mouth, reading his stilted words once more.

Frowning, I turn to Darwin and ask, "Hey, where's the Chamber of Mirrors?"

He shoves his glasses up, and scowls at me. "What?"

I snap my fingers. "Chamber of Mirrors. My boy...friend wants to meet me there Saturday, but I have no idea what that is."

Darwin blinks in that owlsh way he does. "The mines. The Tunnel of Horror."

I stare at him.

"It'll be a sectioned off corridor full of mirrors," he says slowly, like he's talking to a child. "Like a maze. Can't miss it."

Oh. Right. That makes sense. Duh.

I roll my eyes. "No need to be sassy with me, dude. I'm new here, remember?"

Muttering something under his breath, he slams his locker shut and strolls away.

"See you tomorrow!" I yell after him.

He flips me off.

"I see you've made a friend," a voice says dryly.

I tense, turning slowly. "Stalk much?"

Dr. Benson arches a brow over his glasses. Swinging his briefcase in front of him, he grips the handle with two hands. "Just thought I'd come over and say hi. See how you're doing."

I grin widely. "Never better!"

His eyes narrow slightly, before flitting down to the note dangling from my fingers. I quickly crush it in my fist and shove it behind me, hiding it from sight.

Dr. Benson hum-grunts. Then, "You going to the carnival this weekend?"

I shrug. "Maybe."

You bet my tight ass, I am.

But he doesn't need to know that.

He smiles thinly and dips his head. "Right... I'll see you next week?"

I smile blithely right back. "As if I have a choice, Doc."

He glances behind me, and then continues on his way, briefcase thumping against his thigh.

Once he's out of sight, I lift my free hand to my hair, raking it through the strands.

Un-crumpling the note, I take one last moment to gaze upon Vale's stilted instructions before carefully folding it back into a perfect square and

stuffing it in my front pocket.

After I gather what I need for homework tonight, I slam my locker shut, hit Play on the Walkman clipped to my belt, and lift the headphones around my ears just as “Love School” by the Divinyls kicks on.

The music combined with my racing thoughts drowns out everything else as I strut myself toward the doors. Deciding to forgo watching Vale’s practice in favor of figuring out what I’m going to wear Saturday, I text Eden to let him know I’m on my way.

I’m all but floating my way out of the school, my mind buzzing with excitement as I fantasize about all the things Vale might want to do to me Saturday. Making a mental list of all the things *I* need to do in preparation for our date.

A date! My very first...

Just outside, I pass a row of shrubbery, and something fluttering in the corner of my eye snags my attention. Halting me mid-thought and mid-step.

It’s a tiny one, this butterfly. About the size of my thumbnail. And its metallic blue wings with the white speckled underside give it away immediately, distinguishing it from the Eastern-tailed blue which is only slightly bigger. And seen in this region just about just as often as this species.

The Spring Azure.

Celastrina ladon.

They get their common name for being one of the first to emerge in the spring—a symbol of hope and new beginnings. And what’s especially unique about them is that they’re protected by ants during the larval stage, when they’re just witty bitty caterpillars and easy prey for predators, if not for the creepy-crawly little guys.

In exchange, the ants get the sugary substance the caterpillars excrete, called honeydew.

I always wonder what it tasted like. But seeing as it comes out of their butts...

I’m not that brave.

Lowering the headphones, I let the music play muffled against my neck.

“Hey, little guy,” I whisper, slowly approaching the pretty critter. “Bit late in the season for you to be wanderin’ about.”

It takes a couple tries before I manage to snag it from the air.

“There, there,” I say after I’ve snuffed its life out. “It’s better this way. Trust me. You’ll be treasured forever now, and never have to fear anything again.”

I dig through my pocket for one of my Blow Pop wrappers, when my fingers brush something else instead. Vale’s note.

Now, this is what I call a sign.

Humming under my breath, I bring the butterfly back up to eye level, and say, “Everything’s going to work out, isn’t it?” I give its wing a little stroke. “Hmm, yeah, I think I know exactly how I’m going to honor you.”

Closing it gently in my hand, I turn, hiking up my bag, and rather than continue making my way toward the quad, I head in the opposite direction.

Toward the student lot.

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CHAPTER 29

VALE

LATE THURSDAY NIGHT, I've just finished my homework and migrated to the bed when the music playing from my Bluetooth speakers cuts out with an incoming call to my phone.

A quick glance shows it's coming from a familiar unsaved number, so I hit End, sending it straight to voicemail, before locking the screen and setting it on the charging pad.

Grabbing the football that I'd tossed on top of the bed earlier, I flop back against the pillows shoved up against my headboard just as the Yung'cid song that was playing fades back in.

I toss the football toward my ceiling, catching it mid-yawn. I'm just about to repeat the action, when the music cuts out again. The phone and charger rattling noisily across the wooden surface with another incoming call.

It's the same number.

With a sigh, I scoop it up, hit Answer, and bring the phone up to my ear.

I don't say anything.

I don't have to.

"Do you like scary movies?" The breathing over the phone is heavy and choppy, like he's fighting a cackle.

Rolling my eyes, I hang up and toss the phone on the bed. Grabbing the football once more, I squeeze it between my palms and proceed to throw it up at the ceiling. More harshly each time, counting every catch.

One, two, thre— And there it is.

I blow out a sharp breath and hug the football to my bare chest. Feeling around for the phone, I blindly hit Answer, again not saying anything when

I bring it to my ear.

“Well that was rude, Valeykins,” Aston murmurs. “I asked you a question.”

“What do you want?” I ask flatly.

Through the phone, he makes an obnoxious sound that I *think* is meant to reflect a gameshow buzzer, not unlike the one he made in the locker room. “I asked first.”

“Asked me what?”

“Oh, Vale,” he says softly. He tsks. “Come now, don’t be dense.”

I sigh. “Sure, yeah, whatever.”

“Sooo... which one’s your favorite?”

Head rolling back, I close my eyes. “I don’t have one.”

“Li-ar,” he sings. “Everyone has one. Unless you don’t actually like scary movies. In that case I’d have to call you a psychopath.”

My eyes fly open at that, brows creeping toward my hairline.

“Wanna know what mine is?” he goes on without missing a beat.

“Not really.”

“*The Omen.*”

A grunt escapes me before I can help it.

He gasps. “I made you laugh!”

“That wasn’t a laugh.”

“Do you want to know *why* it’s my favorite?”

“No.”

“I find Damien to be a kindred spirit of sorts.”

“The Antichrist? Why am I not surprised,” I say dryly.

He chuckles, and it’s a raspy, edged thing. I grit my teeth, hating the way my dick fills at the sound of it. It reminds me of the laugh that spilled out in the locker room that day, my blood dribbling from his lip.

Balancing the phone between my ear and shoulder, I reach down inside my shorts to adjust myself.

Only...I don’t let go.

Swallowing back a groan, I throw my head back, glaring at the ceiling as I fist my cock. Giving it a long, languid stroke from base to tip.

“No, silly goose,” he says in a soft, almost childlike voice. “Because he too was abandoned at a church as a baby.”

I turn my head toward the window, staring far-off as my mind starts playing through memories filled with blood and glass.

My hand starts to move slowly up and down my cock. Tingles race across my shoulders and down my arms. I bite my lip. The images mingle with newer, brighter memories. Of empty locker rooms and swollen, cum-stained lips.

“This one time, at Ashwood, a couple guys cornered me in the bathroom.”

I freeze, my insides turning to granite. The hand I was using to lazily stroke myself flexes, clenching so tight, I flinch. The vein in my temple throbbing. But he keeps going, not missing a single beat, blissfully unaware of what his little story time is doing to me.

“We had just watched the first *Omen*—it was only my second time seeing it; the first was with you. Don’t you remember?”

My brows crash heavily over my eyes, my dick forgotten as I sit up.

“You were so scared! But I held your hand and made jokes the whole time, and we ate candy we stole from the gas station down the street...” His voice fades, succumbing to the dull roar filling my head.

That...that didn’t happen.

Stealing candy, yes.

But we never watched this movie together. Ever.

The Baders only had one television—one of those old box types with a wooden frame. There was no cable, just a shotty antenna that provided us with a handful of local channels that played the news and re-runs of procedural dramas. Not much else.

Not to mention we weren’t allowed to watch it often, especially just the two of us. The candy would’ve been confiscated in a heartbeat, unless Rick was drunk...maybe...

“...so glad I got to see it with you first,” he finishes with a laugh, pulling me from the memories threatening to surge forward. There’s an odd, almost hysteric sort of quality to his laugh, like it’s forced, and it has my hackles rising. “And to think, I didn’t even *realize* back then how much Damien and I had in common!”

I shake my head. “Aston,” I rasp before I can stop myself. My voice is so quiet, so faint though, and he’s still talking, so at first I don’t think he picked up on it.

But then he sucks in a sharp breath.

My eyes close. I already know what’s coming.

“You said my name.”

I slide my hand free from my shorts, and sit up, switching the phone to my other ear. “Yeah, and?”

“Nothing. Just... I missed it...” His voice trails off, but I hear what he holds back all the same.

I missed you.

I shift around on the bed, suddenly feeling uncomfortable in a way I’m not accustomed to. For a long moment he doesn’t say anything else.

Hang up. Hang up now.

The phone creaks in my grip.

What the fuck are you doing? that annoying little voice demands.

A throat clears in my ear. “Anyway...what was I saying? Oh, right, those guys who cornered me,” he jabbers on as if nothing transpired. My heart pounds. “So, they got the upper hand.”

Squeezing my eyes shut, I run my fingers through my damp hair, despising the way they tremble.

I don’t want to hear this shit.

“One held me down as the other took clippers to my head and started chopping away. No idea how they got their hands on *that*, seeing as it could easily be used as a weapon, and while sucking off the orderlies goes a long way, most—”

“Aston,” I grit.

“R-right, right, focus. *Anywho*, so yeah, much to their disappointment—and mine—I did *not* in fact bear the mark of the devil on my scalp. So then, of course, they decided to check elsewhere—”

I bite out a string of curses and jump to a stand, storming toward the sliding glass doors to my balcony. Throwing it open, I rush toward the railing, gripping it in my fist. Head hanging.

“*Relaxxxx*, shnookums,” he drawls. “We were interrupted before they could have too much fun with me.”

“That’s not—” I bite out before catching myself.

A raspy chuckle fills my ears, and this time, it has about the effectiveness of an ice bath.

“I’m hanging up now,” I say unnecessarily.

He hums. “Are you?”

“Do yourself a favor and delete my number.” I pull my phone away, about to hit *End*, when his whiny voice bursts out.

“Nononono, wait. Don’t go. Not yet.”

Gritting my teeth so hard my jaw aches, I shove the phone back up against my ear. "What do you want?"

"I'm sorry."

"For what?"

"Killing the mood. I do that sometimes. Let's start over."

Shaking my head, I glare out at the surrounding woods. From up here on the third story, in the distance I can just make out the shadowy columns of the Furnaces sticking out from rows and rows of maize.

Beyond that, the skeletal skyline of downtown Crowley glints under the nearly-full moon.

"So what's *your* favorite scary movie? You still haven't said."

My jaw ticks, and for the millionth time in a span of two weeks, I wonder what the fuck I'm doing. I can end this. Easily. And yet I keep playing into his little games.

Or is he playing into mine...

I twist my neck, cracking it, and say the first movie that comes to mind. "*Scream*."

"How convenient," he drawls.

"And why do you say that?" I say suspiciously, not missing the forced lightness in his tone.

There's a moment of hesitation, then, "Well, for one, I *did* call you up to ask you what your favorite movie is. Planted the little seedlings and all. For the record, though, *Scream* is hardly scary. It's more of a comedy."

I scratch my jaw. "Whatever. And?"

"And what?"

At this point, my eyes are going to get stuck facing the back of my head. "You said for one. Implying you have at least one other reason."

"Oh yeah! Well, aside from the obvious, I don't really have another one."

"And the obvious being..."

He tsks. "Come on, Vale. Don't be dense. Ghostface is *all* the rage these days. And for good reason." He sighs dreamily.

Another unexpected snort escapes me. Fortunately, this time Aston decided to keep his commentary to himself. Instead, he changes the subject. Though I can't exactly say this new topic is any better.

"Speaking of getting carved up..."

I stiffen.

“I never asked—how’s your arm?” He says it so casually, lightly, as if the confrontation that led to me fucking the shit out of his face, followed by nearly *beating in* said face with a knife, is synonymous to going out for ice cream.

“It’s fine,” I say tightly.

“Couldn’t say the same for my throat...”

My teeth click together.

“It hurt to swallow for *days*.”

Jesus.

“Next time, we’ll have to take it a step further. I imagine it will pair quite nicely with the ache you leave my hole with when you finally shove that big cock all the way inside me.” He moans, and I picture him rolling his eyes back, licking his lips, stroking a hand down his chest. “I can’t wait, baby. Who knew you’d be such a tease?”

I mutter a silent curse into the night. “That’s never fucking happening.”

“Mhmm, sure. It’s a good thing I love the chase.”

Screwing my eyes shut, I grip the railing tighter, fighting like hell to ignore the throbbing in my shorts. Even our earlier conversation did very little to thwart my raging hard-on. If anything, the wrath I felt when imagining those fuckers holding him down, touching him, ignited my arousal. The equivalent of a lit match kissing kerosene.

“Vale,” he breathes.

At the rate I’m going, my teeth are going to be ground into stubs before this call even ends.

“Are you hard?”

“No,” I lie.

He snickers, telling me he doesn’t buy it for a second. Of course he doesn’t. He’s the only one who’s never been afraid to push my buttons. Hell, he’ll step all over me if I let him.

“Mine is,” he murmurs into a low moan, and I thrust against the railing. “It’s missed you.”

Fuck.

“Are you touching yourself? I am. My dick is so hard for you, little brother.”

“Don’t fucking call me that,” I spit, grabbing my cock through my shorts.

“Call you what?” he says innocently, panting quietly.

“You know what,” I grit out. “Didn’t you learn your lesson last time?”

He hums contentedly. “Do you wish I did?” If I’m not mistaken I can *hear* a slick sort of fleshy sound coming through the phone.

“Are you on speaker?”

“Maybe...”

Whirling around, I storm back inside my room, sealing the door shut behind me so hard I’m surprised the glass doesn’t shatter. Pacing the length of my room, I grip my hair, tugging on it.

Hang up.

Hang up now.

I’ve held out for days—avoided him, resisted texting him, resisted chasing fate in the third floor bathroom...

“Didn’t you learn your lesson last time?”

“Do you wish I did?”

“Did you like my little gift?” he says abruptly, pulling me from my thoughts.

I freeze. “What?”

He moans again, and it takes everything in me not to punch a hole through the wall. “I left you something. In return for the note.”

“What note?”

But he doesn’t seem to hear me. “In your car. On the dash,” he adds stiltedly, breaths growing faster and choppy. “M-made me think of you.” His voice cuts out with a long, wounded-like whine that has me throbbing in my shorts.

Gripping the edge of my dresser, I give a little thrust at the air before I can help myself. “You fucked with my *car*?” I barely manage to squeeze out. Slamming the phone face-up on my dresser, I jab a finger on the speaker icon.

“Nonono. Just left you something, that’s all,” Aston says with a cry that fills my room. Thankfully, Quentin’s room is on the other side of the house. “V-Vale, *please*. I’m-I’m so *close*.”

“Please what?” I growl, shoving my free hand down my shorts, at the same time I bow my forehead to the dresser.

I circle myself at the base, gripping viciously so as to get myself under control.

“T-tell me what you’re gonna do to me. Next time. I —”

My lip curls. “There won’t be a next time.”

A raspy chuckle fills my ear. “Liar. You *lie*.” He pants heavily, and I can hear just how *wet* he is.

Is he using lube?

Spit?

Or is he weeping so much pre-cum he doesn’t need anything but my voice and his hand?

Eyes squeezed shut, I turn my head, burying my mouth into my fist.

“S’okay. I get it now. It’ll be our little secret.” He moans, then, “Y-you can keep hurting me, you know? I like it.”

Nothing but a growled snarl escapes me.

“Like it when I *ache* for you. I crave it so bad. Vale. *Vale*.”

I don’t even know when I start jerking myself. One second, I’ve got my dick in an iron-clad hold, holding myself at bay, and the next, I’m fucking my fist like I could find Aston’s tight, sweltering hole on the other side.

“Make me forget, Vale. M-ake me, make me, make—”

Chills scatter across my neck, spreading like a wildfire over my shoulders, down my arms...

Aston’s blubbing gibberish in between moaning my name. And with my eyes screwed shut, I can picture it—picture all the ways I can destroy him as my name spills from his lips.

I’ll split him in half. Fuck him so hard he bleeds for me.

Fuck him so hard, I erase all the others who came before me. *Hurt* him before me.

Because he’s mine to break.

“You don’t deserve to feel good,” I hear myself say, my voice so deep it’s barely recognizable.

“I know, baby, I know, I know,” Aston chants into the phone.

“Do you though?” I swipe my thumb over my head, spreading the moisture all around my crown. *Not enough. I need more*. Lifting my hand, I spit loudly into my cupped palm.

Aston must hear it, if the high-pitched keening from his throat is anything to go by. It’s nothing short of what a weak helpless little creature sounds like when it knows it’s about to die.

“If I had my way with you, there’d be nothing left for anyone else.”

“P-please.” I picture him lying on his bed, head thrown back in ecstasy, his lithe body arching as he tugs at that pretty cock of his. It was so hard for me at the party. So flushed and sticky.

Not pretty. Disgusting. There's nothing pretty about him.

But fuck if my denial doesn't just conjure up more tantalizing images of him to prove me wrong.

Those full lips I've tried so hard not to imagine sucking and biting on.

Those long, thick lashes I can picture so viscerally—fluttering as I thrust deeply inside him.

That thick caramel hair that would weave like silk through my fingers and look so good when I strangled in my fists, using it for leverage as I fuck him without restraint.

"You want that, sugar?" I grunt out.

"I want *you*. I only ever wanted you. Wanted to keep you. *Mine*."

My nostrils flare as I feel all the blood rush to my nuts. I growl from deep within my throat. Then, "Well, too fucking bad. I'll never be yours. You'll never have me again."

And with that, I hang the fuck up. Jabbing my finger so hard at the screen, I send my phone flying to the floor.

All it takes is two more tugs of my cock, and I'm spilling into my waiting palm with a grunt and clenched thrust to the air.

My toes go numb from how tightly I curl them into the carpet.

Panting, heart thundering in my ears, I stroke myself with my cum-covered hand, imagining it's Aston's blood.

AFTER A QUICK SCALDING HOT SHOWER, I make my way downstairs and let myself into the attached garage. Flipping on the overhead lights, I approach the passenger side door, throwing it open.

There's probably nothing even here. He's probably just fucking with me. I would have noticed it if there was something here.

Except...

Clearly, I didn't.

"The fuck..." I whisper, squinting as I reach across the dash.

A Blow Pop wrapper. Smoothed out and folded into a square. Tucked in the vent.

I debate just crumpling the thing and disposing of it, but curiosity gets the best of me, as it always seems to do when it comes to him. There's no

way he left a wrapper and nothing else.

A note maybe?

I'm not sure what I was expecting to find—probably some cryptic, creepy message.

What I find instead has me equal parts confused...

And something more foreign: disturbed. Bordering on panicked.

"It made me think of you." That's what he said over the phone.

I fumble to catch what falls out and watch as my finger comes up to trace the tip of a light blue petrified wing.

I snap my head up, looking aimlessly around the garage like he might be there, hiding in the shadows, watching me. Holding onto answers that are probably better left unsaid.

Inevitably, my gaze returns to my cupped hand.

I tilt my head, my throat thickening with some unnamable emotion as awareness prickles along my spine. Awareness I can't quite grasp.

Or rather...

I'm not sure that I want to

Did he kill it, or did he find it? I find myself wondering of all things.

My free hand finds my chest, fingers massaging hard into my sternum. There's a tightness there, not unlike that time I strained a muscle in practice.

What does this mean?

Does he...does he remember?

A butterfly.

He gifted me a butterfly.

A dead butterfly.

CHAPTER 30

VALE

THE PAST

“JUST FOLLOW MY LEAD,” Aston tells me, curling his fingers through the chain link fence.

Brow furrowed, I shield my eyes from the bright August sun as I watch his lanky, too-skinny body shimmy up the fence, fingers white around the thin steel wiring. When he reaches the top, he heaves himself over, landing in a crouch, a cloud of dirt kicking up around his feet and hands.

Twisting his head, he meets my gaze over his shoulder, a familiar wild grin stretched across his flushed face. “Your turn.”

In the distance, past the row of trees behind where Aston pushes to a stand, there’s the distinct howl of a monkey.

“It’s easy. Just don’t overthink it,” he says.

Lips pursed, I slowly approach the fence, giving it a little testing tug, before hauling myself up it. Not only did Aston make this look far easier than it actually is, but I’m quick to learn that my being shorter didn’t help matters.

The rusty wire digs painfully into my palms as I use all my weight to scale the flimsy structure.

“Come on, hurry!” Aston whisper-shouts when I struggle to plant my foot on the top rail. I slip twice, my arms throbbing and trembling as I struggle not to lose my grip.

Eyes set in a hard glare, teeth gritted, I somehow manage to climb the last few inches so that I don't have as far of a distance to swing over. This try, I don't bother using my foot like he did. I just curl my entire body around the top, hugging it like a koala, before rolling myself off.

Aston makes a soft surprised sound, and next thing I know, his body is colliding with mine as he tries—and fails—to catch me.

Or at least, that's what I assume he was trying to achieve. We both go down in a heap, grunted oomphs punching out of both of us.

There's a sharp intake of air that's quick to follow. One that didn't come from me. Then—

“Owww,” Aston moans as I hurriedly scramble off him.

Heart pounding, chest heaving, I mumble, “Why'd you do that?” Rust stains my palms orange, and I grimace as I try to rub it off in the dry grass.

Next to me, Aston heaves himself up into a seated position. “Because you did it wrong,” he says in between shallow pants, “and it looked like you were gonna land on your head.”

His voice is tight—too tight. Gritted, like he's talking through his teeth. It has me glancing over, the mess of my hands momentarily forgotten.

Face drained of all color, eyes screwed shut, features rippling, he hugs his middle. His too-pale forehead shines with sweat that I quickly realize isn't just from exertion.

I blink. “Are you hurt?”

His throat bobs at the same time his jaw tightens, and he gives a little rapid shake of his head.

Narrowing my eyes, I walk over on my knees. “Show me.”

A single eye cracks open, darting up and down me as I come to a stop right next to him. “Why?” he says suspiciously.

I lift a shoulder. “Wanna see.” More monkey howls sound from the other side of the trees.

A long moment passes where he seems to be deciding whether or not to trust me. Finally, he gives a short, jerky nod, and unwinds his arms. But rather than lift his shirt right away, he plants a hand on the ground, and slowly, shakily climbs to a stand.

Joining him, I tilt my head, watching curiously as his features solidify into a stiff, blank sort of mask. It's a look I recognize. One that, up until now, I've only ever seen when he sits down sometimes, but never

accompanied with enough information to give me any clue as to what it could mean.

But staring up into his glossy, faraway eyes now, remembering the way he said *Ow* as his face got all scrunchy and white, I see it for what it is.

Pain.

That mask means he's in pain.

He's just trying to hide it.

I file this new knowledge away, to examine it later when I'm alone.

I'm about to say his name—remind him he's supposed to be showing me where he's hurt—when he seems to snap out of his daze, blinking and swallowing convulsively a couple times, before dropping his chin to stare at the ground.

Wincing, just like he did that time we knocked heads playing with the football he gave me, he lifts his shirt, bunching it up over his chest.

My brows crash together as I take in the dark black, purple, and blue splotch over his side, and the lighter green and yellow shades stamped around it.

My eyes go big and round. "I did that?"

His head snaps up, a confused scowl marring his features. "What? No."

I go to brush my fingers over the bruises—see if they feel like anything, see if they feel warmer than unbruised skin, or cool to the touch—when Aston twists away, out of my reach.

"Don't," he snaps.

My gaze springs to his profile, eyes widening with surprise.

Lips pursed, he gives a short, rapid shake of his head, and lets his shirt fall, hiding the marks once more. Ducking his head, he turns away. "It's nothing. Come on, let's—"

"Did Rick do that?" I say in a small, irritated voice.

If not me, it had to be him.

But when? I can't help but wonder. As far as I know, Aston hasn't done anything bad lately. Nor have I, which means there's nothing Aston could've taken the blame—and the punishment—for.

Aston pauses mid-step but says nothing.

A familiar twisting feeling starts in my gut, slowly spreading upward, making me all hot and tingly in a way that usually leads to me doing something bad.

Like that time Mrs. Roberts, my kindergarten teacher from back when my parents were alive, took my worksheet away before I was done with it. And I decided to leave a handful of thumbtacks—pointy side up—on her chair for her to sit on to teach her a lesson.

Or like when Gran told me to go to bed and turned off the TV before my show was over, and I waited until she was asleep to take the remote to her TV and throw it in her fish tank. Exchanging it for the fish I'd leave in her house shoes for her to find in the morning.

Or like a couple months ago, just before summer break started, when some kids were picking on me during recess.

Before I even had a chance to catch my bearings after one shoved me to the ground, Aston was there, shoving the bullies right back and throwing punches. When the kid who had shoved me, who was much bigger than both of us, managed to get a punch in of his own—right to Aston's eye, causing him to crumple to the ground with a cry that made my blood boil—I grabbed a nearby rock, the biggest I could find, and bashed it over his head.

The fight was quickly broken up after that, an ambulance was called, and Aston and I were rushed to the principal's office.

"Don't say a word," Aston had told me.

That's all the warning I had before he took the fall for what I did. Somehow, none of the teachers witnessed it—not until it was too late, and a kid was laying unconsciously on the ground, bleeding from his head—so no one questioned it. After all, this wasn't the first time Aston got in trouble for fighting.

Not that he ever set out to hurt anyone. He was just defending himself, same as this day.

Cops were brought in. Rick and Louise had to come in for an emergency meeting...

Even CPS was notified.

It was a whole mess.

I really thought Aston was going to be sent away. He almost was. Would've been...

Had Rick not insisted he stay, promising he'd handle it—discipline him accordingly—and ensure this never happened again.

It probably helped that the kid ended up walking away with nothing more than a mild concussion and a handful of stitches. Lucky, they'd called

it.

No, it didn't keep Aston from getting expelled. But it did keep him from getting thrown into jail or juvie or wherever they send child murderers had the kid died.

It also didn't keep Rick from giving him the beating of a lifetime later that night.

I was furious.

If Aston hadn't shoved me in my closet the second we got home that evening, and shoved a chair under the knob to keep me from opening it, I probably would've done something stupid like fess up the truth—that it was me—or found something worse than a rock to quiet the cries, shouts, and crashes I heard coming from down the hall not long after he hid me away.

It likely would've been the second choice, seeing as I didn't want to get in trouble, and my need to hurt whoever was hurting Aston was far stronger than any potential urge to set things straight. Not that I felt one, seeing as I was too pissed off.

Not unlike how I feel now, remembering the patchwork of bruising all over Aston's side and stomach. Knowing it wasn't me falling on him that did that.

"Earth to Valeyyy."

Blinking Aston's furrowed face into focus, I frown when I realize he must've turned around and came back for me, where I still stand frozen in front of the fence. Hands balled tightly at my sides.

"You're doing that thing again," he whispers, rolling his lips together like he's trying to keep from laughing. All signs of pain that were there moments ago are gone, replaced once more by his usual never-serious self.

"What thing?"

"That thing where it looks like the lights have been turned off." He points between my eyes, wiggling his finger. "Knock, knock. Anybody home?"

I make a face at that and swat his hand away.

He just grins big and wild and crazy. "Come on, I wanna see the tiger."

With a sigh, I jog to catch up with him as he turns forward, quickening his steps toward the row of trees. On the other side of them, visible through the gaps, I can make out chain link fencing not unlike what we just climbed over. Only it's a sparkly silver, and cages in the monkeys we'd been hearing, rather than the zoo as a whole.

The zoo we'd snuck into because we have no money.

If I didn't have the memory of his bruises tattooed across my brain—or the image of his glossy, dazed eyes and pinched, pale expression—I'd never know Aston was injured by the way he all but skips over to the barrier meant to keep people from getting too close to the cage, and leans as far as he can across it. Getting as close as possible to where a monkey hangs from a branch, chattering away.

Aston's grin is huge. Even as he talks to the monkey, he never stops smiling. Eyes wide and bright in a way I've so rarely seen. It makes me feel...funny inside. Almost annoyed.

Just beyond him, a man with a little boy sitting on his shoulders points and squeals at the monkeys, and I find my steps slowing as I'm suddenly thrown back to the time my own dad carried me like that at the aquarium. It's one of the only vivid memories I still have. Probably because it was later that same day, on our way home, that we got in the car crash that killed him and Mom.

A different funny feeling rises, one that has my throat closing up. I look down at my feet for the remainder of the distance, shoving that day far into the back of my mind.

When I reach Aston's side, I catch the tail-end of whatever he was saying—"...home with me."—before he turns his light grayish green eyes on me. "Isn't he the cutest thing you've ever seen?" he gushes.

From under my lashes, I drag my gaze from his face to the monkey on the other side of the chain link divider, and the thing blows a raspberry, sticking its tongue at me.

Aston bursts out laughing as I scowl. "I thought you wanted to see the tiger?" I mutter.

"I want to see everything. Duh." Grubby fingers curl around mine, squeezing, and next thing I know, I'm being dragged away from the monkeys, past the man with the little boy on his shoulders, and toward the cage on the other side of the footpath.

While Aston oohs and ahhs over the chimpanzees, I dart my gaze around, unable to stop myself from registering the clusters of happy families surrounding us.

I was eight when my parents died. I'm eleven now, going on twelve in a couple months. In January, it will be four years since I lost them.

Sure, I still miss them at times—still feel sad about it, I guess—but I’ve never felt like this. Like I’m looking at something that was stolen from me. A life...not just my mom and dad.

The hand still clutching mine gives a couple tugs, and I whip my head around to find Aston watching me with his head cocked. He’s no longer smiling. I don’t really know what to make of his expression.

“You’re not having fun,” he says.

I just shrug in response.

His gaze darts over my head to where I was just looking. “Does it make you sad?”

I don’t have to ask what he means. “No.”

His forehead wrinkles when he refocuses on my face. “It doesn’t?”

Tensing, I give a short shake of my head. No.

Something’s wrong with me.

It’s not the first time I’ve thought it. Not the first time I’ve wondered why I don’t feel things the way others do.

It’s not that I can’t feel anything at all. It’s just really easy for me to turn off the feelings that don’t really do anything for me. Like sadness. At least when I’m angry, it feels like there’s a point to all of this. Losing my parents. Living in a crappy foster home with crappy foster parents. Living...period.

I didn’t know how to use my feelings—anger, especially—to get what I wanted when I was a little kid, like when I laid out those tacks for my teacher to sit on, or like when I drowned Gran’s remote and killed her fish to get back at her. Once I realized it didn’t solve anything—didn’t get me anywhere but in trouble—it all just felt like such a waste of my time and energy. Pointless.

But now?

Like that time I bashed that kid’s head?

Well, who knows what he would’ve done to Aston after he punched him, if I didn’t put a stop to it. Not only that...but I got away with it, thanks to Aston. A win-win.

Well, that is until Rick hurt him even worse.

Then it didn’t feel like much of a win at all.

If anything, it just made me furious with myself for not figuring out a way to clear us both of what happened. If Aston didn’t rush in to take the blame, we could’ve tried to cover it up. Insist it was an accident—that he fell and hit his head.

Lesson learned...

Now, in the zoo, Aston tips his head to the side, studying me in a way that makes it feel as if he's forcefully peeling layers back. Prodding me for something that, even if I wanted to give it, I'm not even sure I could.

An itchy feeling consumes me, and I find myself snarling, "Stop."

I try to shake him free, but he just holds on tighter, determined to ignore me. Clearly not afraid of what I could do to him, should I get pissed off enough. He might be bigger than me, but when I lose myself to that twisting, boiling red-hot feeling that takes over me sometimes, there's no telling what I'm capable of.

I'll do whatever gets me what I want.

And right now, I want him to back off.

"I like to pretend," he says suddenly.

A beat passes where my need to shove him off me falls to the wayside, as curiosity gets the best of me. "Pretend?"

He nods, smiling. Then, hand in hand, he drags me onto the footpath, leading me around a walled off slope of grass covered in pink flowers.

"That I'm here with my parents," he says.

"But you don't even know who your parents are."

He bugs his eyes at me over his shoulder. "That's why it's called pretend, silly."

I make face. "But you don't know what they look like."

"So? That's what an imagination is for."

Before I can ask him how that works, he points to a tall, wide man standing by himself in line for ice cream. "See him? That's our dad."

"Our?"

"Yep. We're brothers." He flashes me a grin. "Real brothers."

I twist my lips together, and drop my gaze to the ground, watching the rocky path pass under my sneakers as Aston continues dragging me across the zoo.

"As I was saying...Dad's getting us ice cream. Strawberry for me with rainbow sprinkles. And vanilla for you with chocolate drizzle. And look! There's Mom."

Lifting my gaze, I follow his free hand to where he points at a woman standing outside the bathrooms with her phone pressed to her ear.

"She got a work call, even though it's supposed to be family day. But it's okay, because when she hangs up, she'll turn all her attention on us. Her

husband. Her kids. She and Dad are going to meet us at the tiger exhibit.”

“They let us go off by ourselves?” I can’t help but ask, despite how stupid this is. Those aren’t our parents. They probably don’t even know each other.

“Yep! We’re always good boys, so they decide to give us a chance to prove we can be trusted on our own today.”

I almost snort at that.

“Look!” he says brightly, picking up the pace, and giving me no choice but to run after him toward where the path Ts off up ahead in front of a large glass enclosure. I can’t see what’s inside, but I have a feeling it’s the new tiger the zoo brought in—something we saw printed across the front page of a newspaper last week, and why Aston was so insistent on getting in here, even if it meant we’d have to sneak in.

Apparently, this is the first tiger this zoo has had in years, not since before Aston and I were born. While he’s been here a couple times in the past—back before I moved in, with the kid I replaced, presumably—this is the first time we’ve gone together. My first time, period.

As we rudely cut through the crowd, I don’t miss the glances and glares shot our way as we knock people out of our path.

I also don’t miss the judgy looks aimed at our joined hands.

It’s only then that it occurs to me what this would look like if we were older.

Gay.

Even still, I imagine it’s not a common sight to see. Amongst young girls, yes. Boys, not so much.

If Aston notices the attention, he doesn’t let it faze him. If anything, he holds my hand tighter, like he’s worried I might pull away. And it makes me feel... good. Knowing he could care less what these people think. Knowing he’s not ashamed of me—of us...

Of what this sort of thing might imply to creeps who have nothing better to do than stare and judge and assume stupid things.

I find myself no longer wishing to be free of his grip...but instead wanting to do something stupid like stick my tongue out at anyone who dares glance this way.

Aston presses his face right up against the glass wall separating us from the orange and black tiger prowling across its artificial habitat, its striped tail flicking back and forth. And I can’t help but watch the way Aston’s face

slackens with awe. It's the same face he made when I gave him his Christmas present last year—a dingy little butterfly trinket I'd found on the road that made me think of him.

Why? I don't know. Perhaps because Aston's like a dragon when it comes to little trinkets, collecting anything shiny and sparkly he finds. Or maybe it was because of the coloring—a grayish green that nearly matched his eyes. When you held it up against the sun, the wings sparkled.

Maybe it was both those things.

It was such a lame gift, looking back—a lazy one too. He went out of his way to shoplift me a football, and all I could manage was roadside garbage.

And yet, he'd never looked as happy as he did when I gave it to him. Said it was the best present he's ever gotten. Which is just plain sad, but I kept that thought to myself. If he was happy about it, I wasn't going to ruin that by reminding him that the way we live isn't normal.

That hoarding dirty, sometimes broken discarded objects, and treating them like treasure is...well, weird.

"Do you think he's happy in there?" Aston asks after a long moment, pulling me from my thoughts.

I notice now his face is bunched like he's thinking real hard. Following his gaze to where the tiger lays down, licking its front paw, I cock my head and say, "He doesn't look unhappy."

He looks like a tiger, is what I really want to say. Can they even feel happiness? They're animals.

"Maybe he doesn't know any better. Maybe he doesn't know what he's missing."

Before I can think too deeply on what he means by that and figure out why it suddenly feels like he's talking about something else, he gasps. "Vale!"

This time, he releases my hand, and I find myself scowling as I race after him.

It's not until I round the enclosure and see where Aston's headed that I realize what he must've spotted through the glass walls of the tiger's cage:

A greenhouse.

His steps slow to a stop right where the main path breaks off into a cobblestoned trail leading right to the double glass doors. Looking over his shoulder, he grins when he sees I'm right behind him. "Butterflies," he

says, as if that wasn't obvious by the big wooden letters scrolled across the archway just above us.

BUTTERFLY GARDEN

"Come on," he says, grabbing my hand once more.

This time, I find myself adjusting my hold, so he's no longer just dragging me around by the fingers, but so our palms are pressed together, fingers laced.

He cuts me a funny look, and I feel my neck grow warm.

"You're my brother, right?" I grumble quietly, not understanding why I suddenly feel the need to release him and shove him away.

He beams, nodding, and gives my hand a squeeze, as if sensing I'm about to let go. "Right! Come on, lil bro. Let's check out the critters."

Lil bro.

It's not the first time he's called me that. Given how short and skinny I still am, you'd think I am younger. When in reality, I have almost a whole year over him.

It's annoying, sure, but it's not like there's anything I can do about it. Plus, it comes in handy sometimes, being able to wiggle in and out of places Aston can't, like when we need to steal food.

Combine that with the fact I rarely ever talk to anyone but Aston, people tend to just overlook me. Or assume I'm not capable of the things Aston takes blame for, like taking down a kid twice my size with a rock to the head.

Inside the all-glass structure, trees and bushes and flowers take up nearly every inch of space, except for the narrow pathways, and the cages along the far right wall. Butterflies of all different colors flutter around the leaves, and when we look up, we find dozens more flitting about the high arched ceiling.

Aston leads me over to the cages first, coming to a stop between two small groups of children.

Clinging to the sides of the cage are thick cocoons in shades of green and white and brown.

"Must be nice," Aston says softly after a while.

"What?" I ask.

He drags the dirt-caked tip of a finger gently over the cross-hatched wiring of the cage. "Knowing that the life you're born into is only

temporary. That things will change. Get better. You get to start over as something completely new...something...beautiful."

His smile twitches, and it's only then that I realize I'm no longer staring at the caterpillars curled up into their little pods as they slowly transform into butterflies. But staring at Aston instead, waiting for him to bust out laughing.

But he doesn't.

Pulling away from the cage, he leads me down the narrow path, past everyone else standing around, all the way to the back corner where there's a waterfall trickling into a small pond with lily pads floating around it.

In the corner of my eye, wings flap in the air. Aston releases my hand, and when I turn to see where he's going, I find him holding his hands out in the air. He's got his head tipped back, a wide smile stamped across his face as he watches the butterflies flitting around him. "Look, Vale, that one looks just like the one you gave me."

I follow his gaze to where one with pale grayish green wings flutter lightly in the air.

It looks like your eyes, I think stupidly, but know better than to say it out loud. He'd make fun of me so hard if I did. Laugh right in my face.

He gasps softly, and when I lower my face, I find Aston's eyes widen on some spot just past me. They dance around like he's following what I assume is the butterfly I keep seeing in the corner of my eye. The one that keeps getting all up in my space.

Just as I go to lift my hand and swat at the air, Aston says in a rush, "Don't move." His eyes are trained on the top of my head, and for whatever reason, I find myself doing as he says, not moving a muscle. I hardly even breathe.

A couple seconds pass, and then suddenly there's something light landing right on the tip of my nose. Eyes crossed, I take in the vibrant teal and black wings spread out motionless in the air.

Beyond it, Aston's eyes are wide and bright, his smile slow to stretch across his face. "It likes you," he breathes.

I begin to grow restless, and Aston must sense it, because his smile slowly fades and a line forms between his eyebrows. He says, "I wish I had a camera." There's an odd sort of dip to his tone, one I've only heard from him a few times.

Disappointment.

Sadness.

“Why?” I find myself asking, my lips hardly moving.

His gaze meets mine above the flutter of wings. “So I could keep this moment.”

The butterfly takes off, but our eyes remain locked.

His mouth lifts into a smile that creases his eyes. It’s a smile I’ve seen a thousand times, and yet...

My chest feels weird. Tight. Like it’s being crushed. And I suddenly find it hard to swallow, knowing that if I do, he’ll hear it—see it.

So I quickly turn around, and say, “I’m hungry. Can we eat now?”

Aston says nothing as he catches up with me.

And when he grabs my hand outside, I ignore the way my neck heats and my heart pounds. And the fact that there’s no need for him to grab hold of me.

I’m pretty sure I’d follow him anywhere.

“We’ll come back next summer, right?” he asks much later, when we have no choice but to leave and head back to the dump we call home.

I nod. “Sure.”

“You’re the best brother ever,” he says, his voice cracking.

I cast him a sideways look, taking in the way the shadows of buildings glance off his pinched face. His faraway gaze. I want to ask him what’s wrong—why it makes him...sad to say that—but instead, I say nothing.

Something tells me he wasn’t looking for a response.

CHAPTER 31

ASTON

THE PRESENT

Dear diary,

I have a feeling tonight's going to be a scream.

XOXO

-A

'Twas ALL HALLOW'S EVE, when all through the town, the creatures were stirrin'...

"Here, here, little mouse," I finish softly, a wicked smile tugging my lips as I step fully out of Walt's station wagon.

Up ahead, the sign for the Crowley-Whitmore Coal Company swings creakily in the breeze. Beyond it, a ferris wheel rotates against the sky, lit up in alternating flashes orange and purple. And past that, are the looming ruins of the processing plant and other various buildings that once made up the mining company, fanned by red spotlights that provide an eerie, hellish, hazy sort of glow. One that is only heightened by the smoke curling up from food vendors, and the thick floor of fog rippling through the property.

According to Walt's little history recap on the drive here, this mine was where the first discovery of anthracite coal in the United States was made, back in the late 1700s.

Since being shut down in the mid-twentieth century after the river broke through the ceiling, flooding the southern access point of the Crowley mines, and killing over a dozen miners—in turn, leading to the end of anthracite mining as we knew it; *RIP*—the Crowley-Whitmore Coal Company has been property of the town's historic society.

Some parts, like where we're heading now, weren't at all affected by the disaster, and are considered stable thanks to what Walt referred to as the room and pillar method of mining. A network of rooms are excavated within a coal seam, leaving behind strategically placed pillars of coal to support the roof of the mine, preventing collapse.

This has made it possible for the town to capitalize on its history, by making it safe for tours and shit during the warmer months, and in the fall, providing a creepy venue for Grady Prep's annual senior trip fundraiser:

The Harvest Carnival.

And the main attraction? The Tunnel of Horror.

(If I had to hear all this boring nonsense, so do you.)

With my mask clutched at my side, I slam the door shut behind me and tip my head back to watch my breath steam up into the night.

It's so bright—the moon, full and fat, where it hangs over the outskirts of Crowley—that not a single drop of starlight can be seen. Only white contrails, like a giant beast rose from the surrounding Appalachians and tried to claw the moon from the sky.

Another door slams shut, followed by Eden sliding up to my side a moment later, just as Tillie rolls down the window of the front passenger seat.

"This should be enough to get you some food as well as the tickets for the tunnel," she says, handing Eden and I *each* fifty-dollar bills.

I have to hike up my robe to stuff it in my pocket.

Somewhere nearby, a high-pitched scream pierces the air. Whipping around, my eyes widen along with my grin as I see some guy dressed as Jason chasing a cheerleader with a chainsaw. Her screech fractures into laughter when he catches her, mingling with the music filtering from speakers hidden around the graveled lot. I don't recognize the song at first,

until the lyrics register and I realize it's a punk-ish cover of "Monster Mash."

"You both have your phones, right? And you'll stick together?"

I turn a bright smile on Tillie and throw an arm around Eden, yanking him against me. "Of course." I give his head a little noogie, ruffling his hair. "Where Edie goes, I go."

An elbow jabs me in the side. "Don't call me that," he grouses bitchily.

Tillie just shakes her head at our antics, fighting a laugh.

Walt must say something from the driver's side, because Tillie rolls her eyes and says, "They'll be *fine*. You worry too much."

Whatever he says in response earns him a twinkling laugh. Shaking her head, she gives us a little wave. "We'll be back for you guys at ten. Behave, you two." It doesn't escape me that her words might be for both of us, but the knowing, narrowed look is for me and me only.

"Yes, Mom," Eden says.

"Yes, Mom," I parrot sweetly.

Before I can catch her reaction to that, I steer Eden away. They drive off a moment later.

Outside the main entrance, Eden and I hang back to get our costumes in order before we go in and split up.

Eden, in black ripped skinny jeans and a matching oversized hoodie, adjusts the black fabric bunched around his neck, stretching it over the lower half of his face to line up with the white printed skull features with his own.

His idea of a costume. Not very creative, but then again...

I glance down at the hooded mask I shake out.

Tonight, neither is mine.

Tugging the material over my head, I adjust it so the rubber mask covers my face. I wiggle it around until I can see out of the netted eye holes, before raising the hood of my robe.

Spreading my hands, I whirl toward Eden, the black fabric draped around me swishing and billowing in the breeze. "How do I look?" I say, voice muffled by the rubber mask.

Eden cocks his head. He's thrown his hood up, leaving just his hazel eyes visible. "Terrifying," he says flatly, just loud enough to be heard through his own face covering.

"You can't tell, but I'm smiling."

He rolls his eyes and starts heading off in the direction his parents went. Hands stuffed in the pockets of his jeans.

Or rather, *my* jeans.

It took some convincing, but he finally relented after I convinced him just how good his butt looks in them, versus the baggy ones he's always so insistent on wearing.

Jogging to catch up, I say, "Sooooo," bumping his shoulder with mine.

He shakes me off, shifting out of my reach. "What?"

"Whatcha got underneath there?" I ask brightly, pinching at his dreadfully oversized hoodie. *Gotta pick my battles.* "Somethin' pretty?"

He rocks to a stop, snapping a glare my way that would rival my little mouse's. It's downright *scary*. I can't see his mouth, but I just *know* he's gotta be snarling something fierce.

I round my eyes, smiling innocently. Only...I'm wearing a mask. All he's got to work with is the droopy white face frozen in a scream peering back at him.

"What? It's Halloween. If there's ever a time to experiment...or be your true self, babe, it's tonight."

He darts a paranoid look around us. "Shut up."

Now, I'm the one rolling my eyes. Not that he can see it. "No one's paying us any attention."

And it's true. Families pass right on by, hardly sparing us more than a glance.

Normally, I would be offended to go so unnoticed. But seeing as stealth is the name of the game tonight, it's a sacrifice I'm more than willing to make.

I sigh. *The things we do for love.*

Speaking of...

"Here," I say, shucking up my robe to get at my pocket. Between my trusty knife, the crumpled fifty, a couple Blow Pops, and balled up wrappers, it takes a hot second to find what I'm looking for.

My steps slow to a stop.

Where is it...

"Aha!" Whipping out the black tube, I run up to Eden, grab him by the wrist, and drag him toward the fence separating the parking lot from the carnival itself.

"What are you—"

Faster than he can catch onto what I'm doing, I unscrew the mascara and tug out the wand.

He tries to flinch back when I grab his jaw, pinching his cheeks together. Eyes twitching, he tries and fails to get away.

"Stop moving or I'm gonna stab you."

He freezes.

"Oh, jeez, not like that. I meant—" I wave the wand, nearly poking him right in the eye, proving my point. I sigh, shaking my head as I apply the mascara to his long lashes.

They flutter, and his eyes redden—watering—clearly unaccustomed to having anything so close to his eyeballs. If I'm not mistaken, his chest is moving more rapidly than it was a second ago. Rising and falling against my elbow.

I'm honestly surprised he gave in so easily.

Not gonna lie though—it's a lot trickier doing this to someone other than me. It isn't as if I've had much practice. I'm not really a fan of wearing the stuff, and tutorials are not as easy to follow as one would think.

Not to mention, there's my somewhat limited vision to take into consideration. But taking off the mask wouldn't just blow my cover should someone walking by recognize me...but it would likely blow his too, if it's someone from school.

And that's the last thing Eden's poor jittery butt needs right now.

"There," I say proudly. I go to step back, but then reconsider, and lean forward instead to give him a lil smooch on the nose.

Only...I'm wearing a mask.

I forgot.

Again.

"What the fuck?" Eden complains, shoving me away when my mask smushes his face. Somehow, his mascara doesn't get smeared by the assault.

Fixing his face covering, he glares at me, drawing stark attention to how thick and pretty his lashes look. Not that they aren't naturally thick and pretty. But a little brown mascara really goes a long way in adding some *oomph*. The effect is only heightened by the brightness of his hazel eyes and the loose tendrils of brown hair curling over his exposed high cheekbones.

I whistle lowly. "Damn. If you weren't jail bait, I'd—"

"Do not finish that sentence." With a huff, he hikes his shoulders to his ears, and storms away. Fists balled at his sides.

I cluck my tongue, and yell after him, “You’re welcome!” Then with a wave, “Enjoy your date! Make good choices! Don’t do anything I would do!”

He throws up a middle finger.

I sniffle and press a hand to my chest. “They grow up so fast.”

When Eden told me he’d been talking to some boy he met online—

Okay, when I stole his phone while he was sleeping one night to see what had him smiling down at it earlier that day—Eden! Smiling! Imagine!

—I was simultaneously offended and impressed.

Offended because he *didn’t tell me!!!*

And impressed because he actually managed to keep it secret for a whole week. At least according to the timestamp of the first messages exchanged.

(I was worried about him, okay?! And maybe a little jealous...just a smidge.)

Tonight, they’ll be meeting in person for the first time, from what I’ve managed to gather.

He wouldn’t tell me much, and I only had time to skim the messages before I was busted.

He’s lucky I’ll be otherwise occupied this evening. If it wasn’t for my date, I’d be *all* up in my little bro’s rear to find out who his mystery lover is.

I don’t even have a name. The number in Eden’s phone was just that—a number. Not even a cute lil pet name.

Heck, I can’t even be certain it *is* a boy. Though I’d bet the fifty in my pocket it is.

And *not* just because of Eden’s other little secret.

Of course, he freaked when he caught me snooping through his phone—took me two days of groveling outside his bedroom door to get him to forgive me.

Just like he freaked when he caught me chilling out in his room my first weekend living with them, lounging around a pile of clothes I dug out from a chest in his closet, twirling a lime-green bralette around my finger mere days after he warned me awa—

Fuck.

I wasn’t supposed to tell you that.

Don’t tell Eden I blabbed!

Anyway! I tried to resist invading his privacy...I really did.

But like I said before—desperate times and all. He was ignoring all my efforts to befriend him, and I was running out of ideas. Not to mention, nothing tempts me more than a secret waiting to be discovered. And it was very obvious my new little brother was hiding something. And I needed *something* to get him to do what I want.

As for *what* he was hiding...

Well, I'm not sure yet even he knows, if the flushed, stuttering indignation and panic that took over him that day was anything to go by.

"It's not what you think."

"You can't say anything."

"It's...nothing."

"I don't know, okay! I don't fucking know."

"I was just...curious."

Really, I don't get what the big deal is. It's just clothes. I wear plenty of things that society would probably deem *girly*. And yeah, it might get me some weird looks sometimes, but who the flip-fuck cares? They're just jealous they can't be as fabulous as me, rocking cashmere and pink.

Methinks there's something else going on with Eden...

Especially given how weird he got when I told him he was pretty that day in my room.

Something that goes far deeper than bralettes, skirts, and make-up.

He just hasn't figured out what it is yet.

Lucky for him, he's got me now to lure him out of his shell and help move things along.

Case in point.

After catching him eyeing up the lipstick I had on my desk a few too many times to be just casual glances—the one I use for decorating my diary and mirror with kissy faces—brow furrowed like he was trying to solve an impossible problem...

Well, I figured if ever there was a time to encourage him to explore his femme side out in the open, it would be Halloween.

I'm honestly surprised he didn't put up more of a fight just now, especially given our recent little tiff over me snooping. But then again, it was just a touch of mascara. It's not like I forced him into a cute dress and dolled up his hair. Small steps.

Up ahead, a red light flashes, followed by what sounds like chains rattling. The upbeat family friendly music that played in the parking lot

gives way something darker and pulse-pounding as I draw closer, giving way to the roar of the rides, and twinkling carnival music, and din of the crowd.

Following in Eden's footsteps, I take in the sights around me. Surrounding the rides, vendors line up along the gravel—smoke curling up into the night, the sizzling scents of fried foods and sweets permeating the air. Past them, a line leads to a booth with a big handwritten sign stating *TICKETS* above it.

I don't see Eden anywhere, but then again, there are a *lot* of people dressed similarly to him.

Yawn. Where are the ghouls and sexy masked men?

Thankfully, the line moves quicker than I anticipated, and before I know it, I've got one ticket to the Tunnel of Horror and am making my way toward the line for the mine car that is apparently being used to transfer people back and forth.

According to one of the signs near the ticket booth, it's a 300 feet descent down the only currently active slope—appropriately numbered for this night: #666. The numbers painted in drippy blood-red above the tunnel entrance.

It's eerily quiet as I wait, save for the heavy thump of Rob Zombie's "Dragula" playing from nearby speakers—I know this one because it's on Eden's playlist—the low chatter, and the distant sound effects coming from the mine tunnel waiting for me—creaks and groans and the clanging of tools, as if to mimic miners.

Behind my mask, I can't contain my smile as excitement buzzes through my veins, making me twitchy with impatience.

Is Vale here yet? Is he already down there, waiting for me? Pacing nervously, wringing his hands, plotting all the ways he'll wreck my ass tonight...

That chain-rattling sound returns, growing louder, and I realize it's the sound of the mine cars rolling over the track. Now that I'm closer, I can hear the faint whir of a motor.

The mine car looks more like a very shallow train than a car, with six box-like carts made up of dark, gnarled slats of wood. It's a lot bigger than it looks at first glance. I figured I'd have to wait at least another trip, given there's about fifteen people ahead of me. But I manage to squeeze in with a group of two girls and two guys in the last cart.

Rather than pair off, the girls stick together with one of the guys. Leaving the bench facing theirs for me and the fourth member of their group.

Whereas the dude across from me wears heavy zombie make-up—not unlike one of the girls; *finally, some holiday spirit*—making it impossible to determine if I know him or not, my bulky neighbor is dressed more similarly to Eden in a black Archers hoodie and jeans. Only he doesn't wear a face covering, so I can make his features out easily.

Well, as easily as I can through my mask in such poor lighting.

He looks *vaguely* familiar. His voice sounds familiar too. Pretty sure we share a class together—math maybe?

The girl dressed not as a zombie, but as a vampire—with fangs and blood and all—I don't recognize. She spots me looking her way, and her mouth twitches around a quiet, "Hey."

For a long moment, I just stare at her. Loving the way her heavily lined eyes start to dart around nervously, her expression faltering. It's only then, when the air is thick with awkwardness, that I lift my hand, and give her a wiggling wave of my fingers.

Her brow knits and she quickly drops her gaze.

The others seem to have caught on to the shift in the air, making the space feel all the more confining. And as someone who is not a *huge* fan of small spaces, I use their growing unease as a much appreciated distraction.

"*Scared, Sydney?*" the guy next to me says deeply. If it wasn't for the sour smell of beer wafting from his breath, I'd probably be a little turned on.

Vampira kicks him. "Very funny, asshole." Whether or not her real name is Sydney remains to be seen.

"Aw, don't be like that. He's harmless." A heavy arm is slung around me, and I tense. The beer on his breath and eking from his pores makes it hard to breathe suddenly. *Yep. No. Definitely not turned on.* "That right, Stu?" he says on a laugh.

Under my mask, I roll my eyes and huff indignantly. *I could be Billy! Asshole.*

"Dude," Zombie-guy says with a shake of his head.

Slowly turning my head toward the guy next to me—the one who couldn't be bothered to wear a costume—I smile from behind my mask as I feel around for the knife in my left-side pocket.

Some blood smeared around his face would sure help him fit in more...

I'm dimly aware of a throat clearing just as someone else climbs into the mine car, squeezing into the vacant spot next to me. I catch traces of cologne—something familiar—but I'm too focused on the drunk asshole with his arm around me to pay it much notice.

My lips rise in a manic smile he can't see as I lean toward him, getting all up in his space. He stiffens, and everyone seems to be holding their breath.

Soft music playing from hidden speakers inside the train car fill the strained silence. Some mash-up of spooky sound effects—creaking and ghostly moans—interspersed with a little girl humming the lullaby from *Rosemary's Baby*.

It only heightens the thrill of the moment.

Quietly—but not too quiet that the others don't hear me—I say, “I have a boyfriend, you know. And he's waiting for me.” I tilt my head ever so slightly, rubbing my mask along his face, breathing heavily for effect. “He's big, and he plays football...” I say sweetly, before baring my teeth. Through them, deepening my voice, I all but snarl the rest of the words, “And he'll kick the shit out of you.”

For a moment, he remains completely motionless.

And then when it seems to click what I said, the guy coughs out a short laugh. “Ha. Funny.”

Yeah, it'll be even funnier when your insides are on the outside, I think, as I open my knife, and poke into his side, hard enough to be felt through my robe and his sweatshirt, but light enough it doesn't break through the barriers.

He stiffens, a heavy, expectant silence permeating the tension-thick air once more, save for the humming and chimes.

My fingers twitch, and with slow, jerky movements, the arm around me slinks back to where it came from.

And I didn't even have to stab him!

#winning

Without any warning, the door to our car slams shut, extinguishing all traces of light. Much to my irritation, I flinch.

“Jesus,” someone mutters at the same time another yelps. A slimy chuckle fills the space—who it came from, I have no idea.

Closing the knife, I grip it tight enough to leave grooves in my palm.

The stench of stale beer combined with the cologne coming from the quiet lone straggler on my other side has saliva flooding my mouth.

The darkness isn't helping matters. Nor is the sudden inescapable fact that we're moving—slowly, but surely making the descent into the mines, hundreds of feet beneath the surface of the earth, where there will be no escape. Where the earth could collapse on us at any given moment, burying us alive.

Heart pounding, it takes everything in me not to whip off the mask and throw myself out of this too-crowded death trap. Meanwhile, the others resume their idle chitchat, as if what happened moments ago is already forgotten. As if I'm really no threat to them at all.

I am though. I am.

I'm the only monster here.

The handle is slick in my tightly fisted hand as a weird staticky sensation fills my brain, spreading through the rest of my body. Shooting off little sparks in my fingertips, not unlike a polyester blanket would in the dead of winter, when the air is dry and charged.

Vale's waiting for you, I remind myself as I focus on evening my breaths.

It's so hot in here, between the mask and the body heat—humid, not dry at all—yet my skin pebbles from a clammy sort of chill I can't be sure is from the dank air of the mine or old fears coming back to tug me under.

Yeah, I didn't really think this through...

Definitely going to have to have a little chat with Vale about how dating works. What happened to good ol' fashioned drive-ins and milkshakes?

After what feels like an eternity, but in actuality is only minutes, we come to a jarring, lurching halt. A moment later, there's a sort of snicking sound, that can only be the door's locking mechanism giving way.

Before anyone can open it for us, I jump up, practically crawling across the loner's lap, and grab the handle to shove it open and tumble out. Dirt clouds up around the combat boots I borrowed from Eden, dusting my jeans and the hem of my robe where it reaches mid-calf.

I'm vaguely aware of the bodies swarming around me, the mine car emptying. The laughter and sounds making up the haunted tunnel slowly break through the weird buzzy feeling filling my head, making me feel all jittery—like I'm suddenly bursting with energy.

I tell myself it's just excitement for what's to come.

It has nothing to do with the fact I'm all too aware that I'm no less trapped now than I was a moment ago.

Rucking up my robe, I stuff my knife back in my pocket before letting the fabric fall around my legs once more. Wiping my sweat-slicked palms on the silky, synthetic material, I step into line with the rest of the bodies migrating parallel to the car. Following the lantern-lit path into tunnels that glitter black.

Somewhere, a door slams shut, followed by a high-pitched scream I can't be sure is legit or a sound effect. Spooky music plays from speakers positioned along the wall, warring with the clamor of what you'd expect for a haunted house sort of thing.

Banging, creaking, and rattling chains.

Moans, screeches and monstrous roars.

Eyes wide behind my mask, I push up on my toes, craning my neck to try and get a glimpse of what's waiting for me.

Slowly, a chain link gate comes into view over the sea of heads looming before me, where a Grim Reaper stands guard with his scythe, granting entry in groups.

Having never been to a haunted house—or tunnel, in this case—I'm not really sure what to expect beyond darkness and jump scares.

Which is pretty much exactly what we're greeted with past the gate—me and the two girls I attached myself to, following their lead through a maze of various rooms.

My senses are on high-alert—adrenaline surging through my veins—as I keep an eye out for this so-called Chamber of Mirrors.

Something brushes over my shoulder, and I swear I feel someone breathing hotly down my neck. But when I whip my head around, no one's there.

My mouth splits into a grin.

This. Is. AWESOME.

I take back my earlier misgivings. Best first date idea *ever*.

Lights flicker on suddenly, drawing attention to the thick fog swirling around us, and the cages lined up along the wall. A gorilla rattles the bars with a ferocious roar. A werewolf paces, growling. A clown stands with his head cocked; a frozen bloody grin stamped across his face as his beady eyes track us.

I give him an enthusiastic wave. He can't see it, but I am *beaming*.

Now that some visibility has been restored, there's no missing the graffiti decorating the walls. Expletives and penises, and abstract strokes making up an array of colorful images.

Up ahead, where the room gives way to a narrow red-flashing hallway, someone spray-painted the wall surrounding the opening to look like the entrance to one of those old-fashioned Tunnel of Love attractions you'd find at carnivals with the swan boats and heart-framed canal and lovey dovey music.

This one has all that minus the water and boats, and it's splattered from ceiling to floor with blood. It squelches under my boots. *Gross. But also... awesome?*

From hidden speakers inside, old-timey jukebox music plays, broken only by a doo-wops, and a male lead crooning about only having eyes for *youuuu*. Romance at its absolute finest.

I drag my fingers along the bumpy wall, collecting the dusty dried substance they used as blood, absently wondering if perhaps Vale plans to take me through here once we meet up. There's not really any room for privacy, but shucks if I wouldn't be just *keen* for a PG hand-held stroll through the murder tunnel.

Be still my squishy beating heart.

Emerging into a room draped with cobwebs, lit sickly green by glow-in-the dark spiders hanging from the ceiling, I'm wondering at what point we'll reach the Chamber of Mirrors, when a moment later, I have my answer.

Finally.

Not that the lead-up wasn't all fun and dandy—really setting the tone, you know. Gotta build that tension and let things marinate. Who doesn't love a good, slow edging?

The room, or whatever you want to call it, is bigger than I expected.

Or...maybe not. I suppose all the reflections bouncing off each other make this stretch of mine appear far more vast than it is.

Separating from the group, I weave my way through the maze made up of all sorts of mirrors, searching for my boo. Watching in my periphery as my cloaked, masked reflection flickers in and out with the flashing strobe lights in a whoosh of billowing black fabric and streaks of a white ghostly face.

From more hidden speakers, a creepy, tinkling carnivalesque song plays. Like something you'd hear from a music box.

There's a mechanical gasp, quickly followed by a fresh wave of thick, dense fog sweeping across the floor, swallowing me up to mid-calf.

Other groups linger about, but no sign of Vale. Perhaps I beat him here.

Content to wait him out, I look for somewhere out of the way.

Around and around I go, before I finally reach some sort of end—a corner—marked with a wide floor to ceiling mirror with a bronze ornate frame cradled by dirt walls.

There's just enough room to slip behind it.

Perfect.

And now we wait.

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CHAPTER 32

VALE

HALLOWEEN.

The one day of the year the monsters get to show their true selves to the world, hidden by the comfort of rubber masks and grotesque make-up that more accurately reflects what lies beneath than any disguise worn the rest of the year.

They prowl and they lurk, stalk and smirk, their skin chapped with fake blood that they pretend is real, and carrying a conscience as weak as they allow it to be.

It's empowering—vindicating—embracing the idea of being a monster.

For some, I suppose it's a mere escape. A night to make-believe that the world is full of magic and wonder. Where battles are fought gallantly, for the greater good, rather than by the inner demons that plague our dreams.

But for some of us, it's freedom. A night where the chains keeping our inner beasts are slackened just enough to give a taste of what it could be like every day, if we wanted such a thing.

A night where we don't fight monsters but become them.

We become the terror.

And it makes me wonder, as I take in my group of friends and the surrounding people slowly making their way through the dark, dank labyrinth, just how many of us are holding back our true nature.

How many of us are there, truly, hanging on by a mere thread, waiting for an excuse to use this brief reprieve to fully break free?

They say the veil between the living and the dead is at its thinnest on All Hallows' Eve. But what about the veil between our nature and conditioning?

My mouth ticks up. *If they only knew...*

Down here, the jump scares should be the least of their worries.

The dead the least of their concerns.

The real monster is the one that walks amongst them, with a smile as rubber as the one he wears the rest of the year.

“Fuck!” Casey yelps, stumbling into me, when a clown pops up out of nowhere, getting all up in my best friend’s face. Thea cackles, only to screech a second later when some tall, lanky junior dressed as Freddy Krueger comes up behind her, knives clawing through the air.

In the cage nearest me, someone dressed in a gorilla suit thrashes around, banging his fists on his cage. I roll my eyes.

Two of the Alicias scurry toward the nearest opening, dragging Thea along with them, waving impatiently for us to follow.

Adjusting my hood, my fingers bump the small black prosthetic horns I let Alicia Graves cake on me, and I resist the urge to scratch at my cheeks. It’s her birthday, and she’s all about this shit. So, just like last year when we were the ones running this show, rather than get her a normal gift, Fletch roped all of us seniors on the team into being her practice dummies.

Unlike my friends who have their entire faces stained red, I insisted on something more subtle. So she smudged black makeup around my eyes to make them appear sunken in, did some kind of shadowy magic to sharpen my cheekbones and jawline, and forced all-black contacts on me. My eyes are already bordering on black as it is, but these cover most of my sclera too, making them look—and I quote—“*all the more demonic.*”

She did a good job. Can’t deny that. Not just with me, but the others too. They all voted on an angels and demons theme this year. I didn’t care either way, so I just went with whatever the majority wanted.

Whereas we guys are dressed head to toe in all black, the girls are dressed in skimpy white two-pieces with wings strapped to their back. And instead of prosthetic horns glued to their foreheads, they’ve got haloes poking up from some kind of clear headpiece. Silvery white make-up is smeared over just about every inch of their exposed skin, making them practically glow in the dark.

Hanging back to take up the rear, I get stuck behind Alicia as we’re forced into a single-file line by the narrowing makeshift hallway made up of metallic paneling on either side of us. It’s hotter than it normally is down here, thanks to the tightly pressed bodies and heat radiating from the lights,

and I can feel sweat gathering around my hairline and the back of my neck where it's hidden under my hood.

The flashing strobe lights staccato our movements like we're in a stop motion film, drawing even more attention to the snow-white angel wings in front of me. And not for the first time tonight, images of Aston in a similar get-up invade my mind.

Naked and bent over for me, his tight little ass flushing pink from the unforgiving smacks of my palm. Wearing nothing but those wings as he begged for my cock. His own swinging under him, rock hard, uncut, leaking, and so sweetly deprived.

What a picture we'd make now...the shadowy devil fucking his greedy little angel. Making him squirm and sob and scream for mercy as I took what I wanted, never letting up.

The hallway curves, opening up into the Chamber of Mirrors. This is just one of several entrances into this room, done purposefully to make it all the more disorienting as we're bombarded by the clash of reflections coming from every which way.

We'd already been through here earlier, and I hear one of the guys groan, realizing we got turned around. Not hard to do down here, even on a normal day. Pulling out my flask, I take two searing gulps of Johnny Walker as I shuffle along dutifully.

It's just as I hear one of the girls say, "Over here!" that I feel it—the hair prickling along the back of my neck, telling me I'm being watched.

Jaw clenching, I slow my steps to a stop, my friends momentarily forgotten. Movement in my periphery catches my attention, and I tilt my head, flitting a look through the corner of my eye. Only to catch sight of my reflections facing off. Nothing more.

And yet...

Something tells me that's not what I saw.

And certainly not what I feel pulling the air taut with tension.

Not the bad kind, no, not necessarily. Though, I suppose it would depend on who you ask. The average person would probably call it dread. Their hearts would start racing, their breaths growing shallow. A cold sweat would pebble their skin, and their stomachs might churn.

But for me, the tension is just that—tension. A rubber band stretching and stretching, not unlike how I feel on the field in that split second before the snap.

“You coming, Riviera?” Casey calls out from a few feet ahead, yanking me from my thoughts.

“Yep,” I say matter-of-factly, keeping my body language loose and relaxed.

An infinite sea of reflections bounce off us as I join him and the others. There’s a flash of billowing black fabric, disappearing as quickly as it came thanks to the flashing lights.

A short huff of laughter leaves my nose. *What the hell is he up to now?* I wonder silently, more curious than anything.

With the exception of our phone call the other night, Aston’s been uncharacteristically subdued since the lockdown.

I knew better than to hope though, and he proved just how futile that would’ve been when he called me Thursday night, acting like his usual annoying, weird self. As if me flipping my shit on him that day in the locker room and then giving him the cold shoulder, even when trapped together during that lockdown, was neither here nor there. Just a little kink in his plan.

And you stayed on the phone and humored him, why?

Deep down, I know the answer, and it has everything to do with why I’m not surprised in the least he’s here tonight. That he’s been waiting for me. Watching from the shadows.

What he’s got planned outside of stalking me...what he hopes to achieve...

Well, that remains to be seen.

Be it the whiskey coursing hotly through my veins, loosening the restraints in my mind I’d normally cling to, or the fact it’s Halloween, and we’re in an underground mine swarming with people calling upon their more primal urges—even if it’s just in jest; a night to escape the shackles of humanity and right and wrong, and pretend their self-awareness isn’t a cage keeping them from giving into their more base, animalistic instincts...

Whatever it is, I find myself sinking into it. The energy—electric and intoxicating, brimming with piqued interest. It calls to me—calls to that bottomless nothing inside me. Feeding that slow-building fury of *want*.

To consume.

To destroy.

To feel *something*.

Anything other than insufferable boredom, if only for a night.

The lights flicker in time with my steps. Screams fill the cavernous maze, interlaced with the deep, heady, pulse-pounding music playing from the next room's speakers.

All the while as I migrate from one room into another, I'm acutely aware of the eyes boring into my back. The soundless steps trailing after mine, clinging to the shadows left in my wake like breadcrumbs.

Grotesque shapes fracture in and out, dancing off the glittering black walls, and I take stock of where I am, slowing down, hanging back.

There, I think, eying the looming cardboard cut-out of a gnarled tree up ahead to my right. I wait for my friends to turn the corner, and quickly, stealthily slip behind the decoration into one of the many abandoned, off-limits tunnels down here. Taking care to step around the various scattered bricks and rocks and other debris.

The flickering lights fade, slowly giving way to total darkness.

It's been a while since I've explored the mines. Back when Quentin first moved us to Crowley, I had a hard time sleeping. And drawing wasn't really doing it for me anymore. So, I often snuck out at night, spending the early hours of morning exploring my new surroundings.

Being that Crowley was once a booming industrial town before agriculture took over, there was an endless supply of challenges for me to tackle. Places to conquer.

I'd memorized all the ways I could get in and out undetected, should someone catch me trespassing. Just as I'd memorized the layout of the mines beyond the area that is considered stable, where they do occasional tours and the annual Tunnel of Horror.

Reckless? Probably. As I got older I risked it less and less.

Up ahead, there's a wooden archway leading into pitch black nothingness. Letting instinct guide me, I let it swallow me up. The quieter and darker it gets, the more my senses sharpen. Somewhere, water drips. And I can just make out the quiet crunch of distant steps.

It's only when there's not a speck of light to be seen that I veer off to the side, hanging back to allow Aston to get ahead of me.

That is, if he dares to enter. Dares to keep playing this game *he* started, now that he's walked right into the trap I set for him, flipping our roles.

Keeping my breaths quiet and even, I focus on slowing my heart rate as I listen for footsteps.

As predicted, the ones that were following me seem to grow hesitant—less certain—before coming to a halt completely somewhere in the dark. For a long moment, there’s just his breathing—too loud, quick, and becoming more uneven by the second.

My nostrils flare, mouth watering. I can practically taste his growing unease. Salty like sweat. Coppery like blood. My lips rise of their own accord.

I wasn’t really sure what to expect. I only knew he wouldn’t hesitate to follow.

And as I watch his cloaked figure light up from the phone he digs out—watch the way he yanks the hooded mask off his head, and turns in a circle, darting his gaze right over where I hide in the shadows, too blinded with panic to hone his instincts, his senses...too lost in *feeling*, rather than cold, hard knowing...

I recall the way he started to spiral in the bathroom during the lockdown. The way I could see the walls closing in through his dimming eyes.

My sugar has a weakness. A very, very exploitable weakness.

And fuck if some part of me—the baser, irrational part of me, fueled by raw desire—isn’t purring in pleasure at the thought. Crouching, clawing at the ground, readying to pounce.

Who’s the little mouse now?

Just when I think he might actually prove me wrong and give up and turn back the way he came, he toughens his shoulders and strides determinedly ahead, using his phone’s flashlight to guide him deeper into the tunnel. His mask—I never got a chance to see what it was—is gripped in his fist at his side.

Rather than immediately follow, I hang back and wait until he’s far enough up ahead before following him, so that when I eventually do make a sound—a quick, forceful side-swiping kick of gravel at the wall—and he whirls around with a gasp, the light can’t reach me.

“V-Vale?”

It’s just a whisper, but in the vacuum of the tunnel, it carries like a scream. Not unlike his hard audible gulp a moment later. Around his silhouette, the light shivers, further betraying the panic I have no doubt has leached his face of all color. It’s almost a pity I can’t see it.

Dragging my teeth over my lip, I reach down, adjusting myself, and wait for him to resume walking. By my estimation, we're just about at the point where the tunnel rounds a corner, forking off into two directions.

On the left, will be another tunnel—shorter than this one—that will lead into a section of rooms reminiscent of where we'd just been. Only abandoned and littered with rock debris from when water had swept in years ago, causing parts of it to collapse into itself. Highly unstable.

On the right...

I hear his sharp intake of breath when we get there, and then he's moving, running, scrambling down the short, narrow pathway to where the moon, bright and visible in the sky, peeks around a metal gate leading to freedom. If he'd turned off his phone's light a little way's back, he would've noticed the darkness breaking up sooner.

His pounding steps crunch over broken rock and glass, his cloak billowing behind him. When he reaches the gate leading into just one of the many hidden adit entrances scattered around this part of town, he drops his mask in his haste to open the latch and get out. He doesn't seem to notice. A grunt followed by a loud creak sounds into the night—the door giving way.

It all but flies out of his hand, lighter than I imagine he was expecting once loosened.

I catch it before it can slam shut, slipping through after him. But not before reaching down for the mask he'd abandoned. Even before a glance down confirms it, my hands tell me what I probably should've anticipated after our enlightening little conversation over the phone the other night.

"What's your favorite scary movie?" he'd asked.

"How convenient," he said when I gave him my answer.

Something tells me he'd already had this planned.

I huff shortly through my nose as I quickly take in the white, drooping face before shoving it over my head, under my own hood. Now, no part of me is visible, save for my hands.

Up ahead, at the top of a shallow incline, I can make out Aston's bent figure as he struggles to catch his breath, the hem of his cloak fluttering and billowing around in the breeze.

As I draw closer, I can make out the cornfield that waits just beyond him, slowly coming into full view. It sways, rustling into the night, the normally golden and green stalks saturated by the moonlit night.

When Aston senses me nearing, he stills, before straightening to his full height. He fumbles with his phone to turn off the flashlight, before hiking up his cloak to stuff it in his pocket.

Only then does he whirl around to face me.

Not having realized how close I was, he stumbles back with a gasp, eyes widening into saucers when they snap up to mine. Not that he can see them through the mask I stole.

His mouth parts, but before he says God only knows what, I surge forward, eliciting a small yelp when I grab him tightly by the arm, and drag him up right up against me.

Upper arms gripped in my hands, I plaster his back to my front. Making sure he can feel just how hard I am through my jeans when I dip my head toward the side of his head, inhaling him deeply through my mask.

It's not as if I can smell him through the mustiness of the hood. But his little shiver tells me he heard it—felt it in the rise of me against his shoulder—and that's good enough for me.

For a long moment, we stay just like this.

With me breathing heavily, loudly, evenly in his ear, in no hurry to release him.

And with him standing frozen, trembling ever so slightly in my iron-clad hold.

He gulps—hard.

Behind my mask, I smile, and it's as real as it is vicious.

It's then, and only then, that I lean right up against his ear—tighten my bruising hold of him—and break the silence. Snarling through my teeth—

“Run.”

CHAPTER 33

ASTON

“YOU DO REALIZE you’re supposed to be romancing me, not *traumatizing—oomph!*”

He shoves me. Hard.

Stumbling forward, I somehow manage to catch my footing before going splat and breaking my pretty face. Or worse, my dick. Because it *clearly* didn’t get the memo we’re probably supposed to be a lil scared right now...

What can I say? My dick’s a bit of a thrill seeker.

Knowing Vale’s equally as turned on by this little game of cat and mouse doesn’t help matters. I felt as much a moment ago—the solid, thick length of him digging into my lower back. Right above my ass.

“Okay, okay!” I mutter breathlessly. “Message received. Sheesh.” I give a little shake of my head, and take a hesitant step forward, craning my neck to look both ways. The cornfield stretches as far as my eyes can see.

Oh shit, does he mean...

“Um, Vale. Babe. You sure—”

“I said *run*,” a voice grits into my ear, making me jump.

(If you heard a little very unmanly *eep*, no you didn’t.)

When the fuck did he move?

This time, my body makes the decision before my brain can even catch up, and next thing I know, I’m racing into the fields, running like my life depends on it.

Heck, maybe it does.

Maybe I got this all wrong.

Maybe Vale's got more nefarious plans in mind than simply fucking me silly and making me scream his name.

Maybe he's not who I thought he was.

Maybe this isn't Vale at all...

I nearly eat dirt with the intrusion of *that* much unwanted thought.

Nope. No. This is not the time to get all paranoid, I tell myself sternly.

Obviously it's Vale. That was his voice...

I'm pretty sure.

Like fifty-five percent positive.

"Fuck. Me." I gasp, legs pumping, lungs working well beyond their capacity.

Cornstalks rush past me in a blur, making my world feel all the more shrunk in. My heart pounds so fast and so hard, not unlike how it did when I was convinced the walls of the tunnel were closing in on me, I fear it might actually burst free of my chest.

Not having a clue where I'm going, it's only thanks to the moon shining down on me that I can see anything at all. And while I know the smart thing to do would be to zig-zag rather than just book it straight ahead...

I really, *really* don't feel like getting lost.

While this is far more preferable to the underground tunnels, the fact that I've yet to stumble onto any sort of break in the stalks—pathways, like the ones in the field by the Iron Furnaces—isn't really helping the whole claustrophobic thing.

What if he can't find me? What if he waited too long before chasing me?

What if he didn't chase me at all, and this is some sick joke?

It's that thought that has me finally slowing my pace and chancing a glance behind me.

Something in me sinks when I find myself alone.

No disturbance in the stalks that I can see.

Nothing.

I'm alone. I'm all alone out here.

A branch snaps loudly under my foot, making me jolt, my steps faltering as I dart a panicked look around.

At least it sounded like a branch. For all I know, it's the bones of some other poor sucker who didn't have the sense to say *no* when asked to play a game of *Children of the Corn*.

For as much as I hope he *is* out here, chasing me...

I'm equally crawling out of my skin with adrenaline—the nail-biting, chest-squeezing suspense of knowing I could be caught at any moment.

What will he do with me when he catches me?

My side twinges with a sharp pang, and I wince through my teeth as I cup my side, my legs fumbling as my body begins to quit on me. My lungs are on fire, and my stomach churns like I might throw up. Now that I think about it, I can't even remember the last time I jogged, much less ran at full-speed.

Finally, I spot what looks like a break in the stalks.

Oh thank fucking—

I burst out of the stalks, crashing to my knees, chest heaving. Eyes bulging, I sweep a dizzying look around me.

“What...” I gasp, before a coughing fit overtakes me.

Having expected freedom, I deflate when all I see surrounding me is more corn. The small clearing I mistook as the edge of the cornfield is no bigger than my bedroom at the Jennings. Hacking a big wad of spit at the ground, I sink back on my haunches and wipe the back of my hand across my mouth.

My skin tingles. My throat burns. My pulse thunders in my ears.

This is so not how I imagined tonight would go.

Not that I'm complaining!

This isn't me complaining at. All.

Nonono. I mean, so what if I'm woefully out of shape? So what if Vale's idea of foreplay is luring me into dark, confined spaces and chasing me through an endless cornfield like some kind of axe murderer, masked and all?

My mask, might I add.

The little thief.

Not that I really knew what to expect tonight, for our first official date. When I saw Vale disappear behind that wooden cutout, I thought for sure he was leading me somewhere quaint and private for some X-rated canoodling.

What I didn't expect was for him to disappear into the shadows like some kind of creature of the night, leaving me to my own devices.

Did I *have* to keep going?

No.

If it wasn't for the sensation of eyes tracking me in the dark, the deep-seated knowing I wasn't actually alone in there like he wanted me to

believe, you bet your right tit I would've skedaddled right back the way I came and washed my hands of this nonsense.

But alas, a "final girl" I am not.

The things we do for love...

Sydney Prescott would be so ashamed of me right now.

I've gotta hand it to Vale though—as far as memorable first dates go, this is definitely one for the books.

But mark my words—he will pay for this. I'm thinking our next date will involve something with a whole lotta glitter. And edible lube. Maybe some animal print...

Focus.

Blinking rapidly, I force myself to actually pay attention as I take another slower look around. This time, I spot it—not quite the pathway I was hoping for, but trampled stalks could mean someone who ventured out here before was kind enough to forge some sort of path leading the way out of here.

Or it fell over, and you're just making something out of nothing per usual.

I scrunch up my face.

Okay....so we know things are bad when there's that pesky voice of reason mouthing off in my head.

See here, this is why we don't make a habit of exercising—unless it's of the carnal variety, of course—it sucks the oxygen from my brain, taking with it all the things that make me fun. Leaving room for other...not so fun things to slither their way in and take up real-estate.

Just get out of here, and all will be swell again.

Perhaps find a certain little mouse and spank him for once, for scaring me.

In my head, an image of his ass in the compression pants he wears when playing football springs to mind.

That's much better. Follow the booty.

Wetting my lips, I reach under my robe for my knife and flip it open, sighing a breath of relief. I turn towards the crushed section of stalks. The sharp blade catches on the moonlight, glinting like a beacon.

I groan.

Nice.

“Shut up,” I mutter, angling the knife down, before tilting my head back and flipping off the moon. To that motherfucker, still on my knees, I whisper harshly, “I thought you were on my side.”

Big and full it just hangs there, staring down at me. Taunting me, as if to say, “*I know the way out, silly, stupid boy...*”

Grumbling under my breath, I push my heavy, exhausted limbs to a shaky stand. Steeling myself before striding determinedly toward what I hope is my way out.

I get only three steps when I hear it—

A rustling of leaves.

I freeze, eyes wide as they dart side to side. I cock my head, straining my ears, but all I hear now is the deafening thump of my heart determined to beat my ear drums to a pulp.

Probably just a breeze, I tell myself with a nod. Or you imagined it.

Okay, so maybe a touch of rational thought here and there ain’t such a bad thing.

Is this...is this a breakthrough?

Dr. B will be so, so proud of himself when I tell him. *Not*. As if that Dr. Phil wannabe deserves any credit for my personal growth.

Under my breath, I find myself singing, “One...two...”

Dr. B will just take it as permission to—

“He’s a comin’ for yo—” I slap a hand over my mouth, eyes bugging.

Okay, so that crackling sound did *not* come from me, the wind, or my overactive imagination.

Fuck. This is it. This is how I die.

I can see it now—the headlines.

From padded walls to a grisly death: how an 18-year-old twink got himself carved up in a cornfield all because a cute boy told him to run.

The press is going to have a *field day*.

In the back of my head, the song continues playing like an echo, but sung by a child instead. Two children. Flashes of kids jump-roping surge forth, invading the present.

“...buckle my shoe. Three, four...”

Lock the door.

I can’t remember what comes next.

LOCK THE DOOR.

Sucking in my cheeks, I squeeze my eyes shut and give a little shake of my head.

Go away.

When I've reopened my eyes, I tiptoe over the crushed stalks littering the ground, forming an uneven path that extends at least as far as I can see.

That will have to wait though.

First, I need to hide.

Carefully side-stepping back into the thick of it, I crouch down, using the dense cluster of leaves as cover, hold my knife out, and wait. My breaths saw in and out in uneven bursts that I try to get under control.

Was that a door creaking?

I give another rapid, jerky shake of my head. And with the hand not holding the knife, I sink my fingers into the earth until I feel a sting from my nails pushing into the beds.

You're not there, you're not—

Hands grab me from behind, and I start to scream, only for a hand to slap over my mouth, stifling it into a whimper.

I'm yanked to my feet, my grip on the knife loosening from the slickness that's gathered across my palm. I manage to get hold of it before it can drop, squeezing the handle so tightly it hurts.

Either he hasn't spotted the knife yet, or he's truly indifferent to the fact I've got a weapon—one I'm not afraid to use, no sirree—because he pays it no mind when he grabs me by the hood of my cloak, twisting it, and all but dragging me back into the clearing. Cutting off my airway in the process.

With one hand, I wave around the knife. And with the other, I claw at the collar strangling my throat. Feet scrambling, heels digging into the earth, I try to get my legs under me and keep pace with his long, quick strides. But it's no use.

Black flickers in and out of my vision. Next thing I know, I'm thrown on the ground, landing in the fetal position. My knife goes flying, and as I gasp and cough for air, I stare longingly at where it lands in the dirt, far, far from my reach.

Strong hands roll me onto my back, and I blink up at the ghostly white mask leaning toward me. He cocks his head, like he's studying me. Inspecting me like a bug.

I force a swallow, wincing at the burn. Gasping, I say through a twitchy smile, "You caught me, big guy."

Blinking rapidly to see through the blurriness obstructing my vision, I flinch inward, frowning, when fingers descend toward my face. Holding very still, all I can do is stare wide-eyed, mouth slackened, as he brushes his fingertips under my eyes. Collecting moisture there I only just now notice.

In fact, my whole face feels cold and oddly stiff now that I think about it.

Because he was choking you. That's all.

Yet something tells me these fresh tears had tracks to follow, not unlike the path I was hoping would take me out of here.

I watch as Vale brings his hand to his face. I can't see his eyes through the mask, but somehow I just know his attention is currently on his fingers. Fingers that just swept up my tears. It's impossible to get an accurate read on him, but there's something...curious to his demeanor.

Like my tears caught him off-guard.

You and me both, my guy. You and me both.

I open my mouth to say something, but when nothing comes out, I feel my cheeks grow warm and tingly. It spreads to my neck, and down my arms underneath my clothes. Squirming, I tense and still when his head snaps up, his attention fully returning to my face.

Then, through the corners of my eyes, I watch as he lowers his hand to wipe my tears off his fingers. Not on his clothes though. No, he uses the dirt. Taking his time too, as if to drive some point home.

What that point is, I can't say for certain. But whatever it is, I'm pretty sure it's nothing good if the sickening feeling twisting around in my gut is anything to go by.

Suddenly, he's using those fingers, now filthy with dirt, to grip my jaw. The roughened pads dig into my cheeks so hard, I taste blood.

Dipping forward, he gets so close that if he wasn't masked, he'd be in kissing range.

I gulp, gasping through my nose into the mesh covering where his mouth is.

He tilts his head to the left. Then to the right. Then, he's flipping me back over on my stomach. Moving me around like I weigh nothing more than a rag doll he can toss around.

My hands land planted in the dirt on either side of my head. I curl my fingers into the earth and begin clawing my way out from under him. He

lets me get about a foot away, before tackling me to the ground, crushing me with his weight.

My mouth remains open on a soundless gasp, dirt and dead leaves digging into my cheek.

Leaning down, he drags where his nose would be down my cheek, before stopping at my neck. His chest rises against my back as he takes a deep inhale through the mask, and my eyes fall shut.

When he pulls back abruptly, I barely have time to mourn the loss of his warmth—this weight, crushing that it was—before he’s shoving up my costume, and tugging at my jeans. I go to arch up and wedge my hands underneath me to help with the fly, but he stops me before I can. His grip on my wrists is bruising as he extends my arms ahead of me as far as they’ll go. With one last squeeze of my wrists indicating for me to keep them there, he returns his hands to the task of stripping me of my jeans.

Resting my chin in the dirt, I stare straight ahead as he reaches under me, undoes my fly, and then yanks my jeans down. Something gives him pause, and I think I know exactly what that something is.

With a smirk, I turn to look over my shoulder, giving him a little wiggle of my butt. Showing off the hot pink silk briefs I wore specifically for tonight. For *him*. “You like?”

His head snaps up, and I bite my lip, staring right through the mask’s eyes, imagining his dark, hungry gaze behind the thin mesh boring right back at me.

Without taking his attention off my face, he clutches my ass in his hands—so warm, and so big his fingers splay across both cheeks—and he squeezes.

I suck in a sharp breath, shoulders bunching, fingers flexing where I still hold them stretched out in front of me.

Then, faster than I can blink, he manages to scrunch up the thin, delicate fabric of my panties. And he rips them. Right down the middle.

My brows fly up. A moment later, before I can complain—*I really loved those ones*—he spans me right over the seam of my ass. Hard enough for the smack to echo in the night. Hard enough for my hole to clench instinctively as I thrust my rigid cock into the rough dirt and leaves.

Clutching my cheeks once more, he forcefully spreads me, baring my hole to him, to the full moon boring down on us. My body tries to clench, but held open like this, I can’t. It’s humiliating. It’s exhilarating.

It's—

I suck in a sharp, pained breath when a dry, thick finger penetrates me.

Not deep, but it's no matter. It hurts. And I wasn't ready for it. I wasn't...

I wasn't...

"Stop clenching and relax. It only hurts at first."

At that voice, my eyes fly open. I didn't even realize I shut them.

What...how...

I blink, taking in the swaying stalks of corn. Hair dances across my head, following the same breeze. *I'm not there. I'm not there...*

"...three, four..."

"Just like that..."

"You promised... you promis—"

LOCK THE DOOR! I physically jolt at the voice—the alarm—screeching in my head. I'm vaguely aware that there's no longer a finger forcing itself inside me.

"D-did you s-say something?" I hear myself whisper, cheek cradled by the dirt. I blink hard. My swallow is thick, and painfully slow to go down.

"Vale?" I hear myself say in a small voice. It's faint, hollow, like it's coming from miles away. "That's...it's you...right?"

Would it matter?

Just pretend it is and have a good time.

And there it is again, the voice of reason in my head.

A hand releases me, and suddenly fingers are being shoved in my mouth. Down my tongue toward my throat, forcing a gag from me as saliva floods my mouth. Bringing tears to my eyes as another hand squeezes my throat, lifting my upper body up.

The position is awkward, and my muscles, my limbs, they protest.

Hot, heavy breathing coasts over my ear, felt even through the mask. Or maybe it's just in my head. Like the scent of beer. Like the voice...*his* voice...

The mask digs into the side of my head. And against my ear, in a low, guttural voice, I hear six words I didn't know I would ever be grateful hearing. Six words that have the fight leaving my body, and my eyes falling shut in relief.

"You don't deserve to feel good."

It's the exact words he said to me over the phone the other night.

He waits a beat, and I don't really question why. Nor do I question why he seems to be vibrating with tension. *Is he...waiting for me to stop him? Stop this?*

Fat fucking chance.

So, I nod—jerky, desperate movements.

He takes it for the consent it is and tugs his fingers free of my mouth. I gasp, coughing. Drool clings to his fingers, dripping down my chin... the hand squeezing my throat tightens, sealing off my airway just as I go to say his name.

Wet fingers find my hole, and my body reflexively relaxes this time, granting him entry.

One thick digit turns into two. He's quick, rough, but efficient in getting me loose enough to beg him shamelessly for more. Loose enough that when he releases my throat, shoving me down face-first in the dirt and I hear the zip of his fly, all thoughts of that dark, unspeakable place in my mind are forgotten.

Loose enough—*just* enough—that when he drags me up by the hips, and I feel the blunt, sticky head of his cock nudging my opening, it's only relief I feel when he blows his way through whatever resistance was left, impaling me on his thick, long cock. Bringing forth a noise out of me, the likes of which I'm not even sure is human. It's all guttural and whimpery, and if I had any shame, I'm pretty sure I'd want to die from it.

His fingers grip my hips with enough pressure to bruise me, short blunt nails digging into my skin as he fucks into me hard and fast. Not bothering to wait for me to adjust.

And it hurts.

Fuck, does it *burn*.

He's so deep inside me, deeper than I've ever felt anything before. I'd be scared if it didn't feel so damn good. If I wasn't so hyper fixated on the fact that this is *Vale* splitting me into two.

Fuck me, little mouse. Fuck me like you mean it.

Show me exactly what I deserve.

As if he heard me, he pulls back, almost all the way out, before slamming into me, punching out a sharp yelp. Somehow I find myself on my knees, with my chest pressed flat to the earth, cheek scraping along dirt and dead, papery leaves and who knows what else. But I hardly notice.

Everything starts to feel hazy and yet *too much* as Vale starts hammering my prostate with quick, short, unforgiving thrusts.

It's punishing. Borderline cruel, the way he fucks me without mercy. Taking what he wants, not claiming me, but *owning* me...like I'm nothing more than a punching bag for him to let loose on.

Something for him to break.

Somewhere, in the back of my mind, a question rises—one I don't dare risk asking...

If I asked him to stop, go slower, be gentler...would he?

I'm not sure that I'm brave enough to find out the answer.

I'm not sure that I'd actually want him to, if he did ease up.

I'm not sure what that says about me...

That I know this *is* what I deserve.

I'm not sure I ever want to know the answers to any of that.

Suddenly, I'm heaved up against his broad chest. A hand splays against mine, right over my thundering heart, before sliding up to wrap around my throat. In my ear, he grits out, "Fuck you."

A smile crawls across my face—one that is crazed and all sorts of wrong. "Isn't that what you're supposed to be doing?"

Again, he seals off my airway, hitching my voice right as I finish speaking, trapping the breath in my lungs. Growling into my ear, he then says slowly, tightly, "I wanna. Hear you. *Beg.*"

With that, he wraps his other hand around my dick.

Strangling both that and my neck, he uses them for leverage when he fucks into me with short, deep, vicious thrusts.

My balls ache. My lungs are on fire. A scream builds in my stomach, gathering strength in my chest...only it has nowhere to go.

He twists the hand holding my cock, easing up ever so slightly. Warmth gathers hotly in my stomach as my vision darkens.

He grunts, his body tensing, telling me he's close. Really close.

Releasing my throat, he grabs me by the hair, roughly wrenching my head back just as he grounds his dick into me, this time not even bothering to pull out.

He just sits on my fucking prostate like it's his now. His property.

A strangled noise escapes my lips.

"Say it."

Back arched, chest heaving, spittle soaking my chin. “P-please,” I gasp at the moon, eyes wide and scalding with unshed tears.

“Please what?”

My vision blurs. *I can’t...I can’t...*

“Come on, sugar,” he growls. “Tell me what you really fucking want.”

My lips shiver as the word wrenches out of me, one I didn’t plan on saying. “Stop.” It’s practically inaudible. More of gasp than a word.

The fingers around my cock jolt, telling me he heard it. His thighs under my ass tremble, like it’s taking everything in him to stay still.

A long, heavy moment passes. Then—

“I wanna hear you scream it.”

A sob bursts from my lips. Where it came from, that word—that stupid, dreaded word that never got me anywhere—I have no idea.

“Scream it!” he all but shouts raggedly in my ear, shaking me.

He’s barely got the words out when I do just that. I scream. I scream, “STOP!”

His body trembles, the fingers loosening around my hair. I can feel his dick twitching inside me, swelling. *He’s coming*, I realize.

At my plea for him to stop.

That’s what sends him tumbling off the edge.

I wait for the hot silky warmth of his cum to fill me up, half dying for it, half...something else. Something I’m too scared to put a name to. Too scared to spare even a thought. Something that feels a lot like gratitude. Relief. Surprise...

But that’s not what happens.

He’s not gentle, not sweet. He leaves my body the same way he first entered me: Callously. Coldly. Mercilessly.

It doesn’t even register that he held it off. Not until a second later, when there’s a grunt, a groan, a full-body shudder behind me—

And wet warmth splashing my bare ass.

He pulled out.

He...

He stopped.

He came all over me...and yeah, it was me screaming for him to stop that sent him over the edge.

But he stopped.

The hold on my hair loosens, before tightening briefly—like a belated reflex—before disappearing completely. A glance down just before he shoves me away, shows my dick is only half-hard. But still flushed and shiny with pre-cum.

I fall to the side, landing in the dirt on my bare, cum-streaked ass, hand clawing at the dirt to catch me. A moment later, my mask lands in my lap.

I snap my head up, catching Vale's back just as the densely packed cornstalks swallow him up.

And I'm left here...

Alone.

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CHAPTER 34

ASTON

SOMEHOW, I eventually manage to find my way out of the maze from hell.

While that makeshift path proved useless, it *did* lead me closer to where I could actually hear signs of life—music, chatter, the slamming of car doors. Following the sounds as best I could, somehow, I find myself right where I started the night, in the parking lot of the Crowley-Whitmore Coal Company. The twinkling lights of the carnival welcoming me back.

So overcome with relief that I wouldn't die all alone surrounded by nothing but smelly corn and dirt and still trying to process what the fuckity fuck happened back there, it doesn't immediately register that trouble's a brewin'.

Or rather, it's already been brewed, and here I am, just waltzing in as tea-time commences.

A breeze blows through, tossing my hair about. In my pocket, there's a sudden series of vibrations—incoming messages.

Oh shit, what time is it? Freezing in place, I tuck my mask under my arm and dig out my phone. When I see it's only 9:58, I breathe a sigh of relief. Cutting it a little close...but we made it, that's all that matters.

It's only then I notice the number of missed calls and messages I have at the bottom, and my stomach plummets with dread. I must've not had service for a while.

Frowning, I pull up the calls first, seeing Eden rang me three times, and Tillie double that.

I'm about to check my messages, when a ragged sob-scream pierces the air. Snapping my head up, I frown when I spot the flashing red and blue lights.

“That’s not good,” I whisper, slowly approaching where everyone seems to be gathered at the entrance. There’s an ambulance. A firetruck, even though there doesn’t seem to be anything on fire. And cop cars. Three of them.

Scores of bodies gather around the entrance and various vendors in groups.

My first thought is: *Did the mine collapse?*

It takes two full sweeps of my surroundings before I spot Tillie and Walt near one of the police cruisers, chatting it up with two officers. Tillie is visibly distraught as she puts her phone to her ear, and my blood turns cold when it hits me.

Eden.

Where is he?

He called me and I didn’t answer...

I’m vaguely aware of my phone vibrating with an incoming call, but when a glance just shows it’s Tillie, I ignore it. Approaching her instead.

They’re going to kill me. Or send me back. I told them we’d stick together, and he met with some creep from the internet, and now he’s probably dead in a ditch and it’s all my—

I make it about halfway when—

“There he is!”

My steps slow to a stop as slowly all eyes turn toward me.

“Aston!” Tillie says, rushing over, and gripping me by the shoulders. Her wide, frazzled gaze searches all over my face, brow furrowing. “What happened to you? Where were you? What—”

“Eden,” I finally manage to get out, darting paranoid looks around me as people stare and whisper and give me a wide berth. “Is he okay? Where is he? Is—”

Hands cup my neck. “Are those...bruises?”

Blinking down at Tillie, I say more forcefully, “Eden.”

She darts her furrowed gaze between mine with an emotion I can’t place. “He’s right over there, Aston.”

I follow where she points, and the relief of seeing him alive and well is so overwhelming, I don’t immediately realize something’s amiss about him. Not until he must sense me staring and turns around. An icepack held up to his eye.

“What happened?” I mutter stiffly at the same time Tillie asks, “Aston...where were you?” Either she didn’t hear my question, or she’s ignoring it for the moment.

Swallowing around a bundle of nerves, I step back and wave a hand. “Oh, you know. Just went for a stroll. Needed some fresh air. Mines and me don’t really agree with each other.”

She closes her eyes, like she’s resigning herself to something. “Oh, Aston,” she says in a disappointed voice.

I stiffen. “Look, I’m sorry I left him. What hap—”

“Are you Aston Saint James?”

With a frown, I turn halfway toward the approaching officer, and say, “Depends...”

Tillie sniffs and backs a few steps away from me. “Just do as they say, okay? We’ll get this figured out. I know you didn’t—”

“Ma’am,” a different officer says, a warning clear as day in his voice. Walt sidles up next to his wife, and puts his arm around her, with a softly murmured, “Til.”

Our eyes meet over her head, and I don’t know what I was expecting to find, but disappointment wasn’t it. With a shake of his head, he looks down at his wife and leans down to whisper something for her ears only.

“Son, were you at any point down in the mines tonight?”

Looking at the officer, I narrow my eyes slightly. *Is he serious?* “Well, yeah. Isn’t that the point of tonight?”

He doesn’t look amused by my tone. He opens his mouth, but before he can say anything, a commotion draws everyone’s attention over to where EMTs are wheeling someone on a stretcher.

No, I realize a moment later as the lump on the stretcher comes fully into view. It’s not *someone*...not anymore, not really. It’s a body. A dead body. And whoever it was, is covered from head to toe by a white, red-stained sheet.

Cries fill the night, and I find myself searching the crowd, awareness prickling the back of my neck as I take in their glares and wary, fearful looks—all aimed at me—before doubling back and settling on a familiar looking vampire.

The one from the mine car I rode down with.

Her face is flushed and streaked with tears as she says something to the officer talking to her. Nodding, she lifts her finger and points. Right at me.

Or rather, what's in my hand.

The mask.

"What happened?"

Ignoring me, the officer next to me says, "Were you in the Chamber of Mirrors by chance?"

I blink. "Y-yeah." *Wasn't everyone at some point?*

"Can anyone account for your whereabouts for the last hour?"

I open my mouth, but quickly snap it shut when over his shoulder, a good distance away, stands Vale, watching me. His face is pulled taut, the tension visible even from here, his gaze dark and radiating something I can't name.

It feels a lot like a warning.

One I can't ignore.

I mean, how could I? Aside from the obvious, the dude looks like Satan himself right now. Between the small horns protruding from his forehead, the shadowy contour sharpening his stony features, and the black contacts swallowing up the whites of his eyes...

If I didn't have more important matters to attend to, I'd be a puddle in the dirt.

To think that's what was under the mask as he fucked me...

Wetting my lips, I drop my gaze to the ground and give the officer a small shake of my head.

With a sigh, he grabs my shoulder and roughly steers me toward the cruiser. "We're going to need you to come downtown to answer some questions."

"Am I under arrest?" I say blankly. In the background, I can vaguely hear Tillie arguing with someone. Saying something about my rights.

A beat passes. The hand gripping my shoulder tightens. "No...but I strongly suggest cooperating, so we don't have to do that here and traumatize your peers any more than they already are."

At that, I make a face, but quickly recover before he spots it.

Someone opens the door to the back of the police car, and with a palm to my head, I'm forced to duck so I don't hit my head as I climb into the back.

My chest squeezes, making it suddenly hard to breathe as the scent of stale cigarettes and grimy leather wash over me, taking me back to a time where I'd found myself in a similar situation.

Only I was cuffed.

And covered in blood.

Just before the door closes, I hear my name called out. Snapping my head up, I meet Tillie's wide eyes a handful of feet away. Her hands are clasped at her mouth.

I shrug and give her a small, shaky smile as if to say, *What can you do?*

She has to know it was only a matter of time before this happened. Whether or not I did whatever led to someone getting wheeled out of the mines in a body bag makes no difference. As always, my reputation proceeds me.

And trouble always finds me.

The door slams shut, and I flinch.

Moments later, two officers get settled up front. I'm dimly aware of the beeps and static of a radio as one of them rattles off numbers. The engine roars to life, and I'm told to buckle up.

I do as I'm told with numb fingers, ignoring the way they tremble.

As we pull out of the lot, I look out the window with a rock wedged in my throat that won't go away, no matter how many times I swallow.

Through the glass and mottled red and blue lights breaking up the shadows, my gaze catches on Vale's. It's as if time slows down, and in the back of my head I hear screaming.

His.

Mine.

The officer asks me a question, but I can't hear it over the whooshing roar in my head as memories of the past flicker forth, making it feel as if I'm underwater.

What did I do?

What did I do?

My breath hitches sharply, and I can feel myself slipping. The world slanting.

Vale's gone....

He's gone, he's *gone*.

He's letting me go...

The headlights sweep over the crowd, the vendors, the dark abandoned structures of the mine. We're just about to turn on the main road, when in a perfectly timed sweep of light, something catches my eye.

No, not something. *Someone*.

And it's so unexpected...so absurd, seeing him here...that it's enough to snap me out of my daze, replacing it with a swift rush of not only confusion, but anger.

What the actual fuck is he even doing here?

Why isn't he at Ashwood?

If the bleached white hair tumbling over his forehead didn't give him away, the tattoos covering his neck would have.

My lip curls on a snarl, as I bite out the name of the last person I ever expected to see again.

My archnemesis.

"Judas."

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CHAPTER 35

ASTON

THEY PUT me in a room with no windows.

Unless you count the mirror stretched across the wall to the right of where I sit, which we *all* know isn't there for vanity purposes.

It's been what feels like hours since the detectives interrogating me—sorry, I mean *interviewing*—got whatever they needed (see also: a whole lot of *nothing*) and abandoned me all to my lonesome.

Or so they'd like me to think...

I side-eye the “mirror”.

“*Do I need to call my lawyer?*” I'd asked the detectives after they sat down and introduced themselves. Because when one is brought in under suspicion of a crime—murder, especially—that is what one asks.

“*I don't know, you tell me. Do you need a lawyer?*” the cop who introduced himself as Detective Sergeant Lawson fired back oh so predictably. It was all I could do to not mouth along. Something told me they wouldn't appreciate that.

What followed from there was a headache-inducing string of vague, yet pointed questions thrown my way, met with a whole bunch of *no comments* and *I don't know*s from yours truly. Until eventually, *finally*, I learned just who it was that was killed tonight...and why they were so certain it was me.

After all, my reputation might proceed me, but it's all rumors. Some might be true, sure—there's always a little bit of truth wrapped in lies—but without a warrant or subpoena or whatever it is they'd need to access my file, ultimately they've got nothing.

Nothing but a convenient target for people to pin this on. That target being *moi*.

The victim's name meant nothing to me, and they saw as much when they asked what kind of relationship I have with Tim McPherson...*have* because this was before they confirmed he was in fact the one who met his untimely demise tonight.

A quite gruesome one at that. Something I'd learned after it was obvious I didn't know who the hell they were talking about—that or I was a *really good actor*, as I'm sure ran through their heads as a possibility—and they had no choice but to show me pictures.

First, of his school photo. Then of one of him, all sweaty and flushed in a burgundy leotard with the Archers' logo on the front, raising his fist into the air—apparently this Tim guy was kind of a big deal wrestling star.

It was at that moment I recognized him. It wasn't unlike how he looked earlier tonight in the mine car. Reeking of beer, and too cool for a costume.

The handsy asshole I poked and threatened with my knife.

Well, fuck me silly, I thought, *I might actually be screwed here*.

"So, you do know who this is," the detective taking lead said, not missing my reaction. And it was at that point his partner slid me a photo from the crime scene. One of Tim laying on his back in a pool of blood, throat slit ear to ear, eyes cracked open, vacant and unseeing.

Like Rick...

The detectives excused themselves not long after asking me where the knife was, visibly frustrated when I shrugged and told them I didn't know what they were talking about. *Talk about a blessing in disguise...*

Inwardly, I sent a silent thank you to the universe or whatever deity had decided I was worthy of some good luck and stripped me of my knife before I could be caught with it on my person. At what would quite literally be the *worst* possible time.

Now, it's just been a matter of waiting.

I might not know the ins and outs of the law outside of procedural shows and my own spotty history, but I'm *pretty* sure they need more than just hearsay to keep me. Secondhand hearsay at that, assuming Tim blabbed to his friends about what happened, and they're the ones who accused me.

How they figured out it was *me* under the mask...

I sigh, using my finger to draw a frowny face on the table.

Maybe it was...

Groaning, I flop forward, forehead meeting the cool metal table with a dull thud. I squeeze my eyes shut, and all I see behind my lids is vacant

dishwater-colored eyes. And blood. So much blood.

Sticky. Wet. Blood.

My breath hitches, sounding like a gunshot in the silence, the heavy kind I imagine is purposeful, the kind of quiet that will make a person go mad with their thoughts. Weakening them into submission so they'll cave and blab all their secrets.

It reminds me of my early days at Ashwood, before they mastered the art of dealing with me, when being thrown into the pit was a regular thing—locked in, sometimes strapped down. Left to fend for myself against the horrors that stalk my fractured mind.

And then there's even further back, to a time I don't really like to think about. Circumstances that are painfully similar to what's going on right now, where I found myself in a room not unlike this one, haunted by the image of unseeing eyes and red-soaked skin.

I roll my head so I'm resting my cheek to the table. My eyes lift to the one-way mirror, and the past flickers in and out with the present, as I watch my hand lift in a little finger wave.

Last time, they provided me with a snack. A juice box. Clean clothes and a blanket.

A sharp, sudden pain throbs behind my eyes. And for a moment, my vision seems to wink out completely.

"Don't," I moan faintly. Blinking rapidly, I swallow a couple times, willing the memories back. Willing myself to stay in the present. Willing myself not to think about the fact the walls seem to be closing in on me.

This isn't the same thing.

I'm not there.

And yet I can't ignore the tendril of doubt, the one that seems to have a direct line to the black hole in my head that, up until recently, I easily ignored. Pretended doesn't even exist.

I rub my finger furiously along the metal table. Smudging the face I drew. My knees bob a quick rhythmless beat, and I feel like I'm crawling out of my skin.

I need out of here.

What if they found the knife?

What if it's covered in Tim's blood?

It will have my fingerprints...

If you asked me earlier, however many minutes or hours or days have passed since I found myself in the back of a patrol car, I would've said *hell* to the *nah*. I didn't do this. I couldn't have. It's not possible.

I am innocent, I tell you! Innocent!

But as more time passes that takes me further and further away from what transpired in the fields...

A hell of an alibi, if there ever was one, might I add.

Oh, ya know, Officers, couldn't have been me. You see, while good ol' Tim was in the process of being unalived—poor sap—I was getting my prostate rammed by the town's star quarterback.

So, in the wise words of Shaggy—

It wasn't me.

Case closed.

But alas...I'm not really so sure I *didn't* do this anymore. The longer I sit here with nothing but my thoughts to occupy me with, the more I begin to wonder if perhaps my brain did that thing it's been known to sometimes do.

Glitch out.

Resulting in gaps of lost time...false memories...

It's happened before. Maybe even more times than I'm aware of.

But I try not to think about that: the fact that there is a chance the few good memories I hold on to from my past might actually have never even happened. That I just made them up to *cope*, as various shrinks of mine have so kindly suggested.

Because that would mean getting railed by Vale tonight was nothing more than a fantasy. One I fully immersed in to escape the memories of snuffing out someone's life..

Again...

Scowling, I bury my head in my hands, scrubbing my stinging eyes with my fists.

I bet Jude had something to do with this.

Set me up.

Or set me off...

Then again, though, who knows if he was actually even there? Probably just imagined him too. Why? Who knows. Maybe to find someone other than me to blame? Who better than the guy whose guts I hate.

"Ugh!" I scoff into my palms.

There I go again, sounding all rational and self-aware. Which means I probably *am* innocent this time.

But if I am...

Why am I still here? Why haven't they released me yet?

You know why.

My heart pounds. My vision grows shaky, dimming around the edges.

I find my arms slipping once more to my sides, hands dangling lifelessly. Cheek smushed to the table, I watch as the metallic surface clouds with steam from my breaths.

He didn't speak up last time, why would he now? a voice whispers in my head.

I screw my eyes shut. "One, two," I murmur shakily, "he's a comin' for you. Three, four..."

A door creaks open, and I can't tell whether it's real, or if it's the past gnawing on my brain. Ripping seams into my mind that reveal flickering images of splattered blood and deadened eyes, interspersed with me sitting in a room just like this.

"Can I have another juice box?"

"Where's Vale?"

"Is Vale okay?"

"What's going to happen to me?"

"I want to see Vale. He needs me. Why won't you let me see him?"

"VALE!"

A door closes, silencing the echoes in my head. Or maybe it slams. Locks. I think I hear voices, and I have to seal my lips together to trap the moan fighting to burst free.

Shaking my head, I plead silently, *Go away, go away.*

Under my breath I hum, and bounce my knees so fast and hard, the table rattles.

"You don't deserve to feel good."

My throat burns with the scream clawing to get out. Eyes aching with how tightly I seal them shut.

"...better lock the door."

Chair legs squeak across the floor. A thud. Then—

"Here."

I frown, blinking my eyes opens just in time to catch a deeply tanned hand placing a sealed water bottle inches from my face. I wet my dry lips

and waste no time sitting up and unscrewing the bottle, upending several gulps down my throat.

Lowering it, I sniff and wipe the back of my hand across my mouth.

“So, you’re Aston.”

Peering up from my lashes, I come face to face with the dark scrutinizing gaze of a man I recognize instantly.

My lips slowly rise, hand slowly lowering back to the table as I straighten. “And you’re Daddy Riviera.”

His brows spike from behind his thick dark frames. “You know who I am.” Not a question.

Nodding, I recline back in the chair, and cock my head, studying him. This is the first up-close look I’ve gotten of the man. I’ve only seen him a couple of times, and always from a distance. And the pictures online don’t do him justice.

Daddy Riviera is *fine*.

“Tell me,” he says quietly, tone unreadable. “Do I need to bring in reinforcements, or do you have yourself under control?” He gestures at his silky looking heather gray hoodie that stretches across his broad chest like a glove. “This is new.”

I narrow my eyes. And then I find my mouth twitching. His dark features remain smooth as ever, but I don’t miss the sharp, almost rueful glint in his eye.

A *lawyer*, I remember. I’d looked him up that night, after I got home from the party at the Furnaces after the Bell Game.

Quentin Riviera.

Certified genius.

Defense lawyer.

He must face off with crazies all the time. Probably gets a thrill out of it. Dissecting us...

“Tell *me*,” I toss back. “Are you here on official...or unofficial business?”

He tilts his head. “What do you mean?”

I spread a hand. “Are you here to counsel me?”

“Do you need counsel?”

“I suppose it would depend on who you ask.”

His eyes narrow, and I can practically see the wheels turning. A long moment passes before he says simply, “You didn’t do this.”

I blink. Then, “Well, *no shit*, Sherlock.” I scoff and force a laugh. One that is totally *not* unsteady. Not at all. “*Obviously* I didn’t do this.”

His face bunches ever so slightly. “You sound... relieved.”

I open my mouth, but before I can say anything, he clarifies, “Not the fact that you’ve been cleared, but that you really *didn’t* kill that boy.” A pause. “As if you worried that maybe you did.”

I say nothing. Pleading the fifth and all that jazz.

“My son—”

Why I flinch, I have no idea.

Okay, that’s a lie. I very much do have an idea. And it has everything to do with how Vale came to be his son.

Which, frankly, is still a little bizarre, knowing Quentin wasn’t even thirty years old when granted custody of a teenager.

I imagine being a genius, and a wealthy, successful one at that, helped his case. Otherwise, why would anyone in their right mind sign off on that?

Courts would sooner throw children back into shitty homes.

Quentin leans back in his chair, folding his arms across his chest. “That bothers you.”

“Are you my therapist, or are you my lawyer? Because I’ve got to tell you,”—my smile is sharp—“I’m all capped out on the first one.”

“I’m neither,” he says, not missing a beat. “Consider me being here a... favor.”

“Favor to who?”

“Vale.”

I rear back. I’m not sure what surprises me more, how easily he admitted it, or what it could mean.

“That surprises you.”

“Why...” My voice fails me.

“You were with him at the time of the murder, were you not?”

My eyes flick to the mirror across the room.

“The two-way’s off. It’s been off. As is the camera,” he says pointing toward the corner. I wait for a light to flash—any indication he might be lying—but nothing happens. “You’re free to go. I made sure of that. Your guardian is waiting out in the lobby. Legally, they cannot record us.”

He glances down at the water bottle I squeeze and crinkle distractedly between my palms.

“How long have I been here?”

“Just shy of two hours.”

I frown, lowering my gaze. “That’s it?”

In my periphery, he nods. “Time moves a lot slower in these rooms.”

That it does...

The silence in the room becomes deafening once more as I wait for him to say whatever it is he came here to say. Clearly, he came to see me for a reason, and not just to hydrate me and tell me I’m free to go.

“You didn’t think Vale was going to come forward, did you?”

I hesitate a beat, then shrug.

“Nor did you even attempt to clear your own name.”

My mouth twitches. “Aren’t you not supposed to say anything without a lawyer present?”

He tips his head, acknowledging that. “Fair. But you have an alibi. You could’ve told them what you were doing at the time of the murder. Or who you were with, so they could look into it. You could’ve avoided all of this.”

I snort lightly and meet his gaze. “Nah, I’m sure they still would’ve brought me in.”

He says nothing to that.

Jaw working, I return my gaze to the table, to the smudged frowny face I drew with my finger.

“Did you think Vale wouldn’t corroborate your story?” he asks curiously after a moment.

I suck my bottom lip between my teeth and lift a shoulder. “I wouldn’t blame him, if he didn’t.”

His gaze on me is sharp. Scrutinizing. It makes me fidgety. “Why’s that?”

Is he for real?

“If people knew about us...” I drag out pointedly, looking at him from under my lashes. “Well, I think it’s safe to say it would be social suicide for him.”

Quentin’s eyes flare with a mix of surprise and disbelief. “You’re telling me you’d go to prison for murder—a murder you didn’t commit—if it meant protecting Vale’s *social standing*.”

Shifting in my seat, I roll my shoulders, trying not to notice how thin the air suddenly feels. Or the way the walls seem to be closing in once more. As if whatever relief Quentin’s arrival and finding out I in fact did *not*

commit murder tonight—or hallucinate what happened in the field—was short-lived.

Just a temporary relief—a distraction—from the awareness thickening my blood like sludge, keeping it from flowing properly.

My palms grow slick. My neck tingles. There's a lump the size of a mountain in my throat, making it feel impossible to swallow. And I'm once again acutely aware of where I am.

I eye the door, wondering if it's still locked from the outside.

"Aston."

Blinking up at Daddy Riviera, I say quietly, in a small voice I wouldn't believe is mine if I didn't feel how the words pushing their way out of me, scraping my insides, "I'd do anything for him."

The truth of my statement hangs over us, suspended in the thick stillness pressing in around us. Quentin's face slackens with something akin to surprise. Hell, it surprises me too.

It's brief though—the shock. It lasts only as long as it takes for me to register what I just said, before I'm quickly, mentally shaking off the weird...whatever that was. And he's all back to business.

"Why?"

The answer appears in my head instantly, one I refuse to acknowledge out loud.

Because he has a future. I don't.

I give Quentin a slow, rakish grin and say, "Because I'm trying to woo him. Obviously."

His brows flare slightly at that.

"This will certainly get me some brownie points," I go on, shoving back my seat. Hopping to a stand, my body stiff and aching from sitting for so long, I run my fingers through my hair to try and expel some of the built-up restless energy buzzing through them.

I flick a suspiciously silent Quentin a pointed look, not missing the unreadable scrutiny there as he watches me closely. "I don't know if you've noticed," I tell him. "but your son...he's a tough nut to crack. Really likes to play the whole hard to get thing."

Wiping my jittery hands on my robe, I use the other to grip my water. "Anyway," I say cheerily, "can I go now? I'm hungry. My head hurts. And if I have to spend one more minute in this insufferable room, I might end up going to prison for murder after all."

Not waiting for permission, I rush toward the door, desperate to get out of these close confines. There's a sigh, followed by the tell-tale screech of a chair scooting across the floor. And just as my fingers curl around the handle, his voice halts me. "You need to be careful, Aston."

I still.

"There's not much my son wouldn't do for you either."

Frowning, I cast him a look over my shoulder. I don't even get a chance to appreciate what it is he's implying, because the wariness attached to his words is far too potent and nerve-wracking to ignore. Not to mention the leery sort of reluctance pinching his eyes as he watches me.

My heart rate spikes. "You say that like it's a bad thing."

You don't deserve to feel good...

Quentin grips the back of the chair, lowering his gaze. "I just...I don't want to see him...lose himself. Do you understand?"

"Are you saying I should stay away from him?"

He tilts his head, giving me a knowing look. "Would you, if I asked you to?"

The handle creaks in my grip. "Sounds like you already know the answer to that."

He hums, eyes narrowing. "I can see why he's fixated on you."

I make a face at that. Even I'm self-aware enough to know it's the other way around.

His lips twitch with a small, humorless smile. "You haven't figured it out, have you?"

"Figured out what?" There's no missing how tight my voice has gotten..

Quentin straightens, not taking his searching gaze from mine as he turns and crosses his arms, fully facing me. "You'd think after spending all these years at Ashwood, you'd spot it from a mile away."

I blink. "Spot...what?"

"Vale...he's a good liar. When he wants to be. When he has enough motivation to be." He inhales a breath, before expelling it sharply. "Perhaps it's because he's never had reason to hide from you, that you don't see it. The show he puts on for the rest of the world. You just see him exactly as he is. As he's always been."

My hand falls away from the door handle, and I roll my shoulders back, angling toward him more fully. "I don't understand."

He arches a knowing brow. "You sure about that?"

Curiosity spikes. But so does irritation. Jealousy. How dare he insinuate that he knows Vale better than me?

Is that what he's saying though? a voice helpfully points out.

I work my jaw, eyeing Quentin warily. "And you don't? See him as he is, I mean."

He tips his head in acknowledgement. "I see as much as he allows me."

Something in me purrs in satisfaction at that. Sensing my smugness, he huffs a humorless laugh, and removes his glasses, pinching the bridge of his nose.

"He was mine first," I blurt before I even realize what it is I'm doing.

Quentin stills. Slowly, he replaces his glasses and resumes his stoic position, arms crossed over his chest. Where I was hoping I'd find confusion or anger, or better yet, hurt...all I find is pity.

And I hate it. Despise it. It pisses me off more than I already am.

"Did you know Vale didn't talk for over a year after that night?" he asks out of nowhere.

I tense at the mention of *that night*. But then what he's saying registers, and I straighten to attention, arms dropping to my sides. "Not at all?"

"Not while he was awake," he says in a pointed manner. Then, almost reluctantly, he adds, "He'd call for you in his sleep sometimes." His voice is almost...gentle when he tells me that.

My eyes grow wide with shock.

Quentin's brow furrows, head cocked as he searches my face. What he's looking for, I could only guess. "I never told him. I don't think he knows," he admits.

I swallow audibly.

"It's a bad idea," he tells me, eyes creased with something akin to regret. "You two. You have to know that."

I smile ruefully. "Because we were foster brothers?"

"Because he's a psychopath."

I roll my eyes. "Actually, no, I'm not. They ruled that out—wait, *what???*" My smirk falls, along with my jaw, landing somewhere on the floor.

Quentin watches me steadily, pointedly, going on as if he didn't just drop a grenade on my nuts. "And there's nothing more dangerous than a psychopath with unresolved trauma."

I stare at him for a long beat, before blinking a couple times. “That’s not...”

He cocks a brow. “Not true? Because I can assure you—”

I shake my head, cutting him off. “No. No, I mean he’s not...” My voice trails off, failing me as the denial I’ve built in my head crumbles in record time.

Memories upon memories surge forth all at once—those that I still have from back then—from *before*, that is. Safe ones. And more recent ones...

Annndddd cue the, “Oh. *Oh*,” heard around the world.

“Well, fuck me in the ass,” I breathe, awe-struck. Quentin coughs. “That explains a lot,” I murmur faintly, thinking back on our last few encounters.

“You can understand now why—”

Tuning Quentin out, I pinch my lip between my thumb and forefinger as I pace back and forth across the room, running through all that’s transpired. “How did I not *see* this? I mean, okay, to be fair, I can be a little dense. But wow, wow, this is—”

“He can’t love you.”

I freeze, halting mid-step, words dying in my throat. Face bunched up, I turn my head, leveling Quentin with a withering glare.

His eyes widen, and he holds up a hand. “Not because of you...because of *him*. Because of the way his brain works.” At my scowl, he says gently, “Aston...he can’t empathize, he can’t feel remorse...both of which are needed to sustain a healthy, long-lasting relationship. His ability to connect—to relate to other people—is surface-level at best. He can’t—”

I’m shaking my head. “Doesn’t matter.”

“Doesn’t it though?”

I turn fully on him. “No. It doesn’t. You have no idea what you’re talking about.”

Quentin opens his mouth, but I’m not done, so he smartly shuts his trap.

“It took you over a year to get him to talk? It took me less than two months.” At the widening of his eyes, I say, “Yeah, the whole mute thing? Didn’t start because of me. It’s just who he is. It’s just one of his quirks. We’ve all got ’em. Sometimes, I black out and st—” My gaze flicks to the mirror. “*Stroke* people.”

Quentin gives me a what the fuck look.

“And sometimes he just doesn’t feel like chit-chattin’.” I shrug. “I don’t know about you, but given the choice between,”—I mouth *murder*—“and

silence...you might be warning off the wrong party here.” I hold up a hand. “Not that I want you to warn him off. For the record.”

“Noted,” he murmurs dryly.

I cross my arms and jut out my chin. “As if he’d even listen to you.”

“Confident, are we?” There’s something underlying his voice I can’t pinpoint. He sounds...amused, almost. Like he’s just humoring me.

“I know it might come as a shock to you, *Quentin*—can I call you Quentin?—but once upon a time, I had Vale wrapped around my itty bitty finger.” I twirl a digit in the air. “Didn’t you just say yourself, there’s not much he wouldn’t do for me?”

He dips his chin. “I did.” He pauses meaningfully. “But it’s not out of love, Aston.”

“Then what is it?”

“Hubris.”

I open my mouth. Close it.

“And when his pride is on the line? When his ego is put on the chopping block? There’s no telling what he’ll do. No limit to the lengths he’ll go to eradicate whatever it is he felt threatened or wronged by.” He sighs. “It blinds him to what is right and wrong. Makes him reckless in a way that is dangerous for everyone.”

I tilt my head. “Why are you telling me all this? Won’t Vale be pissed?”

“Oh, I’m sure he will. I’m not too worried though.”

“Why’s that?”

“Because he wasn’t hiding it from you to begin with.”

I narrow my eyes. “Are you saying he...*wants* me to know he’s a... psychopath?”

Damn, that’s going to take some getting used to.

The last so-called psychopath I met was some kid named Ollie at Ashwood. He was only ten years old, and he was admitted after attempting to murder his little sister. Something he bragged about to anyone who’d listen.

Dude was a *freak*.

And then one day he was just gone. Rumor had it he was transferred to a juvenile detention center, or Baby Prison as I liked to call it.

“He doesn’t *not* want you to know,” Quentin says in an unreadable tone. “Truthfully? I think he’s lonely. Even psychopaths crave companionship. I imagine it must be exhausting always having to fake it.”

I shake my head, the ache in my head getting more unbearable by the second. “So, which is it? Do you want me to stay away or get closer?”

He quirks a brow. “Didn’t we already establish you’re not walking away?”

When I say nothing to that, he goes on, “Like I said before, I’m worried. All it would take is one step in the wrong direction for him to sabotage everything. He’s got his entire future ahead of him. As do you.”

I look away at that.

“You *do*, Aston,” Quentin says emphatically. “I know you might be... hesitant to reach for it, and tonight didn’t help matters, but—”

“What do you know about any of it?” I snap, glaring at him. “Since when do you care about me?”

He flinches. It’s so subtle I nearly miss it.

Gotcha.

I mock-gasp, rounding my eyes. Tapping a finger to my lips, I say, “Oh, did I forget to mention I know your little secret?”

His mouth thins. “You looked me up.”

I smirk. “Does Vale know what you did? Does he know the real reason why you adopted him? Does he—”

“Yes.”

My mouth slams shut, and I straighten. Then, “He does?” I eye him warily up and down.

“Why do you think I moved us here? Why I got away from all that, and went private?”

I frown.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t do more for you,” he says with a surprising amount of sincerity. “I really am. What happened to you...”

Grinding my teeth, I say, “Don’t.” Our gazes lock, and I make sure he sees just how serious I am. If he keeps pushing, I won’t be held responsible for my actions. “You don’t want to go there.”

For a long moment, we just stare at each other.

Finally, he nods. “Just keep what I told you in mind, okay? Consider this my...Hail Mary.”

I frown. “What does religion have to do with any of this?”

His lips twist. “It’s a football term. A last ditch effort born out of desperation. I figured if I couldn’t scare you away, I could at least...inform

you. Prepare you, so you're not blindsided when things inevitably go sideways."

"Why are you so certain it will end badly for us?"

He smiles but it doesn't meet his eyes. "Because if there's one thing I've learned in my years defending people like Vale, people like *you*...it's that some truths should never see the light of day. And my fear is that the closer you two get," he goes on to finish ominously, "the harder it will be to keep them buried in the dark."

A chill skitters down my spine, and a dull throbbing has taken residence behind my eyes. Turning away, I screw up my face and give a quick shake of my head. Ignoring the way my heart pounds faster, and the floor beneath my feet ripples

Three...four...

You better lock the door...

A hand grips my shoulder, squeezing. "Aston."

I suck in a sharp breath.

When the hell did he move?

Flinching away from him, I mutter, "Go away." I can't even be sure if my words are for him, or that...*thing* inside me.

Just as I open the door, he says, "I'm sorry for pushing. Just...consider what I said, okay? After everything you two have been through, I'd hate to see you hurt, either of—"

I cut him off with a scornful laugh. Peering over my shoulder, I say, "Did you ever think that maybe that's exactly what I deserve?"

His eyes widen in shock, and I want to take the words back instantly. I don't even really know where they came from—what place they were wrenched, raw and ragged. It's not as if I feel...guilty for killing Rick.

Hell, it's thanks to me Vale's got himself this nosy busy-body of a daddy—a real DILF too, but that's beside the point—meddling in our affairs.

At least one of us has a future.

If only we could share it...

The walls around me shiver. My skin grows cold and clammy.

"And Vale?" Quentin says from what feels like miles away. And still, despite how far away from my body I suddenly feel, our eyes remain locked when he asks, "What does he deserve?"

One beat passes.

Two...

Tearing my gaze from him, I throw open the door to leave. But not before vomiting up one last piece of honesty. Another hidden truth I know better than to lend any attention to.

And yet somehow, I find myself handing it right over to Quentin as if he could take it off my hands.

“A choice.”

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CHAPTER 36

VALE

AS I WAIT for Quentin outside the police station, I absently scroll through social media, taking in all the shocked, grief-stricken, and, of course, conspiratorial posts about what happened tonight.

Tim McPherson.

I didn't know the guy beyond his name and the fact he was a senior and on the wrestling team. He might as well have not existed until tonight, as far as I'm concerned.

Now, as a dead guy, he's more popular than ever. A friend of everyone's. A nice guy. The life of the fucking party, with a smile that could light up a room.

I snort under my breath, locking my phone. Reaching for the dial on the radio, I crank up the volume to the SH4RD song playing through my phone's Bluetooth.

Leaning back, I roll my head around until I feel a satisfying pop in my neck. I crack my knuckles next and inspect my nail beds for any lingering traces of dirt.

It's now been two hours since the body of a Grady Prep senior was found slain in the mines.

A little over an hour since Quentin drove me to the station.

Twenty minutes, give or take, since I gave my statement, clearing not just Aston's name, but my own. *Not that I was even on the radar as far as possible murder suspects go...*

After I was dismissed, Quentin handed me the keys to his Navigator—he drove us together—and told me to wait in the car while he hung back to make sure everything was sorted out in a timely manner.

Nothing like the threat of a damn good defense attorney to get the ball rolling. Otherwise, Aston would've likely been kept here overnight, under the guise of *paperwork*. Any excuse to make their failure to adequately investigate a crime feel worth the time. As if it's his fault they jumped the gun.

From the moment they pulled up at the mines, people started pointing fingers, all too happy to provide the cops with every bit of gossip they'd heard since Aston's arrival.

"I heard he pulled a knife on someone at a party! Who does that? It has to be him."

"I heard he murdered his own father. Stabbed him over a hundred times. In the FACE."

"Yeah, he pulled a knife on me once. Even drew blood before I was able to disarm him. I was so badass."

"Someone told me that he was sent to Ashwood because he tortured and killed kittens as a kid. And everyone knows that's the first warning sign of a psychopath!"

"My uncle's best friend's girlfriend's brother works at Ashwood. Said they should've never let that monster loose."

"He's cute...but he's also kind of scary. Definitely scary. Way more scary than cute."

"He doesn't have any friends. He's a freak."

It also didn't help that, apparently, Aston had a small altercation with the victim earlier tonight. At least, according to some chick's social media post.

He pulled a knife on him! Threatened him while we were riding down into the mines. Tim thought maybe it was a fake knife, so he didn't take it too seriously. Tim didn't deserve this! No one

does!! Aston St. James needs to be locked up for life!!! He's a threat not just to his town, but to humanity as a whole.

I'd rolled my eyes extra hard at that last part.

Last I looked, the post was already shared over fifty times. Commented on at least a hundred.

And the ironic thing is the girl doesn't even go to Grady Prep. She's from Crowley High. But apparently she's dating a friend of McPherson's. A friend, who was happy to back her story up, along with the others who apparently shared the same mine car.

How they knew it was Aston under his costume, I have no idea. They didn't say. Maybe he didn't wear the mask going down. Or he gave himself away somehow. Or it was just a damn good guess, seeing as there's only one knife-wielding whack job living in Crowley.

Or so everyone thought...

And it's not like he's ever pulled that thing out at school, with the exception of when I ran into him in the bathroom weeks ago. Otherwise, he would've been long gone before tonight. He's an idiot, but he's not as oblivious and careless as he makes himself out to be—that much I've gathered.

No, he sealed his fate the night at the Furnaces, after the Bell Game. Before he even started going to school with us. And while the guys and I did our best to get all video evidence of what went down that night removed from witnesses' phones, it's only a matter of time before someone can't help themselves and broadcasts it across the internet, regardless of the risks to the team.

"How are you so certain it wasn't him?" Quentin had asked when I called him after the cops let everyone go, shifting immediately into lawyer mode and playing devil's advocate. He knew as well as I did that it was highly unlikely this was Aston's doing.

I was supposed to head to the Furnaces but lied and told my friends I had to run home first. Figuring by the time they realize I never showed, they'd be too wasted to care...

"THE VICTIM'S THROAT WAS SLIT," I say into the empty car, stalling.

“And Aston wouldn’t do that because...” Quentin’s voice filters through the speakers.

“It’s too...organized. Planned. Whoever did this wanted to kill as quickly and efficiently as possible.”

“You know that won’t be enough to clear him. He needs an alibi,” Quentin tells me pointedly, his tone almost gentle, like he knows where this is heading. Why else would I have called him if I wasn’t one-hundred percent confident he could help.

Jaw working, hands squeezing the wheel, eyes fixed in a glare on the narrow, empty back road, I tell him succinctly. “He has one. Me.”

I floor the gas, the engine surging, tires squealing—

BACK IN THE parking lot of the police station, movement up ahead catches my attention through the windshield. Pulling me from my thoughts just in time to see Quentin emerge from the brick building and cross the lot toward me.

Dressed in simple jeans and a sweatshirt, you’d never suspect he’s a cutthroat lawyer who probably just robbed Crowley’s finest of all their fun.

After all, it’s not every day someone gets murdered in cold blood. Not here. This is probably the most exciting thing to happen in this town in decades.

The car dings when Quentin opens the driver side door. Lowering the music, I reach behind me for the belt and buckle up. Quentin doesn’t immediately do the same once the door’s shut. For a long moment he just sits there, hands lightly gripping the top of the steering wheel, staring introspectively ahead.

My eyes narrow slightly. “All good?”

It takes him a moment to respond. Nodding slowly, he says, “Yeah, he should be out any minute.”

Before that can happen, he shifts the SUV into drive and pulls us out of the lot. Buckling as he slows to a stop, he cuts me a sideways glance, before making a wide left onto the main road.

If he was expecting me to object, and tell him to wait, he’ll be sorely disappointed. The last thing I want right now is to see Aston.

Sure about that?

Jaw tightening, I look out the passenger side window, watching the world pass by as I kick that line of thinking right the fuck out of my head.

It's late, the streets mostly empty, save for where some are parked along the curb of the few bars and restaurants positioned along this stretch of town. Light posts cast the night in a golden sheen.

Music continues to play quietly, one song giving way to another. When we pull into our development minutes later, Marilyn Manson is crooning about maggots putting on shirts and selling shit, and the world feels eerily empty of everyone and everything.

Our sprawling gray and black brick three-story sits dark, with the exception of the spotlight over the three-car garage kicking on when we pull into the concrete driveway. He waits for the middle door to fully open before easing in and parking, killing the engine, and with it the music.

It's only then that Quentin breaks the silence. "I met with Aston."

I still, relaxing my hold on the seat belt I'd just unbuckled. It snaps back into the retractor with a loud *whoosh* and *snick*. "Why?" He was only supposed to ensure he got released. That's it.

Removing his glasses, he polishes them off on his sweatshirt. "I was curious." He must sense my waning patience, because he sighs and adds, "I wanted to get a feel for his intentions with you."

For a long moment, all I can do is stare at his profile.

Barking a short, disbelieving laugh, I say, "Are you serious? I..." I turn toward the windshield without really seeing anything. "I don't even know what to say to that."

"You know what I mean," he says, voice laced with a dry sort of amusement.

"Do I? Because all I'm picturing now is you pulling a shotgun on Aston and threatening him with bodily harm if he hurts me." I huff, shake my head, and run my fingers through my hair. "Talk about ridiculous for a number of reasons."

"I just...I worry."

The mood sobers, the air thickening with tension.

"Whatever you think is going on between us, you're wrong," I say tightly.

"Oh, and tonight was what, then?" he says, completely unfazed by the unspoken warning in my tone.

I take a long moment before I'm able to respond, unsure even how to explain it. I'm still reeling myself. What happened earlier, in the fields... what we did, what *I* did...

Or rather, what I didn't do.

As it would turn out, it's one thing to *want* to break someone wholly and irrevocably. To fantasize about it. To crave it.

It's another to act on it when faced with the reality of such a choice.

And once I realized what it would take to destroy him—what I would have to do to rid him from my life for good, and that doesn't involve snapping his neck—I just couldn't go through with it.

I know I *could* have, but I didn't.

I didn't *want* to.

Not because of a sudden shift in conscience—I don't have one of those.

No, it's far simpler and more selfish than that.

I might like the thrill of the chase, the hunt—the whole salacious taboo nature of it all—but at the end of the day, if my prey isn't giving as good as they get, I want no part of it.

I don't need to rely on force to get laid. The day I cross that line is the day I deserve to be put the fuck down like a dog. You don't need to have empathy to draw that line in the sand—self-respect should be enough of a detriment.

Which is why the second I felt the shift in Aston's demeanor—felt him shutting down and slipping away from me—I cranked up the intensity and demanded him to tell me what he wanted.

It wasn't a conscious decision, testing him like that—testing us both. By the time I realized what had happened, what I'd done, how far I took things...I'd already pulled out, and was watching my cum dribble down his crack. Pooling around his puffy red hole.

There would've been no coming back from that...

If I didn't listen...if I kept going...

I think I needed him to tell me to stop, as much as he needed me to respect his wishes.

I needed us to reach our breaking point.

"Vale?" Quentin says, reminding me he asked a question.

"Closure. I think," I find myself saying, surprising us both with the honesty. I shake my head. "Maybe? I don't know. I just... He wouldn't give up. He wasn't going to, not without me doing something...drastic." I grimace as soon as the words leave me. It sounds like I planned what went down tonight. And I didn't.

I just wanted to have a little...fun.

After all, it's not every day I get the chance to drop the act and blow off some steam, without worry of consequence. I figured if Aston's stupid enough to not steer clear of me—I've given him plenty of reasons to—then I might as well test how far I could take it.

I felt it tonight—that thread inside him, the one that if I snapped it, there'd be no recovering. It was in the tremble of his body. In the wetness coating my fingers—his *tears*.

It surprised me, just how easy it was to overpower him so completely, and so quickly.

I can admit I was hoping for a little more...resistance in getting to that point. A little more fight. Somehow, though, by hardly any effort of my own, I was able to lure him into the most perfect storm of a situation for his demons to slip through the cracks and unleash on him.

Priming him for me.

So, that by the time I got my hands on him, he was nothing but a crying, breathless, panicked mess, mumbling nonsense to himself. Clearly on the verge of spiraling into what I assume would've been one those volatile blackouts Quentin mentioned weeks ago.

Something I've been so, so curious to witness for myself.

Who does he become—what does he become—when that wall hiding all the secrets he keeps from himself comes down?

Who is Aston when he isn't wearing his armor of lies?

"He seems to be under the impression you're in a relationship," Quentin says in an unreadable voice, returning my focus to the conversation.

I roll my eyes. "He's delusional."

A moment passes, before he asks softly, "Did you hurt him?"

My lips twitch. "Only a little more than he wanted."

If my adoptive dad's horrified, or even shocked by that statement, he doesn't show it. He just nods. "That's probably for the best." He pauses meaningfully. "Seeing as he's not the monster you hoped he was."

Stiffening, I narrow my eyes. "What the hell is that supposed to mean?"

Again, unfazed by the creeping threat of violence edging my tone, thickening the air, he turns an arched brow on me. "It means exactly how it sounds."

I curl my lip, but he's quick to cut me off before I can speak.

"I truly don't think he's out to punish you. In fact, I'm even so far willing to go to say I don't think he holds any ill will toward you at all."

“If anything, that makes it worse,” I all but growl, though I’d already come to this conclusion weeks ago. *What the fuck did Aston say to him?*

Quentin acts as if I hadn’t spoken. “The only person I think Aston St. James wants to punish...” he goes on slowly, contemplatively, “is Aston St. James.”

I open my mouth to protest, only for what he said to fully register before I get the chance. Stealing whatever it is I wanted to say.

This...this didn’t occur to me. Not once. But it probably should have... right?

Quentin nods slowly, like he figured as much. He searches my gaze closely, and I bite back a scoff. If he’s expecting any sort of empathy to magically appear, he’s going to be sorely disappointed. And he’ll have done it to himself. He knows better than to expect the impossible.

“Is that supposed to make me feel better?” I eventually say.

“I don’t know, Vale. You tell me.”

Lips pressed tightly together, I say nothing. Because, truth is? It does.

It does make me feel better. Not because I sympathize, but because that means I was right about him digging his own grave. I just miscalculated the level of conscious intent behind it.

My mind travels back to earlier in the clearing, when I had him on his knees, and he seemed so torn...so at war with what he wanted and what he was feeling and what his instincts were telling him.

It was a visceral thing. How badly he wanted my touch...how badly he craved it...the pleasure, the pain...

How badly he also wanted it all to stop.

It wasn’t like that day in the locker room, when he got off on the thrill of it. The fear, even when he couldn’t breathe. No, tonight something... something shifted. I felt the shift when it happened.

But he fought it, fought it until I extracted it in a ragged scream into the night.

“*STOP!*”

That was the moment. The moment I could’ve broken him once and for all, just by the simple act of *not* listening.

But if what Quentin said before is true...

“You want to know what I think,” he says.

Massaging my temples, I mutter, “Do I have a choice?”

“Not really.”

I roll my eyes.

“I think Aston wants so badly to believe himself capable of hurting someone. That he’s a monster, with no chance of redemption.” He pauses. “Why do you think that is?”

I drop my head back against the seat. “You just said so. He wants to punish himself.”

“But for what?” he says. “It’s not as if he killed anyone to begin with.”

Everything seems to still—time, the air around us, the world outside...

Me.

Quentin.

As if the truth of his statement, put out there, just like that, grabbed hold of everything, and we’re all bracing for the moment it throws us off a cliff.

Slowly, so slowly, I turn to face Quentin. Head cocked, I say in a deceptively soft voice, “You know why.”

This time, I don’t miss the flicker of unease in his dark gaze. There and gone faster than I can blink, but it was there. He’s not as unflappable as he likes to believe he is.

He’s still...human.

And unlike when he’s facing off with criminals he’s been tasked to defend, there’s no chains or cuffs here. No guards or what have you standing by, just close enough in the event the person Quentin’s trying to help decides to hell with it and fights back.

There’s just this too-small space between us.

There’s just him and me.

And for as much as I’m...grateful toward him. As much as I respect him, and feel a bit like I owe him—because I do...

He knows as well as I do that there is a switch that exists inside me, just as there’s one in everybody. Him included.

The difference is, I know where to find it.

And I’m not scared of the dark. Or the silence. The emptiness.

If anything I see better, stand stronger, when I give myself to the void.

I always have.

Quentin clears his throat, averting his gaze. “The night Rick died,” he goes on casually, a beat quicker than his usual cadence. “You told me you let Aston take the fall because you didn’t want to get in trouble.”

Relaxing some, I nod. This we can talk about. Before, he was getting dangerously close to crossing the line. I could almost praise him for

retreating so quickly. For not trying to...pry.

"Was that a lie?" he asks me.

I frown, and cock my head, considering that for a long moment. "No, not completely," I tell him honestly. "I told you how...in the moment, when everything was happening, I sort of...shut down."

He nods. "You lost control of the situation. Your anger. You went into shock."

"I did." I try not to bristle at the memory. *Such weakness...* "And I didn't know how to handle it."

In my mind, a movie plays out. One of me doing what needed to be done, quickly and efficiently. Only for everything to go to shit, because Aston wasn't like me, and at that age I didn't quite yet grasp that most people *weren't*...like me.

After all, given what Aston did prior to that night...

Was it so far as a stretch to assume he'd be as monstrous as me?

"Later though, you had a chance to come clean," Quentin goes on. "Especially when it was made pretty clear Aston wouldn't be charged with murder. What you did was out of self-defense." We share a knowing glance at that. "What he did after was a result of a psychotic break."

Again, I nod. We've discussed all this, back when I confided in him two years ago. Confessing to what really happened the night Rick died.

Yes, Aston stabbed him numerous times.

What no one but Quentin knows is that Rick was already dead before Aston so much as grabbed a shard of the mirror I broke.

He mutilated a fresh corpse. That was his only crime that night.

"It's so obvious now, I don't know how I didn't see it sooner." Quentin meets my furrowed gaze head-on, features creasing in a way that makes me think he...pities me. "You wanted to punish him. Even back then. And not just for making the situation worse that night." He quickly holds up a hand when he senses he's veering dangerously close to the point of no return here. "I'm just stating a fact. That I didn't realize."

Jaw working, I eye him warily for a long second, before finally nodding. Accepting that.

"I think in a roundabout way," Quentin goes on gently, "you gave Aston exactly what he needed that night. What he's needed ever since."

Seeing my confused expression, he clarifies, "Justification."

The wheels are uncharacteristically slow to spin in my head, as what he's saying, what he's implying fully sinks in.

Justification...

He needed a more palatable reason to hate himself.

Unsure what to do with this new morsel of information—a piece to the ever-changing, nonsensical puzzle that is Aston St. James—I turn to fully face forward. Gazing unseeingly out the windshield.

“I suppose it's...lucky for you then,” Quentin says carefully, maintaining a light tone, “that he's more than willing to be your punching bag.”

Throat squeezing, fists clenching in my lap, I force out, “Maybe that's all he's good for.”

“Or maybe that's just the lie you tell yourself, to avoid facing the fact you do care about him. Still. Despite everything.”

My shoulders tense, everything in me turning to stone. “I do not *care* about Aston. I never did.”

“Says the person who not only killed a man for him—”

I whip my head around. “That was then. And I didn't do it for him.”

Quentin watches me, before continuing as if never interrupted, “Says the person who saved him from being arrested for murder tonight.”

“I told you he didn't do it.”

He smiles thinly. “And yet you could've let him hang. We both know his alibi, the one you backed up, is all that saved him. Innocent or not. The detectives working the case, the entire police force... they were *dead set* on it being him.”

I know...

“You could've been free of him. With no risk to you.”

I know this too.

Teeth snapping shut, I stare hard at Quentin for a long, measured beat. Then—

“Maybe I'm not done playing with him yet.”

Quentin's brows spike in shock.

“Maybe I want him to suffer a little bit more.” My mouth curves into a cruel, icy smile. “Like you said, he's more than willing to take it. I'm just giving us what we both want. What we need.”

Quentin's face hardens, and he lifts his chin a bit. “Vale...” he says warningly.

"I'm done with this conversation," I say flatly, and open the car door. Slamming it behind me. The mechanism for the garage door kicks on, just as I heard Quentin do the same.

I get three steps toward the door to the mudroom, when his next words halt me in my tracks.

"You can't rewrite the past."

Not looking back at him, I say, "You think I don't fucking know that?"

"For as much as you wanted him to pay back then," he goes on, his steps slow as they approach me, "be it consciously or unconsciously at the time...I can't help but think some part of you missed him. Your friend. The boy who was like a brother too."

The garage door seals shut, but not before letting a breeze slip through. One that washes over me, bringing a prickly chill to the back of my neck. At my side, my fingers curl into tight, white-knuckled fists.

"He was never my fucking brother," I all but growl.

Quentin tips his head in acknowledgment. "What I'm saying is, I can't fault you for trying to get rid of all the good memories, just to make hating him feel more warranted." He pauses meaningfully. "But you know as well as I do, that revisiting the scene of a crime never works out for anyone who has something to hide."

Walking around me, he lifts his hand as if to touch my shoulder—give it a squeeze—but hesitates, letting it hover in the air for a second, before coming to some decision and dropping it.

Smart man.

"You're playing with fire, Vale. You both are. And I know you know that, which is why I can't help but wonder if there are some truths you've also been hiding from yourself. Ones you still might not be ready to face." He pauses a beat. "Ones that, I can honestly say I fear might not be worth the risk of ever embracing. For either of you. Because if you continue down this path..."

Pushing open the door to inside, he flips on the overhead light, letting his words trail off, their meaning hanging unspoken.

If I continue down this path, I will have no choice but to confront it all. Not only me, but Aston...

"I'm not...*capable* of missing him," I say in a strained, harsh voice to Quentin's retreating back. "Of what you're implying."

Pausing mid-step, just past the threshold, he turns to look over his shoulder, giving me a small smile. It's one I hate—sad and pitying, accompanied by tightened eyes.

If I hadn't spent several years meticulously gathering control of the only emotion that I've ever been truly able to experience—anger—or blew off a hell of a lot of steam earlier tonight... I have no doubt Quentin would be walking away from this conversation with a broken nose.

Or worse.

And I wouldn't feel a lick of shame or remorse for it.

"I think you're not as incapable as you'd like to believe. Which is why I feel so torn here. Even people like you experience longing. Joy. Relief. Maybe not in the way most people experience it. Maybe not always for the right reasons. Maybe not in a way you can articulate it. But you are not empty, Vale."

And because he can't just end it there, he leaves me with one final parting jab. One that has me turning around, digging my keys out, and heading for my Audi instead of following him into the house.

"You've just been empty of someone like Aston. Someone who has the key to unlock just a little bit of humanity from wherever it's hid dormant inside you. I just hope you can handle it. For all our sake."

CHAPTER 37

VALE

THE PAST

SOMETHING BAD IS COMING.

I don't know how I know that, I just do.

It all starts two weeks into summer break, when Rick comes home early.

He lost his job.

After ranting and raving and tearing apart the house, all while screaming back and forth with Louise, the two disappear for hours. Leaving us to fend for ourselves. When they eventually stumble back in later that night, they're not alone.

It's not the first time they've thrown parties here. Far from it. Yet I can't shake the feeling that something else is going on here. For one, I don't hear any female voices. Only male.

For another...

Aston.

After he all but drags me down to the basement to grab Chloe and the boys, and sneak them upstairs into my room, where we give them applesauce with crushed Benadryl to help them sleep through the noise, he turns to me and shoves a small pink pill in my hand.

"Here. I have a feeling it's gonna be loud tonight."

I don't tell him it doesn't really work for me.

It's not until after I've popped it into my mouth, and swallowed it dry, that I notice he doesn't do the same.

Gripping my shoulders, he bores his gaze down into mine, making me acutely aware of how much taller he is—a whole head. "Lock the door and go to sleep, okay? Don't come out, no matter what you hear."

I frown, widening my eyes and reaching for him when he turns to leave, tugging him by the arm to a stop. "Wait, where are you going?"

The first time he had us bring the little ones up here, I'd asked him why, and he just shrugged and said, "It gets loud. I don't want them to wake up scared and wander upstairs. It'll just piss off Rick and Louise if they bother them when their friends are over. They can just stay with us when they have parties."

I didn't question it—it made sense; same goes for the Benadryl—but I did ask why my room and not his. To which he just blinked and said, "Your room is bigger."

He wasn't wrong. And yet...

Now, he won't meet my gaze as he mutters at the floor, "I, um, I'm gonna go to bed. In my room."

I make a face. "What? Why? You can't leave me alone with them."

He shrugs, lifting his head just enough to look past me. "They already fell back asleep. They won't bother you."

Following his gaze, I find all three of our younger foster siblings curled up on the rug, wrapped in the blankets they brought up here with them.

A door creaks open, and I whip around.

"Aston!"

He's already halfway through. "Just... go to sleep, Vale," he says quietly, more serious than I think I've ever heard him speak. The pale eyes that lock with mine are pinched around the edges in a way that has my hackles rising.

I take a step toward him. "What's going on?"

He shakes his head, and forces a small, thin smile down at me. "I'm just really tired. I think I ate something bad," he whispers. "Lock the door behind me."

And then he's gone.

I press my ear to the door, straining to hear the telltale click of his door shutting. When it does, I breathe out a sigh of relief.

I don't know why I worried maybe he'd go downstairs—or why the idea of him joining the...party or whatever rubs me the wrong way—I just know I'm glad that doesn't seem to be the case.

And confused.

Is he really sick... or is he avoiding me?

Scowling at the thought, I stomp over to my bed and climb under the covers to lay on my back and gaze blankly at the water-stained ceiling. Waiting for sleep to pull me under.

He's been acting odd all day, ever since Rick got home and we caught wind of what happened. We were out back at the time and heard everything through the open kitchen window.

The football we'd been throwing back and forth forgotten, I'd watched in confusion as Aston backed himself against a tree, slid down, and curled into a ball. Tugging on his hair, shaking his head, muttering under his breath.

When I approached him and poked his shoulder—he wasn't answering to his name—he flinched so hard, I flinched.

He's always a little on edge when Rick's in one of his moods, so it wasn't all that unusual. But there was something in his eyes when he met my gaze... something that had a chill shooting down my spine.

Things were tense after that. Quiet. Even after Rick and Louise stormed out and drove off with a squeal of tires, Aston remained distant. Out of it. Twitchy, like I've noticed Louise and Rick get sometimes when they've smoked that gross sulfur, chemically smelling stuff.

Now, I toss and turn in bed for what feels like hours, grinding my teeth against the music blaring from downstairs, vibrating the walls. Usually, I have no problem sleeping through the noise that sometimes fills this house. Be it the television downstairs, or when Rick and Louise have people over, like tonight, or the occasional whine and thumping sound I'll hear faintly through the walls... the knocking Aston told me to ignore all those years ago, and claimed was a gutter that was loose and would bang against the side of the house when it was windy.

But tonight, I can't get my head to quiet. And it feels like bugs are crawling under my skin, making it impossible to hold still for more than a few seconds. It feels like I need to get up and run.

I know it's probably just the Benadryl. It did this last time I took it.

At least, it seems to still work for the others, if their snores and steady breaths are anything to go by.

Kicking off the blankets, I glare at the ceiling when I hear that familiar rhythmic whine and thud against some distant wall. It's only then I notice how quiet it is. The music stopped.

Did everyone leave?

My stomach twists with a feeling I can't really place, but has me feeling sick like maybe I, too, ate something bad. And I find myself counting each thump, mouthing the numbers silently, my chest squeezing tighter and tighter by the second.

I looked for it once. The source of the sound.

Wandered around the perimeter, seeking out a dangling piece of the house.

I never found it. And when months passed without hearing it, I figured someone finally fixed it.

But the sound would always return eventually.

There's no wind tonight. If there was, the tree outside my window would be brushing the glass with its branches. Was it windy all the other times?

I sit up, chest heaving as I stare around the darkened room. A look at the floor shows the kids still fast asleep, their backs rising and falling steadily under the blankets.

My hands ball into fists and I grit my teeth, straining my ears. The thumping stopped. I wait for it to pick up again.

It doesn't.

Floorboards in the hall creak under someone's heavy steps. I wait for the sound of Rick and Louise's bedroom door closing...but it never comes. Instead, there's the distinct fading thud-thud of someone going back downstairs.

That wasn't Rick, is all I can think, heart pounding. I know how it sounds when he walks past, and that wasn't him.

I wait several more minutes, ears strained.

Someone else comes upstairs. I know this because their gait too is different. Uneven and unfamiliar.

My eyes remain wide and frozen on the ceiling, stinging from not blinking the whole time I wait for the rhythmic whine-thud-whine-thud down the hall to stop once more.

Time passes...slow, like molasses.

I don't think I so much as even breathe.

And then it's over.

A door slams shut. The music cuts out. The house is...quiet.

Rick and Louise still haven't come up to bed...but I can't wait any longer. I jump out of bed and charge for the door. Hesitating only when I've got my hand gripping the knob. Questions racing through my mind...ones with answers I don't think I want to know.

All I do know right now, is I need to see him.

Aston.

Everything will make sense again when I lay eyes on him.

Chewing my lip, I look over at my dresser, debating...

Screw it, I think, heading over there and digging out the gift I'd planned on giving him for his birthday in a few months. It's a plastic display box, no bigger than the palm of my hand, about half an inch in thickness. And taking up the center, pressed between plastic film, is a butterfly.

It's a real one. Just dead.

I lifted it from Mrs. Davis's desk, the school guidance counselor assigned to me. Her office was full of all sorts of trinkets. I doubt she even noticed this one disappeared. I snagged it while her back was turned.

Shaking it out of the sock I hid it in, I clutch it in my hand, and head once more for the door. I wait a beat, straining my ears to make sure the coast is clear, before sneaking into the hall, quietly shutting the door behind me, and padding down the hall to Aston's room.

His door is cracked open, and my steps slow, alarm bells going off.

I gently push it open, bracing myself for what I might find.

But when all I see is a motionless lump under the covers, I blow out a breath of what feels like relief.

Closing the door behind me, I approach the bed. It's not until I draw closer that I realize he's awake.

"Aston?" I whisper.

He's on his stomach, face rolled toward the window, his eyes wide and glassy as he stares straight ahead. It doesn't even look like he heard me.

I round the bed and sit down on the edge. "Look." I lean over him to open the blinds, so the light from the streetlamp can shine in. I hold the little butterfly display to the light. "Aston, look," I say more forcefully.

Slowly, slowly, he rolls onto his back, a slight furrow between his brows. I wiggle the thin box-like frame side to side, so the wings trapped inside

catch the light, making it look as if it's glowing in the dark.

It's teal, like the one that landed on the tip of my nose that day at the zoo last summer, in the butterfly garden.

Fingers reach for it, brushing mine. I don't miss their slight tremor. My fingers twitch, losing grip of the frame, and he scrambles to catch it. He sits up so fast, he sucks in a sharp breath when we come dangerously close to bashing heads.

Our eyes clash in the dark.

He opens and closes his mouth a couple times. Then, in a croak, "Why?"

I duck my head and shrug, feeling warm all of a sudden. "I don't know. Just figured you'd like it. It's not like I want it. Was gonna give it to you for your birthday. But..." My voice trails off.

A long moment passes where I sense him staring at me. I keep my gaze focused on the bed, watching my fingers pull at a loose thread.

I can practically hear the questions swarming his head.

But instead of asking them, he just says, "Thanks."

"It's nothing," I mutter, secretly grateful he dropped it. I'm not sure what I'd even say if he asked why now, why am I really here, why do I care.

He lifts the butterfly to the light, wiggling it side to side just like I did. "Did you know they don't feel any pain?"

My brow knits at the unexpected turn in conversation. "What?"

"Butterflies. They don't feel pain. They're too little."

"Oh."

"I also read they...they do this thing called roosting. At night, when they sleep. Like birds. During the day, they keep to themselves. But at night, they stick together. To stay safe from predators."

I lift my head. "How would that make a difference?"

He frowns, looking back down at what's cupped in his hands. "I don't know. Maybe... maybe it's less about surviving, and more about protecting each other. While the predator is focused on one, the others get a chance to flee."

I chew my lip and look at some spot drowned out by shadows across the room. "They'd probably have a better chance of staying hidden if they spread out. Kept to themselves."

"Yeah." He smiles slightly. "And some do. The ones that are braver, or maybe more selfish, I don't know."

“If they’re too small to feel pain, why would they even care to protect themselves...or save each other?”

His brow knits. “I’ve wondered that too. Maybe it’s more of an instinct thing?” He lifts his gaze to mine. “To protect the whole of the species, like... evolution or something. Most tiny creatures do this. Though many also stick to groups during the day.” He lifts a shoulder and glances away. “It’s like the butterflies...know to be scared or something.”

“Scared?”

Face tugged down into a frown, he stares off toward the window, but seems to be miles away suddenly, “To show the world that they care. About someone other than themselves, I mean.”

I look at the butterfly, and say quietly, “Because it’s a weakness.”

He inhales sharply, then twists his head toward me, breathing out, “Y-yeah.”

A weird tight feeling forms in my chest, and I go to stand up. “Anyway, um, I guess I’ll just—”

“Why are you awake?”

Guess he wasn’t going to let it go after all.

I shrug a shoulder and tell him the truth. Or at least, the partial truth. “Benadryl doesn’t really work for me.”

It’s a long moment before he stutters out a quiet, “Oh.”

I swallow tightly, and say, “Anyway, goodni—”

Fingers grab hold of my wrist just as I push up to a stand, stopping me. “Stay with me tonight?”

I tense, keeping my gaze locked on the closed door. “Why?”

When he doesn’t immediately respond, I look over my shoulder.

His eyes are locked on where his fingers encircle my wrist. “Because I’m tired of being brave. And I don’t want to be selfish.”

The tightness has moved up into my throat, making it impossible to speak. So, instead, I just shake his hand away, ignoring the way he slumps like he’s disappointed, and pull back the blanket, crawling in next to him.

He sucks in a breath, and I scowl, nudging him. “Move.”

He quickly squirms his way across the mattress to make room for me. I grab the edge of the blanket, throwing it over us. Side by side on our backs, with hardly an inch between us, we stare quietly up at the ceiling.

“The-the others?” he says near-soundlessly.

“Asleep,” I manage just as quietly.

He sighs, and I get the feeling like he's torn about something. Maybe he's worried about leaving them alone?

For whatever reason though, me staying with him seems to win out.

Nothing else is said for a long while. So long, that I wonder if maybe he fell asleep.

As of last month, it's been four years since I moved in with the Baders. So, this is far from the first time we've shared a bed. But it was always mine, and if he stayed the entire night—not just to check on me, either to shake me awake from a night terror, or to just watch me sleep like a creep; something I never called him out for. I always pretend I'm sleeping when he does that—it was because we'd brought the littles ones upstairs to sleep in my room.

It was never just the two of us. Like this.

At twelve years old, with him just shy of that, I know we're too old to be sharing a bed. Or maybe too young, depending on how you look at it, even though that's not what's happening here. I suppose we're just at that awkward in-between age now, where everything either feels too childish or too adult.

And I guess I just feel...lost.

Like I don't know what to do with my body. To roll away and turn my back...

To draw closer....

For what though?

I don't like this...this feeling. This unknown.

"Valey?" he whispers, startling me.

I roll my eyes. I hate it when he calls me that. And he knows it. "What?"

"You won't ever leave me, right?"

I pull my face in, and angle my head toward him, watching the way his throat bobs with a swallow. He has to know I'm looking at him, but he doesn't take his eyes off the ceiling.

There are a whole bunch of things I could say and know I probably should say. All along the lines of, "It's not really up to me." But instead, I find myself asking, "Why would I leave you?"

His voice is so faint, I nearly miss it when he says, "They did."

I frown. "Who?"

His lashes flutter. "Everyone."

I slowly blink and turn to look up at the ceiling once more. I try to imagine it—a life without him in it. And I don't like it. Just the thought of it—that someone or something could rip him away from me at any moment—makes me want to break something. Or hit someone.

Because he's...he's mine. Like my football. Like the brand new sneakers I bought with the twenty I stole from Rick's pocket one night. Like the Gameboy I had when I was little, that I smashed after the screen froze. Like my favorite Hot Wheels car I lost track of when I was thrown into the system.

Mine like my parents were, before death stole them from me.

Mine.

Aston's not an object; he can't stop working like my Gameboy did.

So, unless he's torn from my life like my parents were, like my grandma....I can't see how I'd ever willingly abandon him. Not when I know what it's like to lose something I should've kept a closer eye on.

"Soon, Rick won't want me either."

I make a face at that. "You mean Rick and Louise?"

A too-long moment passes before he says, "Yeah. They're...they're gonna get rid of me soon, just like they got rid of—"

He cuts himself off before he can mention the boy who lived here before. I don't know his name, only that he was a couple years older. Aston doesn't like to talk about him.

It makes me angry. Hateful toward whoever it was. Not because they left him—they didn't have a choice; no one in foster care ever does when it comes to placement—but because whoever he was...he was important to Aston. Important enough that Aston can't even say his name.

Like it's a secret.

A secret kept even from me, his best friend.

But I try to get him to talk anyway, playing dumb, hoping maybe he'll finally tell me. "Who?"

"No one," he quickly says.

I purse my lips, but before he can tune into my irritation, he blows out a breath, nods, and says, "But we're basically the same age. Maybe they'll send us away together." He nods some more. "Yeah, I'll make sure you come with me," he whispers, and I get the feeling like this time the words are more for him than me. "And we'll go to our next home tog—"

“Why do you think they won’t keep us ’til we’re eighteen?” Sure, one of us could do something bad enough that it gets us kicked out and placed elsewhere. Like when Aston took the blame for me that time. But even when that happened, Rick and Louise were dead set on keeping him. Despite how much trouble he got in.

So, I don’t understand why Aston makes it sound like he’s running out of time. Like we’re running out of time.

Aston shrugs, causing our shoulders to bump. The mattress is so lumpy, it feels like we’re sinking into each other. We probably are. “I...it’s just a feeling. They, uh, they seem to prefer having...kids around. Not teenagers. Teenagers are, um, more work. And...and they don’t like work. They don’t like when we’re difficult.”

My lip curls. If anything, you’d think Rick and Louise would want someone older around to take care of the younger ones so they don’t have to. I mean, they already do put most of it on Aston and me, seeing as Louise barely gets off the couch during the day and Rick works long hours at some factory.

Not that that’s the case anymore...

But it’s only a matter of time before he gets a new job, and things return to normal. Aston mentioned once that he changed jobs a lot. Or, rather, he used to. This job he had since I got here, so that was news to me.

Without Aston and me here to mind the younger ones...

Who will make sure they’re fed and bathed if we’re not here? Who will take care of them when they’re sick?

Aston’s been doing that for as long as I’ve been here. I might be older, but he’s the one who’s taken charge of all of us.

He was only seven when I moved in...

Younger than Chloe now.

I frown. That just...it never occurred to me before now.

There’s a snuffle, and my eyes widen. A second later, arms are thrown around me, and I’m being squeezed in a bone-crushing hug.

“I love you, Vale,” he breathes against my neck. His face is wet. “More than anyone or anything, ever. Promise me you’ll remember that. No matter what happens. Promise me, you’ll remember I love you.”

I gape at the ceiling, lips fumbling for words. “What...what do you mean?” I finally manage. “What’s happening?”

He lifts his head to smile down at me, and I don't miss the way his eyes gleam. "Maybe nothing," he whispers. He darts his gaze between mine, looking desperate. "Hopefully nothing. I'll...I'll protect you. Just know that. I mean if—Okay? I promise, I swear...I'll do everything I can to keep you s-sa—from hurting." He chokes out that last word, and I struggle to keep up with the fractured words that just tumbled from his mouth.

I frown, my pulse skittering with some emotion I can't name. It reminds me of when CPS showed up at my grandma's, and they told me I'd be living elsewhere.

"Aston..." I murmur. Alarm bells go off in my head, and I feel myself shaking my head.

Why does this feel like goodbye?

Why does it feel like something terrible is about to happen? Something he seems to be in the know about...

Something that makes me think of creaking whines and thuds against the wall and three separate sets of footsteps.

He shakes his head, and buries his face in my neck, holding me tight.

"Aston."

"Do you love me?"

I make a face.

"I know it's stupid." He sniffs, burrowing deeper into my neck. "But will you say it anyway, even if you don't mean it? I just...I really need to hear it. Right now. Please," he rushes out, his voice breaking.

I open my mouth, shut it.

He tenses. I don't even think he breathes.

My throat feels unbearably thick in that way it sometimes feels when I'm angry.

"It's okay," he mutters, like he's reassuring us both. "Just forget it. Go to sleep."

For a long moment, I say nothing. Every time I try, it's like something's got my throat in a vice.

He goes to pull away, but I don't let him. My arms tighten of their own accord, plastering his taller, skinny body to me.

It's then I notice he's got no pants on. I'm not even sure that he's wearing underwear.

His breaths are hot and heavy on my throat. Damp.

My swallow goes down like gravel. "I..." I screw my eyes shut. "I love you too."

I have no idea if I mean it. All I know is Aston needs to hear it right now, and for whatever reason I can't not give it to him. Three words I can't remember ever giving anyone, not even when my parents would say them when they tucked me into bed. If I did, it was just because I was supposed to. It was what was expected.

This...this feels different.

Aston tips his head back, finding my gaze with his. Tears streak his cheeks. "Yeah?"

I blink. "Yeah, I... love you, okay?"

His face bunches and his shoulders shake with a sob he buries in my neck. Instinctively, I hold him tighter. Like I could keep him from breaking.

Because that's what this feels like.

Like he's breaking.

And he's not supposed to do that. Only toys are supposed to break. In all the time I've known Aston, he's never fallen apart like this.

Pulling back, his gaze flits to my mouth, and I feel more than see his gulp. "Vale..."

Then, slowly, so slowly, he lowers his face. Brushing our lips together in a light, salty, shivery kiss.

I watch wide-eyed as his lashes flutter closed. He sighs against my mouth, melting into me. His bare leg rubs against the flannel pants I wear.

I move my lips the slightest bit, instinctively adding pressure to the kiss.

A moment later, he pulls back with a small smile. I think he might be blushing. But that could just be from the tears still bubbling over his eyes.

He looks like he wants to say something, but every time he tries, something holds him back.

Then, finally, he murmurs, "You won't forget, right?"

Lips pursed, I shake my head.

"Good. Good." His breath hitches, and he looks away. "Night, little mouse."

I scowl when he boops me on the nose, shoving his hand away. Normally, he'd be laughing. He doesn't tonight.

When he rolls away from me, putting his curved back to my side, my hands flex, my body twitching. Before I can make sense of this...this...urge driving my pulse up, Aston reaches back, blindly grabbing my hand and

yanking me so I'm on my side, mirroring his position, my arm thrown around waist. Giving me no choice but to hold him—snuggle him from behind.

He sighs, his body going completely lax against me.

It takes a minute before I can catch my bearings and do the same. Scooting around, I struggle to maintain a healthy distance between our lower halves, and find a comfortable place to rest the arm I lay on.

In the end, I forgo stuffing it under the pillow cushioning our heads, and instead wedge it between his back and my chest, so it's twisted awkwardly against my front, fingers brushing my stomach.

I shift my head around, wrinkling my nose when his hair tickles my face. I wiggle and scoot down a bit so it isn't right in my face.

And that's when I feel it.

A damp spot on the sheets where my fingers touch, the ones trapped between us.

His tears?

No...that doesn't make sense. Did he pee?

I lean back a bit to bring my hand up and sniff my fingers, grimacing at the sour metallic scent.

Blood?

It's too dark to see.

"Are you hurt?" I ask, pushing up on my elbow to peek over at his face.

But he's already asleep, my hand and the butterfly clutched tightly to his chest.

CHAPTER 38

ASTON

THE PRESENT

Talk about a first date to die for...

RIP

I WAKE up the day after Halloween feeling unrested and just all sorts of *off*.

Not only was my sleep plagued with the weirdest of dreams, making for a very tossy-turny kind of night, but I've got a killer headache.

I suppose that's what the stress of being wrongly accused of murder does to a person.

That and the whole wondering if maybe you *did* in fact commit murder, and only hallucinated getting railed by your maybe-boyfriend (*totally-boyfriend*) in the middle of a cornfield like something straight out of a kinky Malac fanfic (that's the ship name for Malachi and Isaac from *Children of the Corn* for you normies), because mentally escaping to a fantasy world is the only way you know how to cope... thing.

Now go back and read that again—I know you want to. *Slowly* this time, so it actually makes sense. I'll wait.

Okay, where were we...

Oh, right, my dreams last night be whack.

In one, I was a beautiful butterfly cannibalizing other beautiful butterflies.

In another, I was a beautiful butterfly yet again, but I was cannibalizing a very human, albeit still beautiful, Vale.

Dream-Vale just laughed though, like getting gnawed on by a butterfly tickled. Maybe if I was an ordinary butterfly. But I'll have you know, Dream-Butterfly-Me was vicious! I had *piranha* teeth.

Still, I don't think I've ever heard Vale laugh like that, even if it was manufactured by my brain, so that was quite the treat.

But the dream that stuck out the most was the one where I stood in a room of mirrors. Dead bodies were scattered all around me, blood dripping from the walls and floor. Etta James' song "At Last" was playing—I think I even might have been singing along in my sleep—and I was slow dancing with a life-sized butterfly knife.

Yeah...

Flip-fucking weird, right?

I can't wait to regale Dr. B. with it this week, so he can go all Freud on my ass and tell me how I want to bone the mother I never met.

It didn't have a face—in case you're wondering. The knife, that is. It looked exactly like mine, only *ginormous*.

And with a surprisingly good sense of rhythm!

I wasn't scared though. Not at first. Heck, Dream-Me wasn't fazed in the least. Dead bodies aside, I remember feeling...safe. Special even.

After all, it wasn't *my* corpse soaking the floor with puddles of blood that splish-splashed under my feet.

It wasn't until the music slowed, morphing into something discordant—Etta's voice replaced by something deeper and sinister—that the energy changed. And I became aware that my knife friend and I were no longer alone.

If we ever were.

The figure, dark and masked, moved through my dream like smoke—soundless and unseen until he wanted to be noticed.

He had no reflection. Like a vampire, the mirrors could not capture him.

Somehow, I just knew, this was his doing. The carnage at my feet. *He* killed them. Not me.

But why?

Why spare me?

It was at that point, the dream, weird and arguably fucked up that it already was, veered into nightmare territory. Becoming fractured not unlike the explosion of glass as all the mirrors shattered outward.

I remember closing my eyes and covering my face with my hands to protect myself from the onslaught.

I remember the music cutting off with a blood-curdling scream and the wailing of sirens.

I remember arms, thick and muscular, wrapping around my midsection from behind. My hand thrusting out as my eyes flew open. *My knife! Where's my knife?*

Whirled around, a hand closed around my throat, squeezing and cutting off my air before I could so much as gasp at who stood looming over me.

Vale.

The upper half of his face was hidden, but I could make out his mouth. A cruel barely-there grin I registered at about the same time that a flash of silver winked in the darkness.

And then—

Heat.

So much heat spreading across my chest.

A glance down showed the hilt of my knife—back to its normal size—sticking out of my chest.

Blood gurgled up my throat, pain exploding across my body, and just before I jolted awake, I recall thinking—

He didn't spare me.

He saved me for last.

Anywhoozles...to say I'm tired, cranky, and confused this lovely, rainy November morning would be an understatement.

Can you blame me?

It's not every day you get falsely accused of murder *and* find out your maybe-boyfriend (*totally*-boyfriend) is a psychopath (allegedly) all within the span of a couple hours.

Not to mention the whole *getting railed in a cornfield* thing...

Talk about a memorable first date.

No fucking wonder I'm so out of sorts today.

After a nice long bubble bath using Tillie's lavender scented salts, I sneak into the room across from mine, and crawl into bed for some cuddle

time in with my Ediepoo, humming and singing Heart's greatest hits to sweetly lure him from his deep slumber.

And when he does, he promptly falls out of the bed with a shriek. "What the fuck, Aston?"

"Who do I have to murder?"

The look he sends me is nothing short of *adorably* scathing.

Scooting up so my back's against the headboard, I hold up my hands and say, "Hey, I'm innocent. I'm allowed to make jokes."

Pushing to a stand, he smooths out his over-sized Hendrix tee. "Someone *died*, Aston."

"Yeah...and whoever did that to your face is next." I'm quick to add, "Not that I killed the first one. That totally came out wrong. I just meant I'll be...contributing to the...cause or whatever."

Eden just stares flatly at me.

"Does it hurt?" I say with a wince. In the light of day, his eye looks a lot worse than it did last night. It's not quite sealed shut, but he looks like a raccoon. At least on one side. "It looks like it hurts."

"It's fine."

"What happened?" I say with more seriousness than I think either of us thought I was capable of. Rather than draw attention to it though, Eden just slumps, hanging his head.

"Come here," I say, patting the spot in front of me.

With a little huff, he shuffles over, and plops down in front of me, crisscrossing his legs to mirror my position.

I hand him the pillow next to me, and he immediately hugs it to his chest. Head hanging, hair curtaining his face, he mumbles something I can't make out.

"What was that?"

Inhaling deeply, he says in a quiet, yet clear voice this time, "I shouldn't've worn the mascara."

For a long moment, I don't move a muscle. I don't even breathe.

"Your date did this." Not a question. I figured as much, but I wanted the confirmation. What I didn't know was *why* the asshole hurt him.

I mean have you *seen* his face? It's precious. I don't know how anyone could dare look at Eden's pouty little lips and big doe eyes and think, *yes, this would look great wearing my fist.*

Eden nods jerkily. “He noticed when he leaned in to kiss me,” he says, his tinny voice breaking. Making him sound so much younger than his seventeen years.

He. So, it *was* a boy. I figured, especially in the wake of him getting decked in the face. But you never know. Girls can be dicks and throw punches too.

“That. Bitch.”

“It was a guy,” he grumbles.

“Yeah, and? Boys can be bitches too. Anything can be gender-neutral if you make it so.”

“I don’t know what I was thinking.”

My lip curls. “You were thinking *I want to wear make-up and look hot as fuck for my date*. And there’s nothing wrong with that. What’s wrong here is some tiny-dicked, insecure, misogynistic douchebag couldn’t handle just how good you looked.”

Eden peeks up through his lashes, and I don’t miss the blush staining his cheeks. “You sound like him,” he mumbles, and I make a face.

“Say what now?”

Shaking his head, he hunches inward, and says quickly, “Not *him*. I meant the guy who stepped in and broke Eric’s nose before he could do any more damage.”

Eric. I mentally file that away for later. Not that it will probably do me any good, unless I get a last name and a good lawyer. *Yoo hoo, Daddy Riviera. You best be ready for me.*

Then, what else Eden said registers.

I blink. “Wait. Someone...stepped in?”

He nods. “Yeah. I, uh, didn’t get his name. But he...um, made sure I was okay.”

A slow grin splits my face. “*Ohmygod*, you’re so red right now!” I steeple my hands to my lips like I’m praying. “On a scale of zero to Vale, how hot was he? Was he older? Did he have a six-pack?”

Eden curls his lip at me. Not quite a sneer, but not quite a smile either. “He was wearing a shirt.”

I wave him off. “Some things you can just sense about a person. Trust me. It’s like... like skin texture.”

“Like skin texture...” he repeats slowly.

“Stop trying to distract me. How hot was he? Tell me everything. Did he do the *thing*?”

“What thing?”

“You know, the *thing*. Where the sexy antihero gets all up in your grill, pinches your chin between his sexy calloused fingers, forcing your head back, to growl all deep and sexily, *who hurt you*?”

Eden blinks slowly. “He saw who hurt me.”

I wave my hand dismissively. “Semantics!”

“That’s not...”

Snapping my fingers, I say, “Focus. Was he hot?”

He rolls his eyes, shrugs, and mutters, “Yeah, I guess.”

“You *guess*?”

Eden huffs and throws his hands up. “Fine, he was *gorgeous*. What does it matter though? I’ll probably never see him again.” He lets out a cute little growl, before adding on a mumble I have to strain to hear, “Probably already forgot about me—Ow! What was that for?”

“You were saying mean things about my best friend again.”

Rubbing his forehead, he mumbles bitchily, “You didn’t have to *flick* me.”

“Don’t say stupid shit and I won’t.”

Jaw working, he crosses his arms over the pillow and blows hair from his eyes. “Just statin’ facts. He’s way out of my league. Older too, to answer your earlier question.”

“Like *Daddy*, I’ve been a very naughty boy old or...”

“Like, at least eighteen.”

I roll my eyes. “Wow, barely a whole year. Boring.”

“Anyway, now that we’ve covered that, you wanna tell me what the hell happened to you last night?” He arches a stern brow that makes me want to pinch his cheeks.

So I do.

Shoving me away, he says, “Seriously, what happened? Where did you go?”

I dip my chin. “Do you want the PG or X rated version?” I whisper conspiratorially.

He gives me a knowing look. “Do I actually have a choice?”

AFTER SPENDING a considerable amount of time gushing about my night to Eden—traumatizing and horrifying him in equal measure—I drag him downstairs to make frozen waffles that we take back up to my room to eat while we pick up where we left off with *Gossip Girl*.

Seeing as I was otherwise indisposed when all the good shows were still on-air, and Eden spent his pre-teens trying to flush out any interests or desires he didn't deem *manly* enough...

We've been slowly making our way through the classics.

Stripping down to my baby blue cotton briefs, I throw on my favorite floral kimono that I'd scrounged from Grammy Gerty's things, and climb into the unmade bed, urging Eden to do the same.

Not surprisingly, he keeps his clothes on underneath. But the fact he slips on the kimono—*his* kimono, though he refuses to take it with him every time I try to push it off on him—without any bullying from me, is *huge*.

After only a little bit of begging, I manage to get him under the covers with me.

He grumbles about it of course, acting like it's some great sacrifice to snuggle with me. But I see right through my pouty little grump. He loves this. The fact he only bats my hands away *twice* when I start playing with his hair, before finally giving up, says as much.

We've come so far.

Sadly, after only two episodes, Eden's whisked away. It's his godmother's birthday—his aunt, Walt's sister—and they're having a small family get together at her house one town over.

Tillie extends the invite to me, but I can tell by her tight smile she's hoping I refuse.

Can't say I blame her. Especially after last night, despite her promises and assurances that she never for a second thought I was the killer.

I wish I could believe that, I really do.

Either way, I fucked up by leaving Eden.

I don't know what he told his parents regarding how he got the black eye, but I could tell she was more disappointed in me about that than the whole being suspected of murder thing.

Before they head out, she tells me Walt's staying back too—a headache, so he claims, but going off of Tillie's eye roll, I'm guessing that's a lie.

If anything, this information has me itching to go with them. But all it takes is one look at Eden's eye, and I'm biting back the words.

For the rest of the afternoon, left to my own devices, I try to keep busy. And not think about that pervasive loneliness I can never quite shake when left with nothing but my own thoughts to keep my company.

Sure, Walter's here. But I'd rather rip my eyelashes out one by one than entertain that idea. Not to mention he's holed up in his man cave, watching football and being lame, keeping scarce like he always does when it's just the two of us.

I think I might scare him a little?

The rain eventually clears—as does my headache—allowing the sun to make an appearance. Prompting me to take my restlessness outside to wander around the back part of the property where the creek runs through. It's too cold, too wet to work on my garden. Not to mention how pointless it would be now, with winter right around the corner.

No, that will be a spring project.

Will I even make it that long?

Movement in the corner of my eye draws my attention to a cluster of bushes, and some of my mood instantly lifts when I spot the fluttering orange wings of a butterfly. At first glance, it looks like a Monarch. But closer inspection reveals it's in fact a Painted Lady.

"What are you still doing here?" I murmur, slowly approaching her.

This late into the year, it's all but impossible to find any butterflies still hanging about. And this makes two in the span of a week. Most, by now, have migrated or found a dark, hidden place to spend the frosty, bitter months in chrysalis. A dormant state, similar to hibernation.

Her venturing out here is risky, not only is she alone, but it's so late into the season.

Was she woken up? Did someone steal her safe spot? Did she forget?

She won't survive the winter. She will freeze. If she doesn't get eaten first, that is.

"I'll keep you safe, pretty girl," I say decidedly, before reaching for her.

Heading back to the house with my new friend in tow, I hum under my breath as I enter back through the kitchen, throwing the sliding patio door open before sealing it shut behind me. Shoving my sunglasses up with my free hand, I blink a couple times till my eyes adjust and shoot a glance at the clock above the stove.

3:12.

Sigh. Why is it that time never flies when I need it to?

Toeing off my red Chucks, I head into the hallway, making a beeline for the stairs, bypassing the living room, powder room, and Walter's study slash den off to the base of the steps.

The French doors are shut, but I can see through perfectly. He's in his recliner, facing away from me, watching football on a giant flat-screen that practically takes up the entirety of the far wall. Next to him, on the end table, he rests an arm, hand gripped around a brown beer bottle.

My stomach curdles at the sight, and I quickly hang my head and divert my gaze with a grimace.

I didn't take Walt for a beer kind of guy. Usually when he drinks, which isn't all that often, it's a glass of wine at dinner, or a tumbler full of amber liquid sans ice after a long day of boring students with history facts.

Hand clenching the banister, I quickly clomp my way upstairs. Not bothering in the least to be quiet about it, because I'm nothing if not a temptress of fate.

Once inside my room, I kick the door shut behind me, not bothering with the lock, and stride for my desk.

"Crap," I mutter, eyeing the crooked, orange wings I all but crushed with my fist. "Sorry, princess," I murmur, carefully setting her down on my desk, petting and smoothing her wings out as best I can.

Shaking the lingering weirdness from my arms, I turn around and pull off the hoodie I threw on earlier. It's Eden's, but I know he won't mind. Borrowing each other's clothes is just what besties slash siblings do.

Balling it up, I toss it toward my hamper. I miss, but I don't bother picking it up, or the other dirty laundry strewn across the floor that missed too. Including the sweatpants—*Vale's* sweatpants—and socks I toe off next, punting them blindly in the same direction.

Left in nothing but my sky-blue briefs, I take a seat at my desk and dig out my secret journal from where I hid it in the bottom drawer. Buried with it, a sharp butcher knife glints under a stream of sunlight pouring in from the window. I take that out too, setting it atop my desk. Lamenting once more over the loss of my butterfly knife. The one I stupidly left in the field last night.

Yeah, and what would've happened had it been on you when the cops took you in?

I click my tongue at the reminder. *Right...*

Shaking my head at my carelessness, I open my journal, flipping through the stiff, wrinkled pages. It's one of those black, leather-bound kind—really nice, actually, even if it's not as crisp and sleek as it once was. It was a gift from Tillie several years ago. In fact, she gave it to me right around the time I stumbled upon a book about metamorphosis with pretty colorful butterflies all over the cover in Ashwood's library.

And by library, I mean two carts packed with books that had been donated because no one wanted them.

Fate has such a silly way of working out when you're not so preoccupied by what you *don't* have.

Reaching for my Walkman, I forgo setting the bulky headphones over my ears and instead let them hang around my neck. I hit rewind on the Madonna cassette I'd been listening to the other day, starting it over from the beginning, and crank up the volume just enough so I can hear it as the orchestral intro to "Papa Don't Preach" kicks on.

Biting my lip, I open my journal to where I last left off and grab the glue stick.

I mouth along to the song playing, smiling at the part where she sings about keeping her baby, as I write up today's report with a sparkly pink gel pen, jotting down some quick notes in the margins surrounding my new little buddy.

Species: Vanessa virginiensis (AKA American painted lady)

Location: flitting about a shrub

Weather: partly cloudy, damp, cold

Mood:

Hmm...

I tap my chin with my pen, thinking. *How do I feel, how do I feel...*

At first, it's an image of Walter's hand clasping his beer that comes to mind. The rest of him hidden from sight by the back of his brown leather recliner.

But I quickly shove that image away, and all the grainy memories it conjures up.

Fortunately, a new image surges to mind almost immediately. Much more vivid and somewhat less confusing, it easily booty-bumps everything else back to the dark pit that is my past, deep, deep in the recesses of my mind.

Cold, hardened, nearly black eyes.

A flared nose.

That delightfully sinister sneer.

As if they have a mind of their own, my fingers come to my throat, skating down my flesh to press on the little bruises decorating my skin. Reigniting the ache, and making it feel like I'm reliving last night all over again.

Not just last night, but all our encounters. They swirl into a montage in my head, as I recall all the dirty sweet-nothings he growled into my ear the night of the party. Remember the way he called me "sugar" in that sexy-as-fuck deep timbre of his in the locker room, just seconds before splattering my face with his cum.

Sugar of all things! The sap. From anyone else, it would sound grandmother-y at best. Creepy leering dude on the sidewalk whistling me down...at worst.

But coming from Vale? In that rumbly snarl he uses when he's trying to convince himself he hates me?

Just trust. It *works*.

I've a feeling he can make anything sound sexy.

Okay, probably not *anything*. But you get the picture.

And then there's last night...

A quiet little moan escapes me, eyes rolling back. I wiggle in my chair, my ass clenching with the echo of Vale's hard girth stretching me out, pounding into me as if his life depended on it. As if he was chasing something only I could provide.

Who knew my not-so-little mouse has a wolf living inside him?

In the light of day, it's all too easy to look back and laugh at how ridiculous I was for doubting it was him. For begging him to *stop* when it all became too much...

Like what the fuck was that?

Talk about being dick-drunk.

Brain cells, oh brain cells...yoo hoo! Hey, hi, hellooo. Where'd you run off to?

I don't know what it says about me, knowing what I know now (allegedly) that I'm positively *dying* for round two—*especially* now, after he came to my rescue last night, eradicating any and all lingering doubts. Saving me from certain imprisonment.

But I'm not about to analyze it too closely. What happened in the fields last night was *hot*. No ifs, ands or buts about it.

Unless you're talking about *my* butt.

He was very, very much about that.

Grinning, I straighten and lean forward, bringing my pen back to the paper.

Horny.

Nodding to myself, I think, *Perfect-o*.

The cassette has just switched over to track number two—"Open Your Heart"—when the doorbell rings, stilling my hand halfway through writing today's date.

Ears perked up, I hit Stop on the tape player, and rush to lean across the desk to peek out the window. But it's no use. Whoever it is is hidden beneath the sprawling tree.

Turning my head, I strain my ears, feeling my pulse quicken with a mix of hope, anticipation, and fear.

Did the cops change their minds? Find new evidence? Did Vale take back his statement?

A door opens faintly—Walter's study, I presume. A couple seconds later, I can make out the sound of the front door whining as it's pulled open.

I hold my breath so as not to drown out the muffled sounds of whoever it is paying us a visit.

"Is Aston home?"

My jaw drops.

Ohmygod, ohmygod.

My inhale is loud and shaky and telling as it punches the back of my throat, stretching my mouth into a cheek-splitting grin along the way.

And here I thought I'd have to wait allllll the way until tomorrow.

Gently closing my journal, I remove the headphones from around my neck and drop them on top. A glint of metal catches the corner of my eye, and I grab the handle of the knife, debating what to do with it as I slip out from behind the desk and look around.

Well, fuck me.

My room is a disaster. Do I even have any clean clothes?

Oh right...

I was supposed to do laundry today.

Oops.

You'd think after years spent being forced to maintain a clean and orderly room, I'd be a well-conditioned neat freak. But quite the opposite has happened since I earned my wings.

Oh well, I think with a shrug, rolling the knife handle between my palms. If he can't love me at my worst, he'll never love me at my best.

Thudthudthud.

The quick rap of knuckles against my door has me freezing, thoughts grinding to a halt. Too lost in my momentary panic, I must've missed the sound of him walking upstairs.

Stifling a squeal, I collect myself as quickly as I can, fighting the urge not to run for my bedroom door, throw it open, and maul him like a dog in heat.

"One second!" I yell.

Quickly tossing the knife on the bed, I throw a pillow over it and shake out my hands. *Be cool, Aston. Be. Cool.*

Sniffing my pit, I wrinkle my nose. *Not cool.*

I quickly slick on some deodorant and finger-comb my messy hair. My gaze snags on the Yankee Candle room spray I'd found in the linen closet last week, and I hastily spray it all around my room. Heck, I even do a twirl in the mist, so I too smell like a coconut.

Music! We need mood music.

Not bothering to check what CD's currently in the boombox, I hit *Play. Heart. Perfect*. I crank up the volume just enough to add some ambiance.

Grabbing the kimono I was wearing earlier, I slide it over my shoulders, letting the thin, silky, floral material hang open at my sides.

Sparing a quick glance at the mirror, I leer at my reflection, flashing it a rogue smile.

Go time.

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CHAPTER 39

ASTON

IT HASN'T EVEN BEEN twenty-four hours, but the second I throw open the door and lay eyes on Vale, I feel something settle inside me. Like all the wings battering in my stomach just...stop to hover weightlessly.

"You're here," I squeak, quickly biting down on my lip to hold my grin in.

Dressed in a form-fitting black henley and dark jeans, my little mouse looks utterly delicious filling the doorway.

His stony black gaze flits down my body. And when his jaw noticeably ticks, I can't help but notice there's a fine smattering of dark stubble where there never was before. Not that I've seen.

It makes him look older. Dangerous even. Disheveled too, much like his hair, which is equally dark and messy in a way it normally isn't.

And if I'm not mistaken, there are shadows under his eyes I've also never seen before.

Aw, was he worried about me?

Well, shucks. My little deprived heart squeezes at the thought.

With a gallant spread of my arm, I step back, holding the door wide open for him. It takes only a moment's hesitation before he blows out a sharp sigh and steps through.

Closing the door behind me, I watch as he sweeps his eyes over my room, brow furrowing ever so slightly.

"Excuse the mess. I didn't know I'd be having company," I rush out, my voice cracking, clasping my hands together under my chin.

Still not looking at me, his face does that thing it used to do when we were kids, when he's trying not to smile, or show how much I amuse him.

Just a little scrunch of his lips and nose, before he quickly smooths it out with a blank, unreadable mask.

Only back then, I found it adorable.

Now, I find it—

Hot, I think ravenously with a snap of my teeth.

His gaze snaps to mine. “Excuse me?”

I cup my hands over my mouth. “Did I say that out loud?”

He glares at me.

From the stereo in the corner, the chorus of “All I Wanna Do Is Make Love To You” comes on. It’s the most serendipitous moment ever. Pure cinema.

Move over J.D. and Veronica. *Our* love is God.

Something flickers in Vale’s gaze, like a single, threadbare crack spider-webbing its way through thick, dense ice. When it drops to scour over my exposed throat, my chest, my flat stomach...those normally hard, frozen black pools nearly shatter completely. Revealing the oily substance beneath just begging for a spark to light it up.

I lower my hands to my sides, and all but stick my chest out so the kimono gapes further, giving him an unobstructed view of the marks he left on my throat and hips last night.

Little moon crescents from his short nails.

Rosy watercolor blooms from the punishing pads of his fingers.

I’m a canvas of his own making, and hell if I’m not dying for him to paint me all over again and again.

His gaze dips lower to my breasts that leave very, very little to the imagination, lingering there.

Tilting my head, I wet my lips, studying him, wondering what he’s thinking. If the cord-like tendons jumping along his throat are any indication, it’s all dirty things.

God, I swear on Madonna’s cone bra, if he doesn’t kiss or touch or lick me soon, I won’t be held responsible for my actions. Not one little bit.

“We need to talk,” he says.

I blow a raspberry, taking great pleasure in his responding scowl.

He should be scowling. Talking is stupid, and it’s the last thing we should be doing when he’s standing there, and I’m standing here, Heart is playing, and there are things like boning we could be doing instead.

“Nooo,” I say cajolingly, like I’m scolding a child. I draw closer to him, reaching for him. “We need to kiss.”

He stiffens when our chests brush, and just as I’m about to launch myself at his mouth, he grabs me by the shoulders, halting me with a bruising grip.

Stumbling back on my heels, the breath whooshes out of me in a disappointed huff.

“No,” he says harshly, holding me in place with bruising fingers. “See, that is not at all what we need to do. Ever.”

I roll my lips together, fighting another smile. I tip my chin down, glancing up at him through my lashes. “And fucking me last night? Did you not need that too?”

He makes a face. It’s a mean face, but it’s also a cute face. One I want to squish and squeeze, just like that little butterfly’s chest.

Unlike my winged princess, though, Vale won’t break.

No, he’s too big and strong for that.

I grin wider at the thought, clenching my hands in fists so as not to clap in glee like a total loser.

He’s perfect, a voice purrs.

“Jesus Christ, what is wrong with you today?” he growls, all but shaking me.

Then, as if realizing he’s still touching me, he freezes, before roughly releasing my shoulders, practically shoving me away.

I pout as I watch him whirl toward the door, hands clasped around the back of his head.

Did I miss something? I wonder. It wouldn’t be the first time I zoned out or missed a beat in conversation. I do that sometimes. Peopling be hard work.

“You really are out of your fucking mind, aren’t you?” he mutters.

He says it like a question, but it doesn’t really feel like a question.

It also doesn’t feel like the words are for me.

When he turns his head, darting those hardened eyes all over my face, I can’t help but notice there’s something else there too. Something more... calculating. Maybe even...wary.

It has a chill skittering down my spine, and this time, it’s not the fun kind. “I am what I am,” I find myself saying quietly. Dangerously.

Images flash across my mind.

Beer bottle.
A shard of glass.
Recliner.
A shard of glass.
Blood.
Beer.
A paneled wall.
A shard of glass.
Vale's little face.
His face...
SNAP!

Flinching, I blink Vale back into focus—*this* Vale. The grown-up one. The one who's lowering his hand from where he just snapped it in front of my face.

I wouldn't say his expression has grown soft—I don't think he's capable of such a thing. When he was little? Yes. But I see now how misleading that was.

Nevertheless...there's definitely something gentler about him now. Something contemplative to the way he watches me. Giving me the impression that whatever's about to spill from those broody, delectable lips will be profound. Life-altering. Heart-squeezing. A revelation worthy of sonnets...

I just *know* it.

This is gonna be good.

"I didn't use a condom."

"I love you t—" Hold the phone. "Wait, *what?*" I blink rapidly, waiting for him to repeat what I *know* I must've misheard. But he doesn't. He just scowls at me. And that's when what he said finally registers.

He didn't use a condom. Last night. He's talking about last night.

Cocking my head, I say with mock confusion, "You didn't?"

He crosses his arms tightly. "I was drunk. Got caught up in the moment. It was a mistake."

I roll my eyes. *This again?* "It was totally *not* a mistake. And if it takes a little alcohol to get you to loosen up and get your freak on, who am I to judge?"

Ignoring that, he says. "I'm clean, just...just so you know."

Oh, no, he didn't.

“*Negative*,” I bite out sweetly. “You’re *negative*. STIs don’t make a person dirty.”

Still acting as if I didn’t speak, he goes on, “Coach makes us get tested regularly. And I always use a condom with Seth.” He says it casually. Too casually.

Use. Present tense. Does that mean...

I blink. Hard. Holding off the fury suddenly exploding through my veins.

He fucking wouldn’t...

The urge to punch something, or scrape my nails over my skin until I draw blood, comes over me like a tidal wave. Fast and brutal. I feel like I could explode from it.

Vale’s eyes narrow, like he can sense it—*feel* my restraint slipping.

But unlike everyone else who’s stared into the face of a loose cannon, he doesn’t seem scared of me. If anything, he looks bored. With just a hint of casual intrigue.

Right....because he’s a psychopath.

Don’t think I forgot! I just got...distracted—I gesture broadly at the sex god standing before me—by all that.

“What are you—”

“Why are you really here?” I demand accusingly, cutting him off. “Because it’s certainly not to talk *safe sex*, or to check up on me.”

His brows fly up, his shock visible.

Yeah, buddy, I’ve got your number now.

Walking around him, I take a seat on the bed, my fingers sliding under the pillow. “Is it a thank you you’re after?” I say casually.

His jaw clamps together, ticking in the corners. “A thank you for what?”

I bug my eyes at him, mouth curving into a smile as I say, “For coming to my rescue, silly. I would’ve been toast had you not come forward.” Despite how annoyed I might be right now—how paranoid I suddenly feel—I can at least acknowledge that much.

“You didn’t do it,” he says, as if that explains everything.

“So?” I sniff. “Facts are changed all the time,” I tell him lightly, fingers curling around the knife handle.

He freezes at my words, and for a very brief moment, I catch something flash across his face—something that starkly contradicts the cold, hard,

apathetic demeanor I've come to associate with this grown-up version of Vale.

Worry.

It's there and gone before I can blink, but I know what I saw.

Curiouser and curiouser...

"What the fuck is that supposed to mean?" he finally says, his voice stony. His eyes dart to the knife in my hand when I stand up, but other than that, you'd think he didn't even notice it by how unfazed he is.

Arms hanging loosely at my sides, I slowly prowls toward him. Surprisingly, this time, and much to my satisfaction, he doesn't back away or shove me. Even when I reach up to touch him with my free hand.

Just two fingers, trailing down his neck...his sternum...

His heart pitter-patters against my palm through his shirt where I end up resting it. And I can't help but smile and melt a little inside when I feel how warm and solid he is.

I bet he's even warmer and more solid under all these layers...

Tension radiates off him, pulling the air between us taut, like a bowstring being drawn back.

He wants to grab me. Throttle me.

But for some mysterious reason—be it the knife I don't bother hiding, or some other ulterior motive I'm not privy to—he's holding back.

Something tells me he holds back a lot.

Alas, it looks like I'll have to force his hand again if I have any chance of getting that arrow to fly free and back into me where it belongs.

"Why'd you do it?"

"Do what?"

"You know what."

His jaw pulses on either side. "I told you. Because you didn't do it."

I make a loud buzzer sound, like the kind I've seen on those game shows Louise used to watch late at night. Her husband would be stroking my leg as he made me sit right next to him, and she'd be cackling at the television as if nothing was amiss. Good times.

My fingers curl into his shirt, digging into him hard enough I hope it hurts. I tip my chin back. "Wrong answer. The truth."

Come out, come out, little mouse, I think, lips twitching as I stare deep into those cold black eyes. Recalling the dream I had—no, the nightmare—I

feel myself slipping and skidding toward a familiar, dangerous edge. *Show me what hides behind the curtain.*

Show me who you really are.

He looks me up and down, nostrils flaring. “Maybe ’cause I didn’t want you dragging me down with you. Who knows what bullshit you fed them before I showed up?”

My lip curls into a sneer. “Li-ar,” I grit out, emphasizing each syllable. Gripping the collar of his shirt with my free hand, I put us flared nose to flared nose, pointing the sharp tip of the butcher knife to his jugular. “You’re lying to me. Boyfriends don’t lie to each other.”

His dark eyes widen mere inches from mine, and so close that I am now, I can actually make out the little swirls of chocolate brown in his irises.

“First of all,” he says tightly, “I am not your boyfriend. Nor will I ever be. Second...” He grabs my wrist, twisting it back so fast that I’m not expecting it, effectively forcing the knife to point away from him.

I wince as my bones protest.

Towering over me, he forces me back a step, teeth mashed together as he says, “Just because you never learned how to function like a normal person, doesn’t give you the right to manipulate and threaten people at knife-point to get what you want.”

Taking advantage of my flinch at his words, he adds just enough pressure on my awkwardly twisted wrist to make me yelp and drop the knife. By some miracle, it doesn’t land on my foot a la guillotine style.

He immediately kicks it away, and in a move I’m not expecting, he splays his hand over my chest and walks me backward toward the bed. “Now, shut up and sit the fuck down before you hurt yourself.”

And that?

Well, that sets me off.

Shoving at him, I get all up in his face, all but shrieking, “No, *you* shut up and sit down.”

His head jerks back in surprise, eyes flared.

Planting my hands on his broad, muscular chest, I give him another shove. At least, I attempt to. He doesn’t budge this time. “Why the *fuck* do you care if I hurt myself, huh? Since when do you give a shit?” I dart my gaze between his. “Better yet...since when are you *capable* of giving a shit?”

Awareness flickers in the depths of his icy black gaze, mingling with the faintest traces of shock.

“Yeah, that’s right, Valeykins. I know your *little secret*. Truthfully, I still have my doubts, but...” I wave a hand. “That’s neither here nor there right now. What I want to know is...” My lip ticks up cruelly. “Why?”

“Why what?”

“Why bother?”

He frowns.

“Is it just a game to you? Is that what this is?”

“Game...” he murmurs like the word is something foreign.

“This. Us. Everything.” I search his eyes, silently challenging him. “You’ve got the whole world at your fingertips, Vale.” I wiggle mine in his face to emphasize my point. “You want for nothing. You’ve got it all. Money, popularity, influence...” My voice thickens. “A parent who seems to actually give a fuck, despite knowing the truth about you.” *Allegedly*.

Something unreadable passes over his expression, smoothing out his features.

“But it’s not enough, is it?” I whisper, searching his empty gaze. “Not for someone like you.”

His mouth thins, brow scrunching.

“You’re *bored*, Vale,” I say with ragged conviction. “You’re bored and you’re *lonely*, because everyone’s too fucking scared of you to make you work for anything.” I’m not even sure where all this is coming from, but I don’t question it. Nor do I try to rein any of it in.

It feels too big. Too important to hold back.

And after last night, after coming so close to having my freedom snatched away...

I don’t *want* to.

I don’t want to hold anything back.

“Not even your new daddy can fill that void inside you, huh?”

His jaw ticks, jutting out defiantly. “And, what, you think *you* can?” He makes a low, derisive sound, shaking his head. And yet...he makes no move to put some distance between us.

Blinking away the burn in my eyes, I match his defiance, and push past the tremor in my voice to say, “Why else would you keep coming back?”

His nostrils flare, my name rumbling from his lips in a soft warning. “Aston...”

“Don’t *Aston* me. Answer the question.” I poke his chest. Hard. I lean up, bugging my eyes at him. “You said you came over to talk. So, talk.”

Gripping my wrist tight enough to make my bones creak—*again*—he drags me up against his chest. Not unlike what the version of him in my dream did, he uses the other hand to encircle my throat. But he doesn’t squeeze. Not yet at least. He just locks me in place.

“Tell me again how much of a *mistake* last night was. Tell me how it will *never* happen again. Tell me—”

“Stop.”

I pout. “Aw, what’s wrong, Valeykins? Not used to being called out on your bullshit.” I tilt my head, causing his thumb to shift so that it rests over my throbbing pulse. “You don’t scare me.”

His jaw works. “Then you’re even more stupid than I thought,” he whispers so quietly I nearly miss it.

Choosing not to take offense to that, I hum and arch into his touch. “Maybe so.” My lip twitches. “But you know what I think?”

“What?” he practically spits.

“I think you’re secretly *grateful* for it,” I say fiercely.

His brows slam down over his narrowed eyes. “Grateful.”

“Yep. Finally, *finally*, you’ve got yourself a willing victim.”

He flinches.

He actually flinches. The stoic robot himself...flinches...because of *me*.

My lip curves. “And you hate that. You hate that you need this. Need *me*.”

He growls low, the fingers around my neck spasming. “Shut up.”

“Oooh, now we’re getting somewhere.”

“*Aston*...”

“Tell me why that is, Vale.” My heard pounds in my ears. “Seriously. Why are you fighting this so hard? Why are you resisting something we both crave? Haven’t I made my intentions clear? I want you. You are *mine*. You belong to *m*—”

“Like *fuck* I do.”

I grin, getting right up in his face, ignoring the way his fingers tremble in an effort to not squeeze my throat. Alarm bells are blaring in my head, but I can’t stop. It’s too late. “And I belong to you. I always have.” I search his black bottomless gaze...and all I see is myself reflected back. I look as

crazed as I feel. “Does it make it easier on you or something...” I wet my lips. “Pretending...lying to yourself...”

There. It's right there. What...what is that...

“One second you're rubbing your big dick all over me, calling me pet names and staking your claim,” I whisper, “and the next you can't get away fast enough. Telling me to leave you alone. Acting as if...as if I...”

A snarl crawls out from between his clenched teeth.

“Forced...you.” My vision slants, the earth opening up beneath me. Pain shoots through my skull, and I'm—

I—

What...

An overwhelming pressure constricts my throat, abruptly sealing off my airway. My entire body is shaken with the force of it as I'm thrown back onto the bed. There's a quiet familiar snick of metal I only vaguely register, somehow audible even over the music still playing that sounds like it's miles away.

My other senses are even slower to return.

The bed shifts, jostling me, his body heat registering before the sight of him does.

Vale.

He hovers over my prone body, completely caging me in, the hard planes of his face bathed in shadows.

When did it get so late? Tillie and Eden will be back soon...

Nostrils flared, Vale dips down, putting us nose to nose. “You really do have a death wish, don't you?” he growls mere inches from my mouth, teeth bared. “Do you realize how easily I could snuff the life out of you? How easily I could snap this pretty little neck.” I catch a wink of metal in my periphery, and then I feel it—the sharp point of a blade pressing into my neck, right next to my jugular. “How *easily* I can drain you of your blood.”

My body jerks, eyes bulging with the strain to hold still. It's not until I feel the burn of fabric pushing into my nail beds that I realize I've got my fingers fisted around his shirt.

But I'm not pushing him away.

Because I'm not scared.

I'm *desperate*.

Not just for his touch...

But for the lifeline he just threw me at the last possible second, to keep me from careening into oblivion, whether consciously or not.

Lifting the blade from my neck, he uses that same hand to drag the side of his thumb down my shivering jaw. The gentle, almost loving touch is so at odds with the violence consuming the rest of him, it leaves me chattering beyond control.

“I should, shouldn’t I?” he murmurs, dragging his gaze to my lips. “End this once and for all...”

Something tells me he’s no longer talking to me.

I swallow thickly now that I no longer have a knife pressed to my jugular. My body buzzes in a way that makes me feel apart from it.

Vale, I try to say, barely able to form his name on my numb lips.

My lashes flutter, but I don’t miss how he cocks his head, frowning. His attention still glued to my mouth.

“It’d be a kindness,” he whispers near-soundlessly.

“I—” That’s all I manage before he drops his forehead to mine, expelling a gust of air from my lungs. Frozen, all I can do is close my eyes and I claw at his chest. Not to shove him away, but to keep him close. Keep him *here*. With me...

Vale...

ValeValeVale.

“Why...” he starts to say, the deep timbre of his voice fanning hotly over my mouth. It draws a choked whimper from my chest. A quiet wordless plea. My toes curl, my body squirming from inside itself as I fight not to move. I don’t want to disturb whatever this...this moment is.

I don’t want to scare him away.

And no, the irony doesn’t escape me.

He arches into me—I don’t even think he’s aware he does it at first. Not until his hip slides over my prominent bulge, and he stiffens, his breath hitching.

I don’t even have a chance to panic or question whether or not he feels it too—this barbed, toxic *want* between us, tethering us like thorns we can’t dislodge. Not without ripping each other to shreds in the process.

Because *I* feel it...*his* want...dragging up my upper thigh, before mashing deliciously with my own.

Not that I’d want to....be free of this connection, that is.

No, this is all I ever wanted from the moment I first saw him again.

To be bled dry by it—by *him*—until there's nothing of me left.

With a hiss, he drops his face to the crook of my neck. He inhales deeply, gently thrusting his hips into mine, and I *feel* more than hear it when he groans his little pet name for me into my skin.

“Sugar.”

It's followed by the hot, tantalizing slide of a tongue dragging over my pulse point. Drawing another quiet needy sound from my throat.

He stiffens at the sound, before lifting his head and gazing down at me with such fierce, unbridled desire, it has my cock *throbbing* and my heart *racing* and...

Holy moly, is it possible to blow a load from a single look alone?

Something tells me I might have my answer in another second if I don't get myself under control.

Screwing my eyes shut, I clamp my teeth together, afraid to so much as risk breathing out of fear it'll bring unwanted friction where I *really* don't need it right now.

We saw what happened last time I came in my pants untouched and with no warning. And this time, in just briefs, there will be absolutely no hiding it from him when it happens.

His upper body shifts, the mattress giving slightly beneath me as he puts all his weight on one arm, while folding the other to wedge between us.

But he doesn't reach down where I so desperately ache for him...no, he slithers that hand up between our chests, toward my neck.

My eyes fly open just as something cool and hard is pressed against my lips. The flat side of a knife. And not just any knife, I realize—not the discarded butcher knife I held at his throat earlier, like I assumed he'd grabbed when he tackled me—but *my* knife.

The one I thought I lost last night.

He tilts his head in a way that is distinctly predatory, the tip of his tongue poking out to drag between his teeth.

As he slowly lowers his head, eyes heavily hooded, thick lashes fanning his high cheekbones...I become dimly aware of the song playing. “Alone” by Heart. But it might as well be coming from the other side of a padded wall, what with how deafening *my* heart pounds in my ears.

What is he...

I suck in a breath, lips parting against the blade just as he closes the distance. Crushing our mouths together.

My eyes fall shut on instinct, lips puckering, the bite of pain from the knife trapped between us barely even registering as I chase to bridge the divide—to defy the laws of physics and move through thin, but solid, metal to get to him. To fully taste him, finally, at last.

The sound that rumbles from his chest, reverberating from his body, vibrating along my lips...it's nothing short of a *purr* as our flesh grows moist and sticky, melding together around the knife.

So...close. So fucking close....

I splay my hands across his pecs, finally relaxing my fingers. Through the soft thin fabric of his shirt, I can feel his beaded nipples digging into my palms.

What I wouldn't give to drag my teeth over them.

Hell, over his entire *body*.

What I wouldn't give to kiss Vale properly, without any barrier in between. To be free to touch him, hold him, *squeeze* him...

To be *held*, adored, finally, at—

A door slams shut downstairs.

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CHAPTER 40

VALE

TRANCE SHATTERED, I scramble off Aston, throwing myself back, and knocking my hip into the nightstand in the process. Something teeters off, crashing to the floor with a dull, heavy thud.

I don't look to see what it is.

I only have eyes for the figure sprawled across the bed in nothing but a splayed-out pink kimono and the tiniest pale blue briefs known to man, darker where the distinct outline of his cock strains against the fabric. Even bathed in the dark grays of dusk, there's no missing it.

My grip around the knife tightens as I will myself to walk away. To leave and never look back.

But my body won't cooperate.

On the bed, Aston looks about as confused and spacey as I feel, blinking dumbly at the ceiling.

It makes it hard to blame him this time—to pin what just happened on him. And of course that just reminds me what set all this into motion. What he started to say earlier...all that it implied.

"Acting as if I...forced you."

The way his face fell, the way the light in his eyes dimmed...how he just sort of faded away right front of me. Or would have...if not for me forcibly snapping him out of it.

I don't feel...bad. I'm not sorry. He was right after all; that's exactly what I've been doing. Not that it made much, if any difference, once everything was all said and done.

Why acknowledge my own weakness when I could just weaponize his instead? Why admit defeat when I could have my cake and eat it too?

Why not make us both out to be the villains in this fucked up situation?

No. If anything, I'm angry. *Still* angry. At not just having been called out for something I stupidly thought he was too broken inside to figure out, but because he got to be upset about it.

Triggered by the very thing *he* stupidly brought up, giving me no other choice but to fucking tackle him and use his own knife to scare him into submission and away from the danger.

Because I was angry. So fucking angry I could throttle him. Angry he was...right.

Not for any other reason...

I'm dimly aware of steps thudding up the stairs. Quick and heavy...the gait of a teenager. The others must be back. Matilda and the kid.

When I didn't see any cars parked outside earlier, I would've kept on driving. But then I caught sight of movement in the upstairs window overlooking the street. The window to *his* room. And next thing I know, I'm parking in front of his neighbor's house.

It took me all of two minutes before I lost the battle with myself. I wasn't even sure if he was by himself or not...but I didn't care. I just...

I needed...

Now, on the bed, Aston hoists himself up onto his forearms and drags his gaze to mine, peeking through the mess of hair hanging over his furrowed brow. His lips are parted, full and red, smeared with the evidence of what just happened. Evidence I also wear on my own lips, sticky and coppery.

And before I can think better of it—before I can do the smart thing and cruelly wipe my mouth before storming off—the tip of my tongue pokes out for a taste.

Aston's eyes widen, eating up the action—something akin to clarity returning to him, reaching out like claws to part the cobwebs left in the wake of what just happened.

He sucks on his bottom lip, tasting us—his blood. Mine. *Ours*—his lashes fluttering madly.

I kissed him.

I practically kissed him.

Hell, I was a split-second from tossing the knife, grabbing him by the skull, and devouring him wholly and completely when—

Someone knocks on the door, stilted and hesitant. Not unlike the voice calling out from the other side, "Aston?"

Owlsh green eyes from the bed collide with mine once more. He releases his bottom lip. "Uh...yeah?" he says loudly, rougher in a way it normally isn't. And fuck if my cock doesn't twitch at the sound.

A beat passes. "Are you okay? I heard a loud...bang."

There's a weighty moment of silence, and then—

Aston slaps a hand over his mouth, muffling a snort, eyes swimming with mirth.

I glare pointedly at him.

"Oh, y-yeah, um. That was Vale," he manages to choke out, and I want to wring him by the neck.

What does it matter? Jennings knows you're here. He probably already told his wife.

"He came to...visit," Aston goes on, stumbling over his words. "And I..." His gaze flicks across the floor to something behind me. "My bowling ball. I was showing him my bowling ball." He tsks noisily, shaking his head. "He dropped it. Probably should reconsider his football dreams, methinks. It was a total fumble."

My lip curls as I shoot him a what-the-fuck look. The dumbass just shrugs, mouthing, "What?"

I jab a finger at the fallen lamp near my feet.

Aston blinks down at it like he's never seen it before, before his eyes round with comprehension.

Yeah, idiot. You could've just said the truth.

Well, the partial truth.

"Right..." I hear Eden mutter from the other side of the door. A second later, his steps retreat, followed by what sounds like the door across the hall opening and shutting.

Aston blows out a breath, tipping his head back. The sun has mostly gone down, but a stream of dark orange light streaking in from the window catches on his features, lighting him up.

"A bowling ball?" I mutter, my voice like gravel. "Really?"

Aston pushes to a fully-seated position, pulling the kimono back around his shoulders, and points behind me. I twist to find a hot pink bowling ball peeking out from behind his mirror.

"Why the fuck do you have a pink bowling ball?"

When I turn around, he's scowling. "Because pink's my favorite color." I can hear his silent *duh*.

I blink. "That's not... You know what? Forget it. I don't care. I'm leaving."

Surprisingly, he doesn't try to stop me. If it weren't for his eyes tracking my movements as I close his butterfly knife and gently set it on the nightstand before making my way toward the door, I'd have to look up to make sure he's still here.

Still sitting on the bed.

Still half-naked with tiny freshly cut scabs on his lips and pre-cum staining his underwear.

I don't know what exactly changed between that day in the locker when the idea of him getting off to me touching him—finding pleasure in my abuse, my touch, my warped toxic need for him—made me want to hurl. Made me want to choke the fucking life out of him. Made me want to rewind the clock to six years ago, so I could watch the life leave Rick's eyes all over again and actually *savor* what I did that night...what *Aston* did to his body...

And today, just now...

Knowing just how turned on he was, how needy *he* was under me, seconds from combusting, all from a barely-there kiss. From mere friction. From the feel of my heart pounding against his flexed hands, warm and greedy as it clutched at my chest. From our aching cocks rubbing together through denim and cotton.

But I'm not horrified this time around. I'm irritated, yes, but not for the reasons I should be.

What would've happened had we not been interrupted...

"Why'd you come?"

My hand freezes around the doorknob, my shoulders tensing.

His question was murmured so softly, I'm not sure how I heard it at all.

Because you were waiting for it.

Waiting for him to say something to stop you.

"The truth." This time, when he asks for it—demands it, really—there's a...nervous, wary sort of quality to his voice that wasn't there before. It's not a furious command so much as a tired plea.

Is he as exhausted from this back and forth as I am?

Or does he just want to torture himself some more?

Jaw working, I relax my grip on the knob, and turn my body just enough to look back at him.

I'm not sure what I was expecting to find...perhaps a smirk to betray the act he's putting on to sound meek and innocent. But that's not what greets me.

Because there is no *act* this time.

He looks as beaten down as I feel, stripped down to the bone and exposed like the fresh twin wounds scored down our lips.

I don't miss the way he's now got the kimono wrapped tightly around him, arms hugging his middle. Or the way he nibbles nervously at his lip. Or the way his bare feet shuffle restlessly in place. Or the way his eyes dart around my face, brow furrowed deep in thought.

"I don't know," I hear myself say, surprising us both when I don't just leave it at that. "I...couldn't sleep. Been driving around since last night. Trying to get my head straight. Somehow, I just..." I shrug, letting my words trail off.

Looking out the window beyond his head, I take in the dark clouds rolling in across across the sky, broken up only by smudges of teal where the setting sun still manages to shine.

When it's clear I've run out of anything more to say, he says, "How'd you know where I live?"

Our eyes meet. My brow arches faintly. "What, did you think you were the only one keeping tabs?"

His lips part, eyes widening in shock.

Shocked because I admitted it...

Or shocked I haven't been ignoring him as much as I've led on?

"So...what now?" he says after a moment, fingers picking at one of the tassels hanging off his kimono. His eyes track my movements as I cross the room over to where I spot a familiar pair of gray sweatpants balled up on the floor.

"Please don't," he says, voice cracking.

With my hand frozen inches from the discarded pants—*my* discarded pants...that he stole—I turn my head, meeting his wide, desperate gaze.

Wringing his hands together, he says quietly, but no less desperate, "Please."

Frowning, I snag the pants, and stand to my full height. I don't miss the way his face falls, some light in his eyes I didn't notice was there, dimming.

I open my mouth to speak, but he quickly cuts me off.

“There’s been no one else,” he rushes out.

My brow knits deeper.

“N-not since I got out.” His gaze flits between my face and what’s held tightly in my hand. “Only you. And...and I was tested at my discharge check-up. I’m good. I’m...good. *Vale—*”

My knuckles whiten around the fabric. I nod stiffly. Then—

“I don’t want you.”

He flinches. Visibly, like he’d been slapped.

“I mean I don’t...I don’t *want* to want you,” I amend quickly.

His eyes fling to mine, rounding with some emotion I can’t place.

Jesus fuck, why did I say that?

Throat tight, I steel myself for what I’m about to do next, knowing it’s for the best. For both of us. He might not be able to see it...not when he’s so dead-set on punishing himself; *I* see that now. And it’s what prompts my next words.

“And you don’t want me either. Not really.”

The space between his eyes bunch, and he’s shaking his head. Visibly gearing up to protest. His mouth opens, and I hold my free hand up, stopping him with a firm look. “You’re chasing something that not only doesn’t exist...but something that will only hurt you in the long run. And before you ask why I care...”

He knows what I am...

And he didn’t run screaming.

It’s enough to solidify my resolve.

“Because it affects me. My life. My future. I can’t...be what you’re looking for, not without damning myself in the process. And I can’t be what you need either...because I’m not capable of that,” I say meaningfully, searching his reddened gaze to ensure he understands.

He might not be willing to acknowledge what he needs—I see that now. Spent all fucking night and day rolling over what I learned last night, reconciling it with everything I thought I knew. Everything I told myself in an effort to paint him out to be the real villain in this story...

So I wouldn’t have to face the truth.

A fate as cruel and vicious as it is *real*.

More real than anything else.

More real than Aston St. James can mentally handle.

“I—” For a moment, words fail me. *Me. Who the fuck is this person right now? Who am I?* Shaking my head with a scowl, I level a glare on him that has everything and yet nothing to do with him.

His fault, his fault, this is all his fault...

“I don’t have to do the right thing here. I really don’t. You have no fucking idea how badly I want to do the wrong thing,” I grit out, boring my gaze into his. “So, consider this a debt paid. We’re even.”

Something flickers in his gaze, wild and dangerous and *knowing*.

“I forgive you.”

This time, his flinch is internal. I see it play out on his expression. The way his eye twitches, almost like he’s in pain. The flash of panic and sense of *abortabortabort* reflected in his glassy gaze.

The sight throws me back to last night, when I had him facedown in the dirt, fucking him with all the hatred I’ve carried these last six years. Until I thought I might kill him if he didn’t stop me. Until I thought I might kill us both if he turned me into *him...*

Into them...

Into just another weak, sick piece of shit who couldn’t take “no” or “stop” for an answer.

“Move on, Aston,” I tell him gruffly, making my way back over to the door. “You got a second chance at life. Take it. And leave the past behind.”

Leave me behind...

“For both our sakes, just...please leave me the fuck alone.” The knob creaks in my grip. “I swear I’ll do the same.”

With ringing finality, I spare him one last look, duck my head, and slip out of his room, gently closing the door behind me. Ignoring the way my skin prickles and chest tightens as if protesting the distance. The way my instincts screech and claw at me to turn around, go back, claim what’s mine.

All the way down the hall and down the stairs, Quentin’s parting words from last night thrash around my skull as if they could burst free and prove somehow useful. Useful, and not what they currently are: pointless to an agonizing degree, like every-fucking-thing else in my life, despite what I have to tell myself to get through each monotonous second of every monotonous hour of every monotonous day.

“You are not empty, Vale...you’ve just been empty of someone like Aston...”

He’s wrong...he’s wrong...

I am stronger than my base needs.

Stronger than my urges.

Stronger than this hollowness that would rather see me buried six feet under than go another day without feeling how I feel when I'm with him.

Downstairs, I find Jennings' wife rounding the bannister. We both freeze mid-step when we spot each other.

"Vale...right?" she says warily, the wheels in her green eyes visibly turning. Her gaze flits down to the balled up pants clenched tightly at my side.

I try not to think about what taking them will do to him.

I try not to be fascinated by the prospects.

I try not to think about the way his voice cracked, betraying him...and how close I was to handing them over.

It'd just give him another reason to keep hanging on...

I clear my throat. "Yeah. I just came over to check on him, see how he was doing after last night," I tell her, and it's not even a complete lie, despite how much I wish it was.

"Right..." She says faintly. Nodding, she inhales deeply, crosses her arms, and says, "Thank you for that, by the way. Coming forward. Doing the right thing."

I lift a shoulder, hands stuffed in my pockets, unsure what to say. I don't know what Aston told her about me—if anything. Obviously, after last night, she knows *something* happened between us.

I can only assume he hasn't told her about our shared history.

I'm sure she'd have a much stronger reaction to me showing up here like this...to us having contact at all...if she knew.

Cocking her head, she studies me with a pursed look that has me frowning and studying her more closely. From her short stature and tiny frame, to the brown roots and green eyes.

"Is he okay?" she asks, and I don't miss the crease in her eyes. The... concern and something else. Something more pointed that has my hackles rising, eyes narrowing. "After last night, I'm worried he'll—" She stops herself, averting her gaze and shaking her head.

I'd ask what she's worried about, but I already know.

She's worried what happened last night will bring back bad memories.

Memories better left untouched.

Add in me coming here, leaving things the way we did, the way *I* left him...

"I'm sure he'll be fine," I say carefully, eyeing her closely. "But I'd keep an eye on him."

Her head snaps up at that, eyes rounding with something akin to shock. Not so much at my words, but at the bite in my tone I couldn't be bothered to suppress.

Leaving her standing there, gaping and confused, I brush past her, and quickly let myself out.

Unable to shake the last image I have of him, curled up on the bed, looking more dejected and vulnerable than ever...

And the sudden churning, blood-boiling feeling that I just left Aston in a wolf's den...

I manage to make it only a few steps away from the porch, when with a muttered string of curses, I find myself turning around, and setting the hastily folded sweatpants on the bottom step.

Nothing.

This changes nothing.

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TRANSCRIPT OF RECORDED INTERVIEW

DL: WHY DID YOU GO VISIT MISTER SAINT JAMES?

VR: TO MAKE SURE HE WAS OKAY. I'M SURE YOU CAN UNDERSTAND WHY I WAS WORRIED, GIVEN ALL THAT YOU NOW KNOW.

[PAUSE]

DW: AND AFTER THAT?

VR: I KEPT MY WORD. DID WHAT I THOUGHT WAS BEST FOR BOTH OF US AND STAYED AWAY.

DL: AND THIS WAS A MUTUAL DECISION?

VR: NOT QUITE, BUT HE RESPECTED IT.

DL: YOU SOUND SURPRISED.

VR: I WAS. I DON'T KNOW WHAT I SAID THAT FINALLY GOT THROUGH TO HIM, BUT...IT WORKED. HE STAYED FAR AWAY.

DW: BUT IT DIDN'T LAST?

VR: OBVIOUSLY NOT.

[PAUSE]

VR: LIKE I SAID...IT'S DIFFICULT TO PINPOINT THE MOMENT I STOPPED FIGHTING MY FEELINGS FOR HIM. STAYING AWAY WAS...IT WAS HARDER THAN I EVER EXPECTED IT TO BE, AND EVEN IF WHAT HAPPENED NEXT DIDN'T HAPPEN...I STILL PROBABLY WOULD'VE CAVED. IT WAS ONLY A MATTER OF TIME. I KEPT TELLING MYSELF IT WAS FOR HIS SAKE. THAT IT WAS THE BEST THING I COULD DO FOR HIM. HE...HE DESERVED BETTER. BUT--

DL: WHY IS THAT?

[PAUSE]

VR: BECAUSE IT WAS ONLY A MATTER OF TIME BEFORE HE REMEMBERED.

DL: REMEMBERED WHAT?

[PAUSE]

VR: WHAT HE DID TO ME.

DL: AND WHAT IS IT THAT HE DID TO YOU?

[PAUSE]

DW: MISTER RIVIERA, WE UNDERSTAND THIS SUBJECT MIGHT BE DIFFICULT--

INTERVIEWEE'S LAWYER: HOW IS THIS RELEVANT TO THE CASE?

[PAUSE]

DW: WE DON'T WANT TO LEAVE ANY STONE UNTOUCHED. THE MOTIVE--

VR: HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH THIS.

DL: YOU HAVE TO UNDERSTAND, GIVEN WHAT WE FOUND AT THE CRIME SCENE, WHY WE MIGHT SUSPECT DIFFERENTLY.

[PAUSE]

VR: IT'S NOT WHAT YOU THINK.

DW: THEN TELL US WHAT IT IS, MISTER RIVIERA.

[PAUSE]

DL: YOU SAY YOU STAYED AWAY FROM MISTER SAINT JAMES IN THE WEEKS FOLLOWING THE FIRST MURDER FOR HIS SAKE. BECAUSE YOU FELT HE DESERVED BETTER GIVEN YOUR SHARED ABUSE AS CHILDREN AND THE MEMORIES YOU DIDN'T WANT HIM TO RECOVER. AND YET...LET'S BE HONEST HERE. WE ALL KNOW WHAT REALLY HAPPENED BACK THEN. HIS ROLE IN THE ABUSE THAT TOOK PLACE.

DW: AND DESPITE TRYING TO KEEP YOUR DISTANCE, ULTIMATELY YOU COULDN'T. YOU CLAIM IT'S BECAUSE YOU DEVELOPED FEELINGS FOR MISTER SAINT JAMES, BUT GIVEN YOUR HISTORY, CAN YOU SEE WHY WE MIGHT HAVE OUR DOUBTS? OFTENTIMES, IN SEXUAL ABUSE CASES LIKE THESE, WE FIND THERE IS--

VR: YOU STILL THINK I MIGHT BE THE KILLER. BECAUSE I HAVE, WHAT, A MORE JUSTIFIABLE MOTIVE TO SET HIM UP, GET RID OF HIM, THAN--

INTERVIEWEE'S LAWYER: I THINK IT'S TIME FOR A BREAK.

VR: YOU THINK I DON'T KNOW HOW SERIOUSLY FUCKED OUT SITUATION IS? YOU THINK I DON'T KNOW HOW...UNBELIEVABLE IT IS I CAN HAVE FEELINGS FOR SOMEONE WHO--

[PAUSE]

DW: WE'LL GIVE YOU A FEW MINUTES TO COLLECT YOURSELF.

CHAPTER 41

ASTON

YEARS FROM NOW, when Vale and I are happily married, living the dream as star NFL player and enviable trophy hubby, and this is nothing but a memory...

I'll look back on today and see it for the turning point it was.

In our story...

In *my* story.

I'll recall his parting words without black holes spotting my vision and cotton muffling my ears and a vice constricting my throat, so cold and clinical it makes me *ache* for the blazing, unrelenting grip of calloused fingers.

But I'm not there yet. Far from it.

So instead, I'm just left...confused. And something else I don't want to look at too closely. Something that has me wiping my cheeks, rushing out of my room, and locking myself in the bathroom where I can fall apart under the roar of the shower, and tell myself it's just hot water streaking down my face.

Just the steam that has my lungs fighting for air.

Just the chill from the air seeping in under the curtain that has me shaking so hard my teeth chatter, despite the heat of the water.

"I don't want you."

"And you don't want me either. Not really."

"I forgive you."

"Please leave me alone. I swear I'll do the same."

Try as I might to summon forth my usual flair for flippancy and ironclad resilience, neither are anywhere to be found. It's as if he took all

my carefully nurtured sunshine and snuffed it out with his frigid, apathetic darkness. Leaving me with nothing.

"I forgive you."

Nothing but lingering bruises and fresh cuts and this...this gaping, hungry black hole in my brain. One I'm finding harder and harder to ignore and steer clear of.

"I forgive you."

And no, it doesn't escape me that it's because of him. Because of Vale, my Vale, the little mouse I once vowed to protect...

It's because of him I keep finding myself lured toward it. Toward those black icy depths where secrets lie. Their bottomless truths I fear I'll never surface from.

"I forgive you."

As desperately as I try to will it out of existence, there is a part of me that is *excruciatingly* aware of just how stupid this all is. Me chasing after him.

How reckless and dangerous it is.

Selfish, even...

So terribly, terribly selfish.

And cruel...

I seal my eyes shut and summon forth Rick's lifeless eyes. His blood-stained face. His lifeless, blood-soaked corpse.

I did that.

I did that.

And Vale hates me for it.

"I forgive you."

No. Nonono.

I hug my knees even tighter to my chest, suddenly all too keenly aware of just how desperately I wish someone would hug me. Hold me. And not because I...I forced them or manipulated or tricked them into it.

I want them to hold me because they genuinely want me in their arms. Me, and not just what my body can do for them.

I thought I could find that with Vale. *Why*, you might be wondering. *How*, you might be thinking in disbelief, or even disgust.

The answer is simple:

For as rough as he's been—cruel even...in touch, in words, even in how he looks at me...

In his arms, I know I'm safe.

And I know I'm wanted for more than just the holes I provide, despite what he might tell himself. Despite what he tells *me*.

The tiny cuts on my sore lips say as much.

The fact I still breathe reaffirms it.

And all the ways he's looked at me since I swept back into his life. From glares to vacant stares, and every unreadable glance in between...

In the aftermath of what happened that day in the locker room, when he realized how close he came to hurting me—actually *hurting* me—all wide-eyed and shocked and maybe even a little scared, as unlikely as that sounds...

It just serves to drive home what I already knew in my heart.

My Vale is still in there, psychopath or not.

The one who knew me *before*. The only one I ever trusted to actually fully let my guard down with. The one I decided would be mine forever—that I would keep him always—when I was only seven years old. All because he decided to speak to me. *Me*. After not using his voice for months.

Even as a child, I understood just how huge that was—the trust he placed in me. How precious that gift was...something to be treasured and protected at all costs.

I wanted to be his entire universe.

I wanted to be his everything.

And for a brief moment in time I was...

What did I do?

What did I do?

What did I— He's different now, yes. Or perhaps he's who he was always going to be, with or without me. Cold and forbidding and hardened in a way that tells me the trust he handed over was a one-time deal. Something all but impossible to earn back.

"I don't have to do the right thing here. I really don't. You have no fucking idea how badly I want to do the wrong thing...consider this a debt paid."

That's what hurts the most about this, I think.

It's not *this* Vale who doesn't want me.

It's *my* Vale who doesn't.

Or rather, *my* Vale who's fighting our undeniable chemistry tooth and nail.

That's who won out in the end. That Vale who made his choice today—a choice I have to respect, right? I told Quentin as much last night—ripping away any future I may have had with the one I've only just started to get to know. The one whose freak matched so well with mine. The one that makes my heart feel like it could burst from my chest with a single graze of his eyes.

Nazareth was right. Love does fucking *hurt*.

Not that I've had much experience with it.

And yet, somehow in spite of everything, I keep...hoping. I keep dreaming. I still...want it.

To love and be loved and be grossly attached to another human being. Unconditionally. Forever and always.

"You don't deserve to feel good."

I know, I know...

"You're chasing something that not only doesn't exist...but something that will only hurt you in the long run."

I know...fuck, do I know.

I was a fool to think I could pry us from such a thorny past and find some semblance of happiness with what scraps of me are intact.

People like Vale and me...

We don't get happy endings. Not because of what we went through... but because of what it turned us into.

A blight on the world.

But we will push forward, because what other choice is there?

My story isn't over.

Our story isn't over...

Far from it.

And we will continue to fool ourselves and chase some semblance of peace as if it's something we're worthy of. Something we could actually obtain and sustain. Something beautiful and *good* and not tainted in the least.

Call it a necessary evil. A kindness.

A sweet, wicked thing, these lies we live by.

Dear Diary,

I don't understand what went wrong here.

Where's my meet-cute in the bookstore?

Where's my candle-lit, rose-pedaled bedroom where some big, strong, sexy man presses kisses down my spine before deflowering my butt hole?

Can the gays ever fucking win???

Where are the snuggles?! Where is the fun banter?!
Where are the cheesy heartfelt confessions and grand declarations of love?!

Am I not worthy of just a smidge of light-hearted predictability?

Clearly not!

Instead, all I get is this.

Pain. So much pain. My heart has been ripped from my chest, thrown in a blender, and is now being force fed down my throat like beer at a frat party during hell week.

And for what???

And don't even get me started on the whole murder subplot...

WHY, GOD, WHY HAVE YOU FORSAKEN ME?

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

It's Vale's birthday.

I got him a present and snuck into the locker room while he was at practice to leave it in his gear locker. I know, I know...I probably shouldn't have done that. But it made me think of him...and it's just a gift. Nothing special. Maybe he won't even suspect it's from me...

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

He knows it was me.

He left a note in my locker today.

"I know what you did."

Not a thank you, but it's Vale.

I'd expect nothing less.

Maybe there's still hope for us yet...

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

Tillie's worried about me. She thinks what happened in the mines on Halloween, getting brought in for questioning, brought back some bad memories. I don't bother correcting her.

Yeah, she knows about Vale now. Or rather, she knows I had a "fling" with the Archers' quarterback. Not only did him coming forward blow the lid off that secret, but apparently they ran into each other upon him leaving the house. Obviously if the whole murder thing didn't happen, providing me with a very convenient cover story for my melancholy, she'd be all up in my love life.

It also probably helps that in all the time she's known me, I've never actually been in love. For all I know, she's of the same mind as my therapists, and doesn't think I'm capable of such a thing. Not anything more than a fleeting infatuation, right?

Little do they all know...

Ugh. Now I'm sad again.

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

Can someone add corn on the cob to the trigger warning?

Walt made it for dinner tonight, the asshole.

I promptly chucked it at the wall.

He should've known better, even if I never told him.

Doesn't he know it's his responsibility to mind my mental health?

UGH.

It's bad enough half this entire town is made up of fields of the stuff. There's no fucking escape. I just want to put Halloween night behind me. (Not really, but it would make moving on a whole lot easier if I could just have some fucking space!) Anyway, I have an appointment with my psychiatrist tomorrow. Tillie thinks I need a med adjustment. Because *THAT's* the answer to life's problems.

XOXO,

-A

Dear Diary,

Today, Tillie asked me if I wanted to finish out my senior year at home. It's been no secret school's been... rough since Tim's murder. Between Dr. B and Walter, there was no keeping it from Tillie.

Honestly, though, it's been pretty tame. Sticks and stones and all that...

How I haven't had my nose bashed in, or my head shoved into a toilet bowl yet, I have no idea. Instead, they prefer to name-call and shove me around in the hallway. Even my friend Dev won't talk to me anymore.

And as for Eden...well, even if we did see each other during the day, I'd steer clear. I can't imagine he's been having it easy either. Not that he's said anything. He's too nice.

But if I approached him during the day though... showed the world we were friends...

No, Eden doesn't deserve that.

As much as I don't want to take the coward's way out...I'll be real with you: if it wasn't for Vale I'd probably have taken her up on the offer.

~~It's foolish, I know. Pathetic even. It's not as if he would care either way.~~

He'd miss me. We might've hit a rough patch, and he's got issues of his own to work through, but if I suddenly

disappeared on him?

He'd miss me.

XOXO,

-A

Dear Diary,

Confession time: sometimes, I wrap his sweatpants around me like a straitjacket. And I pretend they're his arms, holding me together.

I don't know what prompted him to change his mind and leave them for me...

He had to have known what kind of message that would send...

Right?

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

Earlier tonight, while watching makeup tutorial videos with Eden, I asked him if he thought he could be trans.

Not because he secretly likes girl clothes or has a curiosity toward makeup. It's just a...feeling I sometimes get around him. Like he's not comfortable in his own skin. Like someone else is clawing to get out.

I expected him to flip the fuck out when I asked, but surprisingly he just shrugged and said he didn't know.

He seems to be struggling more with that than anything else...the not knowing.

Can't say I blame him. It's got to be a unique kind of torture feeling like your body isn't your own. And your brain is colluding against you. I've been there...

Not in the same way, but I've been there.

Maybe I'm still there.

XOXO

-A.

Dear Diary,

Can you die from a broken heart?

Clichéd, I know, but it's a valid question.

XOXO,

-A

[song lyrics redacted due to copyright laws]

Dear Diary,

I've been having dreams.

Okay, nightmares if I'm being honest.

I can't remember them very well the next day, but whatever it is haunting my sleep, follows me throughout the day like a black cloud.

Eden said I cry out for Vale sometimes.

It would be romantic if it wasn't so sad, seeing as Vale's not here to hear it, you know?

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

The new meds seem to be helping. I'm sleeping a little better. Eating again when not nauseous from the side-effects as I adjust to the new dosages. And while I'm still heartbroken AF, I no longer feel like I'm walking through quicksand.

The headaches haven't gone away though. Not sure if I mentioned that... They've now been a near-constant presence since Halloween. Or rather, since the day after Halloween. Just this full throbbing in my temple that will randomly flare up into a shooting, teeth-rattling spike of pain.

Tillie said it's probably just a side-effect from the meds and will ease up once my body fully adjusts.

I didn't tell her the headaches started before the med change.

Maybe I've got a tumor. Can heartbreak cause brain cancer?

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

It's Thanksgiving.

I wonder how Vale spent it...

Did he eat corn?

Call me whatever you like, but I hope he can't stomach it either.

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

The more time that passes, the more convinced I am that I only imagined seeing Jude that night...

It just makes no sense.

I should probably tell Tillie, but I don't need her more worried about my mental state than she already is.

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

The Archers won the State Championship.

Vale actually looked happy. He smiled, and it looked genuine. It was an odd sight.

It was also a gut punch.

I wish I could make him smile like that.

He's really beautiful when he smiles.

XOXO

-A

Dear Diary,

We had a snow day today. Eden and I built a snowman.

We named him Milkshake...

Because he brought us boys to the yard.

Ha! Get it?

Last time I built a snowman, it was with Vale. Rick kicked it over on his way walking in after work. I cried. It was embarrassing because I never cried. Not in front of anyone at least. Vale looked pissed. I'd never seen him so pissed.

The next morning, I was...I don't remember what I was doing, but I do remember Rick shouting and cursing up a storm. He slid on ice on the way to the car. The

entire sidewalk was completely iced over. He fractured his wrist.

XOXO

-A

OMG THAT WAS VALE'S DOING WASN'T IT,
WASN'T IT?!?!?

Sneaky, sneaky vicious little mouse.

I'm not swooning. I swear I'm not.

(I totally am.)

Hmmm... I wonder what he'd do now if someone was
mean to me?

Oh wait, that happens daily. And he doesn't even care.

Guess that's what I get for falling in love with a
souless psychopath.

Whatever bit of soul he once possessed when it came
to me is long gone now...

CHAPTER 42

ASTON

DECEMBER

REMEMBER that scene in *New Moon*, when Bella spends three months in a chair, staring vacantly out the window, the camera slowly panning around her as a voice sings about how *there's a posssssibilityyyyyy...*

All because of a stupid boy.

Well, that basically sums up how I spent the last six weeks. Only instead of Lykke Li, it's Air Supply providing the score for my epic heartbreak montage.

Picture it:

Slow, aimless day-to-day meandering.

Longing gazes at Vale's retreating back as he rounds a corner—the only time I dare even glance his way; when I know he's not likely to catch me.

A hand splayed on a window as I watch him walking across the lot toward the field house with his teammates.

Me wailing into an empty abandoned bathroom, the very same one I held a knife to his face and felt his hand encircle my neck for the first time.

Eden holding me as I blow snot all over his shirt. And by holding me, I mean I've been crawling into his bed almost every night to cry and scream into his pillow until he has no other choice but to wrap his arms around me, so I *shut the fuck up and let me sleep, dammit!*

And when I get sick of playing “Without You” on a loop, Foreigner’s “I Want To Know What Love Is” becomes my new anthem—my cry into the void—as I hit the rewind button on my carefully curated montage and start over.

Slow, aimless day-to-day meandering.

Longing gazes—

Oomph.

Crashing to my knees, my books go flying, spinning across the linoleum floor.

Okayyyy, so I might’ve left this part out of the montage. Can you blame me?

If you actually read the diary entries—side-eyeing some of you majorly—you already know it’s been a little...tense lately at school.

But the whole transformation from school freak to Grady Prep’s enemy numero uno wasn’t really meshing with the whole somber, slow-mo, heartbroken aesthetic I’ve been going for. The one where I walk through the halls like a ghost, suffering in angsty silence.

Truly, a killer on the loose couldn’t have come at a worse time.

Er, I mean, me getting *accused* of being said killer—*falsely*, might I stress—couldn’t have come at a—

You know what, that doesn’t sound much better either, now that I think about it.

Before I can so much as catch my breath from the jarring jolt to my knees, a waterfall of ice-cold liquid reeking sweetly of caramel cascades down my head.

I tense, my body solidifying. Mouth open in a frozen, silent gasp.

“Oops,” a grating feminine voice says, not sounding apologetic in the least. It’s one I recognize immediately. I don’t even have to look up to confirm.

Twisting my head, I come face to face to with Alicia Devereau standing over me, flanked by the other Alicias, her ever-faithful lapdogs, smirking smugly like the Regina George she is. “My bad,” she says. “Thought I was aiming for the trash.”

A new wave of laughter rolls through the bodies gathering closer, surrounding me. It’s joined by jeers and taunts and the same ol’ same ol’.

It’s been a month and a half since a Grady Prep student was brutally murdered. And the cops are nowhere closer to figuring out who the real

killer is than they were when I was cleared. Meaning whoever it is, is still at large, much to the dismay of, well, just about everyone. Me included.

Not that I think it would even make much difference at this point if the real killer *was* caught. People are going to believe what they want. And what they want to believe is that I'm a cold-blooded murderer.

Sure, the murderer part is right. Technically.

But *cold-blooded*?

Ehhhh, debatable.

And by debatable, I mean HA! I wish. It would make things a lot easier if I didn't have all these pesky little feelings nipping at my brain like hungry hungry hippos.

That's what they should be worrying about. My *feelings*. That's the real threat here. But nonono, let's provoke the heartbroken, knife-wielding maniac from Ashwood who's just one step away from snapping and massacring everyone and teaming up with the Crowley Slayer.

Speaking of knives...

I pat my ankle out of reflex, double checking that I've got my baby on standby in the event things escalate.

Will whipping out a blade help my case? No. Definitely not. I'm cuckoo, but I'm not stupid.

But what else is a boy like me to do, when ganged up on by Satan on Heels and her merry band of bimbos, all while a whole bunch of bystanders look on and cheer—stupid *Seth* being one of them—because they'd rather spur on the drama than prevent it?

Fortunately, this time around, things are quickly broken up by a piercing whistle and teachers barking for everyone to clear out and get to class.

Does Alicia, or for that matter, anyone get sent to the office for giving me shit?

Of course not.

Someone *died*.

Everybody's still *grieving*.

As if I'm not going through my own crisis being the scapegoat for their trauma!

As if I'm not still grieving a devastating loss of my own!

Before Alicia saunters off, she spares me one last venomous look. One that promises she's nowhere near done making my life the hell it's been

since Halloween. I bare my teeth at her in a maniacal grin and say as sweet as the coffee syrup wafting from my drenched hair, “I hope you’re next.”

Her face falls. Tightens. Reddens. And with a flip of her bleached blonde hair, she storms off. Snapping her fingers for her cronies to follow like the sheep they are.

“Bitch,” I mutter, because some girls really do be bitches.

With a huff, I climb to a stand, grimacing at the chill prickling my scalp and neck. Ice cubes that hadn’t bounced off me melt around my collar. I suppose I could be grateful she didn’t throw the entire thing at me, cup and all. No, she simply removed the lid and dumped it over my head instead.

Aiming for the trash, my ass. Ugh!

The warning bell rings, and I debate whether or not English class can do without me today. Answers to my problems will certainly not be found in *Lolita*, our current read.

I mean, what kind of name is *Humbert Humbert* anyway?

And don’t even get me started on the long-winded inner monologuing. Like *come on*, get to the point. I don’t care about your feelings or the whys of it all, dude. Or how it all contributes to some greater understanding of the work.

Talk about a waste of words *and* time.

There’s also the whole headache and spacing-out thing I’ve got going on these days, which has made it hard to focus in class, much less consume tiny squiggles and decipher all their underlying meanings.

I’m also doing weekly sessions with my talk therapist *on top* of continuing to see Dr. B—something else I’m going to just skim over for now, but only because there hasn’t really been any life-changing epiphanies had, or breakthroughs made, or new information relevant to the tragedy that is my life revealed that would warrant me wasting *your* time.

Perhaps later it will come up.

All you need to know is that I’m riding the hot mess express these days. But, really, what else is new?

I go to reach down for one of my textbooks that I lost grip of, when someone beats me to it.

“Rough morning?”

Rolling my eyes, I push to a stand and turn toward Dr. Benson and take the book from his proffered hands. I brush the wet hair from my eyes and shrug. “What can I say? Drama just flocks to me.”

His lips thin.

“Anywho...class is a’waiting.” I grab my books from where I’d stacked them on the bench. Fortunately, they were far enough away that they managed to evade the worst of the coffee monsoon.

“Here,” he says, when I go to walk past him.

Pulling out a small notepad from his briefcase, he scribbles something down. “Get yourself cleaned up first. Give your teacher this so you don’t get written up.”

He rips the page off, and hands it to me.

I look down at it, brows arched. “Huh. That works. Thanks, I guess?”

He simply sighs. “I was actually going to come find you later to tell you... I have to cancel next week’s session. I’ll be out of—” He cuts himself off when I’ve already started walking away. “I’ll see you first thing Monday when we return!” he calls out after me, sounding as exasperated as ever.

Dude needs to get a grip.

Without turning around, I give him a wave.

Students brush past me in their haste to get to class. I turn down B hall, heading toward the bathroom, when I see a familiar figure walking this way from the opposite direction.

Vale...

Save for that short and sweet thank you note he left me for the birthday gift, he has stayed away. Just like he swore he would that day in my room.

And I’ve done my utmost best to respect his wishes, even as it slowly kills me.

A choice...

I gave him a choice, and he made it. And it wasn’t me. I need to accept that.

Since when? a voice pipes up, arguing.

A twinge of pain tugs at the corner of my eye, and I wince. *I don’t know. I don’t know...*

In the hallway, he’s yet to see me. His head’s down, and at his side his friend Casey jabbers on about something. Fletch is on his other side, arm slung around one of the Alicias. But they might as well be as part of the background as the rest of the students filing by, separating us.

I hold my breath as the distance between us grows smaller. Vale’s gaze is downcast, distant. He’s as part of the conversation with his friends as I

am with the nameless faces surrounding me. We're on our own frequencies. I just hope they cross, intersecting, even if it's just for a moment.

Time slows down like we're some regency era romance.

Where's the weeping violin when we need it?

My heart is stuck, lodged somewhere in my throat, and I will myself to look away, to not make it so obvious that I'm ogling him. For his sake, not mine. If I have any chance of him glancing my way, I need to be the one to avert my gaze first.

But before I can muster up the strength to do just that, he lifts his head, his dark gaze cutting right to mine just as we pass each other. As if he knew exactly where to find me.

The bodies separating us might as well not exist. Because for one frozen dragged out moment in time, it's just us, trapped in this shared connection. Our eyes held by some invisible force.

My mouth parts, an inhale rising my carriage. Lashes fluttering.

His brows dip broodingly. And fuck if I wouldn't sacrifice a testicle to get a glimpse of what's going on inside that handsome head of his.

I suck in my bottom lip, dragging my teeth over the flesh.

Fuck, I miss him.

Ache for him...

I also sort of wish I never met him. As kids, I mean. But only sometimes. Only when it hurts so bad, that it feels like I'll either die or lose myself completely, once and for all, than be apart from him for ever a second more.

Only when I think about the *what ifs...*

What if we only met recently?

What if we were normal?

Just as we finally, finally pass each other, his gaze drops to my mouth, and I can feel how his eyes smolder, even from a few feet away. It's a wonder I don't burst into flames from the heat of it.

We don't break the connection until we have no other choice.

Until we can no longer resist the gravity of a world that won't stop spinning, not even for us.

CHAPTER 43

VALE

“I THINK it’s time we get you back into therapy.”

Not lowering the glass of water from my lips, I flick a sideways look at Quentin where he leans back against the kitchen island.

It’s Wednesday night. The time on the microwave reads 8:18.

I missed dinner...

Again.

Not that I haven’t been eating. That part’s easy. It’s the ritualistic expectations that humans have attached to an act no more worthy of fanfare than taking a shit that I’ve been having trouble keeping up with these days.

Forgive me if I’m not in the mood for pleasantries, and would rather just scarf down what I need to survive in peace.

Arms crossed, brow arched over his glasses, Quentin eyes me challengingly. He knows as well as I do, he won’t be getting a response. Not for such a stupid, yet admittedly obvious, observation.

“You haven’t spoken a single word to me in two weeks,” he eventually points out, even more unnecessarily.

Averting my gaze, I gulp down what’s left of my water, before gently setting the glass down on the counter. I wipe the back of my hand across my mouth, turn fully to face Quentin, and mirror his position with my ass against the sink and arms crossed over my chest. Gaze locking casually with his.

My pulse still thrums from my workout, sweat dripping down my neck and temples. Between the ache in my chest and hamstrings telling me I definitely pushed it too hard on the weights, and the tingling flush I feel all

down my exposed arms and across my face, I feel as close to *alive* as I've felt in days.

Fuck, *weeks*.

"I imagine if I called the school—hell, your friends...they'd probably say the same."

I lift my shoulder. He's not totally wrong.

Sure, I've kept up the farce when absolutely necessary. But I'll be the first to acknowledge my usual gift for giving enough of a shit to blend has been notably missing.

Particularly since football ended...taking with it, the only distraction I could actually lose myself in. One that came with purpose. With *stakes*.

But even the high that came with leading the Archers to victory one last time wasn't enough to cushion the crash that inevitably came that following Monday, when I found myself driving aimlessly around Crowley and its neighboring towns in a pathetic, futile attempt to keep myself from doing something stupid or destructive or both.

Something involving a certain doe-eyed lunatic I can't fucking purge from my mind, no matter how much time has passed. No matter how much distance I've put between us...

Distance he so conveniently decided to adhere to, because apparently somewhere in that cracked eggshell of a skull he has, what I said to him that day—what I asked of him—actually got through to him.

And stuck.

Yes, I'm fully fucking aware this is what I wanted.

Yes, I should be grateful and relieved.

Yes, I know this is for the greater good.

But this is *Aston* we're talking about.

I never actually thought he'd *stay* away.

That he'd give up.

I figured I might get a couple days—maybe a week, if I was really lucky—before he was back on his bullshit with renewed confidence and determination, cornering me in the school, stalking my practices, shamelessly spying on me from the fucking bushes wearing those ridiculous heart-shaped sunglasses.

But that's not at all what happened.

It's been over a month now, and if I didn't see him with my own two eyes, shuffling despondently through the halls, devoid of all that I've come

to know makes him...*him*...

I'd think he disappeared completely.

Dropped out after I dropped him.

Ceased to exist altogether, just like I wanted...

Right?

"Vale."

Blowing out a breath, I give Quentin a curt nod, telling him I heard him. I'm listening.

It's not as if I haven't been expecting this conversation. It was only a matter of time.

His mouth thins like he's gearing up to say something he knows I won't like. Seeing as that list is pretty long these days... it's not even worth guessing.

"You haven't shut down like this since—"

"I know." The words are uttered so quietly, so stiffly, it's only thanks to him looking at me that he knows I spoke at all.

You haven't shut down like this since I met you, is what he was going to say.

Since the last time you lost Aston, is what he would've really meant.

Except...

I didn't lose Aston this time. He's right fucking here in Crowley, walking the same halls I do, sharing the same air I fucking breathe.

And yet, he's never felt as far away as he has these last six weeks. Even when he's standing ten feet in front of me, looking both half a corpse and like every sweet sin I've denied myself... there's this distance that's never been there before. A sense of...resignation. Defeat.

Well, that is until today, when our gazes met across a crowded hallway, and finally, finally I spotted a flicker of the Aston I've come to know these last few months.

And while I know now that some, if not most, of his outlandish behavior is an act. A mask, not unlike the one I wear—only his is like something you'd see at a Mardi Gras parade with multi-colored feathers and enough sequins to set something on fire...

Not all of it is.

Because the thing is...he's always been a little off.

Even as kids, he was unabashedly clingy—even back when my arrival was unwelcome, he was *always there*—and shamelessly demanding, and

infuriatingly dense when it came to knowing when to shut the fuck up—intentionally so, because he’s far from stupid.

The only times I can recall him shutting down like this...disappearing within himself like he had for weeks...

Something bad is coming.

“You don’t have to talk to me,” Quentin says, pulling me from my thoughts, “if you don’t want to. But you should talk to someone. We agreed once you—”

“You told him,” I cut in softly, my voice still rusty from disuse. “Aston.”

Quentin’s eyes widen ever so faintly.

I nod and look down at my sock-clad feet.

I figured as much. Aston might be more cunning and perceptive than he lets on, but he’s also extremely self-absorbed. Especially this older, less predictable, far more delusional version of my foster brother.

So caught up the fairytale he weaved for us since moving here...well, it’s no surprise it took a third party spelling it the fuck out for him to finally open his eyes.

“Is *that* why you’ve shut me out?” Quentin inquires in a way that sounds soft and curious.

I level him with a flat, droll look as if to say, *Really?*

I’m petty, but I’d like to think I carry a little more maturity than a hormonal pre-teen giving his dad the silent treatment.

Quentin’s lips twitch, humor alighting his eyes.

Oh. He was just fucking with me.

Huffing irritably through my nose, I look away, and forcibly mutter, “Fuck off.”

He chuckles. “I’d apologize—for telling him, I mean—but...” His voice trails off.

He’s not sorry. There’s no point in saying the obvious out loud, so I just nod. *I know.*

And frankly, I don’t even care. That he told him, that he thought it wise to meddle, that he felt it was his place...

If anything, it’s exactly what both Aston and I needed.

A reality check.

I mean...why else would he actually listen to me and stay away this time, when he blatantly ignored all of my previous half-ass attempts to

resist his advances and cut him out of my life for good?

It's not as if *I* ever went out of my way to seek him out. Not until that day I showed up at his house unannounced.

No, he just kept coming back like a fucking boomerang.

Persistent, unbothered, and not daunted by my behavior in the least.

Until he learned what I am...and could no longer paint my cruel treatment with whatever pretty sentiments kept his hope alive up until then.

"Given how...unconcerned he was when I told him, I'm going to assume you're the one who ended things."

I don't bother insisting there was nothing to end. Instead, I latch onto that first part. He must sense my confusion—my skepticism—because he says, "Don't tell me *he* did."

Clearing my throat, I give a quick shake of my head. *No*.

Quentin makes a soft sound of acknowledgment. Meanwhile, I grab my glass, and make my way to the fridge for a refill. Ignoring the way his gaze drills into me. As if he could unearth all the things I refuse to say.

There's a soft intake of air, then—

"But he accepted your decision."

Jaw working, I throw the water back in two gulps, swallowing it down roughly.

"...and you regret it." It's spoken so faintly, it's a wonder I even hear it.

Snapping my head around with a glare, I bite out, "I don't regret anything."

Quentin's brow creases, pity eking from his warm gaze. "Vale..."

Whirling around to face him, I spread my arms, empty glass still clutched in my hand. "I don't. I got exactly what I wanted. Finally some fucking peace again. It's almost as if the last few months didn't happen. As if Aston's not even fucking here!"

Before I even realize what I'm doing, I'm whipping the glass at the wall.

It says a lot that Quentin doesn't even flinch.

I suppose, just like I've been anticipating this conversation...he's been bracing for my violence. Bracing for when I finally can't take it anymore, and I can't help but release some of this pent-up energy before I implode or do something infinitely worse...something *permanent*.

Not taking his eyes off me, he crosses his legs in front of him, putting even more of his weight on the countertop behind him. "So, what's the

problem then, Vale?”

“I don’t know.”

“Try again.”

I snarl, “I *said* I don’t—”

“And I don’t believe you.”

A heavy silence descends on the room.

In the back of my head, I hear an echo of Aston’s gritted outburst from that day so many weeks ago. “*You’re lying to me. Boyfriends don’t lie to each other.*”

He’s crazy. Fucking insane.

And yet, just like every time I recall our heated exchange that day, our near-kiss, the feel of him beneath me, all warm and squirmy with need...I can’t help but circle back to what transpired the night before.

Halloween.

The carnival.

The mines...the cornfields...

Finally succumbing to my primal need to claim him, *own* him...*break* him...

It’s a moment my mind just can’t seem to shake.

I can’t stop replaying it.

I didn’t just hold his fragile sanity in my hands that night...I played God with it. Weighed it in my palms and determined whether or not he was worthy of redemption. And in doing so, I didn’t give Aston what he wanted...

No, that night, I gave him what he *needed*. What we both needed.

Just as I did the following day in his room when I ended things. For good.

I didn’t see it before that night, what is so obvious now... The war he battled within himself between desire and destruction.

It’s only in hindsight, knowing what I know now, knowing what I was too far up my own ass to see until Quentin pointed it out and I could no longer *un-see* it...

Not when I had Aston curled up in front of me, clutching his kimono to his chest like a shield, when I stabbed him with three words I don’t think either of us were fucking prepared for.

I forgive you.

He wanted me to punish him...and instead, I forced my mercy upon him.

A giant “fuck you” and blessing all wrapped into one.

“I don’t know what you want me to say,” I finally manage to tell Quentin.

His mouth is downturned. He doesn’t look disappointed so much as... resigned. “I suppose I don’t need you to say anything. I just ask that you at least be honest with yourself. The way you’ve been going...”

He gestures at the splattered wall...the shards of glass scattered across the wood floor.

I grimace, knowing I’ll have to clean that up.

“If you keep this up, I fear what you might do. You can’t bottle it up. You know you can’t. You need to find an outlet, especially now that football—”

“What do you fucking think I’ve been doing?” I interject loudly, gesturing harshly at my sweat-stained muscle tee.

He waits a beat before responding calmly, “Something that doesn’t include you killing yourself, I suggest.”

I scoff.

“You forget you’re not invincible, Vale. When you get like this...” He shakes his head. Bringing his fingers to the bridge of his nose, he reaches under his glasses to pinch the corners of his eyes.

I study his strained expression more closely. Taking in the creases at the corners of his eyes, and the shadows underneath. Noting the tightness around his lips.

He’s concerned. Not just about what I might do...the future I could jeopardize.. and in turn, his future as well...

But he’s concerned for me.

Concerned about my wellbeing.

Instantly, my brain is racing—neurons pinging with all the ways I could use this brief show of vulnerability to my advantage.

As if he senses where my mind reflexively went, he slowly lowers his arm to his side and lifts his hardened, reddened gaze to mine. Gone is that wariness from a moment ago, and in its place is the stone-cold ruthlessness I’ve come to expect from him when he’s summoning forth the lawyer in him.

The hardass.

The one who can look a psychopath dead in the eyes and not cower.

“I’ll call Dr. Davenport tomorrow. See about getting you in before the holidays.”

I nod stiffly. No use arguing it. Sure, I’m nineteen—technically a legal adult, despite my high school student status. I could refuse...

But then Quentin would be perfectly in his right to kick me out. He warned me as much back when I was seventeen and it was decided I no longer needed rigorous behavioral therapy.

I was doing so well for so long, that even when I turned eighteen, and could finally be formally assessed for Antisocial Personality Disorder—and by close association in my case, psychopathy—we opted not to.

It’s not as if there’s a cure.

It’s not as if an official diagnosis changes anything.

Just because I’ve made great strides in recent years, having all but beaten my less than savory urges into submission, doesn’t mean there won’t come a day where I decide, fuck it. I’m done.

Done pretending like I fit in this world.

Done pretending like anything fucking matters.

That we’re not all just bone and dust. Fodder for bugs.

At least in therapy, I learn the skills I need to get by. To fly under the radar and know how to work the system to my benefit.

That way, I can still feed the void inside me with little bites of the violence it craves—just enough to keep it somewhat satisfied, so it doesn’t devour me whole.

So I’m not crushed under the weight of the hollow nothingness... the *boredom*.

Taking my continued silence for what it is, Quentin announces he’s headed off to bed. “My flight’s tomorrow night. Dinner before I go?”

“Sure.”

Just before he leaves, he jerks his chin toward the mess I made. “Clean that up.”

I nod, and we exchange terse goodnights.

LATER, after I've cleaned up and shut off all the downstairs lights, and I find myself standing under the scalding hot spray of the shower...I find myself replaying back our conversation, rolling around all that Quentin said, and what he didn't say. Understanding them for the obvious warning they are...

"If you keep this up, I fear what you might do. You can't bottle it up. You know you can't. You need to find an outlet, especially now..."

Especially now.

Football's over. Who knows what it's going to be like in college?

I'm single. My hand's only good for so much.

And then there's Aston...

Because it always comes down to him.

Quentin's right.

I *can't* keep living like this.

I don't want to.

Something's gotta give.

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CHAPTER 44

ASTON

THE FOLLOWING AFTERNOON, I find the last thing I'm expecting waiting for me in my locker.

Another handwritten note. This makes the *third*. Written in the same blunt scrawl as the other two.

TOMORROW. 6:30AM. FIELD HOUSE. POOL.

My stomach drops like I'd just been flung off the top of a rollercoaster—in a good way! *I think...*

I suck a smile between my teeth, barely containing a squeal.

Did he hear about the coffee incident with Alicia?

Did he hear about how the wrestling team cornered me this morning?

Does he actually care after all?

As calmly as I can, I fold the paper up and glance over my shoulder. It's the end of the day, and the hallway is swarming with students chatting away as they gather their belongings. Somewhere, there's a cat call, and a squeal of rubber skidding across linoleum.

Everything's so loud, so bright suddenly. It's as if someone took paddles to my chest, jolting me to life.

Just like yesterday, everything once more fades to the background when my gaze locks on Vale at the end of the hallway. His body's angled away from me, making it so I can only see his dark hair, a glimpse of a chiseled jawline, and the slope of his shoulders.

As if sensing he's being watched, he slants his head just enough to lock eyes with me. He doesn't even seem to care that his friends are gathered

around him, talking and gesturing animatedly, oblivious to the fact their icy quarterback's attention is elsewhere.

My breaths quicken, and my heart's trapped somewhere in my throat, beating wildly.

In my hand, the folded note crumples, the edges digging into my palm. I don't miss how Vale's gaze flits to my closed fist.

When it returns to my face, I give him a short nod, and a small secret smile, acknowledging I got his note. And *hell to the yes*, I'll be there.

His brow furrows, but then his attention's yanked away by Casey, and the moment's over.

But it's okay. He wants to see me. Despite having told me we were over, that he didn't want me...despite telling me to leave him alone...he wants to meet up and hang out or talk or...or maybe more...

That has to mean something, right?

Is he finally done fighting this?

Is he finally going to put me out of my misery?

"See you tomorrow, little mouse," I whisper.

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CHAPTER 45

ASTON

Trauma.

It really is the gift that keeps on giving.

THE NEXT MORNING, I have Tillie drop me off early.

A group project thingie, I told her.

She didn't look like she fully believed me, but must've decided to give me the benefit of the doubt. Probably because she's still half-expecting me to go full-on Carrie White one of these days, and decimate the entire student body in a grizzly, bloody explosion. All with the power of my mind.

Now, wouldn't that make for a rad plot twist right about now?

Alas, we've still got the sequel to contend with. Gotta save something special for the grand finale. I mean, unless you're just expecting Vale and I to drive off in the sunset together.

Yawn, much?

Digging out a Blow Pop from my bag, I unwrap it and shove it in my mouth as I head for the main doors. All the while, I'm acutely aware of the rumbling engine idling along the curb and Tillie's watchful gaze.

It's like she doesn't even trust me!

Dense fog blankets the woods surrounding Grady Prep. It's been raining on and off since last night. And if the state of the sky is anything to go by, it's not looking to clear up anytime soon.

Between the mostly deserted front lot, and the fact the sun's yet to do more than lighten the sky to a dull, miserable gray that is only a shade lighter than the mottled gray brick making up the school's exterior...

Well, I'm not going to lie—it's feeling real spooky around here today.

Spookier than usual.

If ever there was a time to blow the lid on their vampire operation, it'd probably be now, at the ass crack of dawn, when they're sleepy and readying for slumber after a long night listening to opera and feasting on the blood of their victims.

Hopefully cows and not humans, like that cute movie with the two boys who were *clearly* smitten with each other, despite the fact one of them was cursed and fanged, and it was the early 2000s, so we didn't talk about things like boys having crushes on other boys.

Not unless you wanted to get weird looks and even worse commentary, that is.

God forbid we acknowledge queerness existing before puberty!

But I digress.

Stopping in front of the double main doors, I twist around to give Tillie a little wave. Satisfied, she pulls away, the exhaust gunning a cloud of smoke into the misty morning.

Once the Beetle's out of sight, I release the handle, and turn back around. I take the steps two at a time and cut a sharp right, following the side lot that will take me around back.

The field house—a sleek chrome and glass building that stands at odds against the creepy vine-infested stone castle that is the school—sits on the other side of the student lot. Built into the hill overlooking the football field, at first glance, you'd never know it's home to not only two gymnasiums and an indoor track that is a floor all on its own, but an Olympic sized swimming pool as well.

On top of all that, there's two fitness centers—one located on the ground floor, near the locker room, that the football team primarily uses. And the larger main one students and faculty make use of near the front lobby.

Striding across the mostly vacant lot, I sweep a glance around, looking for Vale's car, wondering if he's already here.

And he is.

I twist my lips together at the sight of his sleek black Audi, my stomach fluttering with a mix of nerves and dread.

I should know better, at this point, than to think he asked me here to tell me he changed his mind—that he’s been just as lost without me as I am without him, and he wants me back because he’s hopelessly in love with me, and *it’s you, Aston, it’s always been you, and I want to have your babies and*—Ahem. You get the picture.

And I was saying, I *should* know better...

And yet here I am, as ready as ever to have my heart shattered all over again.

The lights in the lobby are on, shining faintly through the glass sliding doors and tinted windows. I don’t know who else is here this early, but I’m not about to walk into the lion’s den and risk bumping into anyone who might want to beat my face into a pulp.

Only Vale’s allowed to want to throttle me.

No one else.

If someone’s going to break my pretty face, it’s going to be the love of my— *No. Nope.* Too far. That’s too far. I do have some sense of dignity. Some.

Maybe.

Oh, who am I kidding?

I’m weak.

I know I’m weak.

When it comes to Vale, I’m hopeless.

Ruin me, little mouse. Break me. Snatch all my pieces for yourself and never let them go.

Truly though, for the record, if it came down to it, I really, *really* don’t think Vale would *actually* hurt me, okay? Even knowing what I do now about his *condition*... choking me in the heat of the moment to shut up my yappin’ is one thing, but using his fists on me to *hurt* me? Like, seriously, genuinely *hurt* me...

Okay, so, earlier in the year, maybe I would’ve considered it a possibility. Which, yeah, that says *a lot*, seeing as we were basically in a relationship then and domestic violence is a big no-no.

But after what happened in the cornfield?

After how we left things the next day?

The fact he changed his mind and *left his sweatpants for me to have*...

I don't know.

Either it's all part of some grand, elaborate evil plan to lure me into a false sense of security, before he ultimately kills me.

Or...OR...

He's as hopelessly, irrevocably in love with me, as I am with him. But it pisses him off, because he's stubborn and is allergic to joy, so what else is a starving, repressed man to do but wreck my butt when he inevitably loses the battle with his desires?

Which is what I'm banking on happening this morning.

I mean, why else would he ask me to meet him on school grounds of all places, in this building where there's all sorts of fun we can have before students and faculty arrive?

Vale isn't exactly Mr. Healthy Communication, as you've probably noticed. I sincerely doubt he asked me here to hang out and shoot the shit until school started.

Bolstered by the thought, I roll my shoulders, grip the straps of my bag, and round the building, heading for the unmarked side door I used the other times I was here. It leads into a narrow stairwell, making it so I can go straight down to the pool.

The sharp scent of chlorine greets me on the bottom floor, as I emerge into a white, brightly lit hallway.

I look both ways, straining my ears for any signs of life. Assuming Vale wants to meet me alone, he probably picked this time and place for a reason, so I'm not surprised when I don't hear any voices. Only a low mechanical hum coming from the direction of the natatorium.

Along the walls there are signs and arrows indicating where things are. Boys locker room. Girls locker room. Weight room. Offices. Pool.

The chemical smell grows stronger as I draw near that last one, rounding a corner to where it opens up into a cavernous space.

The pool is empty. Uncovered. And while the overhead lights in here have yet to be powered on, the ones in the pool are, making it so the walls ripple with a faint blue sheen.

I dart my eyes around, looking for a familiar dark imposing figure.

But I'm alone.

Maybe he went to the bathroom? Or ran into someone upstairs?

My Oxfords squeak quietly over the tiled floor as I slowly walk by the bleachers, but given how silent it otherwise is, it sounds obnoxiously loud

and I'm feeling a little self-conscious now.

I burrow deeper in my coat, chin buried in the scarf I wrapped around my neck. I'd actually made an effort on my appearance for school today, you see, something I hadn't done in weeks, not since Vale and I broke up. I can't do much about the uniform, but the charcoal peacoat and pale green pashmina scarf I wear over it helps. I also used the styling gel I gifted Eden a while back, in an effort to tame my unruly mop of hair.

Overall, it's admittedly a little more understated than I'd typically go for. I did consider wearing my fur coat, but after what happened yesterday, I decided not to chance it.

I also figured the more reserved I come off, the better. I need to really drive home just how affected I've been by this distance between us. I can't have Vale thinking everything's all fine and dandy, and that I've moved on.

But I also won't have him thinking I can't function without him (*I really, really* can't, but he doesn't need to know that...yet). Hence, the effort. Minimal that it be.

The scarf, fortunately, more than makes up for any would-be drabness though. It makes my sage eyes *pop*. Eden said so. I stood over his bed early this morning, before the sun was even up, shook him awake, and asked him if it made them pop. And he sleepily mumbled, "Sure." A winning endorsement if there ever was one. He didn't even need to open his eyes, because he just *knew*.

We're connected like that, me and him.

True bosom buds.

A door clicking shut somewhere yanks me from my thoughts, and I freeze. It sounded like it came from behind me. From the hallway.

A moment later, I hear...something.

I can't pinpoint what it is. It's faint, but growing louder by the second. It almost sounds like a...motor? But a small one.

I wait for Vale to appear around the corner.

But he never does.

I frown and take a cautious step forward, then another, back the way I came until the hallway comes into view once more. Someone's out there. I can feel another presence.

And that...sound...

What is that?

Something niggles at the back of my head—a sense of wrongness—but I tell myself I’m just being paranoid.

“Vale?” I call out quietly. “Is that you?”

No response.

Okay...

Louder, I say, “Look, as fun as it was getting chased down in the cornfield...I’m not so sure we should be playing that kind of game at school, you know?” I expel a breath and strengthen my stride.

As the end of the hallway comes into view, I see movement. A shadow. Someone just out of sight. “Someone might get the wrong idea,” I go on, rounding the corner, “and think you’re—”

Whoosh.

My gaze drops to the floor just as something red streaks toward me.

Oh.

A grin creeps up my face as it clicks what I was hearing—the red remote control *Hot Wheels* car I left Vale on his birthday. To replace the one he told me about years ago, the one he lost somewhere in the shuffle between getting taken in by his grandmother and moving into the Baders.

It was his favorite.

I doubt it’s the same model. I don’t remember if he even told me. I just remember him mentioning that it was red, so I ordered the coolest looking red one I could find online using Eden’s account.

The car runs into my shoe, reverses, before running head-on into my shoe once more.

I crane my neck, looking up and down the hall, but I don’t see him anywhere.

He can’t be far though.

“Aw, did you ask me to meet so we could play with your new toy?” I tease. Reaching down, I pick it up, eyeing its little wheels as they spin in place. “You should’ve said. I would’ve—”

It happens so fast.

The shock hits before the pain does, exploding across the back of my head.

I catch sight of a gloved hand. Black pants. White sneakers.

Somehow, I’m on the ground.

The toy car is on its back, spinning across the floor away from me, out of reach.

I don't know how I got here.

I'm vaguely aware of something clamped around my wrist, and my arm being pulled like it's going to snap. I'm being dragged. I catch a whiff of cologne...something woodsy, but also citrusy. *Fancy. Familiar...*

I can't keep my eyes open. I can't find my body.

I try to say something, but whatever comes out gets lost in the ringing in my ears.

It's all stars behind my eyes.

And then, it's nothing.

Just darkness.

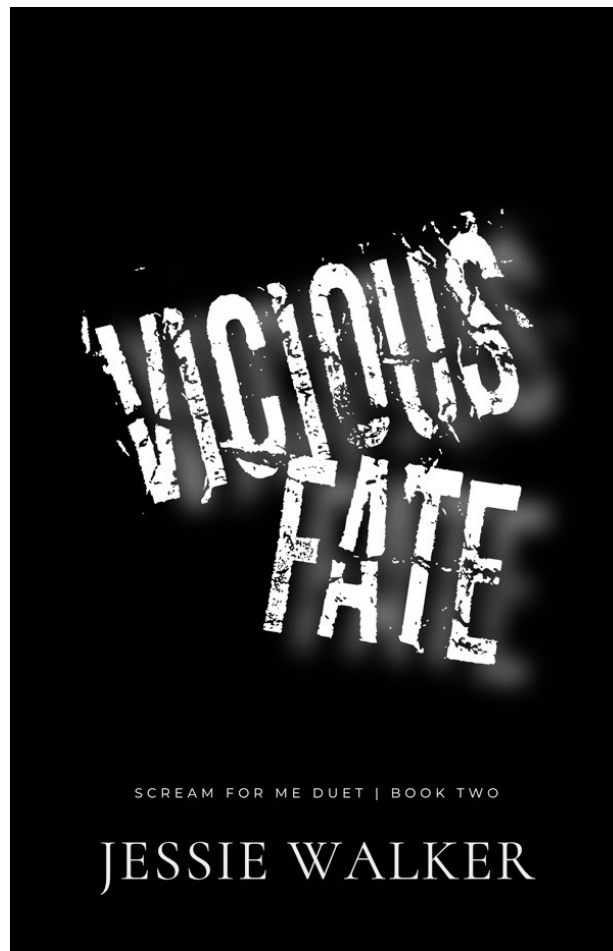
Endless, cold darkness.

To be continued...

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AFTERWORD

Vale and Aston's story concludes in *Vicious Fate*, coming this December.



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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I'll save the extended afterword and thanks for the sequel, but I do want to take a moment to give a little shout out to all those who helped make this book in particular possible.

My PA and alpha, Kayla—literally would be lost without you. Thanks for holding down the fort, and for always being down to chat about all the things. There were many times I wasn't sure if I'd ever finish another book, but knowing you were waiting for more words...for this story to be finished...often gave me the push I needed.

My editor, Heather. You know better than just about anyone how much difficulty I had writing this book. I can't thank you enough for the patience you have with me and the diligence you put into getting the stories I write into their best shape, all while ensuring they align with my vision for them. I'm so grateful to have you as an editor and friend.

My betas—Mikaela and A. Your enthusiasm for these two and for this story came at a time when I needed it most. Thanks for being a fresh perspective, and for helping me with last minute touches to make this book all the better. You made me fall in love with these two all over again.

My Wailers and Misfits—always there when I need you. I can't thank you all enough. <3

And last, but not least, my amazing readers. Some of you have been waiting for more of Vale and Aston's story for years. Some of you have been waiting for another book from me, period. I don't know that I ever would've finished another project if not for the support and encouragement and faith so many of you have shown me in the last year and a half while I climbed my way out of The Burn Out from Hell. I wouldn't be here, still doing the thing, if not for YOU.

To those new here—thank you for giving my work a chance!

ALSO BY JESSIE WALKER

MM STANDALONES

[Exiled](#)

SCREAM FOR ME DUET (MM)

Sweet Wicked Thing

Vicious Fate - coming soon!

THE “SHILOHVERSE”

[Where There's A Will](#) (MM)

[If There's A Way](#) (MM)

[Still Beating: A Lost Boys Novella](#) (MM)

[Little Bird Lost](#) (MMFM)

[All We Are: A Lost Boys Pride Novella](#) (MM, MM) **

[Every Breath After: Part One](#) (MM)

Every Breath After: Part Two - coming soon!

...and more to come

*This order is based on releases. This is an ongoing series, and books tend to overlap/bounce around timelines, so when it doubt just read in the order they were written.

***All We Are* takes place between the final chapter in this book and the Epilogue. It also takes place after *Every Breath After: Part One*. I kept it vague enough so as not to spoil anything major, but it does shed some light on Mason & Jeremy's history, which you get in depth in *Every Breath After: Part One*.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Jessie Walker is an indie author of queer romance based out of Scranton, Pennsylvania, where she lives with her long-time partner and fur-spawn. Drawn to all things dark and twisted, she likes to pretend she's not the hopeless romantic at heart that she is. She has ADHD and a background in psychology/mental health services, both of which contribute greatly to her storytelling and the themes of her long-winded, character-driven works. When she's not drudging away at a keyboard, there's a very good chance you'll find her vegged out on her couch, listening to sad '90s grunge, and day dreamin' about the all the stories crowding her brain.

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